Vanessa (Chapter 39)

Sunday, September 7, 2025 17:25

Derek beside me asks, that was weird right? It isn't just me. I replied, you mean how David was behaving or how Blake had to help him walk out of here. Derek hesitantly says, both. I agreed. Something was definitely wrong with him. As soon as my brother was mentioned his air changed around him. What does that mean. I wanted to follow them and asked him. But the anger I feel towards him was pushing down my urge. Honestly, whatever the reason, he shouldn't have taken agreed to this ridiculous condition.

I saw Marina walking away with Blake and David inside. She was using a charm to take a piece of the barrier with her. The hole she left behind was already closing. Looking at that I turned to Derek saying, looks like we will be spending a little more inside. Derek was also watching them leave inside. He nods, seems like it. He took some steps away from Charles and Kafar's discussion, which is basically Kafar berating mostly now. I tuned out most of it since it was all around the same lines of reconsidering this.

I asks, so what happens now? We can't just do nothing while those two argue. I ask Derek, the tournament over now with Charles surrender, right. What's the point in their argument now. Derek took a moment to respond, I guess the first thing we should notify the admins about it. We are not able to contact them directly from inside the barrier. Whatever happens later, for now, the match has ended, like you said. He faced the two behind one more time. I thought he would finally intervene, but instead he just observes them. A moment later he sighs, this is no good. Kafar is getting too much agitated.

I wondered what to do about them. Derek faces me, lets leave them. I am not getting between them. Let Kafar say his peace. We should go to others. I was more than happy to leave them be. I was occupied with other thoughts in my mind. We began walking to the barrier wall. I turned to Derek and asked him before we reached the edge, do you have any idea what happened to David. He looked so, well, different. Why did he ask about my brother. Derek replied, I don't know. I was shocked as well. Maybe he recalled some memories or something like that.

I ask back, about Wagner? How. David never said he knew him. He asks, did he ever tell you he don't know him. I tried remembering. But yeah, he has always been evasive about his time on Medrine. I felt a tinge of anger now, but to know about Wagner's fighting. That means he was close enough to know him personally. My voice started to get filled with jealousy, even I didn't about that body or spirit breaking stuff. How does David know about it. Derek didn't say anything. He was instead surprised by my tone rising.

Derek replies after giving a thought, they both attended the same college. As an alumni, they could have met back then. I reply, but why hide that fact. A second later, I got even angrier, I can't also believe that my own brother hid he could overdrive. What's up with that. Derek says, all good questions. Maybe David can answer them. Clearly he is knows more than he is letting on. Besides, I more concerned with that sudden exhaustion. That almost looked like, he trails off. He then shook his head and mumbles, no that can't be right. Why now of all times.

It wasn't like I didn't share his concern, but I was too much stuck on David's other peculiar behaviors. I have seen David hurt enough times to know he always find a way to get back up. We reach the wall. Now few more people had gathered around. All the admins. They were talking to Nathan and others, trying to understand what really happened. We all had to wait until Marina takes down the barrier. I zoned off from the their muted discussion. I was too hung up on other things. With so much going on, it’s going to be chaos for a while.

Next few minutes went by a sense of trepidation in the air. I saw Blake and Marina returning a while later. The admins all started asking questions to them. While Blake spoke, Marina started to work on removing the barrier. Derek says, looks like the people are going to be kept in suspense for a while. After a while other staffs came outside, among them Ned. He was walking with a tablet in hand now. The discussion was completely led by Blake taking the lead. I saw him talking as other listened quietly.

Derek asks me with a grim voice, listen, I need a favor from you. I faced him wondering what it was. He usually doesn't ask others in such a serious tone. He continuous, can you keep the stuff about few Medrones on Medrine knowing about Heraknus existence a secret. So far Kafar has only told bare minimum to some people. There's going to be backlash after today on why Heraknus were hidden. Both back on Medrine and now on Earth. You heard some part of it from Charles, but not the whole facts. I don't want to create unnecessary rumors or half details being spread among people.

I understood what he meant but at the same time I wondered how not telling will persuade people. He continuous, its not just you. Others who listened in the conversation also shouldn't keep a lid on it. At least until Kafar or Charles himself explain the situation. After weighing the chaos it could create I gathered that was the best thing to do. I reply, you are right. This will be much better coming from them. Dereks nods, thanks. Please tell others to do the same. I reply, you got it.

After ten minutes of us staring at the barrier, it finally came down. The noise from the crowd also begin to stir around us. The enthusiasm had faded a little, I could tell. People were now just waiting for some kind of announcement. Behind us, I saw Charles and Kafar finally walking to us. They saw the barrier coming down and must have figured times up. From Kafar's expression I could tell he was totally annoyed. Charles on the other hand doesn't look that different. I could judge that nothing changed between them.

The admins came walking to Charles. The head admin, Reinhart spoke first, Charles, we heard from Blake about the situation. Are you sure weren't pressured or leveraged to surrender. Is it really your own decision. Charles looks at him after a quick look over from Kafar. He clears his throat, let me be clear. It is unequivocally my decision to give up. No one made me. The other admins behind Reinhart became a little restless. Ned remained expressionless. I wondered what he was really thinking. Was he frustrated, or was he just didn't care. Hard to tell with him sometimes. He didn't even look at me once coming here. My mood turned even sour after all that David did.

Reinhart understood immediately what to do next. He talks to a person beside him. After confirming something with him he turns to Kafar, we have a proposition of sorts. Kafar straightened up body hearing a possibility of a way out. Reinhart continuous, as I understand there is some kind of understanding between David and Charles on fighting a month later. I don't know the whole details. Regardless, we can call the tournament officially over with David's victory.

Kafar looked like he wanted to rebuke something, but he kept his composure. The person beside Reinhart spoke now, we can then call the match next month a extended match. We can spin this into a two-part event. Since we didn't a proper resolution and also suffered an accident, we tell people that a much more secure and grander second half of the event is waiting in line. Reinhart takes over, If done right this can actually pull in more interested people. The viewership on this match has been extremely effective. By creating such a twist we might have a bigger impact.

Honestly, I didn't care how they wanted to plan this. I actually wanted to leave, but it would be a little rude now that I have stayed here so long. At least I would stay until everyone agrees on something. Kafar spoke calmy, this could work. But should we really say mention David's the winner then. Shouldn't we wait until next month. That type of response was pretty much I expected from him. He is clearly trying to whatever he can to avoid tarnishing his champion name.

Reinhart says, no. Charles clearly gave the signal to give up. We can't just ignore him. It would create unnecessary confusion telling he didn't win. No matter how much we want to, this final match was already a like a bonus match with Charles as a wild card entry. Declaring David the winner of this one half of the bonus event a winner would be best thing to do here. Another admin spoke up, look. We can declare a technical win for David. This would actually make people also not satisfied. That will help in keeping the interest of people going until next month. He turns to Reinhart, we still need to have bigger discussion.

Reinhart replies, absolutely. Right now, I just need to confirm from Kafar and the participants. Do you guys agree to this. Kafar was quite, trying to analyze the situation with his myopic view. Charles didn't need to wait, I have no problem. If you want to keep the next match as part of the tournament, that's your call. He turns to Kafar, but the deal I made with David doesn't change. Kafar clicks his tongue, I get it already. He shook his head dismayed, fine. Yeah, I don't see a better option here.

Reinhart says, great. Moving on then. He turns to Blake standing beside. Can you see to it that David also agrees to it. Blake replies hesitantly, well, that's um. He trailed off. I got a little concerned wondering what's going on with David. Just then Marina chips in, David said he is okay with anything as long as Charles honors his part of the deal. Reinhart replies, that's all fine. I still like to know deal these two have in detail. But that’s later. A staff person gave a Kuretine speaker to Reinhart.

He turns it on and faces the crowd. Two other staff person come front. They had a camera on both their persons. Clear out some space people, one said. We are about to tell everyone in the stadium. People cleared out of the way. I walked a little further away from Ned. I still haven't forgotten that he and I aren't on the best of terms right now. Reinhart begins speaking, hi there everyone. His face got plastered on the stadium screen and his voice enclosed the entire stadium.

How crazy this match was people. That was probably the most thrilling, head scratching and without a doubt the most exciting event of this entire tournament. At that people all over cheered in huge roar. He continuous, I have never witness such as obscene display of strength and determination. Don't you all agree. The wild shouting the crowd answers that question. He laughs and continuous, but there is always a single winner. And after hearing from the people here, we have come to a conclusion.

The stadium quiets down in suspense. Reinhart gleefully shouts, with Charles surrender, the winner is David. The crowd goes wild with frenzy. People are shouting and jumping across the entire stadium. Their enthusiasm is to be expected. Everyone here knew that there was more, so no one were actually enjoying. Reinhart speaks along, unfortunately, David had to deal with his injuries. We will soon get him in front of a camera as soon as possible. He then clears this throat, but there is actually another announcement we want everyone to know right now.

This tournament is not yet over guys. He pauses a while to give people to digest that new twist. He continuous, in a completely unscripted and surprising development, there is another match going to happen people. This was just one half of this final tournament match. He pauses once again before speaking. David won this, and yet Charles has a chance to take back the title of winner. What you all are about to witness next is even bigger and crazier. Charles surrendered this one because he wants to save his strength for next battle with David.

He is cleverly creating suspense and anticipation from the people. I didn't know what all things Blake told the admins, but they must enough to hyping the crowd this much. He continuous, and Charles did that because, he trails off a little, get ready for this everyone. Our Heraknus alpha wants to fight with his overdrive. How insane that is. The shocked people so much that a short while people stopped speaking. And then suddenly, the entire stadium burst into a hysteria.

You heard it right people. Charles has to save his Kuret to show us his full power. This created another round of buzz among the people. He laughs, I assure you, the second half is surely going to be even grandiose. He pauses, we will tell you everything in detail later once we go over few logistics. We will also answer all the questions people have in couple of days. So keep a lookout for our messages. He takes a step back and continuous, and with that I congratulate David for this stunning and unprecedent winning. He has shown something mysterious. But don't forgot Charles is coming for you with something even powerful. He is aiming to take that win away from you. He closes off by saying, and thanks everyone coming today. It was a truly great experience seeing so many people here. See you all next time.

People shouting reaches its peak with this. Reinhart pulls away his mike and hands to another admin. He speaks, all right everyone. Please wait for your designated officer at the exit. Officers, we will let you know the further

details later. For now, please guide people back to your assigned hideouts. Thanks you again. I see the security taking lead and guiding people towards the exit.

Finally, the tumultuous came to a close. People on the stadium might be enjoying this, but the atmosphere here was less joyous. The admins didn't know the whole thing with David. But none of us had forgotten. Kafar and Charles took their leave with few admins and went inside the building. Rinhart was speaking with rest of the staff people, giving them orders. I wasn't interested so drifted away from others, walking back. But then the VIP room people gathered around. Tessa asks, Marina what happened to David. Blake was vague about his condition.

I figured I at least listen this. I was mad at David, but I was also concerned when Blake talked about David. Marina looks over to Blake. They both shared a silent agreements of sorts. She tells others, he is fine. We got him into his nanobot chamber. She raised her wrist to show the watch, M said he is resting now. She takes a sigh then, but that guy was actually more exhausted than he was showing. Turns out he close to passing while Blake carried him to the infirmary.

Nathan smirks, figures. It was visible he was in a terrible shape. But was that really it. Matt asks, yeah. I swear, I saw him shaking a little bit. Catherine says, yeah, what was that about. I have never seen him like that. Blake clarifies, all fatigue guys. Like Marina said, he was so drained out, I was practically carrying him. I wonder though. He was already acting very differently before Blake escorted him out. Nathan asks, and what about that confrontation I saw between David and Charles just before they agreed on the deal.

The three of us who saw him didn't utter a word. It was really difficult to say since no one clearly knows what is going with David. At one point people looked at me as well. I wasn't going to give any answer here. Derek helps out for us, he got just excited to know not even the former crown couldn't beat Charles. I guess you can say he became overzealous. Catherine asks, so much that he agreed to fight with his overdrive? What was he thinking. Derek shrugged his shoulders not knowing the reason.

I had enough of this. Others were going to continue get info from us. Blake and Derek would be enough to tell them. I stepped back deciding to leave finally. I thought about visiting David later, but then decided against it. That freaking dickhead is completely off his bonkers. Being angry him doesn't even begin how I feel. Such recklessness makes me wonder if he got dumber by hitting his head. Marina said he is resting, that’s good enough for now.

Behind me Ned sneaked up to me, you are leaving. I didn't turn, instead said, yeah. That’s right. I don't have anything particular to say, nor do I need to know. I want to be alone right now for a bit. Ned didn't stop me. Instead he kept following me. Didn't he get what I am getting at. I said out flatly, that means you too. I don't want to talk to you also. So leave me. Ned didn't listen to me. I got irritated when he kept following me back in the corridor of the building.

I shout annoyed, I told you to leave me alone. Ned replies, we should talk. I understand you are upset with me, but I want to talk about… I cut him off. I don't freaking care. I am going back home. I don't have anything to say to you right now. So just leave me alone. My anger was spilling into my voice. Even Ned heard it and finally stopped following me. I was finally by myself, except of the usual staffs around me, I was able to get some alone time.

I have so many things to figure out. I don't know even if talking to David would help. Would he give me straight answers or not. I was left wondering what should I do now.

Blake (Chapter 40)

Sunday, September 7, 2025 22:38

Marina and I are staring at M's hologram screen. It shows David's heartrate slowing down. After two minutes she says, boss's vitals are under normal now. He just entered into REM sleep. Scanning for all the internal and external injuries. Programming the nanobots for epidermal reconstruction. I saw a red ooze flowing into the water. That's the nanobots I heard from David about. I had never seen them, only heard from him. The red bots begins to cover all the places where he is bleeding and bruised. Marina says, so its all good now, right.

I make a quick look all over the submerged water. Then turn my eyes to display screen hooked up to that tank. It showed a wired framework of Davids body. It was showing the nanobots seeping on the skin on his injuries. I couldn't begin to understand all the other details shown here. I say, I guess yes. So far I don't hear any alarm ringing. Marina tells me, you know this is the first time I have seen this in action. I have asked him so many times to check it out. And he just brushed me off.

I smirked hearing that, same here. The guy keeps too many things under wraps. I get that its his job and all. But at least he could trust us more. Marina scoffs, that's absolutely true. She turns to her wrist, and what was that about his PTSD. Care to share now? I too wanted to know and got closer to Marina. M speaks out, boss has been having sessions with Dr. Drew every other week. He has been diagnosed with PTSD, and other issues related to identity crisis, nightmare scares and mental health.

Holy shit. I can't believe what I am hearing. Marina curses a little asking, that's bullshit. Everyone was vetted for their physical and phycological state before they entered the tournament. I add on, that's right. PTSD is one of the thing we definitely check. M responds, boss had improved considerably and was believed that he cleared for it. Other symptoms were carefully masked to avoid detection. I reply, you mean he lied. M responds, its not a lie if one doesn't check for those symptoms.

This is ridiculous. I can't believe he has been participating despite with such a mental state. Marina overwhelmed asks, I don't believe this. Did you know about. I rebuked her, hell no. If I had, I would have asked him to drop out. I take a step back and put my palm on my forehead. I immediately recalled something that I had found odd. I ask Marina who was still a little shocked by this, do you remember he was reluctant in the beginning to join the tournament.

Marina thinks for a moment, yeah. Now that you mention, he said he won't do it. But then something changed and he join in the last week. I corrected her, actually he said that he can't, not won't. I think that was because of this. Marina asks, but then what changed. She turns to M, why did he join the tournament when he was clearly sick. M replies, boss initially didn't plan to join. However after a session with Dr. Drew, he decided to do it. I ask confused, I don't understand. Did the doctor told him to do it. M replies, I don't have their conversation recorded. Boss didn't want my decisions be effected by Dr. Drew's evaluations. I only the bare minimum. A therapy protocol was put in place that manages his symptoms.

I ask, explain how. M responds, using the bots in his body, I continuously monitor for early signs of PTSD or nightmare scares. Based on the situation, I implement a series of controlled medicines to help curb the symptoms. This very protocol was developed by the inputs from Dr. Drew to keep boss functional. Marina spats out, functional. Jeez. Seriously, didn't you just say he has been doing better. How bad was it before. M elaborates, boss has been in therapy ever since the war with the Hive leader.

Wait, hold on, I waived my hand, you are telling me he has been in therapy for a year. Marina shouts, how the hell no one knew. M responds, 10 months to be exact. And since boss was vital to the Island's infrastructure, he deemed it necessary to not have any weakness be exploited. I got a little angry at that, how is that a weakness. So many people in the Island have gotten psychological help. Sure, it would not be a good look for him. But how doesn't that make a threat for him. M responds, the issue is not that people finding about his diagnosis. The problem is how he is getting treated.

Marina shook her head, I don't understand. How is that a problem. M responds, for boss to get the best help, he had to divulge some sensitive information about his past. He has me running an ancillary protocol to monitor Dr. Drews activities to make sure they don't get leaked. Both of us were silent for a while trying to process this. I looked over to Marina. Once our eyes met, we had the same realization. David had to reveal some of his past, that includes his role in Shadow.

I was stunned. David had to become vulnerable to treat his illness. I finally understood why he kept it a secrete for so long. Marina had the same thought, so that means he told his doctor things. Secret things. M tells, correct. Keeping them a secret meant that boss had to keep his issues a secret as well. I let out a sigh, well. I wasn't expecting this. But I do understand. Marina clicks her tongue, I guess. Why not tell us about it. We would have kept it a secret. Did he thought we would just go gossiping about it.

I tell her, I agree. He put himself in risky situations despite knowing he could have a panic attack. M responds, actually boss hasn't had a panic attack for 4 months. Ever since he joined the tournament. I was flabbergasted to hear this. So he really was better then. Then what actually triggered him to relapse. I ask M, so then what happened. Why did he have one now. Is it related to Wagner. M responded, information restricted at current authority. I shook my head mumbling, I should have expected that. Marina instead screamed out, oh hell no. She shook her wrist in frustration.

M didn't respond. Marina got furious, I am not sure who I am mad at, this AI or the boss who doesn't share things with his friends. I understood her frustration. But I also know David. I tell her, you know how paranoid David is. It should not be a surprise he would keep something this personal from others. Marina wasn't calming down, but at least I think I made her realize this is how David does things. I ask M, what can you tell us. M responds, I don't have all the details. Marina spats out, even if you did, you wouldn't tell us. M responds, correct.

I gotta admire the M's consistency. She continuous, I can tell you that boss has had 18 sessions. All of them at Dr. Drews house, at 7 PM to 9 PM Wednesdays. The last one was 2 weeks before the deadline of joining the tournament trails. During those time, all the communications from and to the house are closed off. There are no records saved or new directives for me. Marina asks me, do you think this doctor can tell us more. I was actually thinking the same. I pulled out my phone and opened up the app that I have for accessing public information.

Marina leaned on the screen as I search for a Drew with the hospitals directory. That's odd. I went through it multiple times, but didn't find anyone with the name. Marina asks, hey. There is no one named Drew here. Don't tell me that name is an alias. M responds, no. Dr. Drew is her real name. I ask, but how do you explain this. I turned my phone to M that showed no results on my screen. A moment later M explains, Dr. Drew is not registered in the hospital directory. Both of us let out a confused, huh?

M explains, Dr. Drew is not a licensed therapist. At least not for Medrines. I realized what David did, he looked for a qualified human therapist. Since he is dealing with a psychological issue, best to reach out to someone who is a Medrone with experience with human brains. Marina scoffs, wow. That's, well, genius. I agreed with her. So I searched her for in the public records. Few seconds later I found the doctor. I read aloud, Drew Hains. A husband and two kids. Lives in 5th section. Has a background in psychology. Had a long career of neurosurgeon back in Medrine. Currently working as, what. I got surprised.

Marina asks, what. I clear my throat, she's a farmer now. Grows earth fruits that can mix with Kuret. She also works as part time nutritionist for some of the officers. She asks, really. Odd. Why isn't she working in the hospital now. With her skills, she would be more suited there. I scroll down to get more details, oh. I see. It says here the nerves on her joints were effected upon entering earth. She is only 45, but needs to walk with a cane now. So she can't operate on people. Marina replies, that will do it.

I scroll past reading some more her details, David got lucky. A professional therapist with knowledge of both Human and Medrone psychology. Plus she isn't working on a medical capacity, no one would suspect she is helping him. Marina replies, well, you said it your self. David does things very thoroughly. She then faces me, should we contact her then. I wondered if that was the correct thing to do. Marina picked up on my hesitance. She replies, look David allowed M to tell about this. He had to know for sure we would reach out to her. In fact, I bet he wants us to do that exactly. Otherwise why give us that information. He could have just easily kept it hidden.

She did have a point. We need her help. Actually David needs her help. He clearly hasn't gotten over his issues. I said, you are right. We can't do nothing here. David has to fight Charles in a month. We got 30 days to get him better. I would have liked him to drop this match entirely, but. Marina chips in, after hearing David I don't think he is going to back down. I know. We both knew there is no stopping this. Marina turns and looks to the wall on the other side, we should head back now. Need to bring down the barrier. M's hologram went back into the watch hearing her job is done.

Yeah, I said. We both took a once over to David's tank and walked out. We hurried back outside. Once out, all the admins were already on the ground. Reinhart came up to me asking, finally. What happened, is David okay. All the admin leaned on to the two of us. Marina told she would start working on taking down the barrier. I began telling others what happened between Charles and David. I also brought up that David fine, but right now in no condition to move. I kept a lid on many things when I told him the situation.

I knew it wouldn't be good idea to tell them everything now. I didn't tell any info about Charles history or the details of the deal he made with David. Nor that I had carry him out after having a panic attach. I only told him they plan to fight next month with Charles with this overdrive. When I revealed this, everyone got anxious. Anyone would be to know that there is another overdrive user. Reinhart asks me, I can't believe it. We have ourselves a 3rd overdrive user now. And David plans to battle him. Why.

I replied, they made a deal. I could tell, but its better if comes from Charles and Kafar himself. I knew that right now its better not to influence their decision with other details. I need them to conclude this match with David as the winner. Reinhart nods, I see. All right, I will talk to them later. Another admin asks me, so that means its true that Charles surrendered to save his strength then. I think others here told the admins parts of the conversation they heard before I came here.

I reply, yeah. That's right. The admin begin to speak amongst them to sort this development. Some kept asking me for more details, but I was not going to. I told them they should ask Kafar and Charles about that. It was good that Charles was the one who had brought up this deal, it meant they will be ones responsible for handling this chaos. Kafar was the one who kept Charles hidden and made him compete directly on the final match. I am more than happy to let him manage this.

After a rounds of back and forth discussion, Marrina brought the barrier. Once Charles and Kafar emerged from inside, they were bombarded with questions by Reinhart. Kafar still stubborn, kept trying to not declare David winner. But that's not going to happen. Charles had visibly signaled his surrender. No coming from that. Begrudgingly, he caved. When Reinhart asked me about David agreeing to how they plan to handle this, I didn't see any issue. But I couldn't tell if David would have been okay. Its not like he told us anything before passing out. Marina lied about David hoping he would understand. Lets hope so. Reinhart made the announcement and declared David the winner. He is good. He made it look David won, but only in this half event.

Charles didn't stick around long. As he walked away, he gave me look that made me curious. What that meant. Kafar and the admins were next go back inside the building. Other stick around pocking info from me and Marina. I thought I keep it vague, but Marina pretty much told the truth. Well, half truth about him passing out anyways. I was sure others were not fully convinced. But they didn't have any suspicion about his mental state. Tessa asks me, why didn't you tell about the deal between Charles and David.

I told her, that would create a lot of confusion. Especially among the Heraknus house. It would be better if it comes from their alpha's mouth directly. Tessa makes an understanding expression. I continue, plus I don't want to take chance of breaking Citradels trust in their secret champion. All they know that someone has been protecting them. Now that its revealed who it is, a mythical bloodline, they might only listen to them. If Charles comes through with his end of the deal to moving his house here, whether David wins or losses, we would have accomplished our objective.

Nathan says, that was a good call. We don’t know how Heraknus works, from what I heard, Charles word is final. Matt asks, what if others still don't follow them here. That isn't part of the deal right. I reply, yeah. Honestly, we will deal with when we get there. Right now we have to first wait for Charles decision. Cass asks, so suppose they do agree. When do you think they will come here. Derek cuts in, there are only 74 Heraknus. Not all are fighters, but each one is powerful. With such a small crowd, I think they can be easily transported here in secret in 2 days.

Marina says, yeah, but don't they have to pack up all their stuff. That would take time right. Citradel has built with many things catered to particular houses. I would know, since I was the who designed their place. Even if Charles manages to convince others, they won't be ready to move for a while. She pauses a while, best guess, they need about 3 weeks for complete transport. Matt asks, really. They have a lot of stuff. Derek nods, yeah. Unlike you all, we didn't had to move around at all. Heraknus have been given more amenities than others. Most of them can be re-created here, but they have their own armory and weapons. Some even I haven't seen. So yeah, it would take 3 weeks for them.

Catherine asks, I understand all that. But aren't you all forgetting one important thing. David needs to fight a overdrive Heraknus alpha. Charles is already powerful. Overdrive puts him ten times stronger. Whether its for one or ten minutes, that itself is dangerous. I would understand if were Blake or Marina against him. But David can die. All of us were aware of this. Its just all of us were trying not to say it aloud. The odds are not in Davids favor. Derek says, don't be so sure. During the second half, David was back in his feet and actually outsmarting Charles at every turn. With his new anti Kuret abilities, and on top of that that mysterious use of multiple kuret, he also became stronger.

Nathan shrugs, sure. If he gets the time to use it. Didn't you see that it takes him too long to create that kuret storm. Same with that Kuret armor. Charles knows about it now, no way in hell he will give David the chance to use it. I agreed with him, yeah. David had gotten lucky many times. I am not saying that it was only luck that got him the win, but he is not ready to use them in an actual battle. If he was in a war with Echo, he couldn't do any of this. Marina says, then he will just have to level up in the next 30 days.

What she said was the truth, but it was also very difficult. She knows David also has a serious mental issue. Recovering and training in just one month seems very unrealistic. Nathan says, well. That depends entirely on David. He faces me, when can we meet him. There are many things I want to ask him. And looks like others are also eager to know. Everyone waited for me. I thought about for a moment before replying, like Marina said, he passed out. And he will be unconscious for a while. He doesn’t have many injuries, but.

Nathan raises his arm, say no more. I am very well aware how long he takes to recuperate. He snickers, for a guy to be so powerful to go toe to toe against alphas, omegas, and terra, he spends a lot of time in hospital beds. I guess I will have to wait for him to wake up then. Shall we go, he asks Jess who takes his hands and began walking inside. Before he leaves Matt asks, hey. Hold on. You didn't forget about the bet right. You all lost. He points to all the people who had bet Charles winning. I honestly I had forgotten about it. With all the stuff going, only Matt would still care about it.

Nathan stops and just twists his neck with a smile, I didn't forget. The bet is still ongoing. Matt replied what in disbelieve. Didn't you hear, this is was just fist half event. David's a technical winner. He still has to beat Charles in the next event. With that technical loophole he and Jess walks away. Matt looks around us, he can't do that. Right guys. Cass says, well. He isn't wrong you know. He fists his hand, oh come on. I said, whatever. We can wait until then. Also, I like to tell you all one thing. Don't wait up for David. I don't want us to be hovering around his room outside. Marina will let us know when he wakes up. Until then, lets just do our jobs.

Marina raises her wrist to others to show M. Tessa says, I don't see a problem. I explain further, you can visit him anytime. That shouldn't be a problem. But don't stuck around for long. We don't want to create unnecessary worry to others. Especially to Kafar's people. I don't want them to get an impression that him not healing fast can become issue. He can use it to force Charles to back down or something that risks the Heraknus coming over. It’s a delicate situation right now.

Derek says, I hope you don't include Marina and me in those people. We actually want to move here. But you are right. That's a right decision. I actually also wanted to check on him now, but I suppose that can wait. He turns to Marina, let me know he is wakes up. Marina shows a thumbs up, you got it. He nod, okay. I think I should head back and help out Charles. Kafar and admins must be on him all over. I should help smooth things over. See you guys later. He waves us off and leave us next.

That prompts others to also leave. Tessa, Matt and Cass went together saying they are going to get lunch. Marina said she was going back home to rest up. She tells us that all the Kuret use exhausted her and will be skipping lunch. She gave a quick glance at me and then waves to her phone to me. I understood. She was going to reach out to Dr. Drew. I will check with her about it later tonight. Only Catherine was left here now. Wait, I didn't even realize that Vanessa was not here. When did she leave. Catherine saw me looking around, if you are looking for Vanessa, she left us after that announcement. I saw her leaving. Ned followed her also inside.

Hmm, those two were not on good terms right now. But no way am I going to ask them. I turn to Catherine. If I recall, she also has something going on with David. Since we were alone, I thought it was the best time to ask, hey. If you have time, I wanted to talk with you. But only if you are not busy. She took a while before responding, actually I have to go meet with some people at the logistics. I need to discuss about what to do with all the Citradels people staying in the Island. We were supposed to have a banquet for the winner tonight, but I don't think that’s going to happen. So I want to get ahead of this by making a plan to send them back to Citradel in case we cancel the event.

I reply, you know you don't need to do it right. Let the admins figure it out. She shook her head, no. I know many people from Citradel from back I used to spy on them. They have never found about me, so I can handle them much better then Reinhart or anyone else. You know very well that’s why I was given this role. I am the best choice. I understood that much better than anyone. I had assumed she was acting differently due to stress or something to with her job. But it doesn't look like that’s the case. So it really was just David. I replied, okay. I suppose later then.

She responds, I don't know how long I will be busy today, but I can spare some time tonight. Provided the banquet is cancelled. I replied, sounds good. She asks, what will you do now. You didn't go for lunch with others, so you also have some place to go. I nodded, yeah. I gotta also get ahead of this new development and tell our officers we might be getting Heraknus people over to our Island. Which means I have to set aside some land in the island for buildings and whatever else they want. I will wait for Derek to come out from his meeting with admins. If he can tell me more about Heraknus house, I can get the ball rolling. Unless you have any other insights to share about them.

She shook her head, sorry. I got nothing. Its embarrassing, but like I told before, I couldn't find anything about the secret warriors of Citradel. Kafar ran things so quietly and securely, I couldn't infiltrate deep parts of the city. He had rules and contingencies so tough, I would have gotten exposed if I tried. I said, its fine. I was just curious. Catch you latter then. She said bye and went away to the HQ.

Next few days will be busy. Especially for me. I contemplate on our future depending on upcoming days as I walk to the admin towers.

Blake (Chapter 41)

Tuesday, September 9, 2025 17:55

The day went very fast and very busy. I couldn't reach Kafar or the admins. They spent all morning inside the building. This is taking way longer than I imagined. I waited for 3 hours for them to come out. I tried to squeeze in, but Kafar didn't let me. The guards from Citradel told they are in an important discussion and I will be let in only when they want to. I could have forced myself in. But that would only slow things down. I was at least told by one of the admin that they plan to have an press release and broadcasted over the secured network everywhere. So instead I went to the dining building for a late lunch. By that time, almost everyone had left and only a skeleton crew were present.

Seeing me alone eating here, people kept asking what's happening. My answer was always the same. Wait for the admins to have an announcement. One of the dining staff told me they got an huge lunch delivery for the admin building. I realized that they will not be free anytime soon. No point in waiting for them after lunch. In the middle of my lunch, I got call from Marina. Hey, you busy. She was a little annoyed. I replied, just having late lunch. I was hopping to meet Derek, but he is tied up pretty hard. They have basically locked themselves inside. Not allowing anyone from Island. Not even me.

She scoffs, figures. You want me to check it out. I can bug the place. They will never know. To be honest, I was tempted. But I replied, thanks. But leave them be for now. I heard they will hold a press release tonight. So we can wait till then. If they still don't plan to share any information by 9 PM, then I am game.

As shadow operatives, getting intel is key for any situation. Marina replies, hmm. Okay. I took a sip of water and asked, any progress on David. Marina replies, no. He is still unconscious. I just checked 30 minutes back with M, he is recovering without any issues. All though, M mentioned dozens of people have visited him. I asked, anyone we should be worried about. Marina takes a pause, ah, doesn't look like. People from our inner circle, couple of officers from Citradel and some participants. M is monitoring the whole building just in case.

I will have to go over those list of people later. I took a quick glance around me to check no one was listening in and whispered, ask M when we can move David from the infirmary. After a while Marina realized what I was getting at, you think someone will sabotage him. Like how we were? I replied, potentially, yeah. If the match was over, we wouldn't need to worry. But its not. Someone drugged you and tried to drug me. All to influence the outcome of the matches to Citradel.

Marina hesitantly says, and they would have gotten away with it if not for David. Yeah, he needs to be secured. All the admins are only a mile away from the stadium building. Including Citradel people. Someone from Citradel can easily approach him while he is incapacitated. I reply, exactly. I didn't bring this up earlier because our priority was David's injuries and dealing with the matches outcome. Now, they both things are being handled, I think its better to turn our attention to Davids security.

Marina replies, I too didn't want to deal with that until now. I will ask M now if David can be moved. Hold on. Meanwhile I finish my lunch taking the last bite. It took a minute for Marina to unmute, good news. M says he can be moved. That device of his has treated David enough to be ready for transport. Although we should wait until night to move him. Its just in 3 and half hours from now. Dragging him in broad daylight would be risky. I on the other hand didn't want to wait, nah. I want to move him now. It might not be ideal, but waiting that long will be that much be riskier.

Marina asks, ah. Between the two of us, we can move him fast. But not undetectable. The security guards outside will surely know we took David out. Even if we sneak him out, they will know he is missing. I reply, leave that me. Catherine texted me a while ago, tonight's banquet is officially cancelled. So we can't have those guards anymore. I can tell them to help out with Citradel civilians staying in the guest buildings. Catherine needs the help anyways.

Marina replies, okay. Where should we move him then. Into one of homes among our shadow safehouses. I reply, no. If it were someone else than David, that would work. We want a place that is not Islands blueprints. Besides, none of those houses in the Island has the essential things David may need. She then asks, how about his place? I scoff at that, nope. If someone comes after him, that's the first place they would look for. Besides, his place doesn't have sufficient security. I heard Marina smirking a little, I didn't mean his decoy place. I jerked a little sitting on my chair. What. I shrieked. Marina chuckles a little, look. Do you really think he stays in that abysmal place.

This is news to me, how do you know about his actual place then? She replies, I am the best architect he knows. I gave him the designs with all his requests. I am sure he would have added his own personal changes and beefed up the security. And we wouldn't have to worry about security, because no one knows about it. I shook my head a little, why am I hearing about this just now. I swear I could hear Marina's smiling, you know how it is. All of us has their own shared secrets. Like how we both share some secrets, I am sure you share with David too.

I sighed a little. She wasn't wrong. I reply, that’s how we operate, true. But I doubt we have anything secret from David. It wouldn't be a surprise if he knew about. Marina cuts me off and shushes me, not over the phone dummy. M is totally listening. And come on, we can keep a secret, even from David. Don't crush my hope. I wasn't buying it though. Marina and I have been covertly pulling it off during the tournament, but David must have sniffed it out somehow.

I say, anyways, his place is the best option for now. Obviously we have to make sure no one follows us. Where is it and how far from the stadium. At that question Marina felt silent. What happened now. You there, I ask again. She replies, the problem is I don't know where it is now. I snicker, how is that possible. Didn't you say you designed his house. I bet that would mean knowing the topology of the area, coverage, everything. Marina sighs, I know. Actually, when I said his house is on the island, I wasn't being accurate. His place is on the edge of the Island, almost standing on the side like those Human houses in Florida.

I don't understand, I replied. If you know where it is, then why don't you know. She hesitated a little and then explains, well. For a paranoid guy like David, he built his house in such a way that it can't be detected and also be the first to know any threats from the sea. Only one option works. When designing his house, he wanted to be a fortress that can submerge into water, travel inside the sea and relocate itself. I let out a audible scoff from my mouth hearing this. Are you serious, he lives in a submarine?

Marina laughs, no. Its actually a two floor house, 5 rooms, 2 bathrooms, a kitchen, a dining area, hall, gym, open yard and training room. I hope she was joking. But she wasn't done, oh yeah a swimming pool also. I pull up my handing jaw, freaking David. How the hell did he build it? Actually when did he even built it. Marina replies, I have only visited once, after it was finished almost a 5 months from now. As to how he built it, he was vague about it. So I can only assume he used his criminal contacts. I have been itching to visit again and marvel at by beauty. But never got a chance, until now.

I was amazed that David had kept his actual home a secret this long. I had a million more questions, but tabling that for now. I ask, if you don't know where it was, then does M know. Marina pulls out from the call and I hear her muffled question to M. After few seconds she came back on, freaking AI. She won't tell us. I gripped my fist a little frustrated, how the hell are we going to find it. And even if do find it, I doubt we will be just enter without David's authorization.

Marina takes few seconds and says, I have idea. I know of a way we can find the location and allow us to enter. I asked in disbelief, and how will you pull that off. She replies, just trust me. Its better you don't know. You can ask David later, if he wants to. It was a little annoying not being in the know. Then I realize me and David have also kept few things from Marina. Ever since David got his memories, we have started to do things like how we used to back in Medrine. Getting back into all this secrecy and still being friends is a hard balance to keep now.

I relented, how long will that take. Marina replies, I need about an hour. I will text you the location once I get it. I cut in, no message. Lets not keep any digital trail of his location. Even if its only temporary. Instead lets meet back at infirmary in 90 minutes. I will figure out the rest by then. Marina says, got it. See you later. I was about to close the call, but then she spoke again, oh wait. One more thing. I need you to visit the doctors house. I asked curious, what happened.

She explains, after getting some rest I messaged her asking we need her help with a mutual friend. She didn't reply to any of my messages. So I directly went to her house, but she claims to know nothing. I tried to let her know that its was fine since David let us know, but she acted like she didn't have any contact with any of my friends. She said she doesn't trust me. Can you believe it. Me. I get I from Citradel, but come on. I have fought with you all many times now. How can she just close the door saying she can't help me. That explains why she was annoyed in the beginning.

I said, don't take it personally. She is not licensed therapist, she doesn't want to get into trouble. David must have told her not to say anything to anyone. Did you show M to her. Marina replies, I did. She said M only said her name, nothing in detail. Basically accused me of fabricating the whole thing. I chuckle, figures. A patient who loves secrets needs someone who has same inclinations. Let it to me, after we drop off David, I will visit her. She might be more open to me. Marina says, let her know she can trust me too. Before I can speak a word, she closed the call with the same annoyed tone.

I can imagine why she wanted to accepted. With Heraknus relocation, some Citradel people are guaranteed to move here as well. Among their top people, her, Derek, June and the alpha twins must have plans already. We already have plans to make the transitions smoother and less disruptive. But nothings perfect, we will have problems like this from now one. From both side of the cities.

After cleaning up, I head to my officers building. Everyone here is busy with todays work. I heard people talking over the phones discussing about the tournament. Just as I took the stairs on the 3rd flood, Luther approaches me from behind. Hey Blake, where have all this time. He was in a tiff and was carrying an iPad with him. I told him about my successful attempt to meet Derek. Luther's expression hardens up, whoa. Not even you could get in. I asked, yeah. I didn't want to force myself. Not yet anyways. So I believe no has any contact with them as well.

He nods. I reach my office and stepped in. He says, its been such a chaos. I took my chair and pulled to the table, yeah. It certainly is. He continuous, if you were there all this time, then you heard they are going to announce their decision tonight. I open my laptop and it pinged with too many times. I turned my notification off to avoid hearing the dizzying number of messages. Ah, I can't deal with them right now. I turn down he lid immediately. I face him, yeah. I heard. I don't suppose anyone found out more.

Luther takes a seat and opens his iPad screen, actually we got another piece of information after lunch. Color me surprised, what is it. He replies, they will be calling some of the Heraknus people in the admin building. I don't know when. But soon. I lean back to the chair thinking it over. He asks, but you don't look surprised. Of course I knew why they called him. Charles deal with David works only if he can convince them to move here even before the next match. I tell him, I know why. But I don't rummers to spread.

Luther was a little tense. I wanted to ease him a little bit, don't worry though. It's not problem. They are being called for just a discussion. Luther replies, its not that. Its just. He hesitates a little, I can't believe Heraknus are real. I thought they were just myths. They weren't just hiding on Medrine, but on Earth too. And if David wins, they will be living here. Its just, um, overwhelming. He wasn't the only one. Many people approached me since I left the stadium. They all have varying emotions. Some fear, some worship. I bet there are some people who might not even care that much.

I assured him, I am sure everyone is anxious to say the least. But once everyone meets them, it will lessen their worries. Look on the positive side, we will be that much powerful against Echo and Humans. I didn't want to stress him by telling Heraknus are moving immediately. Luther wasn't satisfied, but he didn't pursue it more. He asks, how is David though. You carried him out. Is he okay. I replied almost mechanically given how many times I have been asked, he is fine. Contrary to his composure, he was about to pass out. He should wake up soon. This has been my response to everyone. And so far no one has questioned it considering who he fought for so long.

I continue, since you are here, I want you to pull the stadium security out from their duties. The tournament is over. No matter what decision we get from admins tonight. Luther questions, why. Shouldn't we keep him secure. Especially since there are attempts of sabotage earlier. I reasoned, we don't want to show weakness right now. The longer he remains there, the admins might start to think he suffered too much injuries. What if somehow they decide not to have the next match. We need to achieve our main objective, getting every Medrone move to this Island. I don't know who will win, but we shouldn't give any reason for them to not have the match.

Luther leans back pondering over his thoughts. I waited for him to realize the importance. He finally spoke, it would be bad if they cancel the match all together. And you are right. Keeping David tied to infirmary wouldn't look good on him. I continue, so you understand. Convince everyone who is managing the staffs to redirect people to Citradel guest housing, at least for tonight. He nods and taps the screen, I will talk to them soon. What about David, I talked to someone who visited him. He isn't even awake. Are you planning to wake him up or move the entire tank. I answered, don't worry about that. I got it covered. Just tell everyone he no longer needs security around 4 PM. No need to mention about his condition. Let people believe he woke up and left.

Luther was clearly confused. I didn't want to give him or anyone hints where we are planning to move him. He might have deduced a little that I had a secret plan. So he offered, do you need any help. I shook my head, I already have it. Thanks anyways. He probably thinks that I was going to use some shadow trick. It won't be that complicated. He says, okay. Lets talk about information control. We are getting swamped with calls and people straight up showing here using their kuret and demanding to know what's happening. The overall concern is whether Citradel going to move here or not, you know since David still won.

I knew I would have to deal with this now, what options do we have. He explains, we can say we don't know. No risk, but vague as hell. We say talk to Citradel because their so called champion surrendered. Not vague, but shows less confidence. We can tell the truth that we are waiting for tonight's announcement from the admins. Completely true, but can't explain why they didn't tell people themselves. If we had more details on what happened at the end of the match, we could it handle much better.

I replied, trust me. If I explain what really happened and then later something else is claimed by the admins, it will just create chaos. That’s why I haven't told anyone and waiting to see what they say. I thought about the best course of action. I don't want people to spread rumors based off little pieces of information. But not telling anything is also not an option. I told Marina we would wait till 9 PM. Thats still 6 hours away. Too long to wait without telling people anything.

I wanted to know one thing before we come up with a plan, tell me something. What are the Citradel people who are not in the admin building doing right now. He thinks for a bit and answers, most of them are back in their assigned guest houses. The remaining are roaming around with Island people, probably checking out the place. He then looks back to the hall, a handful of them are here. They are cooperating with us and helping out with some logistics. But if are thinking to ask them, its not going to work. They don't know anything.

I waived my hand, no off course not. I wanted to know if there are more Citradel people out in the streets. I got up from my chair and paced around thinking over it. I really didn't want to reveal any new information to the public. We could tell people there is some sort of deal between David and Charles. But that’s clearly the wrong move here. That would just spark more rumors. Then I had an idea that seems pretty obvious, but still effective. I turned to him, I may have a solution.

He listened in to my explanation and then just remained silent. I wanted his opinion on this plan. After a while he says, that is certainly a way. People don't want to just hear from us, they want to know the truth. If we do this just right, it will help us do actual work and at the same time pressure the admins to hurry up their discussion. It certainly doesn't hurt that none of our representative is there with them. He smiles then, you know, it might actually work. At the very least people will back off from us and instead focus solely on Citradels and Admins.

Glad it made sense to him. This is a good diversion for us to move David out. If everyone's focus is somewhere else, then it will be much easier. With a precise timing, no will know about it. Luther got up from his chair, lets do it. He was enthusiastic about it now. I guess he was stressing it too much. I tell him, lets work out a plan with whoever is here right now. Lets also involve as many as Citradel people we can get.

Luther agreed with it, yeah. I will reach out those who are roaming out. If we can get the top fighters, that would help sell this. He must have made connections with some of them. I tell him, go on ahead. I will be right behind you in a minute. He hurries out to enact the plan. I took out my phone. No messages from Marina. So she isn't ready yet. It was 3:00 right now. Still have a hour till we move David. I decided it would be best to involve them right now. They can help out with the plan. I messaged them with their tasks.

Vanessa (Chapter 42)

Wednesday, September 10, 2025 17:49

When I wanted alone time, I was serious. But people didn't leave me alone. Some congratulated, and some asked it Citradel is going to move here. I am in no mood to explain anything. I kept telling them to talk to the admins for details. One lady asked if I heard what the deal was since I was with them. I got irritated and told her I was just there to help out. She was clearly surprised me reacting like this, but I didn't care. I thought of going back home. But then the neighbors might see me and might bothering me. I wanted a nice quite place.

The only place I could think of was my office. No one would be there right now. At least not for few hours. So I took a trolly ride to the center of the Island. Even in the trolly, some people asked for details. A guy asked me what was David's condition. I didn't answer. Hearing his name was triggering me a lot right now. I didn't want to think about that selfish bastard. Somehow I managed to arrive without loosing it. The door wasn't open, good. No one is here. I scanned my wrist at the door and head to the 2nd floor.

Its eerie to see empty rooms. Its always so busy. I got to my room, locked the door and slumped into my chair. Then finally I let out a loud shout. My fist tighten as I slam it on the table. My kuret leaked out a little and fire came out. It left scorched marks on the table where my fist struck. I am not done yet. I let out another shout filled with Kuret. A gust of wind circled around me and shuffled the stuffs in the room. I am breathing becomes ragged now. This is bad, I thought being alone I what I need right now. I am actually spiraling more. I don't want to leave.

A minute late I finally settle down. I let out air from my mouth to cool down. I pull back my kuret. I close my eyes and lean back. I felt better now. Everything that happened with Ned and David angered me so much. I can't believe I was holding it in this long. I really didn't want to think about them. But I couldn't stop. I spoke aloud, why the hell is Ned behaving like this. Ever since the two week flag capture game, he is active differently. Sometimes he only focuses on me, other times he acts like he doesn't want to do anything with me.

Maybe it's my fault. No, I chided myself. Its both our fault. I am so confused, I couldn't understand what exactly caused us this. I shouldn't have been so much bothered for him betting on Charles. That can't be then. I tried recalling any other bad memories, but I got nothing. None would sour our relationship this much. I got frustrated and kicked the side of the table. I can't believe I am like this. This is not me, I don't get stressed by a thing like a relationship issue. Of all the things I thought I couldn't handle, this wasn't one. Give me dozens of Echo any day to fight over this.

And there's David. Without realizing, I kicked the table legs again. Honestly, without any kuret, it should have stung. I hardly felt. I can't even think about his right now without getting angry. I pleaded him numerous times not to overdo it. But now he is risking his life for fighting alone such a enormous foe. Not only that, I he hiding something about Wagner. Huh. Thinking about him made me realize I still have things about Wagner I didn't know about. He fought Charles before and actually can overdrive. I can't believe he never told me this. We were closer than our parents, and yet he didn't tell me. Why.

I don't know how long I was fiddling around in here. Could have been 5 minutes, or maybe an hour. I heard knocks on my door. My eyes widen on hearing someone is here. I called out, whoever it is, leave me the freak alone. The voice on the other side said, its me Vanessa. It was Siera. What's she doing here. And how did she find me. I stagger a little trying to find an excuse, I am busy right now. Come later. She responds, no you are not. There is no one in the building, and I don't hear you listening to any messages.

I gritted my teeth, I am no mood to talk right now. Just leave me. I didn't want her to see me like this. I thought she would leave if I persisted. But she didn't, would it have to do anything with Ned. My body jerks out a little. When I didn't respond, she says, I got a call from Ned. He sounded worried and told me a little about your fight. I understand you want to be left alone. So I will leave, but not before knowing you are okay.

Dammit. Why did he go and do that. I didn't for a little while. I could just wait it out, but she would just stand there until someone comes in the building. I relented and got up to open the door. As expected she had a concerned look on her. I waved my hand to not come inside. I ask her, how did you find me. She replies, I went to our house. When I didn't see you there, I figured you would come here to be alone. I shook my head at my naivety thinking no would bother me here.

I say, well, now that you have seen that I am okay, you can leave. I hold the door. She slammed the door with her arm instead. I rebuked, what are you doing. She replies, I said I would leave if were okay. That meant mentally too you know. I got angry, I don't have time for this bullshit, okay. I am fine. I forced the door, but she pushed back. She wasn't backing down, that was the very definition of being NOT okay. Let me in and we can talk. I really didn't want to. But what's the alternative, shove her out. I finally caved in and let her in.

I didn't even bother to close the door as I went back to my chair. Siera closes the door and sats on the other side of my table. She just silently sat there. I knew she would be doing this. Every time she and I had a problem, she would just stare in silence until it becomes too awkward. Her interrogation is pretty much natural to me. So I also stayed silent. I just closed my eyes and lead back. A minute went by like this. The probably 5 minutes. I know she has patience, but I have learned from her. So we continue to be like this.

Then it was maybe 20 minutes at which I couldn't take anymore, okay. You win. Lets talk. I swear I could see a small smirk on her. I say, I just had a fight with Ned. She folds her arm and asks, I know its obvious to state, but this is probably the first time I have seen you having a guy problem. And not just any guy, your old crush and then boyfriend. I could feel she was having fun. I let out a sigh, believe me. This is first for me too. She nods, over the years, I have heard all sorts of arguments, how to best ambush Echos, or evade Humans. Even making right decisions in full wars. It was inevitable you would have problems over your boyfriend.

I didn't like how she was expecting this to happen. But to be frank, I was also anticipating it. How I would feel or handle our first big fight. Seeing I was not being open she asks first, so who did what. I answered, obviously its his fault. I blurted out immediately. Without a lack of details after few seconds of silence, she crooks her neck. I was really uncomfortable talking about it to my mother. I hesitantly said, he wasn't siding with me on something. Then treats me like I don't take his side. He also ignored me several times. I had a bunch of other feelings, but I could only manage this much for now.

Siera couldn't hide her surprise, really. I can't picture Ned doing something like this. It felt really good hearing someone else saying it. I reply, yeah, I can't believe it too. He really got a bug up his ass about something. She asks, okay, about what. I screamed, I really don't know. He has been acting little different ever since the capture flag game. Whenever I ask him, he says its nothing big deal. She unfolds her arms and rests her them on the table, that’s hard to believe. He is always so composed.

I know, I responded. I never knew I needed to voice out my insecurities out loud. Siera leans to me a little, shouldn't you confront him about this. It seems you have been wondering this for a while. Of course I wanted to. But then with all the stuff that happened during the match with David, I have been basically avoiding it. I really tell about David as well. His recklessness is eating at me. But I kept my mouth shut about him. It would complicate things with her right now. Siera sighs, avoiding will only make it worse. I know you know what I mean.

I reply, I do. Believe me, I don't want to be like this. Its just, hum, I had to deal with other stuff. It became harder for me to deal with Ned. But I will. I have to. Just not now. There wasn't any meaningful progress, but it felt good to say it out loud. She picked up on me easing a bit, take your time. But do it right. Ned is a good guy. And he is has been good to you. Lately you have been more open and happier. Just a year ago, we would never talk about such things. You are also making efforts to be more social. So give him a chance to explain before you do anything.

I was silent. I knew she meant well. I was a little embarrassed though. Sure, Ned has been good to me. But he wasn't the one who made me open. It was the other freaking guy I was mad at. David and I have become a lot closer since the war. I didn't want to read too much into it so I stopped myself. I tell her, I will. Ah, I am little bit okay now. I guess I just needed to be heard. She nods, trust me. That’s all someone needs. She leans away and relaxes. She continuous, glad I could help out. I replies, thanks.

She raises her hand, come on. I still worry about you know. No matter how powerful you become. I was genuinely glad Siera came first to talk to me, anyone else and I would have just resisted more. She got from her chair, now come on. Lets go for lunch. I am hungry. You must be too. I was. I replied, can we cook and eat something at home. I want to avoid dealing with others right now. I got up and walk with her. She says, whatever you need. We both left my office and headed out.

On the way out of the building she asks, lets walk then. It will take more time, you good with that. I nod, yes. I don't have any stuff after lunch. I do have a meeting later in the evening with Citradel security guys. We were supposed to discuss the banquets security with Derek and his crew. Siera says, didn't you hear, Kafar, Charles and Derek have been in the admins building and not allowing any of us inside. I think its safe to assume plans may have changed.

I didn't know that, I replied. I took out my phone and saw bunch of messages from people. I cleared them and searched for our secure channel network. I tell her, there was no mention of any change of plans yet. But it can change anytime I guess. We passed through people walking on the streets, but now that I was with Siera, none approached me directly. Then I suddenly realized something, how come you didn't ask me anything about the final match. Others have been up my ass.

She laughs, its obvious you don't want to talk about it. So I figures why ask. I was glad she was concerned but I was feeling a lot better now. I reply, only when its from others. I know you are dying to know somethings. Just ask. I scoff a little thinking she must be waiting for me to suggest it first. She glances at me and nods, well, since you asked. How was talking to Charles like. I heard stories about Heraknus, but I never thought they were real. I got way to excited and shoved others beside me.

I chuckle at that image, he seems nice. A normal guy when he isn't using his Kuret. Actually, he was so chill, he starting giving us some advice and answered our questions. Siera head turns suddenly, in the middle of a match. Damn. I would so like to meet the guy. Actually any Heraknus will do. I reply, don't except too much. After talking with him, I get a feeling we have made them a myth. They are ordinary people. Well, aside from the fact they remain hidden for centuries. In fact, they have lot of weaknesses you know. She shrieked, what. He told you his weakness.

I laugh her constant surprised looks, he didn't have a choice. David forced out his weaknesses out of him, using Ruby's kuret of all things. That was the point from which Charles began to pivot to that insane deal. Siera asks, yeah, speaking of which, how in the bloody hell can he use others Kuret. That move basically turned the whole match upside down. I wondered when she was going to ask that, I have no clue. He says he used Human and Medrone knowledge.

What does that mean, she asked. I shook my head, he used math and science to capture Kuret in his anti-Kuret. And then somehow use others Kuret. Don't ask me how because he didn't tell me. He was being careful because others were listening in. She was totally bamboozled, that’s unbelievable. So he can use any Kuret? That’s beyond what Marina could do. I corrected her, not every Kuret. Derek figured it out that David can't control those Kuret, he can only aim and shoot. That’s why he copied some specific kurets. And well some unknown ones.

Wow, she was now completely impressed. She says, no wonder he still wants to fight Charles with his overdrive. Even his kuret took a different form. I thought he was done becoming stronger, but he is nearly on an reaching for omega level. She takes a pause before saying, gosh. As one the few people who known him the longest, I can't believe the same guy who you knocked out by a single punch. He is now fighting omegas and

sigma.

I wish I shared her joy. She didn't know the whole story about the next match. I didn't want to tell her about it, because then we would have to talk about it. I want to avoid that as much as I want to avoid talking about Ned. We talked some more about the match, filling in some details, David and Blake trying to spy on Charles, our bet, the barrier braking and the loophole to save Charles. It was a long walk, but it was good breather. We reached our apartment around 1:30 PM.

Once we stepped inside, she asks me, now I understand what you meant you had deal with so many stuff. This morning was full of chunk full of excitement. I bet everyone watching from outside the Island must find it intriguing to say the least. Do you think that will be enough from them to move to Citradel or here. I shrug, we certainly hope so. I heard the views were more than expected, so at least that's good news. Just then I got a ping on my phone. I read the message aloud, admins are going to give an announcement tonight. Siera asks, that's all it says. I nod. She continuous, at least now we have something to look for now. She walks over to the kitchen, lets table that discussion for now. What are you in the mood for.

I was actually okay with anything. We had to decide on few options from our limited stalk of foods. By the time we were nearly done cooking, an hour went by. Around then I decided to see any new messages on my phone. I peaked on the screen from the counter. Siera asks, any update. I read the message and told her, you called it earlier. Catherine messaged. Tonight's banquet cancelled. She says, what now. You had a meeting with Derek right. That's still on then?

After reading another message from someone in the officers building I tell her, looks like that's also not happening. The admins are still in the building with the Citradel people. Including Derek. One of our people says that they even ordered lunch to their place instead of going out. Pretty sure that means its long to be a long day. She asks, then you free till tonight. I reply, not exactly. Catherine might need my help organizing security around the Citradel guest houses. We had plans for security of the banquet, but now its going to be early night guard shift for the entire night. I will meet up with her later.

With that update, I was at least free for couple of hours. We took our time leisurely eating lunch. We cleaning our dished when I got another message around 3 PM. I read it aloud, few people from Heraknus house are being summed to the admin building. Siera keeps the plate down and asks, huh. That's wired. Why are they being called in. She was expectedly confused. But I knew exactly why. She caught how calm I was about this news. You know something about it, don't you.

When I didn't answer, she got her answer. I understand, she says, its something you can't share right now. I replied, its not that I can't share. But its you. Just for today, promise to not share anything I am about tell you. She nods curiously, of course. I won't. I waved her to sit on the dining chairs knowing it will take some time. Just then I told her everything. All the details of the deal between David and Charles. The risks involved for David with Charles dangerous overdrive.

Siera was visibly shocked to hear this. After finally listening to entire story she scoffs, what the hell David was thinking taking on such dangerous gambit. Being locked in with a uncontrollable overdrive user. Did his new abilities made him arrogant. I clicked my tongue, that's exactly what happened. I told you what happened when the barrier broke, right. Ever since then he has become extremely single minded about winning. I have never seen such a look on him. He was being full of himself and not caring about risks. No matter how much I pleaded to see reason, he wouldn't listening. After a while, I gave up. Maybe I should have kept trying, but then something changed.

She waited for me to continue. I swallowed a little hard, David has some connection to Wagner. She shouts, what. How. I reply, I don't know. I didn't get a chance to ask him. But the second Kafar mentioned that even Wagner couldn't beat Charles, he flipped out. His attitude changed. It looked pale, like he saw a ghost. He immediately accepted the deal once he heard. Siera asked confused, hold on. Wagner fought Charles. He knew that Heraknus were real?

I added, And he lost, even with his own overdrive. Siera couldn't believe, just like I couldn't when I heard it. She asks, his overdrive. Your brother could do it too. I waved my hands in the air, yeah. Add to the list of things he never told me. She was lost of words. She was quietly thinking over it. A while later she spoke, look likes you avoiding to talk to Ned makes sense now. You wanted to time to think over so many things about David and Wagner. I held head on my palms, now you understand what I have been dealing with. Others weren't that much shocked about Wagner, and I don't blame them. But I am a mess. I keep thinking why didn't he tell me.

Siera offers, maybe he couldn't tell you those things. I rebuke, maybe about Heraknus. But why hide he could overdrive. Overdrive users are celebrities. What possible reason he could have that he never told anyone. Siera asks, I have no idea. Wish I knew. I straightened out, I'll tell you what, there is one guy who would know. Its David. If he was close enough to my brother to know about his fighting, he must know more. I'll will get it out of him.

I eased down a bit before I got any angrier. She twitches her mouth, perhaps. Though he is still unconscious for now. I asked, you saw him. She says, not exactly. The guards didn't allow me in. But I spoke to Cass and Matt who did on the way out. You didn't go. I looked away, I didn't want to. I heard he was not in any serious condition. That's enough for now. She says, so you mad at him as well. I rebuked, can you blame me. He kept all those things from me.

Seira didn't have anything to say to me. She just looks at me with pity. We both shared a heavy silence. I dumped a lot of things on her. I felt a little guilty and I finally say, I didn't mean to push all my mess to you. Siera waves, oh no. Don't worry about it Vanessa. You needed to talk to someone about this. She takes a moment to ask, who all knows about what's really happening on the Admins buildings. I told only the people from VIP room. She tells, so you don't want to tell anyone about this until tonight's announcement.

I nod, yeah. Blake must have not been able to meet Derek. And since he or anyone else haven't messaged anything about the deal, it must be to keep from creating confusion. She says, and that's the right decision. If Heraknus really decide to move, then I am sure all the Citradel will move. I got curious on how confident she was, you think so. We were skeptical about it. She chuckles, that's because you were sitting in a room and not outside. Until the half time, every Citradel were fanatic about Heraknus being their secret warriors protecting all this time.

I guess seeing peoples first hand reactions would change your view. She continues, I have no doubt in my mind that Citradel people will be heavily swayed by their decision. Even if people get mad at them to have made decisions on their own, they will still follow them anywhere. David took a completely risky deal, but it was worth it. Seeing me so quite she hesitated, no I meant, it's still reckless. I am not denying that. But… She was trying to back out of her own words. I stopped her though, its not lost on me that those conditions were too tempting. Our only objective was to bring people here. Honestly, if I was in his position, I would have taken it too.

She looks at me strangely, then why are you so mad at him about this. She caught me red handed. Me and my big mouth. I was definitely being hypocritical here. Actually I have known all along, just been avoiding it like everything. I couldn't answer her. Mostly because I didn't know how I could explain. Some of it was unclear to me. The only thing I was sure that I am angry at him. I didn't care about anything else.

With no answer I though she would prod me more she backed down, I hit a nerve. Sorry. I won't ask about it. She is being considerate of me. And yet I didn't know how to a handle such confusing feelings.

Vanessa (Chapter 43)

Thursday, September 11, 2025 21:05

Siera and I decided to go on a run a while later. It was the only thing we could do after the awkward atmosphere we had at the house. A much needed benefit was I needed a distraction and burn off my anxiety. We covered our usual trail along coast. Honestly, it helped me more than I thought. I appreciated Siera's suggestion very much now. We talked more about on the possibility if Citradel people moving here. We already had big plans, but to go over them felt now a reality. We talked about using there technology to improve the Island. We have very little tech help and still rely heavily on manual chores. Using the Citradels Medrine developed infrastructure would help us get back some of our heritage back.

On the way back I spoke to Catherine around 6:00 PM. I hung up after talking with her. Siera asks, they need you. I shook my head, nope. Looks like she got help from Blake. We got some more people from the stadium security team to fill out extra shifts. Still, we are going to use the reserve people, but at least for tonight we are all set. We agreed to meet at 8:00 PM and assign people to guest houses. But what happens tomorrow is yet to be decide.

Seira mentions, the officers building must be in mess right now. We were supposed to take a poll tonight from the losing city on who all wants to move. And the same with all those scattered people around the world. So much planning is now at risk. I also believed we are at a critical point. But then I remembered something Catherine said, actually no one is there in the officers building right now. Its completely empty. Catherine visited a while back and no one was there. Siera looked surprised, really. Why. You still have work after lunch right. I answered, yes. We all had work to finish after 3:00 PM. Mine was cancelled, but others still have jobs. Maybe Blake gave them day off since there is actually nothing to until admins announcement.

Siera questions, unlikely. You didn't get any messages, right. I periodically checked my phone. Nothing new. I didn't even get any update on the Heraknus visit. All I knew for sure that admins are still in discussion. I don't know what's taking them this long. They had all afternoon and still no updates. Its starting to get concerning. I reply, I hope Blake is trying to get in touch with them. He might be only one to force himself inside and actually get to stay. Siera wonders about it a little, he certainly has the right to do. Or maybe something else is keeping them from reaching a decision. It could be other reasons, we have been talking about it little all our run and still couldn't nail anything for sure.

It was becoming dark by the time we reached our house. When we came into its view, there were few people in front of the house. They all wore orange stripped clothes. Citradel people. Three big guys and a women were almost lurking around. They looked almost bodyguards. When we came closer, I was sure they were actually bodyguards for the women. They had her surrounded in a triangle formation. Siera asks me, are we expecting someone. I said, no. I was clueless as her.

Its not uncommon to see people here with bodyguards. That’s usually for someone important. As soon as we were in their view, the nearest guard motioned the women to us. She took step in front of us. She was in her early forties, a dark hair pulled into a pony tail. She smiled and somewhat relieved to see me. Once I saw her clearly, I realized she wasn't anyone I know. I whispered Siera, I have never seen her before. Siera understood and follows me behind as a precaution. The women speaks, Good evening. I am sorry to disturb you. I am Melinda. Nice to meet you. She very polite and her voice had a smoothing tune. Clearly she must be some sort of high echelon of Citradel.

I replied, evening. Are you looking for someone. I directly asked her. She nods, yes. I came to speak to you. Can I take a little bit of your time. She then turns to Siera and says, in private if possible. I told her, this is Siera, my guardian. What's this about. She replies, I am sorry. Its really a private matter. Trust me, I understand how it seems like. Please, I will explain once its just the two of us. I wondered what this could be about. I don't know anyone from Citradel who would want something from me. I looked at Siera for a little help. She was looking at the woman and then the guards. In a calm and relaxed tone, she then turns to me and says, its okay Vanessa. These people are legit Citradels. The dress and those Kuret insignia can't be faked. I will go head to the nearest ship and get something to drink while you guys talk.

I relaxed hearing this and asked her, are you sure. She nods, yes. Let me know when you are done. She waves her phone and walks away. I turn back to Melinda and show her the way in, all right. This way. She replies, thanks. Please, you all can stay outside. The guards keep out and spread out around the apartment walls. I scanned my wrist and door opens. We both step inside and wait at the dining room. I felt she was some higher class lady so I asked, I am sorry I don't have anything in terms of drinks. Is water okay.

She waves her hand, thank you child. I am fine though. She glanced around the house, you have a nice house. Its my first one standing inside a house in this Island. I sighed, its not much. I know. Me and Siera don't need much, we have gotten used to keeping light stuff. But if you want to see really good places, you should visit Nathans place. Out of all the us, he has the most lavish house. I mumbled, a little too ostentatious for my taste. I still can't believe Blake and David let him a house like this. If it were up to me, he should be lucky to have a place with roof.

She didn't see my hidden smirk and says, its still good. With all the stories I heard about you all these years, I could image your house would be like military, functional. She wasn't wrong, but it still stung. At least she is honest. I asked her, please sit. I offered her the dining chairs. She take one and I take the other one. So, I ask, what can I do for you. She clears her throat and takes a serious tone, I want your help with something. It was a little curious she approaching at my home and not at the officers building. She did say earlier it’s a private matter.

She continuous, I have to talk to David. But I can't seem to find him. Do you know where he is. Wait, what. My body tenses up hearing about this. I lean towards her, what do you mean. David's at the infirmary. People have visited him. She shook her neck, no. That was a while ago. I went myself there about 30 minutes ago and he is not there. Then I want to your officers building to talk to Blake, but the place is closed. I am not sure what's going on admins building with the rally, but I can't find anyone there. Its too crowded. And with no options left, I decided to visit you here.

Huh, there's a rally around the admins building. Forget that, David's is not in the infirmary. How that happened. I got from my chair and took my phone. I opened my history of messages. Nothing. No mention of him leaving. Did he wake up and left without telling something. I panicked and ask her, what about the guards outside his room. Did you ask them. She also got up seeing my tensed, there were no guards. I just assumed he left after waking up. This is very concerning, how can no one notice him walking back. I don't think so. And he can't have healed enough to use his Kuret yet. Besides, what would be the point to leave without no one telling. He just won a freaking tournament.

She realized the gravity of the situation. I decided I need to call someone now. Who would know about David. I don't think Ned as left the admins building. Matt and Cass have been managing the block stalls. Catherine is busy with hospitality. Nathan and Tessa should be at the auditorium with the participants gathering. That leaves only one person. I dialed his number and called him. The other end rings several times. Each delaying moment made me more worried. Then finally it opened, Vanessa. What's going on. Blakes voice came.

I almost shout, David's missing. The guards are not at the infirmary. Do you know he is. Blake replies, settle down. He is okay. We moved him to a secure place. I felt my chest unknotting feeling relieved. I told Melinda who was also getting worried seeing me agitated, he is fine. She relaxes and lets out a sigh. She chuckles a little, that was a scare. She takes her seat back. Seeing her I realized I reacted way more than I should. I too calm down but then I was confused, why didn't let anyone know you moved him.

He answered, we wanted to keep in the down low. I was concerned that the Citradel might use his injuries to make a case and stop somehow Charles. Like he is too injured to fight. That sort of made sense, but why hide it. He continuous, more than that. We were worried that someone could sabotage him. Like me and Marina were poisoned. Its still possible since the tournament isn't over. So we decided to be cautious and moved him while no was looking.

That was actually making a lot of sense. Blake made a convincing argument. I ask him, okay. So where is he. He didn't reply immediately. He takes a moment to reply, he is secured and sage I promise. Lets just keep it that. Vague, but okay. Then I heard a girls voice beside him. It was faint but I know who it was. I asked him, you have talking we, as in you and Marina. He replies with a little shaky voice, yeah. Of course it was her. The shadow duo strikes again. He then asks, anyways. We were going to tell everyone that David woke up and left to rest up at his house. Marina is right now drafting the message from his phone making it look like its from him.

After hearing their explanation I sat back down and faced a patiently waiting Melinda. I ask him, okay. I understand. Actually, there is a someone from Citradel asking for David. She wants to talk to him. Blake answers, that’s not going to happen. Last M checked, he hasn't woken up. I am guessing he won't tonight as well. Whoever is there, tell them to try again tomorrow. I relayed the same to Melinda. She looked even more anxious now, that’s not good.

I asked her, what's the matter. Is it urgent. She sighs, it very much is. The admins discussion won't end until I talk to him. I gasped, huh. That certainly was urgent. Wait, who is she. I asked, who are you and what's it got to do with David. She hesitated in answering. Blake heard me over the phone and asked, what's going on. Everything okay. I told him, hold on a minute. I asked Melinda, talk to me Melinda. She finally relents, if David's hasn't woken up yet, I guess you have to make a decision in place of him. I need to hurry and give Charles an answer. But he said to only talk to David.

His name from her was a surprise. If she is in contact with Charles, she must be close to Kafar. I ask her, how do you know Charles. She smiles a little, I am his wife. He contacted me to talk with David about something important. That’s not what I was expecting this. That explains the bodyguards. Does that mean they were also Heraknus. I pushed aside the question and pulled my phone close my cheek. I ask Blake, are you close by.

He replies, ah. We are in section one. Why. I told him, you need to come to my place right now. Charles wife is here and wants to talk something important about the Admins. I heard Blake surprised, seriously. I, then a moment later he corrected, we are coming in 3 minutes. He hung up his phone. I tell Melinda, Blake is coming here. Melinda replies, okay. She was still tensed though. I ask her, what does Charles want with David. I thought everything was done when they made a deal with him. Then a thought occurred to me, don't tell me he wants to change something of the deal.

She lifts her fingers to her lower lips, not exactly. Charles contacted me privately. He wanted ask David two things. I wondered what could be so important that he sent his wife to him. I wanted to ask her what it was. Then I decided its better to wait for Blake to arrive. We waited in tense silence until I hear some hustling outside the door. I got up and moved to the door. As I open it, I see the guards pacing fast and grouping together. They were looking up to the sky at something.

I followed their direction and saw two figures flying. I pulled in some Kuret in my eyes and saw the Kuret colors. I realize they didn't want to wait even a little bit. I told the bodyguards, don't worry. Its Blake and Marina. Their figures becomes more clear as the begin to descend down. The bodyguards relax seeing them. Those two didn't waste any time. A blue kuret ball and red kuret circles land on the road in front of my house. Some people walking nearby looked our way stunned. But this wasn't something new. A moment later they went on their way.

Marina releases her Kuret first and then Blake follows. She looks are the guards and says, whoa. Guys its me. One of the bodyguards told her, next time. Let us know if you are going to do this. Marina scoffs, big deal. Look, we can pretty much free to fly as much we want here. Unlike the Citradel, there are no Humans here. Its true that Citradels are not used to this at all. Blake greeted the guys, hey. Don't mind us. He and Marina walked passed them to my door. He askes me, is she inside.

I let them inside. Melinda was standing and waiting for them. Marina takes one look at her and gasps, wait. You. I asks her, you know her. Before she could answer Melinda says, Marina. I didn't know you would be coming too. She looks at Blake, hello Blake. I am Melinda Heraknus. Blake glances back to her from Marina, hi. Nice to meet you. You caught me a little off guard here. I close the door behind them and all of us take the chairs. Melinda says, I apologize for that. Charles sounded very urgent. He instructed me to only talk to David and be inconspicuous. I told him I didn't any guards with me, but he insisted since I couldn't bring him or any children with me.

Marina asks, you have kids. She was the most confused among us. Its obvious they know each other. Blake asks Marina, how do you two know each other. Marina replies eyeing Melinda, it was not like I knew everyone in Citradel. But I know her. Or at least thought I did. Marina sighs a moment later realizing she never really did know her. Melinda filled in the gaps, we worked together. Or did, before the Echo commander started making waves. I work on matter conversion for the drives using the star dust we mined from the Delago's comet. My family has been involved in mining and processing for generations.

All of were visibly startled to hear that she is the few people who has expertise on inter-stellar travel and our weapons technology. Blake hesitantly asks Marina, this is her. I thought you said it was a guy from some other house. Marina was again surprised to hear this, I thought I knew. Dammit. I can't believe you even lied about your job. I knew her as just a research assistance. I am not one to talk, but you definitely fooled me. Melinda chuckles, Taron is just a figurehead. My area of expertise makes me a valuable to Medrones. I had to lie to everyone, not just you.

Marina is a shadow, so I am sure she would understand. She applauds her, its fine. I get it. But to think you got yourself roped into a Heraknus family. That’s even more surprising. Wait, I remember you were away for about a year on a top secrete mission 6 years ago. She makes air quotes, I always thought why would a research assistance was sent. I understand now. Melinda smirks a little, actually I was pregnant with my twins back then. I was posing as a single women, it would be very weird to see have a baby bump.

Jeez, just how much of a secret was she to the Citradel. Blake cuts in, look I am sure you two have a lot to catch up. Considering there are about a dozen people guarding the place, lets get this over with before someone notices someone important is visiting the chief security of the Island. I shot back a look at him, a dozen people. I saw only 3. He replies staring at Melinda, there are more hiding and posing as Islanders. We spotted them when we circled the place before coming in.

Whoa. I didn't even bother to look for more people. When Siera told me they were okay, I just completely let my guard down. A mistake. Dammit. Melinda doesn't react to Blake much but just smiles and then puts it away a second later, okay. Lets get down to business then. David is not awake, so you all must answer two questions. Marina asks, and this came from Charles directly. She nods, yes. I don't know all the discussion, but the moment Charles explained the deal he made with David, Citradel officials lost their heads.

I could just imagine the faces of people when they heard that Heraknus are going to move here. The panic it would have created is something I wish I saw. She continues, a debate started and people pleaded Charles to reconsider. When he didn't, they began to, well. She pauses ominously. Blake prompts her, they resisted. It's obvious. Your husband word is final for his house, so they must have become desperate. She nods and speaks slowly, Kafar raised a concern saying David cheated during the match with his strange Kuret and was even linked to the sabotages to Marina, and possibly you.

What, I blurted out angered. Blake remained calm, but Marina and I were not going to let it stand. I told her, how the hell that makes sense. Marina shrieks, David was the one who found the bottle I was poisoned with. This is crazy. How can Kafar blame this on David. I tightened my fist uncontrollably. Melinda turned worried and says, afraid I don't know. Charles didn't tell me everything. He said that they wanted David to visit them around lunch and remove such doubts. Derek was very opposed to this. But David wasn't awake, so the discussion kind of went on.

I was speechless at Kafar's shameless actions. Marina got mad and says, he has gone from a sleazebag to a douchebag. I agreed. I also a sneaking suspicion that this wasn't the only thing he did. I asked harshly, what else. I am sure he must be speaking more nonsense. Melinda gulps a little before saying, few hours back, they tried to reach out to David again. But he was not in the infirmary. No guards as well. The discussion somehow pivoted saying he left without mentioning anyone to hide or destroy evidence of his involvement.

Marina spoke aloud, that jackass. I added on, he really is an opportunist you know. Blake for silent a while, but he joins in, settle down you two. This is just all huff and noise. If he really had any evidence or suspicion why not ask us. Blame us. Be angry with us. Or just talk to us. And yet, he didn't even mention a single thing to any Islander. He knows if we heard this, we would ask for evidence. He has nothing. Not even circumstantial evidence. They are just derogatory attempts to have Charles back down the deal. Some may even believe it. But it doesn't matter who said what. If they can't back it, its just bunch of complaints wrapped in hysteria.

Even knowing he is right wasn't enough to make me relax. Marina asks him, but who knows what else must be going on. Charles didn't tell Melinda everything. Blake responds sternly, maybe. No. Most definitely. With David's history, including getting framed by Nathan, human murders or collaborators, and being in top 10 of the most wanted in so many agencies, Kafar has many ammunitions to discredit David. He sighs, I thought when David gave away that 2 billion dollars with his bet, Kafar would leave him be. I guess, that was just wishful thinking.

I rebuked, but he hasn't done anything bad. He has done a tons of good shit. They can't take away those. Blake nods, no one is denying this. Neither can they. Which is why I am sure it’s a sad and desperate attempt to convince Charles to not move here. He asks Melinda, you said you wanted to know two things. Is the first question from Charles about this nonsense. Melinda stares at us for a while and then speaks, yes. So he isn't responsible for these crimes. He didn't cheat during the match or sabotage the tournament.

Before I could answer Marina answers, you know me Melinda. Right. So trust me when I tell you. I have knew David back in Medrine. And having spent enough time with him here, he is a good guy. He is most definitely not a saint, but he wouldn't cheat and risk our lives on the line. I nod, if he wanted do sabotage or cheat, no one would have known. He wouldn't make it complicated by reporting his own crime. Melinda listened to us like she was a reporter, absorbing all the information.

Blake also pitches in, you can tell Charles to ignore such accusations. Even if he is suspicious of his past, David wouldn't cheat in such a crucial match. Like Marina said, its too risky to do that. Just because he did something crazy by pulling out bunch of kurets, doesn't make him a cheater. We waited for Melinda. She glances at us, taking it all in. After what looked like an interrogation eyeing, she opens her mouth, I understand. That’s good. Normally Charles would also ignore such baseless comments. But he was been stuck in that room for hours. No matter how much Derek opposed, Charles still wanted to confirm from David himself.

She looks away to empty air around us, but he isn't here. But hearing from you about him, at least I am convinced. I will tell Charles the same. All of take a little breather hearing this small piece of good news among all this crap. I am still very mad to David, but questioning his integrity is not up for debate. Marina says, thanks. Blake asks, glad to hear that. What's the second thing you wanted to talk about now.

She faces me now, its more like a clarification rather than a question. That's confusing. I asked her, about what. She explains, something about Wagner that made David a little crazy, his words not mine, and he wants to clear somethings.

Blake (Chapter 44)

Friday, September 12, 2025 19:39

Its finally the time. By 4:00 PM, everyone was told what to do. Luther had planned it out around 4:30 PM. I asked him to time it, saying it would give enough people us to work with. Secretly, that would give us the distraction to move David. Me, Luther and four other people were discussing the final orders. I had to come up with an reasonable excuse to explain why I can't be there, but to my surprise Luther didn't want me there anyways. He says, it works in our favor if you are not there. You are our top officer, sure. But you are the leader first. If you were with us from the start, it would definitely be more impactful. But you know what would be even more impactful. You coming in on later.

I was curious where he was going with this. I asked, explain. He shuffles in his chair, we can give an excuse saying you have been sitting inside the admins waiting room. I have people telling me they saw you for hours there in the morning after the match. Who's to say you didn't went there back again and have been there all this time. And then after few hours from now, you come out and show us that you were already inside. I gave this a little more thought. If done right, it would pressure Citradels even more.

One of the other people, Tina asks, but the lobby is also locked. How can we claim Blake has been inside all this time. Luther says, remember the lunch delivery. With that small opening, am I mean literally when they opened the door, that person saw the lobby was empty and the conference room locked. Blake could have been there for hours and even Citradel wouldn't know about it. Looks like he thought of everything. I may have this sleazy idea first, but he made it a politically sleazy plan.

I smiled, I like it. Another person from the group, Forman asks, but can you even get in without anyone noticing. I could hear others sneering at his naivety. Luther says, you do know who we are talking here. His is a freaking shadow. It will be piece of cake. I was pleased to hear such high praises from him. I told them, its not that easy. I am not an trained in that field, but rest assured. I could break into the admins lobby without Citradel or anyone knowing. Everyone laughs with me, I continue, let tell me when I need to come out.

Luther nods and hold up his iPad. I think its best to at least have two hours before we reveal you. So you should be ready anytime after 6:30 PM. That gives me a little over 2 hours. That should be enough to move David. I got up from my chair, that settles it. Lets do it. Everyone looked poised to do this. I went to my dresser to pull out a jacket from my dresser and walked out with them following in tow, I will sneak out from the back. I'll make sure no one sees me. Message me when you are ready for me.
Luther walks beside me as we walked to the 3rd floor deck., got it. I know you don't want any prepared speech or anything like that, but I have some essential points I want you to share. I'll send them later. As I opened the door I told him, make sure it doesn't look desperate. He smiles, yeah. I know. Angry, confused and frustrated. All yes. Pathetic, weak and desperate, big no. I corrected him, hell no. I pulled on my hoodie and grab the railings. Okay, guys. I'll see in few hours. Good luck. They wish me luck as well. I called on my Kuret. It covers my whole body and jump out into air.

I control my landing and then I began running. It was still say, so it was easy to look like I was on a jog with my head covered. I used my Kuret to become faster. I hit the streets and stuck close the buildings or trees as I ran. I kept my Kuret to a minimum, not to reveal others who I was. Soon I was near the stadium. I wasn't going to enter from the entrance. I looked for any entry point from the backside. I saw 3rd floor open window. I looked around me and saw no nearby aura. That’s my cue. With a kuret induced jump, I flew up and suck through the window. I landed softly on the floor and walked slowly to the door. It was an empty room. I remembered this is just a storage room.

It could be locked from outside. And it was. But before I plan to open it, I opened my phone to check on Marina. She hasn't messaged me yet. I didn't want to go out in case someone sees me wandering around. She still had 10 minutes till 4:00. So instead I decided to wait here until she messages. I sat at the corner and decided to pass the time by noting down my own thoughts. I obviously don't want to incite anything so it has to be enough to sound objective.

15 minutes went by and then finally got a message from Marina. She was ready and coming to get us. I messaged to meet around the back garage. I got up and peaked out from the window. I saw a crowd forming near the admin tower on the side. Seems the plan is working. I walked back to the door. I poured out my Kuret into the gaps of the door. My kuret feels resistance from the bolts, I apply more pressure to crush it open. Since this was a empty storage room now, it doesn't matter if I broke the door.

I check for any aura before walking out. The stadium is mostly empty. I only saw few auras on the ground, the clean up crew. With no interference, I jolted across the floor and head to 2nd floor from the stairs. In a minute the infirmary room was visible. The security guards were no longer here. I opened the door and went inside to David's room. I see him in the same place as last time I saw him. The display was showing his recovery to be 70%. Wow, okay. I didn't know it shows this accurately.

I submersing tank is quite big to inconspicuous. I looked around the room. There must be something to cover the device with. I looked in a cabinet, but it was empty. There was a bed, but the sheets weren't big enough to cover. Huh, great, I forgot to realize this issue before. I was more focused with the other plan. I looked around another minute, this time the whole infirmary, but nothing. There wasn't anything I can use to hide the tank. I should have planned more properly.

As I walked back to the tank, I remembered something. When David was explaining to us all those months ago, didn't he mention something about stealth option. I recalled the memories and I vaguely remembered it. I inspected the tank and after a while I saw a symbol of shadow. It would look like just a mark to others, but to us it was a like a big poster. I ran my hands across the cool surface and realized it had a hidden button. I pressed it and heard a rumbling noise. Immediately I took a step back. The device's surface, even the glass, is transforming into a smooth white capsule. Damn David, you got some serious tech. A moment later it looked it was a giant pill.

Somehow this is even more conspicuous. I can't take this out. The shadow mark was still there, so I hit the button again. This time, it transformed into a oversized fridge. What, how in the hell is this a setting. I kept trying hoping get something good. After few tries, I finally got a suitable cover. It's looking like a big box of crate. Perfect for carrying it out in the open. I had noticed it didn't have any wheels, so I guess its all me. I take a deep breathe and poured out my Kuret. I glide my hands motioning the kuret around the tank. Then I pull it up. It was quite heavy. I should be able to manage for a while. Without wasting a second, I walked out the infirmary with a levitating tank.

Soon I reached the garage loading area. Thankfully no was here. But neither was Marina. Where is she. I pushed the tank onto the loading stage. I opened my phone. Marina sent a message saying she is getting delay from people blocking the paths. Shit, another mistake. I didn't think about the people out in the streets. I tried very hard to not look out of place. I was the only person in an empty loading garage so few people did look my way. , They didn't suspect too much. Few minutes later I saw an familiar aura coming from the side.

Marina came in a small jeep. She saw me and turned inside towards the loading area. She was also incognito wearing a ragged jacket with a hat and goggles. She calls out anxious, what the hells going on. What's with all the people gathering around the roads and buildings. We were in a hurry, so I told, I'll explain when we get out of here. I used my Kuret to hold on the disguised tank. Marina looked suspicious me dragging a large box into the back of the jeep. She then realized, wow. Where the hell did you get a big enough crate that fits the tank. Once I put down the tank behind, I hop on the passengers seat. I told her, it’s the tank. David built a stealth option. Marina laughs, sweet. She puts the jeep in a reverse drive and pulls us out of the loading garage.

For a while we only focus on keeping a low profile. We already stand out with a big ass create. I didn't want anyone to give us a second look. People were now coming from everywhere. Filling up the roads and building entrance areas. It took us about 10 minutes to navigate out of the hot zone. Once we crossed the middle sections, Marina picked up the speed. Marina asks, okay. We should be good now. She pulls down her hat and goggles, now explain. What the hell is going on.

Just has a precaution I inspected the tank. We both were on guard, but can't track every person around us. Doesn't look like it was disturbed in anyway. I face the front road pulling my hoody, sorry. I should have warned you about this. I didn't think people would be gathering this fast. I thought it will be taking longer. Luther wasn't kidding when he said how fast he organized it. Marina confused asks, huh. What did you do. I answered, since morning we have been getting calls and people asking us what's happening with the admins and Citradel. We have only rumors and very little actual fact about what's talking them so long to discuss. We were continuously getting approached by people, to a point it was getting in the way of our actual work.

Marina snorts, damn. I didn't realize it was that bad. I reply. Neither did I in the beginning, but just think about it. David was declared winner, but Reinhart mentioned only for the first half event. That was a spur of the moment from them. People don't know what's happening. Is Citradel moving here. Or only half of them. What's with the deal between David and Charles. The longer this goes, the more concerned people will be. And obviously, we can't tell people what really happened. So I had an idea on how to deal with this.

Marina asks, which involves people gathering on the streets. I nod, that just the beginning. My idea is to shut down the officers building, turn off our network and have the officers rally around the admin towers. The people you saw around the stadium were just gathering, I am sure they either have started to move or will do in some time to the admin towers. With all the recognizable officers on the streets, people would naturally be curious. That will eventually leading to a full blown rally once they explain that we also want Citradel to explain what's going on.

Hearing me Marina whistles excited, damn. You don't pull any punches huh. I chortle a little, of course not. Why should we suffer for something Citradel has to explain. Luther perfected the plan by selecting the more well known officers, while the rest would resume work from a secluded location. Once people recognize that few of us are out there, the would assume everyone are also here. We also got some luck in pulling some of the top Island and Citradel fighters. All this in an effort for people to get off our back and instead stuck them on Citradel and admins. It would pressure them to hurry up their discussion.

I continued with worrisome tone, giving admins more time is not good for us. I am personally worried Kafar would do anything to stop Charles. Last I saw him he was still arguing with Charles. I don't want him to have more time to come up with anything that makes Charles back down. Marina left the steering wheels and applauds, hot damn. Now that’s political maneuver to choke them. This is very good plan. I nod, thanks. And as an added benefit, it would also serve as a distraction while we move David.

She laughs more loudly, love when a plan comes together like this. At that I also was mildly impressed by the effectiveness of this crazy plan. I didn't expect it to work this fast. The she asks, wait. Won't it be better if you were also there. I then explained Luther's final trick. At that she giggles, let me guess. You need my help to snuck in. I most definitely was. I answered, its going to be tight, but with you helping me, we can pull this off. She nods, I may of a way. Lets figure that later though. We are almost here.

We had crossed the outer sections and now crossing the forest areas. The road here wasn't proper and it jerked us quite a lot. I ask, whoa. Slow down. The tank is creating dents on the back. Marina scoffs, who cares. This is a very old jeep. Trust me, I got it because no one will look for it. She actually floored the gas and increased the speed. I had to throw my Kuret on to the tank and keep it from falling out. We crossed into rocky forest terrain. I recognized this place. We were close to the northeast coast, the mountains here turns into a large cliff towards the ocean.

I ask Marina, how do you know David's house is here. She didn't reply right away, instead she took us into a unmarked location through the mountain bottom. A moment later she turns the jeep sideways and halts. She turns

off the jeep saying, his house is not here. Well not yet. She got out and I followed a second later. She points to the cliff on the middle of two mountain edges, the house is going to be on that cliff. Puzzled by this I asked, again. How do you know.

She pulls out a device from her pockets. It looked like a small remote with just one button on it. She waved it with her hand, with this. We are not going to where the house is, we are going to summon it. She was purposefully being ominous. She is clearly teasing me with such word play. I shook my head, fine. So we carry David manually from here. She nods, that’s the plan. The path is two rough for us to go in this rusty bolts. So lets go. She offered to take the tank this time, so I gladly let her. She creates mini charms and throws it at the bottom of the tank. It levitates and follows her as we begin climbing through the boulders around us.

A minute later we took a small opening of the path into open cliff. I asked finally, are you really not going to tell me how or why you have a device that can, I really didn't want to say the word. She offers with a laugh, summon the house. Yeah, whatever, I said. She replies, again. Its my secret. Let David tell you. She is enjoying way more than she should. Soon we reach the cliff. She waves her fist to me, stop. This is as far enough. She dispels her charms and the puts the tank of the grass.

She offers the button to me. I said, by all means, your secret. Your button. She smiles gleefully and pushes the button. Nothing happened. It wasn't like I was expecting suddenly, but the device wasn't beeping or making any noise. Marina however was very excited. I ask her, so long will this take. She shrugs, no clue. From what I understand, when David is not inside his moving fortress, it is in a suspended mode somewhere in the sea. But it has to be someplace close by. So I don't know, maybe 5 minutes.

We waited in suspense for minutes. 3 minutes went by. Now even Marina was showing less excitement. I ask her, ah. Just to make sure, that device works right. She gets offended, it works just fine. Its not supposed to make any sound by design. Same with any progress or wait time. I figured it was best not to pester her. Another 3 minutes went by. Its becoming more like nothing goings to happen. Marina looked tense, it will be here. Trust me. She is mumbling under her breath. I was becoming less optimistic about this.

Then a minute later we hear a large surge of water gushing somewhere. We both immediately heard it and run to the edge to gaze over the ocean. Large waves were now coming from a place on the ocean. The water gushed inside and crushed under the rocks. A moment later a small structure came out. Marina beside me laughs excited, yes. It worked. See, I told you. She jumps in joy. I was more fascinated at the rising structure. Slowly the object takes in shape of a rooftop. It looked like it was made of black steel or iron. I couldn't see any aura from it, so there is no medrite is used in the construction. I look in awe as I begin to realize how huge it was. It was as big as a villa.

The house emerges from the ocean and floats towards the shore. I was thinking that at this depth from the cliff, we had to go down. Marina notices me looking at the bottom. She says, no. We don't need to go down. It will come out. That surprised me, what. She smiles, just wait and see. I don't know what to expect. Suddenly the house rose up quickly from the water. Shit, I realize what's happening. The house gathered up momentum and shoot up straight into the air.

My jaw hung with awe. This technology is beyond humans, closer to ours back in Medrine. The bottom of the house had some kind of thrusters that threw large streams of water. I still didn't see any aura, so this was all pure medrite free technology. The house jump straight up, but what now. From my view, it was slowly loosing speed. I turned to Marina, she wasn't worried. This is supposed to happen then. Immediately, large beams of pillars come out from the bottom.

Those think beams stuck to the cliff and break apart. I got nervous for a second, then I saw it wasn't getting destroyed. The beams were actually spitting and spreading around the walls of the cliff like an army of ants. My eyes widen stupefied. I shouted at Marina, isn't that the same as Echos technology. Yeah, it is. I bet I saw this during the war last year. Their vehicles and ships could transfigure like this. More beams comes out and scatter when in contact with the wall.

Marina was also surprised at this, what the hell. I didn't know about this. I have never seen the boarding procedure. The house somehow didn't fall off. I can't believe that those small looking Echo material were this strong. A moment later the house starts to climb up. I point to the house, are you kidding me. Will such a big and heavy house be able to climb. Marina sighs with nervous, it will. We should get back. We take backward steps and get some distance. A moment later, the entire freaking house was able to climb a 400 meters cliff in seconds. Up close I could tell distinctive features like the rooftop, windows and doors.

The ground beneath us shook. The rocks roll on the ground as the house completely emerges from the sides. The tiny moving beams become solid and then froze the house in place. About a dozen of medium sized beams come out from the sides and bottom and lodge itself into the ground. It creates shocks on the ground around us. Then came silence, filled with suspense. Marina then waves her hand excited, Blake. Welcome to Davids home. The building surfaces then change colors, some parts even transform shapes. I could now see outlines of window slits and sliding doors. The roof turns into red color, walls turns light yellow, the windows become transparent.

I spatted, this is where David lives. Freak this. When he showed his ratty place months ago, I thought he didn't care about aesthetics or maybe he was just a minimalist. This is crazy. Marina laughs at my amusement, what this. Its nothing. Wait until you visit inside. I didn't know what we supposed to do now. The door looked closed, maybe they will open for us. Then Marina's arm started to make noise. She lifts her wrist and M pops out, Unauthorized boarding protocol detected. Deploying security measures.

Wait what, Marina shouted. Before we could understand what happens, the house begins to do something. From the side, I heard something like a door opening and three objects shoot out. The objects jump out and fly in the air. I shout in disbelieve, are those freaking robots. Not the echo kind. But it was in the shaped like us from the middle, but on the bottom were two sets of small pillars with propulsions levitating them. Theres a square head with two cameras as eyes. Torse with two arms, an elbow joints, hands, fingers, the whole package. There are guns hoisted all around the robot. They were probably made of same material as the house.

Marina shrieks, what the freak are they. I was nervous now seeing Marina didn't encounter them before. Those robots glide in the air, flying straight at us at speed. I spoke to the watch on Marina's wrist, what's going on. M, tell them to back down. It's your boss for god sakes. M's hologram had gone, and no response came. I asked Marina, any ideas. Marina didn't respond. She had prepared a charm and waving it around us. The robots weren’t the only security. She freaks out, look out below. I sense something.

Just then the ground erupted. I instinctively used my Kuret to block us from the debris. Turns out the robots were also distraction. Five huge spheres made with the same Echo tech were flying around us. They were circling us with mini thrustors on them. Then spheres open a part of it showing a barrel. I still can't see any aura. What the hell David build here.

Blake (Chapter 45)

Saturday, September 13, 2025 21:59

This is nuts. We are being surrounded by flying robots and spheres. Marina asks me exasperated, ah, any idea what should we do. She had tried M several times. But no response had come. I shouted back, are you serious. I thought you said you had this. What did that button do exactly. Marina shook her head, its not my fault. I told you I find a way to locate his house. I had no idea about this. That’s what worries me. She mentioned David would have increased or changed other things. I say that was an understatement.

We both were using kurets to guard us. The robots were positioned at three corners, boxing us in. They had something on their hands pointed to us. It could be only described as a trident shaped gun. I venture a guess its not gunpowder inside it. Marina yells, lets just blast them. We can take them. I waved at her, don't. We don't know what kind of response it will follow next. They are not attacking us. Lets wait for a some more time. Marina says angered, I can't believe David wouldn't have excluded us as hostile threats. Come on, how paranoid is he.

I couldn't agree more. But I had to believe this is just a standard protocol. Few seconds went by, then nothing changed. I told Marina, keep trying M. This has to be due to something she mentioned just after the house came up. Marina kept calling M, but no response came. Then one of the spheres left the group and flew over to the tank behind us. We look at it with anxious eyes. A laser comes out from it and begins scanning it. The next second the two spheres still circling came out and also begins scanning us from the foot.

Marina was fidgety with her charms. I hesitantly tell, don't. The lased completes its scan once it crosses our heads. All the spheres stop moving. They flew towards the tank. The robots that had their weird guns pointed at us, also took flight. Both of us relax seeing they left us. Marina yells at them, oh sure. Yeah. Your boss is there, so we must be not be threats. Your welcome. The robots grab the ends of the tank and lift it up. The spheres hovers around middle and top, like they are guarding David.

The all flew back into the house carrying David. I asked, well that happened. Does that mean we can now go inside. Marina was still a little angry, who the hell knows. You know, David could have mentioned he had some guard dogs here. We started walking to the house. The robot landed on some kind of deck that opened up on their arrival. I was sure this meant that we were also invited now. But that didn't happen. The whole house begins to transform and slowly revert back to the structure we saw as earlier.

Marina shouts realizing what this meant, oh come on. After all this, we aren't even welcomed in. This sucks balls. She stomps on the ground. I sighed seeing the doors and window closing. I tell her, leave it. We got David into a secured place. Let him go. The support beams begins to disassemble and the house begins to move. After some more dismantling, the house begins to climb down. With the same mechanical movements, the house journey down happens in seconds.

Just few meters before reaching the ocean surface, it launched itself horizontally towards the ocean. It creates a giant splash, which create huge waves to the shore. Moments later it starts to swim outwards and then submerges gradually down. Soon it was just the two of us staring at empty ocean. I spoke aloud into the air, David you crazy son of a gun. He had everyone fooled with this. Even us. Marina clears her throat. I corrected grudgingly, okay. Just me. But he didn't tell you everything too.

Marina had to realize that as well. She scoffs, yeah. Can't deny that. Then a moment later she cheers up, wait, that means he upgraded the insides of the house too. I have to see it. I turned my back to the ocean, later. Lets head back. Theres nothing left to do now. Marina stared a little longer and then we both walk back to the jeep. On our way back, Marina's watch starts to beep. M hologram comes out. Marina yells at her, you could warned us about those robots.

M says, updated temporary access. An unauthorized request was sent to bosses house AI. We have isolated me running there. Since the protocol request was valid, but antiquated, it decided to still follow through with the boarding with a potential risk assessment. I looked at Marina curious. She became nervous at my continuous gaze. She asks, what. I replying, I didn't say anything. She retorts, its not my fault. I replied, again. I didn't say anything. After few more staring she blurts out, ah. Okay. Fine. Her voice takes dip in tone, I might have done something David not to do.

I sighed. I knew something was up, David didn't give you that device, did he. Seeing her silent meant I was right. I waited for her to speak up while we continued walking. We reached to our jeep, she finally breaks the suspense, I stole it. I was expecting this. We both take the seats. I ask, how. She explains, last time I was in his house. He was giving me a tour, he showed his control room. There were bunch of these devices lying on a table. She waved the device in her hand. I was a little surprised David didn't notice it. She continues with a little nervous smile, actually it have been from a sperate pile.

That got me curious. I asked her, did that pile was meant defective or maybe even old? I stressed on the last parts. Marina takes a while to respond, yeah. It could be. I let out a scoff that showed my annoyance, there is a reason why you are not trained for stealing stuff. Come on. She reflexes, I had to. The way he was showing me stuff and speaking, it felt he wasn't going to show it again. I yelled, why the hell would you think that. Marina shrugs, I don’t know. But there must be reason why he wanted to keep this a secret don't you.

I thought about it a little. Was it wrong to steal from David. Maybe she was also right for being suspicious. Why hide from us about his house. She says, see. I am telling. I couldn't put my finger on it, but he was very suspicious. So I thought to have a back up. She turns on the jeep and pulls us out of there. I can't tell if what she did was wrong then. I spatted, I will make David give us some answers. Marina smirks, exactly. He owes us a lot of explanations. All about his therapy and then this.

I thought about the reasons for this. But I realized it was pointless, he was trained to be the most secretive among us. I guess after regaining his memories, he reverted to his old self. When we crossed into the forest road Marina asks me, did you see the material the house and robots were made from. I nodded, yeah. It was had to miss. Marina says, I scanned the whole house with a charm and I found no Medrite or Echo signature. And yet the way they transformed and moved…I answered the rest for her, it looked like Echo's ship. I wonder if he salvaged some for himself from the war last year. I thought we kept it locked it away for analysis in our R and D.

Marina says, he must be took some before we moved it here. I can't believe he used it and reproposed it like this. She raised her wrist and asks M, what can you tell us about the house and those killer robots. M pops out and says, information access denied at current authority. However, I am allowed to say that the robots were only part of the protocol for initial risk assessment probs. The actual killer robots weren't deployed. M pops back in. I gasp hearing this. Marina yells, what the freak. I was kidding about killer robots. They were just some sort of resonance probs. Those robots and their weapons looked battle already. What kind of hell machine are the actual ones.

I couldn't stop myself from laughing after I had a thought, he reproposed those Echo tech, knowing how ineffective it was against us in the last battle. So imagine this, with all the resources he has, he may have improved it. He didn't use Medrine or Echo tech, just Earth's tech. I can't even fathom what those killer robots are. Marina is instead smirking. I ask, you want to seem them. Right. She yells, hell yeah. Don't tell me you don't want to. Our defenses are not automated, his is. I could already tell its way advance from what we can make.

I tell her, you know he isn't going to share the secrets. Her eyes becomes sharp, oh. I am going to pull it out from his ass. With the bullshit he made me do, he owes me big time. I didn't argue with her more on this. David knew what he was getting into by telling Marina about his house. I have some understanding of David's view. But I won't lie, I want some answers too.

We were now back on the outer section. It is now 5:30 PM. The rally must be on going strong by now. I still haven't gotten any message from Luther. So I still had some time. I had another thought and I did not want miss this opportunity. I ask, Marina, How far is Dr. Drews home from here. Marina says, you want to go visit her now. You sure. I nod, yes. I don't know if either of us will get time after this. After the tonight's announcement, I don't know happens tomorrow. But right now, I have time and an convenient excuse. You are also here, it could be better if you are with me when we meet her.

Marina thinks about it and says, she lives in section one. Its not that far from here. We can be there in 10 minutes. But what if she is not at home. I answer, then we will have no choice but to try some other day. You said she's now a farmer now, so lets hope she spends time there. Marina agreed with me and she turned towards her house. We won't get much time with her, so Marina and I discussed beforehand what we wanted to talk. We have no idea how much David had revealed to her, so its better we play it safe by keeping our stories straight.

We reach section one a little earlier than expected. We didn't find much traffic here. I guess most of the people would be moving to the admins building. Marina parks the jeep in the lot and we got down. This part of the section was designed primarily for agriculture so population density was low here. I follow Marina to a big house, kind of like ranch, with a shed separate on the side. The backyard extended to a large land. I saw aura's of various plants grown here.

Marina asks me, so you agree we do this my way. I nod, yeah. You are right. I thought about it and there is definitely risky to announce ourselves here. We only want to meet Drew, not her family. We will sneak in without anyone knowing. I didn't like this approach, but I am supposed to be inside the admin buildings lobby. Marina creates a charm and waves over the field. I pull in more Kuret into my eyes and see the auras. I saw 5 aura's people inside the house. The public information on the network says, she lives with her husband, their kids and brother-in-law. Marina confirms no was in the fields. As we walk closed I whisper, okay. Do it.

She opened her phone and sent a prepared message to Drew. It told that Marina has brought me with her and wants to meet at the east of their lands under the cover of trees. We both wait outside her house, avoiding any detection from anyone. Nothing happened immediately. We has to wait patiently until she read it. Marina had used a priority message with my authorization. That means her phone has to be buzzing continuously. Finally, after a minute, I see one aura leaving others and moving around the house.

Marina also sensed it, she motioned to move. Under the cover of the shed and fields, we stealthily dashed to the designated location. We passed through a field of apple orchids that were emitting medrites. Once we gained enough distance from the house I asked her, do you see what I am seeing. Marina also picked what I meant, yeah. Hard not to. Those orchids and now this groves of plums, they shouldn't be able to grow in such proximity, and with such high concentration of Keret inside. She must be making more of the other side. This is actually incredible. We reached the meeting place and glanced over the field.

I answered, yeah. We had a tour on a different farm, but we should have shown this as well. I wonder why she didn't put her name in the list. This would have been a great addition to show others. Marina lips twitches, I know why. The farms you all decided was all Medrine grown crops. Not a hybrid like this. She might have decided this would not help our cause. Think about it, the most selling point we are giving people is that no humans, no interruptions. We can finally be ourselves. That includes, able to grow our food. But this, she waves around the field, can be grown in Citradel also.

She was right. I told her, I can get on with that explanation. Its just I can't believe I never knew someone was growing this. Marina laughs, you have been busy with the tournament. Give yourselves some credit, this isn't like managing during resistance safehouse or wartime. We so many people coming over here now, things will go unnoticed. Even for us shadow agents. I knew this new paradigm shift would be difficult for me. Its just now hitting me how different things will be happening from now on. I tell her, thanks. I guess I was still have to learn things.

Marina pokes me on the shoulder, you got that right. And its not just you, I also have will have adapt. You know David has been pleading me to hire new people and maybe even start teaching some. Can you imagine, me as a teacher. I barely had patience learning during shadow training. I smirk at that thought. Those unfortunate soles will have to face hell, that sounds a lot of hustle huh. But you will do it. Marina reluctantly nods, yeah. I can't take on such massive restructuring without more people. When Citradel moves here, I will have to interview people who have some basic knowledge.

I realized something hearing this, you are already assuming Citradel is moving here. Nothing decided yet. Marina tilts her head a little, I guess I do. When Charles told his reasons for coming here, I think the no one can change his mind about that. I wasn't as optimistic as her. I have been thinking that Kafar might be up to something. I didn't have any proof, not even a rumor, but I bet he is any way to convince Charles. And given David's checkered past, he can use it somehow.

Our discussion was suddenly halted when we head an engine noise. Marina points to the source and we see a mini cart car coming at us. Marina sighs, she's here. Game face on. She pulls out an irritated expression. She is still reeling from their previous exchange. Dr Drew stops the vehicle when she sees us and comes out. She takes out cane from inside and walks to us. She was wearing a stripped shirt and jeans. From the looks of it, they weren't planning to go to the rally.

She waves at us, Prince Blake. What a surprise. And nice to see you too Marina. She was polite, but something about her tone. It was like mechanical, rehearsed. Which was not possibly, we literally just told her 3 minutes ago. I answered, evening doctor. I apologies for calling out like this. But it's important. Marina cuts in, like I told in the morning. You had the gall to make me prove that I was a close friend of Blake. I put my palm at her, let it go. I understand why she was being cautious.

Marina had more to say, but hold her tongue. I already told her earlier on the ride here to not make things worse. I turn to Drew, I don't have much time. So lets not waste time like you did earlier with Marina. What do I to prove I only want your help with David. Drew is silent, analyzing us with her gaze. She says, like I told to Marina. I am not a licensed therapist. I don't have any patients. And certainly not David. Her expression wasn't showing any deceit and she wasn't angered by our presence either. Her aura was calm as well. Only fluctuated when she saw me first.

We anticipating he reluctance. So we knew what to say to make her help us, you are right. You don't have any patients. But we have a friend, someone who certainly didn't tell us about you. Now, I clear my throat, he has unfortunately gotten worse. He got the shakes, panic attack and vomited his guts out. All happened during a critical point during the match. So we were wondering if you have any suggestions. You know, since you have background in this area.

Drew's expression finally broke. I see a slight change in her aura. She glances over to Marina. Marina says, that’s true. I was there. And I would have told you the same, had you listened to me. Drew didn't speak for a while. Her stare became even more intense. I thought I had to reveal some more things without mentioning David's name. But then Drew whispers, how bad was it. Marina tells her, pretty bad. I have seen him interning at my home in Medrine in crutches, fought wars with him. Never seen him so broken before.

She showed guanine concern. I added, I have known him on Earth and seen him at his worst. This is new low for him. One second he was fine, then he is smiling, following loss of strength. I practically carried him out of the match. Drew closes her eyes and leans her head up. She then opens them and faces me, I understand. I get it now. She turns to Marina, I apologies for my rudeness earlier in the morning. Her mood changed all of a sudden. I guess revealing the brutal truth was the best way for her to open up to us. Marina clicks her tongue, yeah. Lets just move on. Faint traces of resentment still remains.

Dr. Drew says, my only condition for treating David was he absolutely not reveal about me to anyone. No matter what happens. I ask her, why is that. She answers, I faced a lot of criticism from other when they realized I enrolled into a PhD course in Havard university. Before coming to live here, my husband and daughters were ridiculed that they got to live easily due to my decisions to later work on human patients in big cities. Living free from Echo. Maybe if I had taken up some work without studying like others, we wouldn't have suffered such stupid things. But as an academic, I wanted to learn first.

Then she shook her head, I admit I was a selfish. Also foolish to think people would understand. People thought I was running away from Medrones. She pauses a little, and maybe I was. Its hard to tell now. So when we moved here, I decided to hide my qualifications. My family has had it much easier now. Her story wasn't uncommon. Since 80% of the us sent to Earth were kids, many had to learn first about Earth and its science. It looks she fell into rough situations with her groups.

Marina says, I am not saying this to patronize you, but you just got unlucky. If you had moved to Citradel, you would have been welcomed. Even become important. Drew says, I appreciate the thought, but as you already know, I can't operate anymore. She stomps the ground with her cane, I thought becoming an advisor of sorts. But that time I was more fascinated by human psychology. The mysteries and studies on Earth is much vast than on Medrine. Because we have evolved with Kuret, illness and diagnosis had been moved from studying our brain to Kuret readings. With such a completely new area open to me, I just couldn't resist studying about it.

After listening to her, I understood her overwhelming sense of caution and reluctance to admit. I spoke to her, you had it rough. So I won't tell ask of you anything you don't want to. But for now consider just helping David. David wouldn't have broken his promise to you if it wasn't important. She sighs loudly, no. I understand. We did agree that he might involve others only if involves matter of life or death. I look over to Marina and we reached the same thought. I tell Drew, the situation is very similar. We are very worried about his state of mind. He has to fight the Heraknus alpha soon. I can't believe he hide his illness so well that no one saw it.

Marina says, trust me. He needs to be a 100% for his next fight. Drew is a little hesitantly with her words, so its true he will have to fight that mythical overdrive guy. We both nod. She shook her head, you know, it's not an easy fix. I can't tell you any specifics about his progress or treatments. I am still wanting to keep that privileged information. Well, her strict priorities are commendable. She continuous, I can tell you we agreed not to have session during the last few rounds of the tournament. Messing or changing with anything new, even by accident, at this juncture would be devasting. What would happen if he froze in the middle of fight. His composition is very human like.

I tell her, I can understand that much. M told vaguely that David had made progress and hadn't had any episode for a while. Marina says, so why now. Does it have something to do with Wagner. At that name Drew faces her with surprised look. She didn't say anything, but that look told us everything. There was definitely a connection. I wonder what kind. How does he know him. Drew says, I can't discuss about it. She tried saving her betrayed expression. But I already caught with her aura and Marina with her sense.

None of us prodded more. After a silence Drew says, I thought he had gotten over it by now. I was certain he would be okay to join the tournament after multiple sessions. She puts palm on her cheek, I guess I was wrong. This is the problem with smart patients. They can lie or skillfully deceit show half truths. She stayed silent. Marina asks, so you will help now. Drew wasn't sure, I don't know. We have been working on his issues for 8 months. It takes could take even longer, but not in a month. She pauses and has a thought, unless. Well, no. Even then its not something easy to deal with.

This isn't good. I was hoping more optimism from David's therapist. She caught my disappointment and says, I know this isn't what you want to you. Sorry. But if its possible, don't let David fight that Heraknus guy. Its too dangerous. I was there today at the stadium. I had a nagging feeling something wasn't right. Its hard to describe, but he felt like he was desperate. You confirmed me by telling this. Unlike this match, the next one could go horribly wrong.

This is bad. I have been worrying so much about Charles backing down from his deal, never thought David would be the one to do it. No, I did think about it. I just didn't want to deal with it. Marina was also perplexed, but we can't. Our future is on the stake, if David doesn't fight Charles, then the deal breaks down. Drew asks, looks like you know what it is. I have my guesses, but nothing for sure. Marina says, oh, believe me. If we could tell you, you would also agree. She then looks at me nervous, should we tell her anyways.

I didn't know what was the right thing to do here. Maybe Drew would agree if she knew everything. Drew made the decision herself, wait. Don't tell me. I rather not get biased. My priority is the patient. If David tells me instead, that’s different. Drew looked at our worried faces and says, sorry guys. But in my professional opinion, he shouldn't be fighting anyone. Then I had a desperate thought, take one session with him. Just one. If you asses that he is can't handle it. Then, I gulped hard, will, we will cross that bridge later.

Drew says, I told you. Getting involved would do more harm than do good. Also, there isn't any time. I cut her off, I know what you said. I also know David. The freaking guy would do it regardless what you say. He was strangely dead on fighting Charles even before his PTSD triggered. You could tell right, something changed halfway the match for him. Marina backs me on this, trust me, he is smart and crazy enough at the same time. We can't do what you can. With your help him, at least there is a chance he gets better. And that means better chances for him surviving the next fight.

Drew was dead silent. We gave a lot for her to chew on. I can't believe we are in a situation where Charles or David, either or both might back down from the deal. If that happens, Charles won't move his house here and we are back to square one. Drew finally speaks up, okay. Just one. She pulls her index finger in the air to us, I understand its very important. At least David himself knows he is a dire situation since he told you about me. What do you know about his condition.

That brought a little ray of hope to our gloomy discussion. Marina raises her wrist, M show us Davids charts. M hologram comes out and shows us the live status. Drew comes closer to inspect and surprises us by saying, M, show me the brain scans during the match. And also show the secondary charts on his dozes. M says, voice recognized. Accessing temporary authority on 2nd level medical status. Welcome Dr. Drew. M then enlarges and shows other stuff we never saw.

Marina shrieks, what is this. I didn't see this before. Did you know, she asks me. I shrug no. Drew took some time to analyze the new images shown. I ask her, you know M. Drew nods, yes. Its been actually quite effective tool in treating David. I also have a device setup in my room that connects to M. All though, it hasn't opened in the last four month. Having David as a patient has some benefits. We gave her some time to study whatever M was showing. After a while Drew tells us, this looks pretty serious. The last time I saw like this was…she stops realizing we were there, well, never mind. I have a general idea on his mental state. I will need time to study these.

She says, M, send me all these data to my access portal. Also, give me all the recordings you have during the match. I don't need to know the details of whatever deal David made, I only need to know what he said, when he said and how he said. Collate the data with that timeline. M says, running analysis and generating requested data. Estimated time, 2 hours. Drew continues, also show me the drugs you are using to treat him right now. I want to know the usage and history as well. M responds, request accepted. Creating a priority protocol for bosses recovery. With that M closes.

I ask, this isn't your first time asking such things. Is it. Drew says, I have gotten pretty used to M now. You think I would be helping David just because he sought me out somehow. In exchange of my help, he agreed loaning M for my own purpose time to time. Some guarantees about my family and this land. Marina laughs, that's makes sense. He can't pay you directly. Drew says, its been beneficial to both of us. I ask her, so what now. Drew says, I will go over this tonight. I should have something by tomorrow morning. Also, I want to talk to him before anyone. Its important for me to know his mental state before he is infused by you.

Jeez. She is very meticulous about her methods. I tell her, its going to be a little difficult. We had to move him to a secure location. And for the time being, we can't let anyone know where he is. At least until he wakes up. Drew didn't know about our situation, but she did her best, I see. How do I contact him then. Marina says, I don't recommend the way we did. I don't know what would happen. Drew is confused at this. Can't blame her. Marina raises her wrist, M, I know you said you can't tell me how to summon his fortress. But can you do it for the doctor.

M pops out, checking. Drew mumbles to herself, summon, fortress. I best ignore this for now. M says, granted access. Give a time, a high priority onboarding protocol can be provided for only Dr. Drew at a place. Marina waves her arms, great. Drew looked a little clueless here, but she nonetheless said, ah, how about you contact me when David wakes up. Even if it was the middle of the night. M says, confirmed. I will message you to your personnel portal. M pops back in setting that reminder.

I thank her, thanks doctor. Marina says, yeah. I almost thought it was over when you said David should quit. Drew says, maybe he should. But, I do agree it's not that easy. Besides, its my job to help him. I don't want to leave him helpless. We each shook her hands showing our appreciation. Drew says, I should head back. I told them I got a message something tripped our sensors. She walks back to mini car and drives off as we waved her bye. I ask Marina, David has to pull through, right. It was more of concern than a question.

Marina scoffs, he has to. He doesn't have a choice. He kept it hidden this long without any trouble. He has to get better. I felt the same. We began walking back to our jeep stashed further away. Once we reached the jeep, I noticed I have been getting a call on my phone for a while. It was on silent during the discussion. I thought it was Luther saying it was time. But it was Vanessa. I opened the call, hey Vanessa. I wondered what she wanted. Marina listened our conversation. Someone came to her asking about David.

Marina says tired, who is it now. You know, it's been a long day. I just want to hit the bed now. Then Vanessa told me Charles wife was there and wanted talk about the admins. I stopped in my tracks. This is very important. I looked at Marina who was jarred from her tiered attitude. I told Vanessa we are coming in. I close the call, Marina. We don't have time to take the jeep. Marina says, exactly what I was about to say. Lets jet.

With zero delay, we called on our Kuret and flew at full speed to Vanessa's house in section 3.

Vanessa (Chapter 46)

Monday, September 15, 2025 18:01

Clear what, I mumbled under my breath. My heart beats a little faster. Melinda turns to me, Charles told me he didn't get to explain everything of his fight with Wagner. And he wants to tell David. Charles told he doesn't want to fight David without telling the whole story. I got impatient and ask her, tell us. What happened with my brother. My voice came out harsher and coarser. Others noticed it also. But I didn't care. Blake clears her throat, she doesn't mean like that. Its just that Wagner didn't tell her about a lot of things. So please, don't held this against her.

Melinda looked little lost. She probably doesn't know of what's going on here. But she nods and continuous, let me first tell you that I didn't knew about this until Charles told me today. Also, Charles didn't want to explicitly tell you Vanessa. Because there are somethings you can't unknow. Especially when it comes to family. You really want to know. She was ominous, but it felt she was preparing me for something. I can't imagine what Charles didn't want me know. With a subtle nod I say, yeah. I need to know, no matter what.

Melinda replies, okay then. She takes a moment, glances to all of us and says, its true Wagner fought Charles. Its also true Wagner couldn't defeat Charles, but neither did Charles. Marina first spoke, what. The heck does that mean. She continuous, just what Charles told me. They were in a stalemate before using their overdrives. After, Charles couldn't fully control himself. Wagner realizing he couldn't defeat him straightforward, he took, ah, Heraknus kids hostage and used them as shield.

I spatted, what. That’s a lie. My brother would not do something like this. He was the freaking crown. He would never stoop so low as to use children like this. I could feel anger whelming in me. Charles is lying. My rage scared Melinda a bit. She shifts uncomfortably on the chair. Blake faces me, Vanessa. Stop it. You need to get a grip. I directed my anger at Blake now, are you serious. You can't believe this lie. Blake looks stern and says, I didn't say anything. I just need you to tone it down. Melinda is only telling us what Charles told.

But I was in no mood to listen to this nonsense. Marina steps beside me and says, maybe you shouldn't hear this. We can leave if you want us to. I can't believe these two. They don't even want to defend Wagner. They were just defending David, why can't they do the same for Wagner. Blake cuts in, yes. You don't need to hear everything. Lets leave. But then I cut in, no. No one is leaving. I want to hear what other lies you are going to say. Melinda looks worried and kept silent.

Blake and Marina looked at each other and to me. Blake sighs, I am going to say this only once. You either listen to what Charles told, or don't. You can't do both. Whether it’s a lie or not, Charles wouldn't risk contacting Melinda without a reason. So choose. He stares at me and waits for an answer. I can't believe I have to listen more lies. But I also can't walk away. Ah, this is so infuriating. After a lot of time, I made up my mind. Fine. I'll listen to her.

Blake nods and faces Melinda, sorry. Its not your fault. You warned her before. Whatever you say its okay. Melinda wasn't relenting this time. She had become even more hesitant. Other two stare at me. No way I am going to apologies to her. Marina shook her head and asks, Melinda, please continue. Melinda finally breaks and says, okay. Hum, those kids were actually Charles children with his first wife, my step-children, Gina, Rory and Tory. Thankfully, they were too young then to realize what was going on. Charles believes Wagner figured out Charles doesn't attack his blood family. He took them and barricaded in a house. Charles was out of his mind in that state, so he kept circling the house with his overdrive continuing to drain. In the end, Charles mother stepped in and stopped Charles completely. In that chaos, Wagner escaped.

I never thought I could get even madder than I was. Such lies. But I had promised to behave. Marina asks in confused voice, it’s a little hard to believe. Maybe he got desperate and had no choice. I shot a death stare to Marina who got nervous, or, you know, Charles is lying. Blake asks, what do you think Melinda. Do you believe your husband is lying. If he is, it doesn't make sense, why he would ask you to tell David. But if it true, that’s also crazy, the crown, everyone knows, would never risk children getting harm. There is a time where he risked his life to save kids instead of adults.

Melinda nods, even I can't believe. I have known Charles for 8 years. I know he won't lie about such a thing. I also can't believe Wagner doing this. I have met Wagner once. He seemed a good guy. When Charles told me this, I almost didn't want to do this. Blake says, setting aside whether its true or not, what did Charles wanted to confirm with David after hearing this. Melinda replies, David only accepted the deal after learning Wagner couldn't defeat Charles. He wants David to know the whole truth. This is nuts. Did Charles wanted David to back off the deal by spewing such lies.

Marina says, it doesn't make sense, why not just say just that. What's the point telling the rest of the story. Blake says, I was thinking the same. Did Charles wanted to show how dangerous his overdrive was by this story. He already told us abundantly before to David. Why bring the fact that Wagner had to use his kids to escape. I finally say, nothing about this makes sense. Melinda understood our confusion, I really don't know why. Marina asks, does he holds a grudge against Wagner or something like that. Melinda says, I really have no clue.

I had a nasty thought, he must be jealous then. If Charles really is this powerful, maybe he didn't like that fact that someone else is crown. It didn't matter to me if it made sense or not, I could only feel it. Blake murmurs, jealously. Is that really it. Marina scoffs, I don't think we will get anywhere without talking to Charles himself. For now, lets focus on this guys. I understood Marina was trying to get back to the task at hand, but my mind is too clouded to think clearly about Wagner and Charles right now.

Blake nods, you are right. He faces Melinda, ideally we should let have David decide himself about this. All I can say is that even if you did tell David that Charles didn't actually defeat Wagner, he would still fight him. I am sure of it. Melinda asks concerned, will he. How can you tell. Before Blake could speak, I cut in, because I talked to him earlier in the match. Two times to be exact. He has his mind set on winning no matter what. You can tell lie or truth to him, it wouldn't matter. Marina adds, yeah. I can vouch for it too. He wouldn't stop just from some story that's in the past, on a lost planet.

Melinda takes this in. A moment later she says, fine. I can at least see David would not back down. She tilts her head and makes up her mind. She stands up and says, I will talk to Charles and tell him about this. The rest is up to him. She walks to me and says, I am so sorry. I don't know if any of its true, but I know hearing something like this hurts. I was also why I chose to reach out to you as a last option. Please understand, I didn't have much choice.

I am aware its not her fault. But I couldn't bring myself to say anything to her about it. She turns to others, thank your time. I will take my leave now. Blake says, we appreciate you coming to us. It actually helps me a now knowing why the admins are taking so long to discuss. Marina also waves, and I haven't forgotten about you hiding your identity and job. I will talk to you later, you can bet on it. Melinda giggles a little, I would like that too. With that she walks through the door and steps out. I saw the 3 bodyguards on the move and they walk away from our view.

Marina whistles, damn. This is a mess. I don't know what's bad, people accusing David, Charles accusing Wagner or Davids condition. The last part made me momentarily forgot about the haze in my mind. I ask her, what do you mean by his condition. Is he not okay. Marina got nervous, which made me anxious. Blake waves his palm to me, she meant he hasn't woken up. Even now. He is fine. Marina nods impulsively, yeah. He is still resting. If he was awake, this would have been easier.

I felt a little relieved it was just that. Blake says, its best we don't say anything about this. About David's cheating or Charles, well, alleged story. We will only tell David when he wakes up. I honestly don't know what he would say. So lets not just blow our heads and create rumors. Okay. Marina says, agreed. They both turn to me. I already didn't want to talk about it, because they are lies. I nod in agreement. Blake says, good. I need to leave now. Luther messaged me when we were on our way here. I am so late, I have to leave now.
Marina says, seriously. That means you need to snuck into the building now. He nods. I was confused. I asked, sneak in where. Marina ignores me, but what about Melinda and those bodyguards. They saw your face. Blake nods, yeah. I was in such a hurry here, I didn't care much. Also, it doesn't matter after speaking with Melinda. Remember, Melinda herself said she didn't want to know anyone where she was or what she was doing. I believe that includes those bodyguards. So they won't tell she met me, well except for Charles. And right now, that’s the only concern now. Whether Charles would agree to us being Davids proxy.

Marina says, I really hope he doesn't back down since he didn't get to reach David. They both walk out through the door. I shouted behind them, hey. Where are you going. Marina says, you will know soon enough. Just turn on your TV. With that, those two used their kuret and flew away. Where the heck are they leaving to in such hurry. I closed the door behind me and slumped into the sofa. I put my arm on my eyes and laid down. I can't keep stop thinking those lies about Wagner. They have be lies. The brother I knew would never, ever do such a thing. Charles is lying. Or maybe he is confused. Maybe it wasn't Wagner. Yes, it has to be it.

But then how did Charles knew something that David also new. It can't be. I couldn't keep my thoughts in check. I obsessed over it continuously. I didn't know how long I was like this. Even when Siera came back, I didn't hear her until she asks for me, Vanessa. What's going on. I didn't answer her. I was in turmoil. Siera become worried, what happened. Did that women say something. Tell me. I finally moved my arms and sat straight up. Siera looks at me with fretting eyes. I told her, I don’t want to talk about it. She told me awful things. All lies. I don't want to talk and get worse. Its all lies anyways.

I tell she was bamboozled. She looked around the house like expecting to find some clue. I realize what she thought, no. We only talked. Nothing physical. Seria sighs, that’s something. If you don't want to talk, that’s fine. Its almost 7:00 now. You said you had a meeting with Catherine at 8:00. So, why don't you clean up a little before that. I didn't realize it was this late. How long was I lying here. I got up and tried to shook off the haze over my mind. I need to just focus on other things for now. I say, yeah. I think I will.

I go to the bathroom to take a bath. With a quick shower I got of my clothes into fresh ones. I am still shaken, but I pressed myself to focus on other things. I spent a little while going over the list of people assigned to the guest houses. With the addition of some reserve and volunteers, we have enough people to cover for tonight. I need to talk to Catherine what's the plan for tomorrow. In the worse case, Citradel people might stay here longer than anticipated. So we need around the call security around those parts of the Island as well.

After finalizing a draft of the roaster, I recorded it in my phone that dictated it. I took my jacket, tied my hair up and walked out of my room. Siera was sitting in sofa and looking at the TV. As soon as she saw me she asks, did you see this. I asked, see what. She points to the TV. I turned around. There were a lot of people in the background and a reporter talking, …going to wait for a decision. That’s the question in everyone mind tonight. We have seen many officers coming in, even after hours since this started. Lets ask one of them.

I recognized this place. Its in the front of the admin tower. I ask Siera, when we went to run, we saw unusual number of people out in the streets. Is that why. Siera nods, looks like it. I have been tracking since I left you earlier. I thought it would die out soon, but its still growing. The reporter come near an officer. Its Tina. She looked agitated. Reporter asks, how long have been here. She replies, I have been here for the same time other officers. Since the beginning. People behind them were now using kuret to draw attention to them. There was one that had drawn answers with a exclamation mark in the air.

The reporters asks, we have been getting reports from the officers. What's your take on this. Tina replies, I have pretty much the same questions as others. Why are they not announcing the result even when David was declared winner. Few hours ago, we saw few Citradel people going in, they were neither officials nor participants. So who and why were they here. I mean, people have been asking me all these questions, and I am beyond frustrated not having any answers. We created this rally to demand answers from them.

Reporter nods, and we all still wait for it. Thanks again officer. Tina leaves the screen. Reporter says, so heard it. The officers also have the same questions as anyone. Now lets switch over to the other side of the building, were now some Citradel participants have joined in. Siera asks, did you know about this. I shook my head, no. I did hear Blake and Marina talking about something like this before, but I didn't think much of it. I sat down beside Siera, I guess this was inevitable.

Siera answers, I am little shocked to see it organized so fast. In just 2 hours, almost a third of the people are over there. The camera now shows zoomed scenes of June and Marina walking into the crowd. I could make out some others too. So that’s why they hurried out of here. They wanted to get in the action. I spotted Matt and Cass near the front of the crowd. I didn't know they are also there. Siera asked, no one asked you to go. I replied, no. But I

wouldn't go even if someone asked. Me being there might cause more confusion when people ask me for details. Also I already know what's going on.

Siera says, that’s probably why Blake is also not there. I have been watching closely and no sign of him. Then I remembered Marina said about breaking in somewhere. Is that where he went. What's Blake doing. I got my answer after 10 minutes. The scene changes to the front of the admin building. Reporter was jubilant saying, we just saw the door opening. He and the camera ran through the crowd and navigated near the top. There was a line of people barricading the crowd. They were the Citradel bodyguards. My mind became focused and both of us leaned towards the TV.

The camera zooms into the person walking out of the building and walking down the steps. It was Blake . That’s where he was, with the admins. The crowd became chaotic, but the Citradel bodyguards kept them back. One of the bodyguards ran up to Blake. It felt like they were talking. Then Blake started walking inside, but the bodyguard followed him and they halted. They were talking more and then a while later they both came down the stairs. Siera asks, what going on. Was he with the admins now.

I don't know, I said. He was here just 30 minutes ago, does that mean he broke into the admin building. That’s bold. Citradel bodyguards part ways a little to allow Blake to leave. People all gather around him in frenzy. So did the reporter. Blake kept waving his arms around and saying something to people. The reporter comes in, Prince Blake. Were you with the admins just now. Can you tell us what's going on. Blake turns to him and shoves around to him.

Blake says, no. I didn’t meet any admins. I was in the waiting area. I have been there since morning except for while when I went for lunch. This caused a stir among the people. On the other hand, my jaw hung low hearing at this blatant lie. He has just here. Why the heck is he lying. The reporter confused asks, wait. You have been there all this time and still haven't meet with the admins. Blake nods, that’s right. I wanted to get answers from them in the morning, but they didn't allow me in. So I have been waiting. I told the officers that I will wait here until I get answers.

Reporter asks, that’s incredible. Why didn't you tell anyone. He replies, well I did. I told the admins that I wanted answers, just like everyone. Initially, they had agreed to let me in. But then the Citradel officials said it was an internal matter and didn't want me there. Fortunately for them, I don't have to listen to them. I do listen to the admins, and they told I could wait outside, and that’s what I have been doing. Trying to pressure them by my presence. Whenever someone comes out and goes in, I am there to remind them I am the leader of this Island. And people have the right to at least know what they have been doing all this time.

He takes a beat. Looks around the crowd who had gone a little quitter as he spoke. I also told the officers not tell others I was here. I didn't want people to get any ideas and barge in like I did. I didn't want anyone but me to take responsibility for whatever happen later. But I didn't know that this would happen. Reporter immediately asks the follow up, you didn't know about this rally. He nods anxious, yeah. No one told me. And the rooms were soundproof. I was actually coming out to get dinner. Next thing I know, there's all these people who are also waiting for answers, like me. I tried to go back in, but it looks like I pushed my luck. Citradel doesn't want me even inside the building now. The people around him shout at the security line. Some begin to cheer for Blake now.

The next question comes in, so you are also clueless as rest of others. He nods, yes. I have tried to play this safe. But they are testing the limits. And now it looks like others are also worried. I am sure they are watching this right now from their conference room. So I ask them now. No, order them. Give me some answers now, or I am about to bust in. You guys are mocking my authority, and that will not go unnoticed. Not while you are here. He was displaying anger now. Not a lot, just enough to make others around him riled up.

He then abruptly waves of, apologies. I am hungry, and a little tired now. He creates path around the people and walks away. The reporter says, you heard it everyone. Our prince is spoken that he is doing whatever he can to get answers. I just hope Citradel listens to him and all these people here. The scene then changes to an arial view of Blake walking around.

I chuckle, now that's a performance. Even though he lied through his teeth, it doesn't look like he is worried one bit. He must have kept hidden himself while he was out moving around. I did remember he telling Marina about no one knowing he was here. Siera asks, what do you mean. I told her, I just meant he basically threatened Citradel now. Seria smirks, sometimes pressure is necessary. Its been almost 8 hours, so I understand how he feels. Imagine being a leader of millions of people, but not able to do anything about this. Anyone would be angered.

I pretty much understood Blake's plan. And I guess Marina's too. They were talking about breaking into the admins waiting area without anyone knowing. He purposely made it look like he was there all this time. And still didn't get any answers. It's a dicey, but a clever plan too. If I remember, there are no cameras outside the rooms in the buildings. So no one could tell he lied. And even if someone did realize that, this public appearance there can't be denied. The best option was for Citradel to come out now. If they delay it further, it would only make him and now the people furious.

I got up and took my bag. I turn to Siera, looks like that was the most highlight of this event. I better go and meet Catherine now. I spotted some of the people that are supposed to be guarding the guest houses. They may be frustrated, but also made my job tougher. I have to pull them out of there. And soon. I'll see you later then. Siera asks, okay. Text me if you want to have dinner at home also later. I nod and walked through the door.

Blake (Chapter 47)

Wednesday, September 17, 2025 18:53

That went well, considering it took Marina and me much longer to find a way without anyone noticing. Luther had texted me more than ten times before I came out. Once I left the crowd he found me, hey, you had me worried. You were late. I replied, only 20 minutes. I am not a magician, you know. I didn't expect this many people. Our ideal way in was gone, so we had to improvise. He asks, we, you mean someone helped you. Was he really going to ask me this. I didn't want to share our shadow tricks. When I didn't reply, he gasps and says, right, the less I know the better. I nod, yeah. Besides, we sent the message to Citradel.

He says, you adlibbed some of the things I wrote, but that’s fine though. I was curious about one thing though, you said to say I wasn't aware of the rally. Why did you want it that way. Won't people now ask why you all never told me. He replies, I know it was idea, but imagine this. What would Citradel think when they heard you knew about this and did nothing. They would think you can't control people hear. That just undermines your authority. We can't have them think that. Its much better to have deniability by having you claim you hade no idea. I have told others to say that if we let you knew about it, you would shut it down. In fact, I will say that you tried to tell me now. And I resisted.

That actually made sense. Then I had another thought, that be just as bad. Won't Citradel think we have no control over people if they can go behind our backs. He shook his head firmly, let them think that. Actually, I want them to think that. That was a surprise. He saw me confused and explains, look Citradels officials have better military infrastructure than us, there's no doubt. But they also have stifled peoples own voices. Their civil infrastructure has holes. Since they hide among humans, people can't openly voice concerns like how we can do here. They instead have to schedule, meet in secret and keep everything under wraps. Only the representatives can make things happen. And the ordinary people would have to hope it gets done from few people. This causes more miscommunications, different intentions, or even different result than anticipated.

He really put this much thought into it. He continuous, actually, it has happens quite often after speaking with some Citradel people I befriended. Obviously, Citradel knows this weakness, but they flaunt their authority by showing how secure and stable they have been for almost a decade. Compared to the other risker groups, they are the most reliable. I figured we can show our strength in this particular area, where they can't. I have explained others to also say that people living here can approach openly. We would focus on the benefits of living here. People will cast aside their doubts of whether this whole thing was right or wrong and reinforce our promise of better life here.

Damn. He planned for everything in just short time. I am impressed by Luther's political aptitude. He exceeded my expectations. I slapped his back in admiration, I think you joining us was the best decision ever. Luther laughs, so that means I can have a raise. I chuckle, aren't you in charge of it. He smiles, deflecting. You are learning. You will have to do this for a while until our cities merge. There is still much to do. He doesn't how true he was. If the announcement goes how I think it will, the following days are going to be completely busy.

My stomach grumbled. I was hungry, that wasn't a lie. I asked him, want to get dinner. He chuckles, so that’s true huh. You go on ahead. I had an early bite. I have to go back and explain what we discussed to the people. I have informed some more reporters to join in. I want to bolster these benefits myself. Better impact, hopefully. I say, okay. Good luck. See you later then. We waved each other off and went our separate ways. On my way to the dining building I passed few people who wanted to express their feelings. Some asked if I knew anything more, some thanked me for my perseverance. I tried to have a good poker face.

I checked my phone which was buzzing with messages from the officers. I scrolled past to see if anything useful was there apart from comments about my performance. Sometime later I reached the building and entered through the officers door. I could tell by the auras from the walls that there were already few people inside. I walked up the stairs and stepped inside the hall. About half the people were here. Most of them were the ones who worked remotely. As I walked to get food, I bumped fist with people who cheered on my apparent sudden appearance.

I pulled up my tray and start organizing my dinner selections. Behind me I saw Catherine coming in with her tray for a refill, so. How was your day. She asks me coyly. I don't know what she heard so I replied, you heard right. Boring and tiring. I am used to be patient, from my training, but man, spending almost 5 hours straight killed my back. Those seats are not comfortable. I should ask you to fix that. Whoever chose that clearly has no taste. She laughs lightly, oh really. You do know that I picked them personally after painstaking time and effort.

Shit. I didn't know that. I just assumed someone else did it. Honestly, I was in such hurry, I didn't even check if they were good or not. But I had to keep going this, well. Ah, then I suppose you have to change it. I didn't know you were had such poor judgement in selecting. Remind me not to ask you for my new office later. She pokes me hard on my side. I had to keep in a laugh and tray from falling. She smirks and whispers, I know what you were doing all day. Vanessa told me. So you can drop it.

I figured Vanessa would tell her since they had a meeting some time ago. Catherine and I finished up picking my food. She points me to the table she was sitting in. It was by the glass windows. I saw Nathan and Jess already there eating. I would have preferred to eat alone with Catherine. I guess I can't choose so freely. With a slight disappointment I pulled up a chair and sat. Jess asks, saw you in the TV. Gotta say, I didn't realize you were trying to get in this whole time. Some people noticed you, but only till lunch. She looked slightly impressed.

I nod and started eating not waiting any longer. Nathan asks, its very curious though. No one knew you were there. Not even Citradel people. Which is quite confusing. I asked him, what makes you say that. I just came out from the admin building. And didn't you hear me telling I saying I saw other people coming in and out. Nathan scoffs, I heard. Funny enough, you didn't say they saw you though. Makes me wonder if you were really there. That guy. He accuses with such conviction. I think he has more definite proof that I was lying. I continue chewing my food, you can believe whatever you want. What matters is what people believe. That’s all I am going to say about it.

He laughs while eating a salad, fair enough. Catherine asks, what happened to David. I tried to visit him a while ago when I had a break, but he wasn't in the infirmary. Did he woke up and left already. I gave some thought on how to answer this. I have been telling others vague answers, but I wanted to tell Catherine the truth. I turn to face Nathan. Then I wasn't sure what to say in front of me. Nathan caught on my hesitation and says, you don't want me to hear. Right. He laughs amused at my suspicions. He glances at others and says, don't worry. I am done with my dinner. I am going back to the auditorium. I have arranged for some fun activities for the participants to engage in. Keep their mind off all the other politics.

I wondered his definition of fun, don't tell me you are having some competitions. Come on. My guess is right when he pulls out a suspicious smile, its nothing too extreme. There is minimal bodily harm. I grunted a little as my food logged in my throat. I coughed a little, what the freak does that mean. He takes his tray and gets up, just kidding. See, I don't you he would believe me. He points to others sitting here and leaves amused at my surprise. Jess shook her head, don't listen to him. I got that now. She says, its just a gathering of top fighters. We have organized few of them before, but not with these many people. He wants to share some stories.

I ask, about what. Catherine replies, about what they did on Earth. We know what Citradel did, but not people. Not individually. He is hoping to gather more information about their technologies and research. That’s actually not a bad idea. Then I ask Jess, you don't want to go with him. She laughs, yeah right. Like I need people judging me with my history. If I went with Nate, we both have to lie about the time in valley, if it came up. She sighs, David has pretty much warned me not to speak about the past. He told me for anything like that, I should let Nate be alone.

That’s strange. I didn't know that. I asked, but Davids okay with Nathan's lying. Why. She shrugs, I don't know. Frankly, I am relieved. I don't want to discuss that devastating part of my life. Catherine says, but also you don't want to set the record straight too. You could tell the truth what really happened. Jess keeps silent. I understood her feeling about it very well. I backed her, leave it alone. She doesn't need to do anything. We all agreed, as long as Nathan behaves now, it doesn't matter now.

Catherine wasn't happy about it but she let it slide. Jess thanks me with a nod, so. Lets hear what you didn't want to Nathan to hear. I glanced around once more with my aura to see anyone listening in. Few people looked are way, but that’s just because they waved at me. It was okay to talk about. I swallowed a bite and explained what I could. Even though I knew it was safe to talk, it was still a public area. So I told the things me and Marina did today, except leaving out my name. I hinted my involvement and they caught now that I didn't want to expose the lie is said in TV. I told them Marina moved David to his actual house. I heighted about the Echo technology, submerging house and robots.

I wished I also told them about Dr. Drew. But David's mental health has to be hidden. At least until her assessment. After I finished that bit of story they both were amazed by it. Catherine shrieks, the hell kind of home is that. Jess laughs, weirdly, it suits him. Virtually unpredictable, hard to detect and easily accessible. It was strange he lived in that normal house. Guess it makes sense now. Catherine then has a thought, is it okay to tell us that. Didn't you said David wanted kept it hidden for some reason. I reply, maybe. I don't know his reasons. But if he really wanted to keep it hidden, he wouldn't have even told Marina about it. So I guess its fine. Even I am little offended he kept such huge place secret.

Jess asks, now I have to see it myself. Next time I see David, I am going to demand him to let me see it. Catherine laughs, me too. Why only you, I mean, Marina got to see it. I nod, I am sure there will be line of people wanting to see. I hear someone coming behind me, line of people for what. Its Matt. And behind him Cassandra. They both walked to us with a dinner tray. I turned around, you guys finally made it. I heard its stalls are still going on late.

They both took a seat facing each other. Cass says, yeah. Our shift finally got over. I can't believe we had to keep it open. Matt sighs, the banquet getting cancelled made the day terribly busy. I am going to get shut eyes as soon I get home. It wasn't just them, it was everyone. Everything that was planned for tomorrow, we had to prepone it today. It couldn't be helped, thankfully we got through the day. Cass says to me, your day was also rough. Saw your surprise appearance in the TV. Matt while eating asks, and oh man. I love how you basically threatened them. I denied, to be clear I didn't. He scoffs, yeah. Fine. A warning then. Whatever, I bet that smoked their ass.

I eyed Catherine without anyone noticing. She immediately understood to keep the lie for now. She then says, it will most definitely will. But listen to this. She and Jess told about David's secret place. It was hilarious seeing their expression when they heard. I laughed while eating my food. Matt slams his fist on the table lightly, echo killer robots. Are you freaking serious. I corrected him, no. Later M told there are actual killer robots. So what Marina faced was just a patrol unit. Cass laughs shaking her head, freak it. How the hell David keep this from us.

All of us began talking what the insides of his house would have. This was a much needed fun topic to decompress. Even when everyone had finished up their dinner, we discussed other things. Matt and Cass talked about their arduous day. There was an incident where Citradel and Island kids fought over something silly as comparing food. Honestly, I have been on edge whole day. Its been a very long day. From finding David's actual home, to finding about his illness and getting Citradel to hurry up. Its nice to distract however much I could, before the impending bombshells, I am certain, heading our way.

After this well needed respite I told others I am going to the deck to check my messages. They all were pretty engrossed in speculating things about future now. I was a little anxious hearing them discuss so I used that excuse to get some air. There were few people on the deck. I took a empty spot on the edge beside the wall. With my back against the wall I leaned on and closed my eyes. Truth was I was now getting worried and didn't them to see it. After gathering my thoughts, I opened my phone to see any messages from Marina.

I told her to let me know when David wakes up. No messages yet. Dammit. How long will David need his beauty sleep. Actually, this is normal for him. He always needed this much time to recover, especially after an hour of intense fight. But we can't afford him to rest too long. He has to himself tell people that he is awake. Marina and I have told people that he has gone home to rest. But I am sure people have visited his decoy home. I wonder how long we can put off this.

My thoughts got interrupted by girls voice, you look tiered. Catherine is in front of me. I stagger a little. I didn't even notice her aura approaching me. I really am tiered now. I nod, can't deny it. Its been a stressful day. I enjoyed speaking to you guys, but reality keeps pulling me away. She nods and leans beside me. She says, I can imagine. I also had to deal with very unpredictable things. Citradel families keep asking about their stay and security. Did

you know the families wanted to open the park again. It wasn't supposed to open until tomorrow, but we had no choice but to open it early. And so many other things to keep them occupied.

It wasn't like my day, but I could image being hard on her. I laugh, you know. I got reminded today that we need to get used to this new life. But let me tell you, its been very tough. All this new responsibilities, I can't even begin to think how crazy it will become later. She laughs, yeah. Sometimes I feel it was way easy earlier. Fighting Echos or waging revolution. It was simple life then. Only she would think it was easy. It was a different kind of crazy for everyone. She caught on, I know what you are thinking. I must be out of my mind. But sometimes I just wish we could have stayed like that.

I saw aura changing slightly. Her mood worsened a little. I realized what she was meant. But I was too anxious to talk about it. I don't want to bring that up right now. We both were silent for a while. The silent was actually worsening my nervousness. I gave up and asked, you mean wanting to stay with Ned. I risked it and asked her finally. She looked somber when I mentioned his name. Actually, this been a thing with her. She said ever since coming here, she has less contact with Ned. It must have strained on their long distance relationship on them. She didn't respond, but I did believe she was talking about him.

I whispered hesitantly, the tournaments over. Regardless whether the next match happens, you can take a little break and visit him. Immediately I wished I hadn't said that. Her aura dipped once again. I didn't know it had became a sour topic for her. I spoke, everything okay. You seemed concerned about it. The way she is behaving, don't tell me they broke up. I couldn't stop from being a little anxious about it. It was like I was expecting it to be true. I soon realize it was a nasty feeling to have.

I quickly reflected on myself and said, forget it. I was just carelessly saying without thinking about it. She finally broke her silence, no. Its fine. Really. Its actually a nice to hear you say it. That nasty feeling just grew more and I wanted to kick myself over it. I don't even know anymore what I was expecting. Did they broke up or not. I definitely can't ask her directly. She says in a somber voice, I have visited Ned few times now. I took your advice and used the routes which no would look. I have been able to go out with the excuse of getting shipments from Citradel. We have been making it work. And its been nice. But..

Something happened. I could tell. I waited for her to say what it was. I don't know what I was expecting. Did they really broke up. But then she sighs, David found out that I have been sneaking out. He found out somehow. I don't know how. Huh. That’s not what I wanted to hear. But then again I didn't want to be jealous like this. I thought I made sure no one would ever find out she has been visiting him. Then it hit me. I asked, you two are at odds ever since your match. Don't tell me its about this. She nods reluctantly, yeah. He caught me before our match. He flipped out when he figured out I lied about breaking up with Ned. I got so mad at him. Did he really think it was easy to do walk away from someone you have been with for 5 years.

So that’s what's going on. I askes, is he really so much against it. She nods vehemently, sometimes he can be such a jackass. I know his previous relationship with a human didn't end well. But that doesn't give him any right to tell me how to live or with whom. She smirks, it got so bad that I told him if I won the match he would back off. That was silly. I lost so miserably. I finally realize the scope of what she has been going through. I told her, it wasn't silly. It just showed how much you wanted to be with Ned. I felt like I was forcing myself to say these things.

She shakes her head, no. I have been giving it a lot of thought for a long time now. It is silly because I thought I was giving myself an out. Like how I could have avoided this conversation if I didn't myself came over to talk to you now. I wanted to blame David and become the reason I had to leave Ned. I'll be honest, I have no idea what she meant. Did she want to break up with Ned or not. She sees my confused face, its nuts right. Believe me, I know. That’s why I have avoided talking about it with anyone. I don't want to leave Ned, and at the same time I know I will have to. I can't stay in a Medrone city and still have a relationship with him.

I wanted to say something that could help her. But I had no clue how. I am not exactly feeling impartial here. I just hope she doesn't ask me what to do. She then asks me, maybe you can tell me. You are the only one who has been supportive of this. Do you think I should leave a doomed relationship or make it work. Dammit. I had no luck here. I really didn't want to say I want to say here. I could tell she was waiting for my undecisive ass to say something. But I didn't.

She understood something and laughs, sorry. Its wrong to ask you this. I have to figure it out myself. I wanted to assure her with something, so inspired from Luther I said, my advice is that you do whatever your hearts tell you. Whatever makes you happy. That's sad. I couldn't come up with anything original or specific. She replies, wow. That’s, well. Okay I guess. I laughed, yeah. I know it's bad. I wish I could tell you what's right. But I am not going to be like David and make you force it. She replies, thanks. I knew you would understand. I should talk to Ned to figure things out.

I nervously asked, wait. Does that mean when you lost your match David asked you not to talk to Ned. Would he really use that silly bet. If she told me this yesterday, I would say no. But after knowing so many secrets Davids hiding today, I can't say for sure. She immediately says, no he didn't. Actually, he said nothing. Whenever we spoke, it would be just about work or something unrelated. He also avoiding talking about it. She then thinks about something for a while. She continuous, can I borrow Marina's device. I think I should talk to David also and clear the air.

I hesitated on this. She asked, is something wrong. I can't use that device. I glanced around and didn't see any one close by. I wanted to tell her about it for a while, but when others came in, I pushed it for later. But now, I think she deserves to know. I whispered, listen to me. You absolutely can't tell this to anyone. You hear me. No one. She was taken a back by my seriousness. She nods. I lean in and say, its best you avoid him for a while. He is not in a stable condition currently. She got worried, what do you mean. You told us he is okay. I revealed to her, physically yes.

Her jaw opens when she realizes, you can't mean. He isn't fine mentally. I nod, yeah. I myself found out today with Marina. He had been suffering from PTSD and other issues. She yelled a little loud, what. How that happened. And what other issue. I told her the symptoms M told us. Then I explained about Dr. Drew and how he has been going to therapy for it. Catherin's reaction was just like us. She didn't even see a hint of that this whole time. I explained how he would have hid it and has been actually getting better.

She scoffs, until today. Is that what happened when you carried him out of the stadium. I nod, yeah. The poor bastard was half passed out by the time I got inside his tank. Imagine the repercussions it would have if the doctor declares him unfit for the next match. It was the thing stressing me out the most. Her eyes widens, wait. Do you think he behaved like that towards me because. I answers, yeah. When you told me, I had a feeling it could be related to it. David's not the type to deal such indelicately on such matters. Considering is own history. Catherin says, you know. I couldn't put my finger on it. But he has changed a little since the war. I thought it was because he got his memories. Now I know its more than that.

She then asks me a difficult question, why did he not tell anyone. People have been getting counselling and therapy for years. Why keep it a secret. I didn't want to tell the truth, that it was because he is also a shadow. I also didn't want to lie. I have already lied to others. I told her, you have to ask David that. Both, me and Marina have a long list of things to ask him. She relents, I see. Must be tough on you both especially. Shadow agents not knowing others secrets. I can imagine.

I am a little conflicted since she really can't imagine. David's true identity. She then asks, who else knows. I tell, no one besides me, you, Marina and Dr. Drew. She realizes the gravity of the situation, seriously. Until today no one knew. How did he manage to keep it a hidden. I knew he has a good poker face, but this is crazy. I offered, like Vanessa says. He is genius, but crazy also. So now you know. And that’s why I am asking you to not talk to him. I don't know how exactly, but he has gotten worse. He might not be in his best mindset to hash out your differences.

After giving it some thoughts she says, after everything I thought that he. Our conversation got interrupted by someone yelling, everyone, there's an announcement from Citradel coming on now. My body jerked up hearing some guy calling out inside. I told Catherine, remember what I told you. Keep some distance from David for a while. She also reacted to hearing that, and I didn't see her agreeing to what I said just now. I was too anxious to worry about it now, so decided I will talk to her again later. I hurried in. This is it. Its finally the time everything is decided.

Blake (Chapter 48)

Thursday, September 18, 2025 17:29

The air had become filled with suspense. Everyone were staring at the big wall screen on the opposite end of the dinning area. Right now it was showing the admins building entrance. Everyone here hurdled near the screen. Some people preferred to sit and see. Catherine and I were on the first floor, so it was the best view anyways. We found others near the glass railings leading to the stairs. Matt waves when he sees us, guys, here. We squeezed into gaps among our friends. I ask them, its not yet started.

Jess replies, no. But the news came telling that the announcement is being broadcasted now directly from the conference room. Matt says, the rally and your speech did the trick. They had to do it soon since you provoked them. I am actually relieved that this crazy plan actually worked. Its been only 45 minutes since I spoke, so I hoped they would not keep me waiting for long. Otherwise I would really do what I said about forcing in. Cass gasps, look. Its starting. All our eyes glue to the screen. The screen changed to show the conference room. There are only two people visible in the screen. Charles and Reinhart. They both were wearing the same dress since I saw them this morning. Charles looked much better now. There were still signs of bruises over his face. Other than that he looked fine. They were seated on the conference chairs and facing us.

Reinhart goes first, good evening everyone. Let me first get out say that I want to apologies to everyone for how long this took. It wasn't our intention to make people worry. The contents of the discussion varied and we had to make sure nothing was overlooked. Citradel officials were put in a difficult decision over what happened during the final match of the tournament. Primarily the deal between David and Charles made. We have come to decision now. I will let the person who proposed it in the first place explain it. Please refrain from asking any questions until the end. He waves towards Charles.

I gulp hard. My nerves were acting up little. What would he decide after talking to his wife. He wanted to talk to David. Will he still go ahead with it. Everything about the deal would be laid out now. Charles leans in and says, hello. Like he said, I do want to apologies my part of the chaos that happened. That said, it was necessary. As some of you heard, I had to talk with people from my house. That took longer than anticipated. And now, we are in agreement. He takes a pause, during my fight, David found something. He found out I can overdrive. But there's a problem, I can, he clears this throat, I could involuntarily hurt others. I don't have complete control. Its also has the same weakness as any other overdrive, burns out my Kuret very fast. In my case, I can't use Kuret for months. While its powerful, its also dangerous. When he figured it out, he was about to make me use it. I couldn't let that happen with a crowd in close proximity. So I temporary asked for a break.

Suddenly there were murmurs and whispers getting passed around in the crowd. Charles continues, like everyone, I am very interested in his multiple kuret trick. I want to fight with my full strength. So I gave David an ultimatum, either we could continue the match without my overdrive or if wait for a month till my kuret recharges enough to use overdrive. And as Reinhart announced in the morning, David choose the deal. And after a little bit of negotiating, we both agreed. And now I want to confirm one crucial part of the deal. I asked for more time, selfishly, so in return I offered a compromise. Something that I had to discuss with my house before telling anyone.

This is it. My heart picks up faster waiting for the highly anticipated decision. So much is riding on this, which only few people knew about it. Charles takes a short breath and smiles, I am delighted to tell you the Heraknus house as decided to leave Citradel and move here. That moment, everyone were silent. The conference room was also silent as here. People were confused, amazed and anxious about it. But I was elated. I put my fist up in air, yeah I whispered loudly. This is what I have been waiting to hear all day. The four people around me saw me excited and took turning looking at the screen and me. I was smiling and laughter escapes my lips. I felt a lot of pressure off my shoulders.

Then people broke the silence and a commotion started. Then he continues, this wasn't just a whim. I had been thinking about it for some time. Ever since seeing the Island in person and its people, the tournament, I found that we can live openly here. We have been hiding our existence on Medrine for 150 years. We had to hide on Earth as well. I am tried living like this. Its time we come out and live free. He makes a stern expression, it will be difficult. I have no doubt our people will find adjusting to a life without anonymity. But its time, after winning the war with Echo we are on the cusp of finally becoming a defiant force. Us hiding would only hinder that effort. So I took this opportunity and offered up the deal to David.

People began speaking in groups loudly now. Would they realize what this means. Charles says, my house also agrees with me. After I explained my vision and hope for the future, they understood. And I hope with time, even those unsure about it will realize it’s for the best for our future generation. I am grateful for all that Citradel did for us, but its time to move on. Now's the time to build up our forces, not just hiding. To all those who have supported in keeping our existence secret here at personal costs, I thank you. Please understand it was a heavy decision after seeing the benefits for my house. Hope you all will understand. Thank you.

He turns to Reinhart, who takes over, regarding the next match. Its going to be a little different. As Charles mentioned, his overdrive is dangerous. We have to add more safeguards. Other particular details will be coming later. For now, I can only tell it will take place a month later in the same stadium. Now, we will open for questions. Give us 2 minutes for Citradel officials and Charles to setup here. From the side, 4 more people came in. One of them was Kafar. During this time, people here began discussing.

Jess is the first to yell, holy shit. I can't believe Heraknus are coming to live with us. That’s huge. Her excitement was showing up with a smile. Matt says, whoa. He actually did it. He convinced them to move here. Catherine says, that’s great and all but don't forgot what Charles said earlier. His overdrive is not only dangerous, its uncontrollable. Convenient he left that part out. I nod, that might be because he didn't want to scare people. But yeah, you are right. He could have shared more. Cass says, doesn't matter. We know. And David knows. That’s what's more important.

She wasn't wrong. Charles might be okay with sharing his overdrive dangers to us, but maybe not to people he is going to live with. He probably wants to ease into this. Catherine asks me, is David seeing this. Is he awake. I shook my head. Matt asks, seriously. Its been close to 10 hours. Is he really fine. At this point even I was a little skeptical. Nothing I could do about it. Cass says, his crazy gamble paid off. With Heraknus moving here, how long until others as well.

That’s now a waiting game. I glanced at my phone which as now constantly getting buzzed with messages over the network. Now that the officers know the whole truth, they must be overjoyed to hear this. I took the opportunity to add this message, just to let you know, Citradel people would now follow Heraknus here. So that means we have won the tournament. I am sure people would eventually realize this, I promptly shared to let everyone know of our victory.

The break was over. Reinhart says, we now going to answers from questions. I looked up to the screen after posting the message. I can't tell how many reporters were inside, one asked, Charles. I have question for you. Since your reveal, there's one question everyone's been asking. Why were the Heraknus kept their existence a secret on Medrine. Charles take a moment to answer. He looks a little concerned, I am sorry. I can't answer that. Its not just me, but the decision of my entire house. I know its pretty selfish of us to not explain. What I can tell you is that it was due to a terrible and worst moment of our history 152 years ago before leaving Medrine. I wish I could explain. Maybe in time I will be able to tell. For now, you have to believe it was for a good reason. A reason no longer having any meaning now that Medrine is gone. One of the officials says, what matters now is that Heraknus are now allies and fighting with us. Our focus should be on this, rather than the past lost on a distant home planet.

That’s strange. Earlier he said he was okay with explaining to David the reasons. I suppose after discussing with his house, they made him not share it. What could have happened that was so bad they went into hiding. Another reporter asks, its sounds incredible that no one knew your existence. Someone must have known about you. Charles nods, yes. That’s true. Few people did know about us. Obviously, the towns and cities in the mountains were we lived. They were our bridge to outside world. We didn't live in complete isolation you know. We just didn't have our presence known. If you think about it, we are like the shadows. They also operate in secrecy sanctioned by nations. Similarly two important bloodlines knew about us. Handful of the Earatius and royal family knew about us. I later learned Marina didn't know about me in Citradel and realized they never told the kids.

Several people around us stare at me. I shrug, don't look at me. I also didn't knew. The faces leave me and focus on the next question, you said your overdrive is dangerous. Can you explain more. Charles turns a little uncomfortable answering this, I have same problems as Blakes. I am can't control it well. And like I told before, it takes months for me to recover, so I don't get enough chances to train. Its very hard to learn under such harsh circumstances. Back in Medrine, the delays only few weeks. But I wasn't the alpha for long there. That's why I want to take precautions. He kept the part of attacking others to himself. Looks like other Heraknus didn't want him revealing too much.

The same reported asked a follow up, you mentioned your lack of control comes from not having opportunities. Are you treating your match with David to learn. He nods, that’s exactly right. I rarely, if not ever, get chance to fight someone in my overdrive. I believe he is up to the task. If not, I would have never suggested it. A follow up question comes in, can we get any details about your overdrive. Charles smirks, apologies. I can't reveal it, for now. You know who my opponent is. He is someone highly intelligent and resourceful. I can't leave any information here that he can use it against me later. I have heard enough stories about him to know that I can't underestimate him.

Its good to see Charles giving David high praise, but internally I am conflicted. With his current condition, his performance has to be impacted. Next reporter asks, there's a rumor going on that David cheated during the match. No one can explain how his anti kuret is able to do the things he did. Does that concern you with the decision to move here. Shit. I can't believe this leaked out. Melinda told this was part of the reason their discussion took long. Charles remained silent, for sure he was also not expecting this. Reinhart took this question, let me answer this. Theres nothing suggesting that there was any foul play. No evidence to suggest this. This is just a baseless rumors. That’s a relief. I guess Kafar's accusations didn't have much impact.

Another reporter asks, no one has seen David since the match. He left the infirmary and hasn't been since then. Is that not a concern. Reinhart replies immediately, not at all. Everyone knows he doesn't heal fast, so he is just resting at home. I don't know how he would know. Did he just guess, or someone told him. The only thing people know for sure he left. No one knows if he is even awake.

A new line of question comes next, now that Citradel is going to lose the Heraknus house, can you tell how it will impact you. This one was directed to the officials. The other 3 people turned to Kafar. This whole time he looked stiff. He didn't show much emotion the whole interview. I think he is defeated and painfully frustrated. He was so confident that Charles would never lose and we would move to Citradel. But all those plans fell apart with this deal. And now, it won't matter who wins. Citradel will have no choice to follow Heraknus here. Lets see how he handles it.

Kafar's clears his throat, obviously this is a great loss to us. They were our most powerful group of team and efficient deterrent that kept Echo leader away from ever invading us for a decade. Even when they knew where we were. People never knew about them, but they are our most treasured warriors. I wish I could have persuaded them to wait until the next match. He looks to Charles for a second, but I also understand their predicaments. Citradel main reason to remain secure this long was because we prioritized developing lost technologies and providing safe place to hide. Things have changed since winning the war against the echo leaders group. Heraknus now have different priorities. That’s just how things go, nothing we can do. He sounded salty and resentful. Even though he says he understood, its just for show. He truly believes moving to Citradel is the right decision for us.

A reporter asks, what about the people of Citradel. Since your most powerful house is moving here, will they also move. This women asked the most important question. Only few us knew about the conditions and their implications. That was until now. Kafar didn't answer. Or rather he didn't want to. I don't think defiance is going to accomplish anything. Realistically, there is only option. One of the other official spoke instead. She's a middle aged women, we haven't decided that. When we planned the tournament, it was to show each cities warriors and their strength. As a way to inform all the other scattered people over the globe. Its true we also made an agreement that we would move to the winners city, but David only won on technicality. Charles still has the opportunity to win the second half match.

I am sure they outright can't say they will also move. There will be resistance to this huge decision. At least they didn't say no directly. This is actually the best answer they can say. Reinhart cuts in, guys we have taken took much of their time. They have been here all day. Especially Charles, he didn't get much rest since his match. I would only just one last questions. Other questions will be answered later. The final question came, can you tell us

when Heraknus are planning to move. Since it was a sudden development, there would have challenges.

Charles answers, I have discussed this. We don't have all of it ready yet. So far, we will be leaving tomorrow morning back to Citradel. I will have to manage everything there in person. Since its our own decision, I don't want to trouble Citradel with helping us. However, I do want Blake to help us organize the travel. We have 74 people in my house. The families have their own stuff, we have our armory and weapons. I would like help on secure ways to transport them here. Meanwhile, I am sure it will take some time to build homes for us. We used to live in mountains in Medrine, but we do live in proper houses. We our own their preference. I hope they can be meet here. Considering all this, we have a tentative plan of about 3 weeks. I am sure I will be here few days before my match.

I was expecting that. Looks like I need to get ready for this as well. Our plans for explains have to be pushed faster. Its unexpected, but welcomed. The faster we can bring them here, the better our chances that they don't go back on their word. Reinhart cuts in, okay. That’s all for now. There are lot to be discussed, but lets table that for now. Thank you everyone for your patience. The people got up from their chairs began walking off screen.

The atmosphere here became full of exhilaration. People were cheering and applauding. It became chaotic, but for a good reason. People were relieved to here this. Actually more than ever. Catherine sighs happily, so I guess I have important work coming on soon. I nod, for everyone. But yeah, you will be travelling a lot I suppose. With her kuret, she has been guiding and managing bringing people from all over the countries. And she been to Citradel the most. She would the secure routes and ways to travel incognito.

Matt howls, hell yeah. We won. I don't care what that lady said, there is no way Citradel would do nothing as they lose Heraknus. Cass smiles, when they see their prized warriors leaving, they would have no choice. I say, it really depends, but I don't see how they can replace the loss. Jess says, imagine how it would be like if to know that secret team is a mythical bloodline. Right now the people might be in shock, once they get over that they will decide whether to stay or not.

Matt says a little excited, I know I am just spit balling here, but just imagine David winning. That would definitely be a decided then, right. Catherine says, if he won. Didn't I tell you earlier, Charles overdrive is dangerous. And David is. She shot me a look of concern. I shook slightly to warn her not to tell others. Matt shook his head, I didn't forget. But come on. This is David we are talking about. You saw him today. He is on fire. I'll admit I was worried earlier, but I think he will be fine now. I mean, think about it. He himself said he has a month time to master his new Kuret form. Cass had the same opinion, and don't forget about his strange new ability to use others Kuret. I also feel he has a good chance of winning.

I didn't have the heart to tell them that he wasn't in the best condition right now. Jess says, Catherine, I know you are worried about him. But don't forget he has knack for getting what he wants. Catherine felt conflicted, just like me. Now I am feeling a little guilty sharing this to her. Maybe I shouldn't have. But I wanted to tell her the most. She and David have been oddly similar in their thinking. And also, their argument could be due to that as well. I just hope it wasn't a mistake.

I made up my mind about something, guys. Lets not get carried away. Not until David wakes up and tell us himself. I am sure its not just you, soon everyone would wonder about this. Weather David wins or not, the most important thing is we got our objective. Okay, maybe not completely. But I bet it will become clear when Heraknus moves here in 3 weeks. Actually, I think with this revelation, it’s a good assumption people all over the world would join us. That what's important. And I want all of you to also mention this to others. I don't want to pressure David more than he already is in.

They all agreed and understood my intentions. Matt says, Cass, lets go celebrate our win. Lets go get a drink. Cass was surprised, really didn't you said you were beat and wanted to go home. Matt scoffs, after this I am wide awake. Come on, lets call in others too. We can have a party at Catherines place. She shot a look a resentment at her name, hell no. The last time you guys came in, you all left a big mess. Go do it some place else. I actually want to sleep now. Matt smiles, oh come on. When Catherine should more reluctance, Cass says, its fine. I also want to have a drink. Lets do it your place Blake.

Now I became the target. I was worried about many things. Maybe a night off is what I needed. I at least deserve this much, yeah. I am down. I was also tiered. But now I too much excited to sleep. I turn to Catherine, you sure you don't want to join. She shook, I need an early head start tomorrow. So I am going back home. Before I can stop her, she already left us. I asked her to wait, but she didn't listen and disappeared in the crowd. I can't really blame her, I did tell her about David's secret.

Matt asks, Jess you in. Jess looks over to me. I say, I have no problem. Matt says, I know I am being rude, but don’t invite Nathan, he would only bring down the mood. Jess smirks, don't worry. I wasn't planning to. He messaged me a while ago, he is staying late with his group of warriors. Matt cheers, great. Lets see if Tessa and Vanessa can also make it. I also messaged Marina to meet us at my place. It didn't even take a minute before she responds she is in.

She also added that she is bringing her special home brewed drinks. I sighed. Great, a drunk shadow is what our predecessors never would have imagined us doing.

David (Chapter 49)

Thursday, September 18, 2025 23:11

I am looking over a corpse. No. a dying one. Then another one. Then others. I have seen them before. Many times. This is a nightmare. I could felt my body was weighed down. Why was it. I didn't need to look far to realize, it was the guilt. This is what happened on the last day on Medrine. They all died, I survived. Somehow I was spared. I felt the blood of others on me as I fall on the debris. Where was this. I know this. Where have I seen it. I felt an explosion behind me.

My body is paralyzed. I couldn't even move an inch. I turn my head, the view changes sideways to a burning ground. The heat felt so hot, it was searing my skin. My vision is distorted from the fire consuming everything around me. I hear someone beside me. They were shouting something, but my ears were ringing too loudly to make out what they were saying. Soon my vision turns blurry to see a two figure moving around me. One of them was big and clearing the debris around us. The smaller one was kneeling down on both legs and doing something. What's going on. Who are they. Like a hammer drilling into my head, I felt a bone chilling pain. I cry out in agony, but no voice came out. Or maybe I couldn't hear it because my ears hadn't stopped ringing.

The taller figure comes closer to me and speaks something inaudible to me. I hear only muffle noises. The tall figure moves over me and begins to moves his arms over me. I didn't understand what it wanted to do. Then I realize it wasn't just gilt weighing me down. I was actually buried in debris from the explosion. The figure is removing it from me. My body gradually begins to feel lighter. Soon I could hear the figures voice better, can you hear me. I am getting you out of here. It's Hanson. His voice is still muffled, but I know its him. I couldn't reply. My body is still paralyzed.

He pulls me out and carries me up with his arms. Like a lifeless doll he carries me out from what looks like a mini crater in the ground. What was it. Slowly I began to remember. We are boarding the ship. I am in the dantlement base in the Tangela empire. I remember an explosion before I boarded. Hansen lays me down at the edge, I need to help others. I am too dazed to remember who were others. Then it came back to me, Brandon and Zakerine. I wanted to help too, but my arms won't budge even a little.

I had no choice but to wait from them. Then I heard a screaming voice. A girls voice, let me go. He is still alive. I can save him. Its Zakerine, she is yelling and crying. I vaguely see Handen carrying her on his arms, listen to me. There's nothing we can do now. He screams over her own. He says, you can still make it. You both can. He comes out of the ground with a kicking and shouting Zakerine on him. She tries to resist and free herself from him, but he persists to carry her away. She yells, let me go. He can heal. He can't die. He promised me we both are leaving together. Her voice is breaking from her cries and wailings.

Hanson says, not from this. You know that. Don't let their death be in vain. John wouldn't want that. He wants you to escape. What. Even with my mind in scrambles, I couldn't believe what I heard. John is dead. How is that possible. I didn't saw him earlier. I don't understand what's going on. What happened to Brandon. Just then I heard the sky creating huge noises in front of us. My head is still not moving, so I roll my eyes instinctively. Two ships were zipping towards us from the edge. A chill went down my throat. They are here, somehow they found us again.

Hanson says with a stern voice, so two made it through the defense line. I expected them reaching here, but not so soon. He grits his teeth as Zakerine took her chance and brake away from Hanson. He shouts behind her as she rans back into the hole in the ground, what the hell are you doing. We have to go now. But she didn't listen, instead she used her kuret to pulverize the large debris. Hansen turns to me look at me. My vision was clean enough to see his bruised and battered face. Blood slipping down his forehead. Then he turns to the sky. The two ships begin firing at our ship.

Their weapons fired blue streams of missiles. Our ship was still grounded, and it couldn't evade it. No. This can't be happening. Our ship wasn't fully active, it was still charging. Those shields will not be up in time. I tried to move, to warn them. A rather useless move since I can't move at all. I closed my eyes to avoid watching the horror about to unfold. I felt a big tug from my shoulder like someone dragged me. Then came a large crushing noise, so loud that pales in comparison to the previous explosion.

My body stopped getting dragged and I stumble inside the hole. I open my eyes in a confusion on what happened. I saw Hansen pulling me back inside. He says confidently, just in time. We got reinforcements. Don't lose hope just yet. Your guys are escaping no matter what. I couldn't see what happened, but I saw many kuret waves in the air. The two Echo ships were still firing, but they were pointed to other targets. Something I can't see from here. Hanson turns to Zakerine, Z, we need to leave. We don't what other reinforcement are on the way.

However, she wasn't going to back down. Now that I was back in the hole, I could see what happened earlier. She is using her Kuret on a body lying on the ground. My heart beats faster while my blood freezes. Its John that's laying on his back covered in blood. His mouth gushed out blood flowing into the ground. My eyes widen when I focus on his eyes. They were open, staring into the sky unblinking. He is dead. Zakerine is trying to revive him by transporting his blood inside. She scooped up his blood with her bare hand from the ground and uses her kuret to open a channel inside his body. I wanted to help her, but what can I do with this useless body I have. I still can't move.

I dart my eyes over to the another body lying beside him. It's Brandon. He is also not moving. My heart sunk down further into despair. His covered in debris and pool of his own blood. His neck cocked to the other side. No. No. Not him. This can't be happening. Even after seeing so many bodies, I still am haunted by another one. Hansen comes over to my view, kneeling down and dragging himself towards a wailing Zakerine. She kept using her kuret fiercely transplanting Johns blood back inside. Hanson says, stop. Save your strength. There is no point. He lost more than just his blood.

I can't see from here, however, I could tell there was a big hole on his stomach. No, I wanted to say. He can be saved. They both have to be alive. I could tell my rational part of the brain was gone. I couldn't think straight anymore. Hanson puts his arms over Zakerine and tries to pull her away. She rebels with fierce intensity. She elbows Hansen in his stomach and gets shoved back. She yells, get out of my way. I will save him. He isn't dying. Hansen stumbles backwards on his back towards me. He spats out, snap out of it. I know you much he meant to you, but you have another one who needs your help. He can't move at all. I have lost too much kuret. I need you to carry him to the ship.

She didn't budge, she continued with her pursuit in reviving John. I wanted to help her, and yet again I am reminded of my uselessness. She cries out, he protected me from that blast. Stupid. He pushed me down before I could react. I am not letting him die. Hansen barks, I know. Brandon saved us too. They were true soldiers. So are you. Don't let their sacrifice be in vain. They didn't save us just to be killed later. So lets leave. She shouts back, I don't care about shadows. I only care about John.

I can't tell what's worse. Zakerine trying to revive a dead body. Hansen unable to pull away her. Or a strange nasty feeling that she didn't even care about. No. I am going crazy. She is just in shock. Seeing her thralling like this jerked me out of statis. I am able to focus a little now. I am still angered with their deaths. However, I also don't want to waste it by staying here. I try to open my mouth, nothing came out. Then I tried moving my hands. I felt a little bit sensations in my fingers. I began tapping on the ground, hopping it would get her attention.

Someone did realize I am trying to reach out. It was Hansen. He turns to me while still lying down on his sides. He saw my hand. He immediately understood and says, Zakerine look. He also wants you two stop. He needs our help. So please stop this. I thought she would listen to his pleas. But both of us where wrong. She didn't even stop for a second. I couldn't tell how much blood she has transported into Johns veins. But their were no signs of life returning in his body. Hansen shouted again, but was cut mid sentence when a ship's noise became louder.

I heard the sound of ground erupting around us. And it was getting closer. Hanson grew desperate in his attempts. He grabbed Zakerine on her waist and pulls her back. She rebukes him and wrangles her arms to get free of him. But Hansen was more determined. With a tighter grip, he drags himself and Zakerine across the debris filled hole. He slithers closed to me and pushes closer towards me. He pulls his body over the two of us. Zakerine yells her lungs out, creaming and waving her hands towards the other side.

The sound of erupting ground became louder. The debris were now flying all over us. I couldn't hear Zakerine scream over the noise approaching us. She kept trying to shove Hansen while pointing to John's body. Which was now riddled with a barrage of attack. I couldn't control myself from feeling nauseous when I see both their bodies being pulverized. My eyes become blurry with tears. I tried to close my eyes, but this time I was too afraid to close them. The countless rounds of attack kept moving, like nothing happened from one end of the hole to the other. I was too much in shock to know if we were also hit.

Once the sound of the attack subsides, Hanson moves a little. Zakerine is now hysterias with madness calling out Johns name. She pushes Hansen away, he grunts and rolls down. She drags her body to where John and Brandons body were seconds ago. A whole new layer of dirt and stones covered us. Hansen shouts, Z, don't. We need to move. As she drags on all fours, kicking and pushing away all the debris in path, she says, shut the hell up. I can still save him.

This is too much for her. She has lost it. I can't see them anywhere, but Their bodies must have been torn into pieces. There were blood stains in their places. I felt I could pass out anytime seeing so much blood and carnage. I pushed myself from getting lost. I have to focus on getting Zakerine out. Even when there is a blood coming from Zakerine as she dragged away, I kept trying to move my hands. Hanson also saw it and shouts, Z, stop. You are bleeding. Why didn't you use your kuret to protect yourself.

Hansen crawls behind her. She spats in anger, I can still save him. I need to save my Kuret for him. She's far too gone. There is no one there anymore, yet she continues to struggle. She was hurt and couldn't move properly. Hansen got up slowly and slid across the ground. He puts his arms on hers and pins her on the ground stomach first, stop this. Focus on healing. You are bleeding too much. She struggles to get free from his grip, let me go. I will use all my kuret to save him.

Her rant is becoming more deranged by the second. Hansen calls her out, he is gone. Theres nothing. But you are still alive, help yourself. Heal. Now. She didn't listen, she didn't use her kuret. More blood pours from her on the ground. A sharp tug pulled in my stomach. At this rate, she will loose too much. I try to tap my fingers more louder. But it wasn't going to reach them. Zakerine had completely lost touch with reality. Hansen yelps, Zakerine. Stop this. Heal your wounds before its too late. Save yourself. We waited for few seconds, but nothing happened. She either wasn't listening or refused him.

Hansen kept trying to convince her to focus on healing. But she never did. The pit in my stomach grew. I kept thrashing my fingers on the ground, thinking she will listen. Then it happened. The moment of complete dread. Her arms and legs struggle less and less. And then, the inevitably they stopped. Hansen looked distraught when she lies still on the ground. He shouts, no. no. Wake the hell up. At that moment, I stopped breathing. My heart left like it was just a rock pulling me down. This can't be happening. Hansen moves her body from below and lays her on her back. Her entire body is covered in streams of blood. From her face to her abdomen. I saw a large wound on the waist. The last attack, she was hit there.

In my utter despair, I tried to move with all the strength left in me. Nothing happened. I cursed myself and kept trying. Hansen shakes a lifeless Zakerine from her shoulders, Z, come on. Heal. You hear me. You can't give up. Her face looked tired and her eyes stared unceasingly disconnected to reality. My effort to move didn't yield any result. I saw the slivers of life draining from her. It felt like it was coming out of me too. No matter how much I shouted from inside my mind, she never heard it.

Hansen kept calling her name and shook her vigorously. Her necks suddenly tilts sideways towards me. The last of her life slipping away. I could only watch in horror as I see her kuret and life leaving her eyes. Blood gushes out from the corners of her mouth when she opens it. She struggles while whispering, I am sorry. I have to tell you something. Hansen shouts over her, no. Save your breath. There is still time. She ignores him and coughs

out more blood, my, our, secret. We should have told you before. Its…

Just then her mouth stops moving. Here eyes becomes vacant. No kuret. No life. Nothing. I can't see anything in them anymore. My heart felt it was literally going to be torn into pieces. I can't let her die. I won't. I have to save her. Hansen kept trying to pound on her chest, don't die. You can't. The continues drumming on her chest does nothing. Hansen slumps on his legs beside her body. I shout at him to keep trying. Don't stop, I kept saying in my mind. He saw me looking their way. He looked defeated.

He speaks to me in a slow somber voice, she's gone. My mind went blank. I couldn't save her. I couldn't save anyone. This is a nightmare. Yes, it is. I just need to wake up from it. Then everyone will be back. I will wake up from this horrible nightmare and be back in my room. I could see Zakerine, John and others in the shadow training grounds. Everyone will be alive and happy again. I kept trying to leave this nightmare, but I wasn't waking up. This can't be real. It has to be fake.

Hansen voice cuts in, lets go. We have no choice now. If I can save you, I could at least do one thing right. I hear Hansen footsteps getting closer to me. Just then a huge noise came from above us. I look up into the sky. One of the ships were directly on top of us. This is it. I could see our end now. There is no way Hansen can get himself or me from out of here now. I wished to wake up from this horror reality. Hansen yells to the sky, you haven't won. Even if I die, you won't be able to kill our future. His voice is trembling with fear. He is scared.

Then came a flash of bright light. That’s it. Yes, finally. I am walking up from this retched reality. But it wasn't what I expected. The ship blew up from the middle. Pieces of burning pieces shoot down from the sky. A figure came down from the Echos ship. It's a person. I couldn't see the persons face. I couldn't tell from the Kuret who it was. This person covered in dirt and lands down slowly between Hansen and me. With his back facing me he turns to Hansen, who was shocked to see this person. He asks, how are you here. I heard you were on the other side of the shore.

The mysteries person says, I was. Then I heard a warning about few encroachment ships crossing the border. I knew this would turn into a bloodbath, but I had. He suddenly pauses. He looks to the ground and sees Zakerine body. He crouches down and puts his arm on her chest. He hesitantly says, she died. I was too late. Another thing I couldn't stop from happening. I didn't understand what's happening. I didn't care anymore. Hansen voice breaks down, I couldn't save her. Her death was completely my fault. Even with Branden and John saving us, she died. His voice filled with regret.

The person stands back up. He speaking in a stern tone, I know you did your best. It was her own decision. Don't blame yourself. Hansen jerks up staring at the person, you saw. No, You knew. But then why didn't. The person cuts him off, I warned her. And I hoped she would make the correct choice. But I can't control someone's destiny. No matter how much I want to. I have tried numerous times. The best I can do is nudge in the path we need to go.

Hansen was silent for a long time. Then he pull himself up, you are right. We haven't lost yet. The person replies, that’s right. This is just the beginning. I am here to make sure that. Hansen walks to me and pulls me up. I didn't have any strength in me to even resist. I didn't want to leave Zakerine. Her lifeless body lying there reminded of my failure. If only I could fight back, only if I was stronger, I could have protected her.

Hansen pulls me up in his arms and asks, are there more of those ships. The person says, not anymore. I destroyed the rest coming here. We should be fine for a while, at least until the ship is fully operational. Hansen carries my in his arms and walks out of the hole. The other person follows us from behind. Hansen asks, is he going to all right. I am worried about him. He has seen too much. The person didn't reply for a while. Then he says, eventually, yes. The scars from today is not something he will be able to overcome soon. But it will happen. Hansen says, what happens to others meanwhile. He will be emotionally damaged, he can't help others in this state.

We reach near the ship now. I felt the silent humming of the engine coming off it. The hanger was still open. The person replies, trust in your successor. And trust in the other kids. They will find their own way. Hansen brings me closer to the entrance of the hanger. Two people come outside to meet us. One says, your made it. Well done. Where's is she. Hansen steps forward, she couldn't make it. Take him instead. The other guy shouts, what. No. But she was just here.

Hansen says, she got caught in the attack from the last two ships. Take him instead. The first person says, but he is not authorized. We have a strict list of kids to take in. We can't take him. The second person says, we even had to replace the Baratheon kid from her brother just now. Is there any relative left that can replace Zakerine. Hansen shouts in anger, she was last of her bloodline. Just a while ago before dying she turned from alpha to omega. There is no one to replace her. So take him.

The two guys were shocked and stayed silent. The mystery guy says, listen to me, you don't have much time. Other Echo ships will be soon here. Check the reserve list. Search for the name David. The first guy pulls out a kuret device from his pocket. It opens to a display and he searches for it. A moment later he says, yes. His name was added as a priority. The second person relieved says, is that right. Then we will take him. Is he okay. He isn't moving.
☐Hansen hands me over to the person. I felt no sensation as he hands me over to that person. I didn't even feel anger being handled like this. I just wanted to leave this nightmare. The mys
details in his directives. Make sure you follow everything it says, no matter how absurd it sounds. Follow it to the end without a single mistake. Do that and I guarantee he will survive this. The person holding me says, I understand. We promise to protect all the kids onboard this ship.

The person then carries me inside. I didn't have even the strength to resist leaving Hansen. Hansen behind me says, don't forget what I told you. Survive, no matter what. You will become stronger. Do it for others, but more importantly, for yourself. And if luck allows us, we will meet again somehow. I didn't understand a word he said. He said with such convictions that made no sense. He probably also lost it like Zakerine. The mystery person steps closer to Hansen and puts his hands on his shoulder, come. Like you said, this isn't over yet. We have work to do. Hansen says, lets go. They both turn and walk away, leaving me like this.

That was my last coherent thoughts of Medrine. I saw the insides of the ship with blurry images. Nothing resisted to me as the man carried me inside to who knows where.

David (Chapter 50)

Monday, September 22, 2025 19:55

All I saw see is darkness. Nothing. My mind is completely disoriented, so is my body. Where am I. Then my eyes open flew open immediately. Bright light encompasses my view, jarring me out from the nothingness. My body jerked around figuring out what's going on. Gradually my eyes adjust to the light. I see something familiar as I stare at the white ceiling. I rack my brain trying to figure out what happened to me. Then I see movement on my side. I turn my head to see the source, which turned out to be something big and dark.

Its familiar, why can't I remember. My vision becomes focused and I see what it was clearly. Its an Echo. My heart went wild uncontrollably. My lazy senses became sharp at the sudden anger swelling inside me. Just on raw instincts I forced myself up. I could vaguely feel I was in a bed. The Echo was twice as large as me, with long arms and a weird head. I don't care who it looked like. They killed everyone I cared. Zakerine, John, Brandon and Hansen. Their names came to me before my own.

I didn't care to check where I was. I got out of my bed and attacked that echo with a fist. The Echo didn't block and instead took it squarely. There was large sound coming from around us. But I am on a rampage. My mind solely targeting it. I punched another time, even kicked barefooted. The pain coming from my hands and foot didn't even register. I continued attacking on my instincts. The Echo didn't fight back. It just stumbles back without falling down.

My anger grew, I shouted at the top of voice, I am going to kill you. And your king. You hear me. My barrage of fists unceasingly pushed the Echo back. There was a voice saying something, but all I am thinking about is killing the Echo. Suddenly I felt something surrounding me by my torso. It felt like straps is covering me slowly around my arms and legs. I yell, don't even try to stop me. I am going to freaking kill you. My mind is laser focused on fighting, I didn't care about the restraints I am about to be in.

The straps becomes tighter and I felt my movement become restraint. I struggled to get out of it. This triggered the memories of Zakerine and how Hansen had to drag her away. That made me even madder and I lashed out like an animal. I felt a small prick hitting me in my neck. I immediately leaned away shouting, get your freaking hands away from me. Suddenly I felt a wave of chill running through my blood. I felt my body becoming colder. No, I can't die. Not before I kill all the Echos. I kept shouting and struggling to get out.

A second later a sharp sting passes through my brain and spine. I close my eyes from that disorientation and jerk my head around to shake it off. A second later I stopped my arms and legs from lashing around. Wait, what happened. Why am I being like this. Gradually I able to think more about me and my surroundings. My thoughts become more cognizant as each moment passes. I rolled my eyes around the room I was in. I know this place, and then I realize its my room. Its my table, bed, windows and fridge. Everything like I recalled.

Like a wave crashing, my memories flood my thoughts. Dammit. I know now what I am doing. This is not Medrine. I had another night terror. I had to relieve my final day on Medrine. Just like during the match, I was able to recall my memories better now. I witnesses their death with more details now. The conversations that eluded me earlier was clear now. I can't believe there was a chance to save Zakerine. Hansen did his best, but her stubbornness got her killed. How did I not remember this. I thought she was hit from the stray attacks and died protecting me. But that’s only half true. She could have healed in time. I recalled Hansens desperate attempts to snap her out of her delusion.

Its strange, but I can't stop feeling confused and anger at her. We were all close friends, but we were also shadow. She was in training for this. And also I can't believe she chose him over me. We were supposed to be together, no matter what. I immediately threw that horrendous thought from my mind. She was distraught about losing John. I was the same. I don't know she experienced before that, she must have been through more than just that moment. But still, it pains to realize she could have lived if she just gave up on John. Branden and John gave their life protecting us three, and somehow only I survived. She could have lived too if I was so helpless back then. My mouth dried a little with this revelation.

And then there was the person who saved us. I can't recall who he was. Maybe the memories are still incomplete, but that doesn't make sense. Why I can't remember only him. I must not focused on him at that moment. Makes sense, I was not in my right mind after witnessing their deaths. So who was he. What did he know about Zakerine and me. The way he said things, like he has been in contact with Hansen and us for a while. I don't understand how anyone outside of shadows would be. Hansen seemed very trusting of him. More than that, he probably knew him. I know all shadow members, present and past. He wasn't in that gathering.

The way he destroyed the ship and landed on the ground, there wasn't any kuret around him. I didn't have the abilities to see them back then, but to destroy a ship singlehandedly so easily, his kuret must be strong enough to seen physically. Yet, nothing. I don't recall any kuret around him. Just who is this person who is this strong and trusting of Hansen. No matter how long I thought, I couldn't figure out. I refused to believe he was a random person helping out. But its also true I can't figure it out right now.

I let out a big sigh, its okay now. ART, you can release me now. The bindings on me begins loosening. My arms free first and then other body parts. I stumble a little as I regain my stance. Number 3, the one I attacked was just waiting in front of me. A hologram comes from the walls to my side. It was M, vitals stabilized. Sedative effective at 88%. Are you feeling better now.

I actually did. I nod at her. I look to my back and see two other Echo bots, Number 1 and 2. I shook my head in distraught. I really thought the last time was final. I haven't had a night scare for long time. I still haven't gotten it out of my system. I turn to the display in front of me that was monitoring my vitals. The time at the corner showed 2:18 AM. Jeez. I have been asleep for about 16 hours. I look down to see a white medical dress on me. Then I look down on my hands. My knuckles were bruised and few drops of blood fell to floor. My toes were also similar condition. I grit my teeth in anger. I totally lost it this time. All the previous times, I am scared. But this time went beyond just shouting. I put my hands down suddenly feeling tired.

M says, boss, you should to lie down. The modified sedatives are very powerful. I had lost all any resistance and just listened to her as I lay back on the bed. M says, one and two, sterilize the floor. Three, bring the prepared electrolytes and medicines. Three runs off on his wheels through the door. The other two prepare to clean up the blood from the floor. I leaned my back on the pillow, what happened. How did I get here. M replies, you were brought here by Blake and Marina.

That’s surprising, since I didn't gave Marina's device the authority to call ART. I ask, how that happened. M says, unclear. ART received an decommissioned onboarding request. Instead of denying it, he decided to follow protocol with a risk assessment protocol. I recalled what that meant. I laugh lightly imagining what those two must have faced, they must have been surprised. M continues, the patrol bots brought you in and we dived back into the ocean. Three hours from now, your tank device cleared your recovery and so we pulled you out and into the bed. We are currently 700 meters below surface sitting on a underwater reef edge.

One and two finished cleaning the floor. Then they took bandages kept at the corner and rolled on each side of the bed. M says, boss, we need to disinfect the scratches on your hands and foot. I understood and spread out my hands and legs. They each take one hand and began cleaning with disinfectors.

Then three returned carrying multiple trays on him. With his four arms he dexterously places them beside me on the side table. Apart from the food and drinks, I don't remember adding other stuff here. I ask M, what's this. Did you add stuff without me knowing. M's hologram walks near the spread on the side tables and waves, these are the usual. And these, pointing to the new stuff, are the recommendation from Dr Drew. I realize something from this. Drew knows about my episode. Shit. I remember now, just before passing out I told Blake and Marina about her. I ask M, tell me everything I missed. I have a feeling a lot of things have happened now.

I listened to M explaining all the conversation recorded from Marina watch during the day. I asked M to cut out any personal logs. Once the bots cleaned up and bandaged my cuts, I grabbed all the food. After settling down my hunger rose up. I drank and chewed on as I listened all the conversations Marina had. I had to endure her complains about my illness and the security of my home. Although I knew she was right. I shouldn't have kept about my therapy a secret. From both of them. They both were rightly angry that I evaded the psychological tests when I entered the tournament. Listening to this discussion was somehow more painful than imagining being there myself.

I felt Marina's frustration over the recording when Drew denied about knowing me or treating me. And seems like she gave Marina a little bit of attitude. Drew told her to leave her house and not bother her family. She made plans with Blake to ask her later in person. I was eager to find out how that would go. I made an agreement with Drew I wouldn't tell anyone unless its life or death. This may qualify or not is entirely up to her to decide. When I heard their plan to move me, I was shocked to learn Marina had a way to get ART out of standby mode. She visited ART just once, way before all the new modifications and security I placed. How is she going to do. I didn't the answer immediately. For more than hour after her call with Blake, I only heard rustling and movement. The GPS showed she visited multiple places inside her home. It sounded like she was searching for something.

I chuckle when Blake explained what he did to pressure the admins and Citradel. That was a genius idea. He also used it as a cover to get me here. I didn't to listen to his side of conversations, but I imagined other officers improved upon it. It was a cruel suspense until Marina told Blake showed something that would summon ART. That’s strange. I couldn't figure out what it could be. All the remotes is accounted for. There is no way she could break any of ART's firewall. Also M would notice if anyone tried to breach. It was both mystery and amusing to hear them shocked when ART onboarded the Island. A smile appear on my face I hear them freak out a little when the petrol bots inspects them. Then my smile vanished when I heard Marina stole the remote from me.

I call out, M, how the hell you not notice her stealing. We have a 135 cameras in this house. M replies, I didn't see any irregularities. A while later she continuous, it seems I have discovered a small flaw. Unfortunately, ART can't detect movement of objects smaller than 20 centimeters that are not tagged before. The disposed pile were tagged together, not individually. I close my eyes irritated a little, your telling me it some dumb luck. That’s crazy. Add it to the ARTs vulnerabilities list. M notes, added 384 item. Looks like ARTs been busy figuring out his own issues. That’s good, but on the other side, the numbers too high.

Then I resume the recordings. I came across a very anxious topic of my health being discussed now. Drew was reluctant to speak at first. Hope she isn't still upset. When Drew said she wanted me not to fight the next match, I become conflicted. I was painfully aware that her reasoning and advices were spot on. Once those two convince her to assess me first, I was too much mortified at my selfishness. I have troubled those two more than I anticipated by telling about Drew.

I felt naked and annoyed at my secrets getting peeled off one by one. I kept doubting my decision to tell them when I was passing out. I didn't consider anyone. Not them, or anyone else. It looked like they didn't tell anyone, but maybe they told people later. My mind began reeling from imagining the aftermath once people realize I hide my condition.

What would Vanessa do. She probably scold me or even get physical. Everyone will. I risked our future. In my defense, Drew and I agreed I was stable enough to enter the tournament. And I trust her more than myself on this matter. My relapse at such a critical junction is a affront to all the progress I made. I can't even begin how to explain this to others. I have to tell others. But I can't think about it. Its too much. So for now I continued on the conversations.

I ask M, did you already notify I woke up to Dr. Drew. M replies, yes. Once you were sedated and stable, which was 10 minutes after you woke up. I remembered something then, when I was zoned out, you mentioned

about modified sedatives. Was that also recommended by her. M replies, correct. Before she closed off her access portal, she recommended that modification when you woke up. I accepted them within the risk parameters and injected the solution.

That women is way to clever than I thought. With just my brain scans and interactions, she predicted how I will come out from my sleep. I didn't realize earlier, but it was strange how clear headed I became seconds after I got injected with that sedative. She must have realized how screwed I would be without it. And that’s when I realized something. This wasn't something anyone could do. Not in the time she had. I reassessed my opinion about her. I will ask about it in person. I ask M, send her an invitation for meeting anytime after 5 AM. I am feeling better now, but I do want to take breather before meeting her. Let me know when she sees it.

M responds, message sent. I should have enough time to prepare myself mentally by then. Its good I woke up so early. With such a kicker waking up, I won't sleep anytime soon. I had finished eating my food and now I craved for open fresh air before listening anything more. I say, M. Scan the surrounding for a secluded spot for an ocean onboarding. I need to get some air. M's holograms turns off and the display in front switches to a view of the ocean topography.

I used the break to clean myself up. The smell of food on me is glimmering the space around me. I was too hungry before, so I brushed and showered properly now. As I changed into a trousers and sweatshirt, I began thinking my next course of actions. I should listen up all the rest of the conversations, but what then. Since M hasn't told me anything alarming from the Island network, nothing major has happened. So I should be okay to stay here until morning.

I walk back in the room where one and two were ready with another set of fresh bandages. ART's intuitive behavior is getting good. He must be learning new models from me. I took a sofa chair at the corner and let them work on my knuckles and foot. This one was made of thinner material, so they should not be constrictive. Once they are done I told them, looks good. Your movements and responses are getting sophisticated. I haven't visited you guys for weeks, so how is your progress. The two bots roll back some space and show a thumps up sign to me. Really. When did they learn that. I didn't design them a voice, so they learning gestures is normal. But showing emotional ques and quips is a big milestone.

They then roll off out of the room to their standby station. M speaks up, boss. I have a place 5 km away from here. There is satellite cover from the clouds and no ships or submarines around the area. However, based on the weather models, the place will be only available for approximately 2 and hours. There is a routine fisher line ship scheduled to cross at the route. I reply, that's fine. We won't stay here for long. ART prepares to lift off the ocean floor and swim to the designated spot. The underwater view outside the window changes slowly. The lights turn dim in this room and the suspension wall activates. M says, ART will reach in 15 minutes, 30 seconds.

Until then I listened to the rest of the recordings. Its a unexpected surprise that Charles wife took the role of messenger from Charles. He must only trust her for this. It was a little uncomfortable to have Vanessa with them. She left the stadium early on. I can only imagine how mad she is at me. I remember her asking me about Wagner, and ignoring her. I am clueless on how to handle this. I can't tell her the truth, but she won't let it go either.

As their conversation progressed, my expression become rigid. I can't be surprised that I was accused of such things. Anyone rational would at least once think if cheated. And my history is always something to be used against me. But I was confused why they Kafar or Citradel would try such thing without any proof. Their tactics to dissuade Charles felt petty and frankly, distasteful. If Blake hadn't rushed them with his rally, I have no doubt they would have gone further to discredit me.

I was grateful to others defending me. My guilt about keeping so many things from them grew even more. Vanessa may not understand my behavior, but I should have been at least straight with Blake and Marina. And then my mood turned to sour hearing the next segment. I crouch down, resting my forehead in my palms. I still have the sedative running through me, so I shouldn't have an episode again anytime soon. But hearing Wagner's skirmish with Heraknus, and Vanessa's insistence on it being a lie was getting on my nerves.

Vanessa kept saying it was a lie, while others kept it together and answered that I would still fight despite Wagner's behavior. I grit my teeth and tighten my hand into fists. I began breathing a little hard from anger. I tried to remain calm as much I could. It wasn't because of others who assumed I was going to fight even if it was a lie. They were right, I had already decided to fight. This wouldn't have made me back down from the deal. I didn't care if Charles actually didn't defeat Wagner. Instead, I am annoyed because it wasn't unexpected Wagner could do something like this. Its entirely possible Charles kept some stuff even from Melinda.

I become even enraged thinking Vanessa thought it was a complete lie, without questioning even a moment. She truly believe her brother was a good person, someone worthy of her devotion. If only she knew half the stuff he was up to. Before I took it too far, I sat back upright and took long breathes to settle down. I shouldn't think about it more. Not now. I haven't decided on how to talk to Vanessa. I table that scary discussion for now. It was a some comfort to not hear rest of Vanessa's voice from the evening. I couldn't handle all the anger she has at me if I heard her.

The next part was easier to listen. Blake and Marina were planning to break into the admins lobby. They both flew to the inner sector. When they land on the ground, Blake asks, okay. We are two blocks away from the building. Tell me you have a plan to get me in. Marina replies, there are 4 ways to get in. The front, which is crowded with people. The side door entrances, we can force it open, but we don't have the time to disable the alarm. The hanger is locked and again, we don't enough time to break open quietly. That’s leaves only one option.

I mulled over the other ways to get in. I never had any real reason to break in, but I do see the obvious way. Fly over to one the decks or windows on higher floors and break in from there. Sure, they still have to avoid the security, but it wouldn't be as difficult than other ways. Blake asks, so we fly in through those decks or windows. Seems he had the same idea as me. Marina scoffs, ah no. Obviously that would be difficult we so many eyes on the building. If I could use my overdrive, we could do that. Instead, I want to sneak in from underground. Specifically the basement.

Huh. What she means. Theres no way to get into the basement from outside. Blake asks, how am I going to do that. Don't you have to be inside to get to the basement. Marina laughs, not if you are me. You think I would not have designs in place that connects underground ways. When you all asked my help to create blueprints for the Island, I purposefully left out a little bit of underground spaces that can be used as tunnels. What the hell. Even I wasn't aware of this. Marina had planned almost 3 years ago.

Blake cries, damn Marina. You are telling we have hidden passages all over the Island all this time. And no one knows. Even from the recording I could imagine Marina smiling ear to ear while explaining, its not just here. There are in Citradel as well. Well, saying they are passages is a stretch. The paths are not tunnel, but can be made into one. The bedrocks of those paths are not load bearing, so drilling a tunnel won't create any issue. I haven't mapped all buildings paths, about 70% do. Fortunately, the admin towers is one of them. Also, the paths exists, but that doesn't mean anyone can take them. You need to have a crew working to open it or a particular person with specific kurets.

I began to realize what she was getting into. So did Blake. A while later he says, you planned this for shadow. But why not tell us about it. Marina replies, I am telling you now. They are just underground paths, not a big deal. I wanted to complete the survey first for the whole Island before Citradel moves. If I told you or David about it before I finished up figuring out all the possible paths, you might use it. I can't have anyone messing with it until I am ready. Besides, who was I hurting by keeping this from you both. Not like it was a bigger secret than David's illness or his Echo house.

That stung me more than I thought it would. She had a point though. Its almost a Shadow policy to reveal things only when its completed. Blake sighs, okay. I get it. So I just have drill a hole to get through. Marina says, yes. This building and the admins one the closest. Thats the entrance, do you see. Blake asks, where does that go. She says, its just a utility closet. Look for a small false wall in the left corner. It should be just huge enough to fit one person at a time. Go through that, you will fall into a small empty underground pit. Theres nothing there, just a hole made of raw earth. From there follow these directions.

I hear a hissing sound in the air. Marina is drawing the paths using her Kuret. Blake asks, can't I just draw it instead of memorizing it. Marina chastises him, hell no. I have taken great pains to keep this hidden. Even I haven't written anywhere. That’s incredible, so she has memorized the entire Islands underground paths. Blake sounding worried, I don't have a perfect recall like you. This has how many, lets see, 7 turns. I have to keep track of the distance and direction as I dig through. Marina says, yeah. So better make sure you don't. And GPS won't help. These paths are possible because of hard rock bed close to the surface, so you can't track yourself.

Blake sighs, so let me get this straight. I have to go in blind and make sure I follow the path perfectly, otherwise I would end up someplace else. Marina says, yeah. Shouldn't be hard. You can still see aura to navigate. Blake retorts, not when I am underground and surrounded by bed rock that can block signals. Marina says, oh grow a pair. Stop complaining and go. You said you were in a hurry. This is the fastest way without anyone knowing. Blake relents, ah. Fine. We are going to have a talk about your management skills. At least let me see this map for few more seconds.

After a minute, Blake got ready and left Marina. She went around the building and joined into the crowed. Later she met June and leisurely strolled around. I am amazed how ridiculous Marina handled this. She could have at least waited or somehow helped Blake in navigating. Maybe she thought it was easy for him. I am being realist, I could also done it. But I am concerned about Blake. Fortunately, this was hours before. So I can easily check what happened next.

I heard Marina saying that Blake is coming out of the building. I looked up and ask M, I am assuming whatever Blake planned to tell everyone was being broadcasted over the network. Do you have the recording of the news. M replies, I do. I also have the recording of the Admin conference from one hour later. So they did reach a decision before the end of day. I looked out through the window, we were still swimming underwater to the spot. I still have enough time then. I tell, show me the news from the evening that are about me, admin, Charles or the deal.

M replies, archiving completed. Showing only 19 of 37 news recordings which I have determined to have any bearing to your request. I nod at the number, okay. Show me.

David (Chapter 51)

Tuesday, September 23, 2025 19:00

Its been almost 2 hours of listening and analyzing the news streams. I am currently sitting in the beach chair on deck staring at the ocean. The waves were high, but the suspension circle around me has kept the floor I am on steady. I had prepared a green smoothie to sooth me. The subtle wind blowing and the noise of the waves was very relaxing. And with no other noise or distraction I could focus on what I wanted. As I gulped down a sip, M alerts me, boss. The fish bots have detected some large aquatic life passing by. Requesting ART to adjust sightly to avoid them. ART gradually glides on the surface as it avoids whatever we were about to encounter.

Its good that M and ART are operating at full capacity, because I had other stuffs on my mind. Blake had done a great job throwing mud at Citradel. Other officers and people had positive things to say about his performances. And it seems people have bought it. I had a few concerns how he would explain the lie about officers not telling Blake about the rally. Or the lie where Blake didn't want to tell people he was inside. Luther explained them in another news. He was quite convincing, and directing the flow of conversation to be on Citradel always. I suspect he and Blake planned much more than he told Marina.

I especially liked it when Luther tells how Island doesn't need to hide their administration and people can openly have conversations. Unlike Citradel, where you have to always have to meet in scheduled hideouts. If this was a debate, Citradel would defend by talking about their safety and technological progress. But he didn't touch on any of those topics. It also doesn't hurt that the Citradel people interviewed in the rally where swept in the chaos to get a chance to speak about it.

The result was Citradel conceding to the deal I made with Charles. I was a little wary when I heard Kafar was trying all kind of bullshit to break this deal. When Charles said he has decided to move, I almost jumped out of my chair in joy. At least my selfish decision has not been a complete disaster. There is still chance people won't move right away. Like that lady from Citradel said, the agreement was for winning the final match. I haven't won completely. This was a very risky gamble. Surprisingly, it turned out to be even ideal than a straightforward win.

I only shared this concern with Blake and Marina earlier. I had doubts that Citradel people would decide to move here even if one of us won. There is no authoritarian law to force them. We have been basically hoping that when they see all warriors strength, they would themselves decide to move here. Many will follow those warriors who have sworn on honoring the agreement. But there was always some doubt not everyone would move here. Kafar's reveal of Citradel secret champion actually played in our favor in the end. People would definitely follow someone who kept Citradel secure for a decade. On top of that they were a mythical bloodline who everyone thought were just a fairy tail.

No one would have known Charles would make a deal and move here. Kafar always touted no one could beat Charles. Turns out, even if I lost to him in the next battle, we still got our objective. I could tell how devasted he appeared in the broadcast. Now everyone knows about our deal. As expected, people had different opinion's about this deal. Some said I was genius, others said I was stupid. I smirk seeing very few people complaining to Charles. It's very coinvent Charles didn't tell it him who offered to move here as part of the deal. In fact many details I thought he would tell everyone didn't come out. Like why they remained a secret on Medrine. Or his arrangement on Citradel with Kafar. Maybe it was Kafar, or his house, discussed with him and allowed to only share those things. I wasn't bothered by it. Rather it didn't matter since it they were inconsequential to the next match anyways.

After that admins news, Marina went to Blake's home to party. I was glad they were at least happy and got time to enjoy our accomplishment. I heard it was Blake, Marina, Jess, Matt, Cass and Tessa. Nathan, Catherine and Vanessa didn't join them. I wished I could hear more about Catherine and Vanessa's day. But that would be too much intrusion. I already have done a lot of snooping on Marina. So I stopped off the recordings of the party. I tell, M. Switch to passive recording from this point. M responds, done.

I lean back on the chair mulling over what I learnt. I understood that this was a very long day for everyone. People have been a lot busy since my match ended. The bottom line is I need to somehow get over my issues fast. Which is what Dr. Drew will help me with. A while back M told Dr. Drew replied to M's message and has agreed to meet at 5 AM. That’s only an hour from now. I was in no mental shape to have an evaluation done immediately after an episode, which is probably the most terrible one I ever experienced. I also knew I had zero chance of fighting Charles, let alone winning in my current state.

I was too exhausted thinking and decided to completely avoid obsessing about it for a while. I got up my chair and sat down cross legged to mediate. I need to center my thoughts and at least be composed enough to think clearly. Then I did Pilates for a light workout. It felt back in control. After about 40 minutes I got back up on the deck. I thought to try testing my new Kuret form. I pull my Kuret out, but suddenly a chill went through my spine. My body tremble slightly at the sight of my own Kuret coming out.

I stumble back and fall down on my back. My breathing suddenly turn ragged and I sweated through the dress. I spatted out, dammit. Number 1 bot came from the other side of the wall and helped me up. I took one of arms to stand up. My legs suddenly felt weak. Its the same feeling when Blake carried me out of the stadium. I can't believe at my own weakness. Just at the sight of my Kuret I am break down. Right now am not even at zero chance of winning. I am at a negative.

Number 1 bot had a syringe on one his other arms. Its probably the same modified sedative as before. I waved my palm at him, no. I am better now. I don't want to be sedated when speaking with the doctor. Its time to get ready, I told M, lets move from here and onboard to shore nearest to her Dr. Drews home. What's the status of the car. Is it operational. M replies, its only at 40% capable. However, its sufficient for a simple pick and drive. I nod, okay. Then once we onboard, send one to Dr. Drews house and let her know about it. M responds, programming decent now.

I turn to Number 1, help me get to my room. I need to take another shower. I smell like the sea now. With the bots help, I walk back inside. ART shifts itself to prepare diving. M responds, surveillance fish bots recalling complete. Preparing to dive now. The windows and doors shift into solid. When I reach my room I tell, ART, prepare a drink for the Doctor. She doesn't prefer coffee or tea, so make a fruit kuret mix from apple, orange and pinnacle. Lets try out the kuret synthesizer now. Make the another one for me. I'll let you decide the correct ratio and tasting. Just don't make it too strong. You can use your desertion to change slightly if you want.

Number 1 drops me off in my room and wheels off to setup the kitchen. ART dives into the ocean, the window shows water filling upwards. M responds, optimal onboarding position located. Preparing the car now. Adding the directives to its OS. With that note I went back to the bathroom to freshen up. 20 minutes later, ART had parked on a cliff in the northwest side of the Island and sent out a car for Dr. Drew. I changed into a shirt and jeans for my meeting. I would usually wear more formal with her, but since its not a real session I decided to be casual. I didn't want to seem overly eager to get her help.

Of course, what I really needed was a miracle from her. I don't have a single clue on how to get back my mojo. What could I do now that 8 months of therapy couldn't achieve. Hope she has some answers for me. I went to the kitchen which number 5 bot operated. He had prepared a drink for me to try. Since I could only taste earth materials, it was kuret free. I took a sip trying it out. I say, its too sour. You added few more lemon squeezes. Take down a notch and we should be good. The bot behind the counter worked on preparing another batch, this time with less squeezes. I made a mental note about this prototype being quite effective.

As I waited in the common area sofa, I explained all the modifications I wanted in the room prepared for the meeting. I wanted the room to shift into something more comfortable. I added 3 large windows, asked the bots to move two sofa chairs into opposite sides and a large table in between. I even went far as to change the color of the walls to a soothing color, like yellow beige. I can't believe I am trying so hard for such a simple thing. I am very aware that my apprehension about this meeting. If she doesn't help me, I am screwed. And then everyone will be screwed. M told me she didn't explain the deal to her last night, but she most definitely know about it now. And I would have to reveal things that neither Charles or anyone has told her.

My legs shook uncontrollably as I waited for her. My fidgeting gets worse thinking the worse case. After 10 minutes of trepidation, the car comes in view. I grit my teeth impatiently as I walk to the door. Its dawn and the sunrise will happen in few minutes. The air had a orange glow right now, but it was completely clear. The car stops in front of ART and the passenger door opens. I take deep breathes and calm my nerves. I pulled the best poker face I had as I greeted her, morning Doctor. Welcome.

She was wearing her usual attire whenever we met. She puts out her cane and M's access tablet. She looks at me strangely, oh, morning to you too. This is where you live. When she closes the car door, it drives off to the shed on the side. She visibly looked surprised walking through the door. I give a slightly nervous laugh, yeah. Apologies I never showed you. For security reasons, I couldn't invite anyone. Her gaze fells on the interiors and takes its in, how long did it take you to build this here. Because I didn't see this in the island plans 2 months ago when I was searching for locations to extend my farm.

I guided her to the room I prepared. I think she hasn't noticed my nervousness as she marveled at my house. I replied, that’s because it wasn't here. She turns to me looking confused. Its expected, no normal person would believe what I meant. Instead of explaining I decided to let her see. I told, you'll see. But before we get started, here's a special drink I prepared for you. I took one from the table and waved at her. She took it with a smile, a smoothie. You think I don't like something like tea or coffee in the morning.

In a small panic I blurted, if you want, I can prepare something more strong. I got an coffee machine. Do you want an expresso. With a slight smile, its fine. I prefer this in the morning anyways. You guessed right. She takes a sip as I clam down. I can't believe how childish I am behaving right now. She gulps it down her throat and says, wow. That really good. I tasted kuret in it. That’s impressive you made this given your affliction. I let out a small laugh, well, just because I can't taste it, doesn't mean I can't make it.

I waved her to the seat, take a seat. We will be moving now. She gave a curious look as she sat down. She puts her cane down and the tablet on the table. I take the other chair and say, ART, prepare this room for suspension isolation. Take us down to only 300 meters. I don't want the doctor to feel uncomfortable. She looks at me shocked, are we going into the ocean. From here. She gripped the chair arms tightly in reflex. I assured her, don't worry. You won't feel a thing. Check it out. I pointed to the windows.

ART shifts and locks all the outside entries. I take a small amusement seeing her slightly anxious expression when ART beginnings to climb down. She soon realizes, how is this happening. We are moving down, but I don't feel us moving at all. I smile explaining, every part of this house can be turned into like a bubble that is isolated from the houses external pressures and movement. I will skip the technical details, but basically this room is magnetically levitated with a 10 cm gap from the rest of the house. So even if the house rotates on his head, we will be on the level.

Her eyes widen as we plunge into the ocean. Explaining and experiencing are two different things. I was sure she could handle the vision reaction over her bodies natural response to such a thing. This actually confirmed the thing I suspected, but I wasn't going to tell her until we start talking. Soon ART begins to dive underwater. The 3 wall window dims the room a little. But the sunrise made shadows dance from the surface waves. After gaining the depth I told, ART seamlessly travels at that level.

She smiles seeing the underwater life and faint see floor visible. She turns to me, I thought I was living in a weird place. Enough distance from others and privacy for my family. But that pales in comparison to this. I nod, that it does. Like I told you earlier, I need a lot of security. Privacy is an added bonus. I was actually happy to make small talks. Seeing it was finally happening, I was becoming too much anxious. I wanted to hide it from her as much as possible.

She gazes at the ocean and laughs a school of fishes pass by, was that you trying to impress me or a normal day for you. I shrug with a smile, I may have asked ART to plot a route that’s easy on the eyes. There are some reefs too dark to see, and well, an average person would freak out seeing up close through just a glass wall. She smiles, that they would. I am assuming that this glass is strong, since you don't seem worried. I reply, this glass is tank proof. Short of a ballistic missile attack, nothing could break it. And besides, there is round the clock surveillance going on. Anything other than a fish appears anywhere in a 500 km range, be it human, Echo or even a Medrone, I would know. So we are completely safe here.

She nods, I can see that. She takes another sip of the drink. Meanwhile, I didn't take sip of mine. I realized that’s not normal, so I finally take a sip. This is a non-kuret version of the same smoothie. It tastes much better than the previous one. She turns to me and places the drink on the table. Then she puts her hands on her crossed legs facing me, as much as I want to know more this submarine, I think we can get started. My nerves started acting up again in anticipation.

I cleared up throat, yeah. I waited for you to compose yourself. She takes a relaxed face, thanks. I am good now. Besides, I am not the one who is a nervous reck. My eyes focuses on that. I became quite for a while. She did too. She caught me. I was fooling myself thinking she didn't notice. Not seeing her glimmer clearly made me unprepared. Then I gave up, you noticed. She nods, just because I was caught by this doesn't mean I didn't notice the signs. When I didn't say anything she continues, you prepared a fresh drink for me, something I never told about my preference. You kept trying to focus my attention on the house, instead on you. And you didn't brought a single line about what happened yesterday. I say calling you a nervous is pretty mild. She was spot on with her observations. She smiles, I bet you even thought of wearing less formal to make this feel less like therapy and more like a chat. My smack my tongue wondering how much she saw.

She then waves her hand around the room, and lets also discuss the biggest clue. You picked a room which is completely opposite to mine we use for your therapy. Chairs instead of longer sofa. Lighter colored walls instead of dark ones. And window walls instead of no windows. Everything here is screaming at me saying its not therapy. I wonder if even noticed that. Ah, not good. I looked around and it hit me that I really did choose subconsciously choose blatantly opposite things.

I couldn't stop a disappointing laugh from my lips. I put one palm on my forehead, freak. I never noticed. She nods, you had to know your worsened condition was going to be discussed in details. So why try such subtle insulations. I reply frozen in place, I heard your conversation with Blake and Marina. Your early instinct was for me to not fight. I put my hands down after saying that. So I guess I have been overly anxious. She takes that for a second, you know about it. But I thought I asked M to tell me as soon you wake up.

I tell, and she did. But you saw it around 4 AM. I have been awake since 2 AM. I heard all of conversation from watch I gave Marina. And went over the news. So I know every little detail I missed yesterday. She stares at me for a while, ah, lets keep the blatant and gross violation of privacy aside. Then her faces perks up, did you bug my place too. I waved her off, no. I didn't. Well, not exactly. M records all communication around the devices I design, but there are privacy protocols. She can't let me hear anything too personal. Its a passive recording. Only important and absolutely necessary to me.

She looks a little uncomfortable saying, I have to believe you, I suppose. We had 18 sessions and I never found any signs of you using any personal knowledge to your advantage. We will talk about that later though. She clears her throat, there you go again avoid to talk by touting your fancy skills and tech. You can stop being evasive now. I wasn't trying to be. Or maybe I am. Its hard to tell if its my brain or body instincts to avoid it. She says, at least this saves time explaining some stuff.

She continues, so you know I went through your brain scans and vitals yesterday. And judging by your need to avoid talking about it, I was right in assuming you will wake up with a night terror. So, did you have one. I close my eyes in resignation. Its finally time to explain my mental state. I gathered my thoughts once again before saying, the worst one I ever had. She asks, this isn't going to be like a normal session, that much is true. Like we agreed, its dangerous to get influenced by anything during a fight. That being said, I will still need to know your thoughts during and after the match. I heard your reactions, and now I want to know from you directly. Based on what happens, I will tell you my recommendation.

I had no choice but to agree, I understand. From When do you want to start. She replies, I noticed an erratic neural activity near the middle of the match. Until then, it was normal. At least normal for a person fighting a Heraknus. She didn't even bat an eye talking about Heraknus. People would ask me how they are in person, but not her. She was down to business with every intention of focusing on me.

Then began my recounting the memories of the last day on Medrine.

David (Chapter 52)

Wednesday, September 24, 2025 18:28

It was completely different than other times. I was so disoriented I didn't know where I was, who I was. Just I needed to kill Hive. It consumed me. With a slight nod at my explanation she turns to look at my vitals of the event in her tablet. Its been around 45 minutes of discussion by now. We exchanged a lot of back and forth with her questions and my answers. I told as much as honestly I could about all my emotional state of the moments leading up to the night terror. It was mortifying and nerve wreaking to hear my voice when I accepted the Charles deal. I could tell how conceited and egotistical I felt saying I could win no matter not. I told her about my memories about the other shadow members without mentioning their names. Fortunately, she also understood not to pry that information. She didn't need it anyways.

Dr. Drew puts down her tablet, honestly. Its almost a miracle you were able to fight in such a state. You were almost like riding a high. Once you discovered a new Kuret abilities, you began taking risk much easily. Even if you had thought of your actions beforehand, you took risks that you normally don't. I know she wasn't pointing out to anything particular, but I know it well myself. I thought I would find a more simpler weakness of Charles. I had no plan to deal with his overdrive at that moment. She continues, you became singularly focused winning. Its actually impressive you still had your wits to negotiate that deal. So its not necessary a high but, in laymen terms, sudden overblown confidence. Clearly your god complex took a part in it.

I wanted to protest getting called out like this. I don't think I have a complex like that. Yet, I kept quite. We are reaching into the crux of our discussion. She smiles, you still could restraint yourself after being called like this. This wasn't the first time she kept poking for a reaction. Often times she would make a quip about something to gauge my reaction. I can't even tell if she was serious about most of the things she says about me. She continues, you believe the person, the one who tormented you as a kid, was the trigger right.

I nod, naturally. I mean, I had a nervous breakdown immediately I found out even he couldn't defeat Charles. She replies, but that’s not actually true, is it. Does knowing the whole truth is why there's no new episode ever since then. I gave it some thought, I don't know. Maybe. Or it could be the sedative you gave me. She says, you only took one. It would have been flushed out of your system by now. So that can't be reason it doesn't trigger you when we talk about him. And I guessing you have thought about him also, many times. But you are still fine.

I replied, that’s not how it happens. Just because I mention his name or think about it, doesn't automatically breaks me. She asks, but it did in the stadium. Did you really had a panic attack just because you got anxious on finally having a chance to get your revenge. Even in such a roundabout manner. I got annoyed at this. I didn't want to talk about him in this context. I kept quite, unable to articulate any response. She notes my silence, let me ask another way, you told me your memories of the last is clearer now. So isn't it possible your feelings about him is the not the complete reason you had a panic attack. Maybe just like your incomplete memories, you PTSD is linked to something more than him.

Rationally, I understood her point. But I couldn't believe anything other than him being the cause. I shook my head, no. I believe its just him. I didn't have clear memories only of the last day on Medrine. But every other day is crystal clear and the truth. It doesn't change what I know about him. She stays quite for a while at my answer. She speaks, if that’s what you believe so confidently, it may be true. But until now, I believed he was definitely linked to triggering your PTSD. After this, I think it might not just be him. Just keep an open mind about it.

I didn't need to rethink my diagnosis after 8 months, but at the very least I keep a note of this. She says, lets switch topics. I became relaxed to know I didn't have to talk more about this. I am a little interested to understand why you became so confident during the match. You say your shadow mentor knew your potential, even when your Kuret was blocked and weak body. Explain it to me how that memory changed you. It may be obvious, but I still want to hear your thoughts about it.

I didn't need to think about it a lot, he must have chosen me for a reason. I have suspicions that he knew I was a project MARS kid from earth. That makes the most sense. She asks, Even if that’s true, why would be believe you become physically stronger. Neither of you have definite evidence of you coming to Earth will save you. I reply, perhaps he know more about that project. Or something else. Whatever the reason, since he picked me as a shadow even with my terminal illness, I owe him my life. Don't ask me how, but I know how difficult it was for him to let a outsider, let alone a terminal kid, join the shadows. So I need to get stronger to honor his sacrifice.

She nods, he is impressive after hearing his story. To carry you over 3 continent and an ocean, especially through the most dangerous place during the war, no ordinary person could do. I don't doubt your intention to become strong for him. But is that what you want though. Whatever knowledge he might knew about him, you were just a kid who were terminal. I replied sternly, I don't have any other goal or ambition. Whatever plans I had, all gone when Echo invaded Medrine and then Earth. She asks, but surely you want more. Didn't you said you wanted be normal. That was the whole point for therapy.

I get her confusion. Its because I didn't have a definite answer. I said, I don't know. Maybe I am conflicted about it. But I know this for sure, I was never planning for a normal life. That wasn't possible. What I need is to be better. I thought it would be enough to support Medrones from shadows. But I also had a life on Earth. One free from constantly being paranoid and scheming. So I just wanted something like a middle ground. That’s my reason for therapy. You know about it. But now, I am not sure about that. She asks in a lighter tone, you want more, isn't that right.

I had to agree on that, yes. Its more than just being a shadow or a stable mind. I need to get strong enough to fight Echo all on my own. I don't care much about humans progress or even Medrones. I'll admit that’s presumptuous and arrogant. But that’s what I need. She leans forward, you said need. Not want. Meaning its much deeper. I shrug at her. She continues, when you joined the tournament, you said that you needed this. The context and reasons are completely different, but I get the same feeling from you as before. When you joined, you weren't aiming for winning, but to eliminate Citradel warriors to increase odds for Blake, Vanessa or Nathan. But now you don't want that, you want to risk your life to win.

I nod slightly at her. She continues, you still have such strong feelings when you are this terrified of my possible negative evaluation. I sorted out my thoughts about it. And I reached an answer, I think of it as two different things. I am worried of being not mentally stable to fight Charles. I also want to win no matter the condition I am in. however, I would like to get over my issues before the match. Two things can be true at the same time. At my blatant response her expression hardens, I don't want to call it optimism. But I also don't want to call it delusion. What a thin line you made it. You know, you have been lucky so far. How long will that last.

I answer, as long I can get. I'll use whatever I have to defeat Charles. She says, and that’s how you repay your mentor. I nod, not just him. Everyone who died saving me that day. I have seen the bodies of so many shadows, dying for me just to get me board a ship. I can't have a life like everyone with such a guilt over me. I have to be better than everyone. She hesitantly asks, better than Wagner. I replied immediately, especially him. I want to be strong without becoming cruel like him. I know how I sound. Me beating Charles doesn't mean I am better than Wagner. But that’s the best I got. She stares at me and thinks for a while. After an agonizing silence she says, you are already strong enough to stand with some of the most powerful people in all of Medrine history. Isn't that enough for you.

I reply, I'd don't think like that, because like you said, I have been lucky. I won against Derek because I caught him by surprise. And Blake lost because he was worn using his overdrive in earlier match. Others may say I am on par with omegas, but I don't think like that. I still have a lot of gap to cover. She laughs lightly at my claim, did you see your own match. You got lucky, but that’s not enough to explain how you fought off a mythical alpha for an hour. You don't believe your new kuret abilities are enough.

I nodded, I know its not. I want to start my training right away. But I am not stupid to ignore my issues. I am terrified you will say I am unstable or delusional or both. Now that I think about it, I also concerned there is nothing I could do to mitigate it in the next 29 days. And that means I would be fighting in my current condition. She leans back on her seat, that’s a problem with smart people as patients. Their blind spots are easily missed and still able to judge objectively themselves. She takes a short breath, I think I have a grasp of yours though. She clears her throat, I have one last question.

I prepare myself. I knew what it was about because she hadn't touched on it yet in all our discussions. She picks up her tablet and turns to show me a frame of the video of me waking up. She asks, among a lot of things, this is most concerning. Everything we discussed till now was about your panic attacks or PTSD. I didn't ask about this one until now because I wanted to know other things first. This nightmare, like you said, it was different. You had recalled a memory of your friend dying. And something different about it. I didn't ask then, but I am asking now. What do you remember.

I fidget in my seat knowing I had to talk about this. My legs began trembling a little. I put my hands on my knees to force them down. She wasn't going to ignore this, what just happened. You showed a physical reaction, something you tried to hide. I closed my eyes trying to calm down. I had noticed it a while ago. Actually, this is what made me worry the most. Every time I think of using my kuret or about Zakerine, my body begins to shake. I gathered my thoughts and said, my body begins to feel irrational fear when I think about it. To be honest, I have been having it few times since I woke up. I thought it was a side effect of the drug you gave M. I knew it was out of my system, but I didn't want to believe it was due to something else.

She asks, its understandable you didn't want to add more problems to your list. What is it about. I sighed and explained what I knew now. All this time I had different physical symptoms going on, shaking legs and arms had become the most common though. Then came the irrational need to ball up and cry. I didn't tell her that though. I was already pathetic enough already. Once finished I took the water from the table and emptied the whole bottle. I was even sweating now.

She waited for me to finish drinking. I lean back was I felt a little calm. She says with concern, I am sorry I made you relieve that. That’s a devastating loss. With a nervous look I reply, it is what is. But this one is pretty obvious to me. She asks, oh. What do you make of it. I clear my throat, I was paralyzed completely due to blood loss for hours before leaving Medrine. I had to suffer through watching 3 people die in front of me. But my friend, who I originally thought died from an injury, could have been saved. Only if was able to move or even talk. I felt so hopeless lay paralyzed and see her die when didn't have to. And now I am experience that same fear whenever I think about her. She nods, yes. That’s the obvious answer.

I sensed she thought of a different one. I ask, so what's not so obvious answer. She answers, you experience the same thing when you use your kuret too. Don't you. That genuinely froze me up. I never told her about that. My face turned pained trying to figure out if M told her about it. She puts her palm to me, I can see you are trying to understand how I know. It was just a lucky guess. I haven't seen you use your Kuret to see any glimmers. So I wondered if you were just scared to observe me, like how you were worried what I my evaluation be. Or maybe you couldn't use it.

Sharp as ever. I click my tongue irritated a little, yeah. You are right. I didn't tell because, well. I couldn't finish my own words. She says it for me, you didn't want to appear even more unstable. Not the same word I would use but close enough. She says, its fine. You don't have to worry me judging. If it were anyone else, they would have been admitted to a psych ward by now. Compared to others I seen in your situation, you are doing great. I didn't share her optimism, its been one thing after one since I got my memories. I just want it to end now. This is tiring, I have so much else to focus on. And I didn't mean just the fight.

She says with a serious face, listen to me. You just hit rock bottom. You can't get worse from here. That's actually good. There is nothing positive about it. Rationally, I knew what it meant. But it felt bleak now. She would almost certainly think I am far too gone to fight Charles. She says, coming back to this fear you mentioned. Its true, you felt angry you couldn't help her. Its also entirely normal if you are angry at her since its also her own fault. I immediately wanted to rebuke her, but I stopped at the last second. I took some deep breathes. I felt trembles all over my body.

She notices me, but ignores it, you most also be angry because if you had your kuret with you then, you could have saved her. With all this built up, made you completely nervous about meeting me. And that's the main reason you feel so much on edge. Everything else we discussed, sure it was also a factor. But this is main reason for your current state. I am sure you realized it as well. I only bring it up now because I know this had to be the main root cause of your issues. I had been bottling it ever since I woke up. But now, hearing this from someone else I finally broke.

I yelled out, why the freak she didn't listen. She kept trying to revive a dead person. I was alive, and needed help. She only cared about him. He was only a friend, I was more. We were in a relationship. I used to feel regret not being able to protect her. I even was able to let it go because I didn't have kuret then. I would never be able protect her no matter what. I accepted that. But now I know that she chose it herself. If it were a regular person, I would understand. Buts he was a shadow in training. She was trained to fight in wars. How could she lose it so much that she died like this. This is so stupid, even pathetic.

I begin heaving at my rant. My trembles worsened. She waited patiently for me to calm down. But I didn't feel it was anytime soon. I shout, this is so messed up, I can't believe it. How can she choose not to heal. She was a freaking omega when she died. Her injuries could have been healed in time. If she wasn't so stubborn, she be alive right now. And I,. I lost my words. No, I didn't want to say this. Saying would mean it could be true. Drew didn't utter a single word, waiting for me patiently. I finally spoke up, if she were alive, I wouldn't have tried to erase my memories. The reason I did it in the first place is because she died. Without it, I might have been someone different. Someone more trusted by others. Someone who would made different decisions I did. I could have had a different life.

My breaths keep me agitated for a long time. I close my eyes and laid back on the seat. I could feel tears wheeling up in my eyes. Even after I already shown my pathetic side, I didn't want to show something worse. Drew probably understood my emotions, because she didn't approach me for a long time. Once I settle down a bit I gather up a slight courage to say, sorry. I got caught up. I open my eyes and wiped any wet surface around my eyes. Drew didn't change her expression much, but she did appear more relaxed. That's was peculiar from her.

She asks, that must have helped. Your earlier talk about getting strong, they were true. But this so was this. You do wish for a different future. I scoff, and different past. That’s not going to happen. I know that. She asks, yes, but have you accepted it. I mean really. I honestly can't her answer her. I thought I could. She continues, I am not going to force to accept it. I sometimes myself can't accept the fact that I am living in an alien planet. Everyone wishes it. You aren't all that different in that regards. So you are not alone.

I knew she was comforting me, but it didn't help. She says, and I also won't ask to accept your friends death. Its not the first time I heard people dying trying to save others. All though, I admit its strange for an omega, but I am sure you would have at least tried rationalizing her actions. Whatever they were, knowing won't change the fact she still died from an attack. I think your subconscious has known about this when you got your memories. It have been also a driving force for many of your actions. You may not even realize it. So just give it time, you will reach an answer yourself.

I couldn't begin to how to deal with this insight. What actions have I been making unconsciously from this. I know I didn't have the answers right now. Drew shrieks a little, oh. Shoot. This isn't a session. I shouldn't have given an advices like this. A thoughtless mistake. She chastises herself. I also didn't realize how easily she slipped back into her therapy mode. She tilts her neck a little, lets focus back. I understand why you had that particular nightmare. You attacked your robot thinking they were Echo because that’s your anger originally directed towards. I knew it was more to it than just simple rage.

As I remained silent, she looks to the glass wall and stares into the ocean. I realize she is going to finish her assessment. I already knew the result though. I had very small hope she would allow me fight knowing my currently worsened condition. It wasn't just self depreciation. I am a mess right now. Drew doesn't know how dangerous the next match is. If I had a panic attack, a moment of hesitation or even as simple as trembles, in the middle of the fighting, I could lose more than just the match. With such incredible stakes, I shouldn't fight. No, I can't fight. And the repercussions of it would be too severe me to bear.

Drew took a long time to decide about me. I didn't want to get sucked into my own mind, so I also turn my chair to view the ocean underwater. She saw me joining, it is a gorgeous view. Especially now that the sun is up. I don't know what this was. Maybe a delaying tactic of small talk. But it eased me since I don't have to talk about my issues anymore. I answers, yeah. When taking test dives, I found many good spots. You are seeing the early fall life. Once winter comes, most aquatic life moves deeper. If you want, I could us to the reefs at some depth. Not even human divers have that far. Its also nice view.

She puts her hand up, maybe some other time. But I'll keep that in mind. This might to be one of your secrets that anyone would forgive you for. Its nice and peaceful here. Oh what I wouldn't give to live like this. She is still going on making me wait. I thought she was only delaying. But she sounds she really wants to just chat. What weird strategy is she doing here. I can't figure it out. Although, I had an opportunity to ask something now. I ask, you know. You have been asking me a lot of questions, so let me ask just one now.

She doesn't look at me answering, oh. I haven't decided yet. I wave my hand, no. I know. Its not that. I think I am not only one good at hiding stuff. She turns to me surprised, what do you mean. Her expression showed nothing new. But I know I am right. I continue, I knew you were smart. That’s why I chose you. But its not just that. Even with M's help, you where able to tell I would have night terror when I wake up in just few hours. I know one can learn a lot from my vitals and medicine history, but what you did was nothing short of brilliance. A smart person would prepare for all eventualities, but a genius would know exactly what would happen and prepare for just that.

She didn't faze at what I am implying. So I blatantly ask her, you are a genius prodigy. Aren't you. I have noticed signs of it earlier in our sessions. Your hot and cold readings are almost always correct. You are can memorize a lot things in very less time. You have PhDs from both Medrine and Earth, and you experiment with growing hybrid crops. So its hard not to believe you lied about your IQ during your Island intake. What is it really. I am curious to know.

She had kept a poker face until now. She turns back to see the ocean from the glass with a smile, it always nice to get praise from others. But you are overestimating me. I am not a genius. I could finally let out a small laugh after such a harrowing time facing my issues, that was a lie. I don't need to see your glimmers to know. Come on, just tell me. What's the big tell. She answers still having the smile, don't you think pestering me like this is not a good idea. I might make a decision you don't like just to spite you.

That’s funny, I say. I am a mess right now, but I can still observe this things clearly. You would never make a crucial decision biased like this. And also, I have pretty much given up convincing you. I am not sure myself I could resolve my issues before the match. So, just give me this. It would make me feel better that even if I can't fight properly right now, my instincts are still good. I'll admit, it was a weak argument. But that’s all I had. I had no solid proof.

After sometime me staring, she sighs. Turns out I didn't need proof. She says, you caught me. Honestly, I was worried you might realize it when I had to meet you so soon. I was quite happy and a little proud that you never figured that out. I knew you would eventually figure it out, I just thought it would be near the end of your therapy. I curled my fist in satisfaction. She chuckles lightly, I have an IQ of 173. I wasn't expecting such a high number. I say, wow. Freak me. You might be in the top 10 smartest people in the Island right now.
She says with a small laugh, I don't know about that. I don't think much about it. You know my situation. I didn't want to work on anything crucial to Islands administration. My decisions has hurt my family. So now, I am just a farmer. Okay, not just any farmer, maybe a more smarter one. I did understand her situation. I agreed I wouldn't tell anyone she used to work as a psychiatrist to humans. Then I had a thought. But maybe I showed it in my expression because she interrupted me, and before you ask, no. I am getting recruited by you for anything else. I am only doing this because you are helping my family.

She perfectly guessed my thoughts, are you sure. The job I have in mind is something you can do from home. You won't have to leave the Island, or even talk to anyone about it. No Medrone or Human. She still refused, thanks, but I must decline. You don't need me, you already have other people working for you. I imagine this house we are in is something you built taking their help. I haven't fought in any wars, but I can tell its Echos technology. So you clearly don't lack people helping you. You don't need me.

She wasn't wrong. But I do need people from her particular background. But we are not in that stage yet. We still have to break through few milestones in the project before we have a brain related problem. I say, it’s a loss, but I got it. All leave you alone, for now. I emphasized the last part. She looked like she would criticize me, but kept her cool. It was still amazing to know another genius Medrine alive.

We both gaze back to the ocean. I don't know if this small talk made her rethink in anyway of her decision. It wasn't my intention to influence anything. But since it happened anyways, I had a hoped she would help me out. After some deliberation she finally says, I honestly can't decide. Its very difficult to know if you have enough time to recover. Also, I still don't want to have sessions until your fight. We can't risking infusing you in any unexpected ways. Buts its just as dangerous not to get help. I understand how important this deal is. You were sleeping all night, but I have seen people enjoying and cheering you on for your fight. So I know the pressure you are in. Anyone would be reeling from it. Genius or not.

It was a good to know she understood me and how grave the situation is as well. She says, I don't know if this is right or not. But there maybe something could help you. Seeing there was even a possibility, I tighten my back, what do you need. She asks, an alternate, actually a radical, treatment which you could undergo. I don't know if it would work, but that’s the only thing I believe even has a chance. That felt almost a miracle to me right now. I ask curious, what is it. She says, I'll reach out about after I have researched a bit more on it. I read about it when I studied in college, but never thought I could apply to a Medrone. Well, you are uniquely different from others. So, who knows, it might just work.

This was the best thing I heard till now. A hope gave me confidence and believing I could make it work. She says, give me a week's time. I'll have done the research by then. Know that its completely experimental. We are going to be in unknown territory. I reply, all take anything right now. But a weeks time is too long, I can't hole up in my home until then. Other things beyond my control will also make it impossible to wait that long. She nods, yes. I understand. Heraknus will be moving here. If you can't fight their alpha, your deal is void with them not moving here. And that’s why I will allow you to start your preparation. You can train, strategies and do whatever you normally do for a fight.

I tried to understand what she was saying, are you saying I should fake it. Convince others that I am okay until your experimental treatment. She replies, no. Its not going to be simple like that. Because of such a time crunch I need assurances that the treatment has any chances of working. Actually, you need it more than I do. So for that, we will have to test you. Specially your mental and emotional state. It made sense, but I ask, and how do we do that. She answers, instead of waiting for a week sitting on our hands. I'll am giving a task, a test if you will. I waited for her to reveal this task. She says nervously, show me that you can control your kuret by end of today. If you can do that, then there is a chance you can recover soon. If you can't do it, we can forget about everything and I will declare you unfit for the fight.

I can't believe she asked me to do the thing I feel impossible right now.

David (Chapter 53)

Friday, September 26, 2025 22:55

We are currently in the dining counter drinking. Drew showed a sudden interest for coffee when the smell of the beans roasting filled the house, so I offered an mochaccino mixed with kuretines. Its been 10 minutes since Drew gave me the herculean task. No, a test to see my resolve. ART began to climb up the same cliff as the one we used climbing down to drop off Drew. I put down my coffee mug on the counter. I had been thinking a lot and ask her, did you conclude that these tremors are a simple psychological response to night terror and could be easily rid in just a day.

She takes a sip and says, of course not. I won't deny that these two are related. But its not a simple one that can be so reductive and solved easily. Normally, it would take weeks for an average person. But you are not an average patient. I gave a short duration because you finally had a sort of relapse, something like hitting rock bottom. Like I said before, any progress from now on, no matter how small, is towards the right direction. You think things very differently, so you feel things differently also. I believe you can show progress differently too. Add on top the pressure you are currently in your situation. In such unpredictability, you might recover unpredictably too.

I scoff, that’s a lot of uncertainty. She nods, yes. A broken compass that wiggles too much can point south just as easily as north. I have seen patients recover in short periods. So its not impossible. Its difficult. That was understatement. I don't even have a plan how to deal with this. Give me a military base to destroy, a prison to infiltrate or a sow chaos in a city. Those I can do in my sleep. But this is way out of my abilities. I need help. The irony is the person I would normally go for help is Dr. Drew herself.

We soon reach the edge and onboard completely. It was completely lit now from the sun. The high waves had begun to recede. The local wildlife had also taken presence with birds in the sky and small animals on the ground around the house. Drew puts her coffee cup down on the counter and stands up, I guess times up. Despite our somewhat dubious conversation, this has been a very unique and pleasant experience. She grabbed the cane from under the seat and begins walking. I follow her behind, I appreciate your discretion. Even if you say you enjoyed the trip, I did ask your help at such an odd hour. And not to forgot the research you are doing on my behalf. Thanks for your helping me out.

We pass through the door into the fresh Island air after an hour and half. ART had already sent out the car from the hanger. The passenger door opened for her. Drew stops before getting on and faces me, don't worry about it. You were right to have Blake and Marina bring me. I don't think someone who is passing out would think of calling for their therapist first. It was good to know you had your priorities right. That helped in making the decision to visit you. So even if you don't feel like it right now, I think you are making progress. Believe in yourself and you will manage your issues.

I flatly said, you didn't even gave me whole day. Just 17 hours. She laughs, consider that extra incentive to figure out, in layman's term, your shit. Even I laughed at her professionalism. I just had a thought, since you didn't mention anything about it, I must have to figure out my shit myself. Is there any suggestion or hint you can give. She nods, I was waiting for you to ask. She stares at me intently, you already know what you need to do. I am sure you learnt one particular thing from our sessions all year, use that.

I was expecting a clue, not a riddle. I scoff, not making it easy even now huh. She replies with a smile, maybe I am just a bit salty you figured something about me. Yeah, that I believe. She gets in the car and give me a parting words, like we discussed, no confirmation over call or video. Only in person by midnight. I nod, I got it. Hopefully, I will see you then. With that, we waved each other off. The car drove off using the same route it took in the morning among the woods. I stood in my place for a while, unsure on how to take the first steps. She said I already knew. I didn't no exactly what it is, but it had to be simple. She wouldn't risk me wasting time stuck with this.

Nothings going to happen stuck here looking stupid. So I walk back to inside. On my way I saw a group of seagulls on the railings supporting the house. Their unceasing noise kept disturbed my thinking. I close the door behind me and say, M, scare the birds away. I don't want them to take a shit on ART. M responds, it’s no use boss. We shoo them off, and then they just come back. When onboarded, we can't maintain the magnetic resonance long enough to keep them away. Its already in the list of vulnerably we have on ART. There are some organic solutions we want you to see.

I didn't have the mental capacity nor do I care right now to deal with this. I take a seat in the living rooms Barcalounger, not now. Just get rid of them for now. M replies, understood. Shall we dive back in the ocean. I decided, no. Lets stay here till lunch. I know it doesn't make sense, but being inside a pressurized container under water is adding to my stress. I laid back on the leather. M replies, all right. Deploying bots to deal with the avian friends. That’s an odd way of saying. Where the hell is M learning this new quip from.

I close my eyes and gather my thoughts. I have to deal with the deadline, that’s my number one priority. That being said, I also have few things to do. I haven't met with anyone since yesterday's match. People have been discussing a lot about my disappearance and absence last night. I need to spare some time and visit the officers building. I have to explain what I have been doing all this time. I am sure people have visited my other home, so I have come up with an excuse to explain that too.

And finally, I think I need to meet with Charles before I leave. I don't know what will happen tonight, but all I can do right now is stay the course. I should let him know I am okay and looking for our next match. I should also talk about my last interaction with him. I ask, M, is there any information in the network when Charles is leaving. M replies, yes. Mr. Charles, few Heraknus people and couple of Citradel officials are set to leave today at 9 AM via a cruise from the south port. So they are taking an early trip. Not waiting for the nights cover means he wants to be in Citradel as soon as possible, even if its less safe during the day.

I have enough time to visit him then. And since I am going there, I should address the officers there itself. That should save me time meeting them later. A sound of the birds came again interrupting my thoughts. I yelled irritated, are you freaking kidding me. I open my eyes and gazed to my side at the window of the deck. A lone seagull was being chased by a number 1 bot around the pool now. I screamed out, for freaks sake. How the hell are you not able to kick it off yet.

M replies, apologies boss. ART is not able to make sense of the abnormal behavior of this one bird. I didn't have time for this cirrus. I got angry now, I need some peace and quite to think. Just shoot the damn bird if you want. I want it off my house, right now. M responds, boss, the wildlife protection protocol stops us from taking extreme measures. Even if you ask, we can't harm a bird for invading its migrating routines. I scoff hearing that ridiculous answer. Then I remembered the protocol. I can't be angry at M, since I wrote that one myself.

I sighed and let my annoyance out. I got up from my seat and walked over to open the glass door. Number 1 bot was still trying to catch the bird. If it had been allowed to use its full strength, it would have grabbed it already. Still, I can't believe one bird is giving it this much trouble. Animals unpredictability is accounted for in their programming. I guess they still have to be tuned more. As soon as I lay my eyes on the bird, it turned it long neck towards me. I wouldn't have given a second thought to that look, but it kept staring at me while making the noise and running around the deck.

Something is weird here. Some animal may not be threatened by cold metal, but a warm bodied one would definitely scare it away. And yet it stares at me for few seconds while running from the bot. I gradually walk back inside closing the glass door. I had a strange instinct about it. I asked M, where are the other birds of the flock. M replies, they already left. Number 1 bot scared it away. Only this one stayed behind. I have seen them enough times to know that they stick together in groups always. No matter the time or place. So why this one is behaving strange.

My mind went many scenarios here. Is someone using this bird to spy on me. I ran down all the kurets in my head that could do it. I knew of people with abilities to control or influence simple minded creatures. But why. And how they know where I live. Has someone been following me. Then it hit me, they could have followed Dr. Drew to me. My mind instantly went to Kafar or the culprits who are trying to mess with the tournament and me. Yesterdays Citradel discussion about me could be a sign they are escalating their approach to get me.

This is not good. If they realize I am meeting with a doctor, before I talk to Charles, I could get exposed. They might use it to finally convince Charles to break the deal. To avoid suspicion further from the bird, I get back to my seat. I need to deal with this now. Should I let the bird go, capture it. Or something I was itching to do since I kept hearing that annoying noise, kill it. I had to use my kuret and see glimmers to see what do next. I bit my teeth hard feeling the discomfort. I didn't want to do it, but I had no other choice. I need to know if there is any kuret in play here.

I closed my eyes and fidgeted a little in the chair. An outsider might think I was relaxing. However, I am conflicted inside. I pull out my kuret. Immediately I felt my head getting hotter. Emotions of seeing Zakerine and Hansen floored my thoughts. My body begins to tremble. This is a terrible plan. I couldn't focus one bit. Forget about focusing kuret in my eyes, I can't control my own mind. I grabbed the side arms of the leather seat in anxiety. My legs begin shaking like the vibrator from the seats were on.

Anger. Despair. Madness. Nausea. It overwhelmed me. Zakerine, what the hell happened to you that day. I should have done more. I let her to die. Thoughts kept coming to me. My breathing became ragged. Shit. Freak this. I stopped my kuret. I can't do it. Its hopeless. My kuret falls back inside me. My thoughts still remained rampant, but I felt them getting dimmer. Small sweat drops from in my forehead. I open my mouth and breath fast like I was drowning. Then gradually I begin to calm down.

I could sense something over my eyes. Just for a split second, I saw strands of thin glimmer in front of me. A familiar color of kuret. After few seconds, I open my eyes in confusion. I know that kuret. How did she find me. This confusion actually distracted me enough from the wave of emotions flooding me from the trembling. I am able to cool down after wiping my forehead. How long has she been following me. And how much did she hear. I guess I have to ask her directly.

I speak aloud, ART, I authorize you to use full capacity in catching that bird. Bring the bird to me now. M responds, are you sure boss. I nod, I am not going to harm it. I am only going to interrogate it. M replies, temporarily authorized to use full capacity. The next moment, number 1 bot uses its impulse propulsion from behind to sped up its pursuit. The bird didn't react fast enough. The bot caught it with its four arms. The seagull squawks even louder with its capture. What a performance, I applauded for the commitment to this bit.

The glass door opens and the bot wheels inside. I tell, ART. Initiate umbrella protocol. The surface of the room shifts and begins to rearrange the sofas, chairs and tables to the side of the room. The glass windows and doors turn tinted black to avoid anyone seeing us. I put my fist under my chin and elbow on my thighs unamused by this trespass, I know its you. The bird struggles to get of the grip. Guess she isn't going to give up like this. I sigh, If you want to be treated like a bird, fine. M, prepare the grill. I am feeling a roasted bird for lunch. Prepare something from menu.

The bird continued to struggle, now, biting one of the bots arms. I didn't know how long this farse would go. Apparently, M didn't think I was joking, how would you like the lunch, boss. Cooked, grilled or baked. ART has 22 current different recipes that works well with a seagull from this region. There stomach are rich in protein and guts have good omega content. It was frightening to think M really thought I was serious. I should check out her context ques programming.

The bird finally gave in. It stops tying to break free. A purple kuret comes out from it and wraps the bird. I say, number 1. You can let go of her. The bot releases its grip on her. The purple kuret unravel round her and grows in size. The body morphs into a person shaped figure and then I saw it talking the shape of the only person who has this kuret. I push the bottom of my Barcalounger to rotate to the other side showing the backside to the intruder.

A second later a surprised voice says, what the hell. Were you really going to cook a random bird. I shook my head ignoring her, what are you doing here Catherine. I could tell from her voice she was anxious and a little freaked after getting caught like this. She says, are you seriously asking me that. What are you doing living in such a gigantic place. I have got a ton of questions for you. She got her composure back and got angry at me. The last time

we spoke, it was around a month back. We parted in not so good terms.

I wasn't expecting this, M, how did you not see her infuriating ARTs defenses. M takes a while before responding, apologies boss. ARTs sensor picked many Medrones since we dived into the ocean. All the signatures detected are labeled as normal since they are part of every day morning routines, fishers, patrols and other activities. Since Miss Catherine was disguised as a bird, ART couldn't account her signature as a Medrone. I sighed realizing the sensors wouldn't can't detect anomalies like Catherine.

M says, adding this flaw to ARTs list of vulnerabilities. Freak, I wasn't here for a week and suddenly so many flaws are popping up in just one day. Catherine shrieks, hey. Don't ignore me. How long are you going to keep me embarrassed and naked here. Hurry up and give me something to cover up. She is being obnoxious now ordering me when she spied on me. I took a second to consider on how to deal with her. I didn't want to speak to her while I am in a terrible shape. On the other hand, I have no idea how long she has been spying me for. And what things she heard about me. I can't let her leave without knowing about it.

With a reluctant voice I ask, dammit. M, get some clothes for her from the axillary closet. On the double. I hear a rumble on the rooms down the end, a bot was dispatched to fetch her clothes. Catherine says a little calm now, thank you. God, what the hell is this place. I reply, how about I ask few questions first. How the hell did you find me. I waited for her to answer. She then smirks, what. You think I would just tell you when you keep so many secrets. I know a lot more about you now. So you owe my answers.

From her reaction I could tell one thing, she is somehow even more angrier at me than before. I didn't utter a single word and instead thought this through. Finding me isn't just a question about a location, its time also. So clearly I was right that she followed Drew to me. How did she found about Drew. And then it's the matter on how she has been spying on me ever since we dove into the ocean. ART didn't warm me any suspicious Medrone near me. That means only one thing. Slowly I begin to uncover how this unexpected guest made her visit.

Number 2 bot came inside the common area with few clothing options in his arms. Catherin shrieks a little, there are more than just one of these robots. What hell David. I ignored her. The bot zips past me and halts near Catherine. I hear clothes rummaging, you always keep woman's clothes here. A while later she says, hey. This is my size. How do you have these. Her voice became a little quite and hesitant. Like she felt creeped out. Before she had any weird thoughts, I answered this time, settle down. I have a spare supply of clothes for everyone. Men, women and children. So don't go accusing me for anything. Also, I know your size, in case you forgot about the incident on capture the flag game. M heard that and picked the ones that fit you.

Catherine coldly says, I was kidding earlier you know. But now I am little freaked out. And make sure you delete the videos that recorded me just now. I won't feel at ease knowing there is a video of me getting caught like this. I felt amused by her panicking a little. I tell, M, you know what to do. M responds, instead of deleting, blurring out parts of the footage as per protocol. Catherine says annoyed, guh. Really. You are the worst. I snicker, you came into my home uninvited. Deal with it.

A while later I hear Catherine finished putting on clothes. I rotate my chair back to her. She took a brown blouse and black jeans from my rack collection. The bot wheels away with the rest of the clothes out of the room. I pull my head up and cross my hands, interlocking the fingers. She finished pulling her hair backwards, you think you have to right to be angry, hell no. Its me. I can't believe you kept your illness a secret this whole time. You shouldn't have entered the tournament, let alone fight Charles. What the hell were you thinking.

Her indignation towards me on my illness proved what I was thinking earlier. I say, just to be on the same page here. You didn't find anything yourself. Someone told you about me, Drew and my home. You didn't wear your morphing clothes, so you were only going to be surveilling me. That meant prepping for it beforehand. You knew about Dr. Drew and followed her here. She takes a stern stance with me, crossing her arms and staring at me angrily. Her expression didn't waiver even a little as I spoke.

But I had figured it out, only two other people knew about the doctor. Either Marina or Blake told you about this. It was a matter of time before people would begin hearing about it, but I didn't think it would happen in just a day. So obviously, one of them told you, despite knowing how much of a stress and pain I had to endure to keep it hidden. Marine feels the first choice, but she is quite reliable in keeping it a secret when she wants to. So it must be Blake. You two have been spending a lot of time together this whole year, so its not a stretch that he told you.

Her expression finally showed cracks of small surprise. I made it look like I was deducing, but already knew for certain. I didn't hear anything about Drew from Marina's recording. Its possible she texted it, but to Catherine of all people. Theres no reason for Marina to share that information. She remained quite despite the angry rant she was on earlier. Though her attitude didn't change. I continued, he must have told you not to butt in to my affairs. And clearly you didn't listen or care. I will have to explain this to Dr. Drew also. She will not be happy to know people are begin to realizing her involvement with me.

Catherine finally speaks up, what is going on. I caught you in therapy, and all you care about is covering your ass. She still harbored annoyance at me. I wasn't being like this just to add flames this situation, I was gauging what else she knows. I say, I know you weren't inside my home. My sensors are flawed, not blind. But I also wasn't warned about your presence in the vicinity. So that means you kept spying on me from outside, even in the ocean. The creatures I saw while we were drifting underwater, you morphed and blended into the crowd. The whole time we were underwater, more than an hour.

If nothing else, I was impressed by her commitment to follow ART underwater for so long. She would have to morph into other fishes, and she kept up her kuret that long. Her abilities as an omega are leagues above her families. Catherine scoffs, you have no idea how hard it was. I lost your trail multiple times. Thank fully, your submarine of a house was circling the same path. Once I figured that out, it was easier to follow. Damn, I should have asked ART to take random paths. Then I realize it can't do that in ocean with limited options to remain hidden.

We state at each other intently now. She followed us underwater, however, that doesn't help her much. She couldn't hear in water, ART is soundproof here. So I suppose she couldn't have heard the conversation. The most she could was, my thoughts froze realizing it. I become vexed at my own mistake for this. I tell her, what did you see from the glass walls. I remember you can lip read, so you must have picked up somethings. My voice turns grim thinking she potentially knows a lot of my secrets. Its probably partly why she is so mad at me. What did she learn.

Her expression finally turns nervous, you figured it out. Even when you have PTSD and bunch of other issues, you are still, well, you. I held my breadth a little as she continues exasperatedly, what makes you think I will tell you. I will just ask Blake or Marina about it. I initially came to find your actual home. But I had to follow you once you all dove underwater. And like you said, I am here to only spy on you. If your wired robots hadn't kept pestering me, I would have left by now.

I gave some thought to her claim and say, that's a lie. If that was all, you could tried to run off as soon as I caught you. Instead you ordered me to get clothes for you and stand here pissed at me. It feels more than just because I kept my therapies hidden. I take a long breath knowing she did read some parts, you picked up some parts of our conversation. And you want to know about them, don't you. I knew I hit the mark when she becomes annoyed, you think you are such a hotshot figuring it all. Aren't you. I wasn't amused by her, I did found you out in the end, didn't I. Let it be a lesson to you, no matter what's going on, I will know the kuret used near me with my eyes.

She makes even angrier face. That boastful provocation was meant to probe her a little more. She didn't know my kuret is on putz right now. So didn't hear anything important from us. I sigh in relief knowing she was only testing me earlier, trying to pull out more information. I lean back in my chair relaxing a bit, I'll commend you for being able to deceive ART completely. But that's all you are getting from me. I have a lot to deal with already. You heard from Drew before, I have to work on myself. So please, leave.

She wasn't going to budge so easily. With a angered voice, she yells, you think I'll leave just because you say. You owe me some explanation. I had enough of her for now. I got up from the chair and move to the center room, I told you. I don't have the time. She follows me from the common room, make time dammit. Don't think this will be like the last time we spoke. I didn't want to do this, but maybe I should force her out with the ART bots. Then she says something that stops my in my tracks, who's Hansen or Zakerine. And how the hell do you know my dad and brother.

Freak this. She heard that. My fists tighten unconsciously. Of all things she could have heard me, she had to stumble on this. What a crappy luck I have. Catherine came to my side and became anxious seeing my expression, so you know them. I thought I imagined it, but I swear I saw you speaking about them. I only have broken pieces, but I was sure you spoke about them. So tell me, why didn't you tell me you knew my family.

I grit my teeth anxiously. I really shouldn't have made the wall transparent. That was the mistake I did trying to distract Drew for some misguided attempt to hide my mental state. Turns out I did a lot more damage than that. You mis read me. I don't know what you are talking about. That was probably the dumbest attempt to hide. Catherine didn't believe a second of it. She points a finger at me not amused, that's a lie. You should look in the mirror. The moment I mentioned them, your pace turned pale. He turns her finger into a fist and says, why are you trying so hard to hide it. It make me more suspicious that it has something to do with me. Blake said there might be some connection with your illness and the fight we had earlier. Is this the reason. Something about my brother you are keeping me out of it.

This is exactly what I don't need right now. Aside from the risk of getting worse, I shouldn't broch this subject willy nilly. But she wouldn't leave me alone now, not after this. She continuous, what the hell is up with you. You have been acting different ever since you got your memories back. Was you life in Medrine so different that you turned out like this. Keeping so much from your friends. I thought I knew you the best, but I was wrong. You are. I couldn't keep it together after he constantly egging me.

I say, you think I want to be like this. Why do you think I put myself in therapy. Just for fun. No. I face her directly now. She stuns at my sudden outburst, you have no idea how much it hurts to keep things from all you guys. But I can't just turn a new leaf after getting my memories. I needed time to sort myself. And that's I have been doing the past year. So don't go judging me just because its coinvent for you to blame on me. You broke the promise when you gave me your word that you and Ned will end your relationship. No, actually, you swore to me that it was over. Turns out, it wasn't. I didn't even force it on you when you lost against me in our match. So you better back the hell off me.

I chewed her out with my rant. She looks completely puzzled listening as I blabbed on. I sighed with my anger subsiding. This won't get us anywhere. Anymore of this line of thinking and I might have another panic attack. I walk to the kitchen, take a glass from the shelf and drink water from the tap. I gulped down 2 cups to calm my nerves. Meanwhile, Catherine just gazed at me nervously now. I closed my eyes and begin taking long breathing. I have no choice. Even if somehow I make her leave, she might do other unnecessary things. She could keep spying on me, or talk to someone else about this. Both options make me feel uneasy. I feel like I am getting exposed, like I am naked right now.

I open my eyes and say to her, fine. Lets talk. That's what I decided. I don't want to drag this out anymore. If I am to get better, I need space. If that means I tell you what you want to know, that's what I'll do. She asks hesitantly, how do I know you will tell me the truth. You have been lying all this time. She is getting on my nerves again. I spat out, you either believe it or not. Take it however you want. But know this, I didn't lie anything. You never asked if I knew from anyone in your family. Theres a big difference.

She scoffs, like that makes it okay. You can't just decide whenever you want to hide things from us. It was hard to stay on topic when she kept pushing me to my limit. I kept reminding myself this is not her fault, it was mine, but she was making me hard to think. What happens when it becomes too much for me to handle. Would it worsen my condition, the one day it shouldn't.

With a heavy restraint I gradually regain my composure, before we talk, do you want anything to eat or drink. Catherine was completely caught off-guard, what, her voice now bamboozled. I answer, you probably stalked Dr. Drew since early morning. You didn't even bother to wear your morphing clothes. So I doubt you ate anything. You have been using your Kuret continuously for more than an hour. You must be exhausted. I don't want you get even more cranky than you already are. This won't be a pretty talk, so yeah, before we talk, I am offering some breakfast.

I point towards the kitchen with the number 3 bot ready to cook, it can make dishes with kuretines. Just don't expect too much. She remained motionless seeing me being so courteous. I wanted her to calm down. She heard few things from us, so she obviously must be imagining a lot of things. I can't talk to her in state where she keeps being mad at me. Also, I needed time to figure out what exactly I should reveal to her. I continue, look, I also need to eat breakfast. So if you don't want it, that’s fine. But I need to eat now. I tried to ease her into this.

She looked suspicious of me at first. Slowly she gives in and nods, fine. I haven't eaten since morning. I used too much kuret. So yeah, you are right, I am exhausted. But don't think I don't know that you are delaying this. I am not leaving without answers.

I sighed at that determination. I could tell this is going to be a harrowing conversation. I have to stay clear of Zakerine or other stuff, while talking about my worse day on Medrine.

David (Chapter 54)

Monday, September 29, 2025 22:58

While we waited for the lunch to be prepared, we both are sitting in the deck basking in cool air. To pass the time I asked her what Blake told her. She is still wary of me, nonetheless she relayed what Blake told her last night. Fortunately, Blake didn't reveal everything. Although I am amazed he was able to link my mental issues to the argument with Catherine. She mentioned Blake did ask to stay clear of me for a while, a correct judgement, but she never promised it. Instead she setup a e-surveillance on Dr. Drew on the network with her own personal codes. Once she got alerted this morning when Dr. Drew left her house around 5:00 AM. She intercepted the car heading out the section and followed me since then.

I sigh at her, we didn't create the that feature in the network to be used for personal reasons. She feels guilt, but the prospect of learning things is not weighing her down, its fine. I have wiped the records now, the only thing anyone will see is a missing log, which no one will find unless looking for it. I am a little worried about the abuse of power she just did. She sees my disappointed face, what's that look for. Like you never do things for personal benefit. It was hard to deny it completely, but I was trained for it. Too bad I tell her why its fine when I do it.

Number 2 and 3 bots dash out from hall. They both carried food trays on their arms. They also brought two glasses with a jug filled with iced juices. The bots laid out the breakfast on the table in front of us. I speak, ART, make us a sheet of cover above us to give us shade. ART shifts the wall from the behind to produce a thin material above us. Catherine looks in awe as it grows horizontally and begins to cover us. The bots leaves us once they setup the table with cutlery. M says, anything else boss. I replied, prepare an emergency sedative for me. I don't know how this will go. M responds, okay, synthesizing a new doze now.

Catherine faces me with now a confused look. I wasn't going to explain that, let her assume anything she wants to. She remained stiff seeing ART modifying my house around us. I dig into my scrambled eggs, not waiting for her finish gawking. She then asks, seriously, what the hell is this place. Blake wasn't joking when he said you used Echo's war remains and technology to build this. What is this ART that you keep talking to. I pondered if it was okay to explain this to her. Maybe revealing a little about it would help with the later topic.

I answer, Autonomous Reconfigurable Technology. Its a system that is a specialized AI clone of M and hardware designed to interface the programmable Echo's material. After the war, I salvaged whatever technology I could from Echos broken ships and weapons. Echo and Medrine tech are not compatible, so instead I used Human science and tech to build this house. With a team of DARPA, NASA and DECA scientists, I build this house. Though, I did use Medrines architecture and design blueprints. This is still just a prototype. She looks at me shocked as I chew on my food. She hasn't yet touched her plate. She says hesitantly, you shared Echo's technology with humans. Isn't that opposite you always wanted.

I reply, I didn't share anything. They work for me. She gasps, say what. You have a team of scientists working for you. I had to reveal this piece of information because no one would I alone built this, especially when there was a tournament going on. I take a sip of lime juice and nod, yes. I couldn't have done this myself. I have them tasked to create weapons and technologies from everywhere, Human, Echo and Medrine. All in preparation for the war we will soon face against Echo. Once she takes in that, I continue, I didn't tell anyone about this because this would create a huge uproar. Medrones are still trying to figure out the Echo machines and techs. If I tell them that I have already figured out a way to use, but it means working with Humans, people may not be thrilled about it.

Catherine fidgets a little, you maybe right about that. Citradel is currently the most advanced technological society, and they prided on being self sufficient. They haven't researched the Echo's weapons we recovered completely. Only just enough to see their effect and how to counter it. They have been delaying the research to use those weapons and instead saying ours will soon be more advance than them. I shrug, and maybe that will happen. But I don't want to rely only on one avenue. Reverse engineering an enemies tech is pretty obvious and important. And I don't particularly care who I have to work with to use it. Maybe once everyone moves here, someone will have the brains to work with humans.

She asks, not you. I shook my head, not me. I already have target on my back, it will worsen if I join the politics. I'll leave that to you guys. She stays a little quite after hearing my explanation. Then, like an internal acceptance she picked up the fork and knife to start eating. She took a bite saying, freak. This is so good. Its better than anything I cook. She enjoys herself as she takes another bite of the fish she ordered earlier. I asked ART to add in kuretines suited to her tastes. Seeing her getting relaxed and eating with such gusto, I was right in making this decision. She didn't show it, but she was exhausted from using her kuret so long. She gulps down half glass of the fruit juice.

I let her eat some more before speaking, lets come back to the topic on hand. She faces me after talking another big bite and nods. I ask, first tell me what you heard. I want to know how big of a mistake I did by using the glass walls. She thinks for moment before replying, I didn't get much. But I think you were talking about your match. I caught Charles and Heraknus name a lot. I picked up some other things like Echo, dreams, and memories. Some things I don't understand, but I did saw you saying my family name. You wouldn't talk about them when referring to just me. So I realized you know them when it came up few times later on. And few names, Wagner, Hanson and Zakerine. I didn't quite read how they are linked to you completely. And yeah, that’s pretty much.

Honestly, it wasn't that bad I was expecting. There was nothing specific and all she heard were dead people names. Its good she didn't pick up on other things I talked, shadows, my issues with Wagner and most importantly, my kuret issues. She continues remembering something, oh. Wait, I also picked up something about your kuret. Like it was blocked or something like it. I am not sure about that one though. My hopes immediately crashed out. Out of all the things she could have heard. My eyes stare at her with such an intensity that she froze while eating. She asks me, what. I didn't reply and kept staring. She understood my intent, that’s all. I don't know anything else. She puts her arms in air resigning.

I so wish I had my kuret to see the glimmers coming off her. I could at least tell if there is any sign of deception. She puts her arms down and says, so its true. You can't use your kuret. I turn my gaze away from her and to the ocean to my side. I felt like I was about get a headache, so I drank a half the jug of water from the table. She looks confused seeing my weird behavior. My throat felt a little cooler now. I open my mouth, I am not going to discuss anything else except about you and your family. That’s the deal, you got it.

She wanted to rebuke, but after thinking about it she nods, yeah. That’s all I care. You can deal with your issues yourself, like you always do. Her harsh tone was a jab at me for being selfish. I was okay with it as long as she doesn't stay mad at me. I clear my throat, so lets talk about your dad first. Brandon was my sponsor in the university. That’s how I know him from. Her eyes become sharp hearing this, but you said you were a scholarship kid. I answer, that’s true. He didn't sponsor me directly, instead he put his own money into the scholarship funds to get me enrolled.

She got curious hearing this act of generosity from her father, why would he do that. I gather my words carefully here, I later found out he wanted to use my thesis on non-kuret applications I published into practice. He let me in the university because he saw potential in that work. I had initially pitched that thesis hoping to get someone attention, and then become my sponsor. It just happened to be your dad. So I agreed to give him my theories and work to be researched in his department. It was an lucrative arrangement for us, I get to live on campus and he get to research on my work.

Catherine jerks a little in her chair, are you kidding me. He wouldn't pay for my summer trip to my favorite place, but he paid for your entire stay and education in one of the costliest university on Medrine. She got annoyed and complained to me about her dad, what the hell kind of theories did you write to give a cheapskate of a father to endorse you. I answered, it doesn't matter. They were just theories I wrote after my own condition not able to interact with Kuret. I don't even know if it even led to any fruition. Brandon never told me the specifics, he just said they are making progress. That was true, I think about it sometimes. He paid such a heavy amount for it, it must have been for something. Otherwise, it was just a pointless endeavor.

I sigh, well, whatever the case, it doesn't matter now that Medrine is gone. With so much of our tech lost, one small research area like mine doesn't matter. Catherine slightly nods, okay. So you met by dad in the university. That can't be the end of it though. She is right, I nodded, we met for purely academic reasons. But he gradually become more of a mentor for me. He showed me to new things I never experienced before in my orphanage. From politics to society to culture. He took me to various work trips, even became an academic advisor of sorts. Once he realized my high intellect, he became more interested in involving me in his department. I had envisioned my life at university to be a quite one, away from others who didn't understand me. But he did. It wasn't long until I began enjoying the work. I became the youngest student to be under his advisory.

They were good times. I recalled what fleeting memories I had of my time there. The time we celebrated the night on completing a project. Or him complaining about his wife or kids to me. I didn't understand why he would unburden his family stuff on a kid. Even if was precocious for my age, you shouldn't talk to kids about that. It was only later I learned the real reason he hand picked me. Catherine saw me reminiscing, you really know him, huh. I can't believe he never mentioned you at home. That pulled me out of my little day dream. I knew why he didn't talk about me to others. But I can't tell her about it.

I continue, I never visited your house, so I am sure he just wanted to keep his work separate. I told her a version of the truth. She asks, and my brother, you knew him too. I reply, not as much as Brandon. He had joined the university two years ahead of me, so we didn't share much in common academically. He was more hands on than us academics, studying in the social department. But we had a mutual friend, so I met him couple of times. She asks, who was this friend. Do I know this person.

This is were it got tricky. I say, she was in the same year as him. We became friends only in my 2nd year, her 4th year. You both never met. And that was all I was going to divulge to her about Zakerine. I hoped it was enough to not dig deeper. Her eyebrows raises and she makes a puzzled look, I don't understand. If you were just good friends with my Dad, why never tell me about it. I was relieved she didn't ask more about Zakerine. But now I do have to tell her something worse, for her at least.

I swallow hard, what I am going to tell you is going to be difficult to hear. So listen to the entire story before judging your dad or me. Got it. My serious gaze met hers and she became tensed. With a suspicious look she nods. I continue, on our last day of Medrine, 1000 kids were chosen to be sent in our fastest spaceship, Galexon. You know that already, and how kids were chosen. What you don't know is that your father had chosen John to be sent instead of you. But he never made it to the ship, so you were taken in instead.

I waited to let her sink this in. She remained stunned for a moment. Then she spoke meekly, so I was the backup. I didn't want to tell her this, I even warned her enough it wasn't pleasant. But maybe she can handle it now after surviving on an alien planet. She nods hesitantly, it hurts, but I get it. John was older, more experienced and was better than me. So it makes sense dad would pick him. Her face betrayed her voice though. It showed disappointment. She knows kids weren't selected based on current physical and mental state. They were picked considering their potential in the future. She asks, did my dad tell you that.

I nod, yes. Couple hours before our departure, I met him at the university HQ that was evacuating in the middle of Echo attack. He explained his reasons to pick John to other parents and guardian. He told. I felt uneasy telling this to Catherine. Seeing my reluctance she spoke, tell me. I want to know. I didn't need to see her glimmer to know she was hurting. Anyone would be upset at this. With a heavy heart I continue, I'll just bottom-line it. He told you weren't mentally strong enough to endure and protect others. I didn't knew much about you back then, but it seems your dad had the opinion that you were more like your mother. It wasn't a bad thing, she was kind, caring and fiercely protective of her children. He believed those qualities passed on to you more than your brother. Qualities not meeting the requirement for sending you in Galexon.

Her silence and blank expression showed her discouraged emotions. But now that I have decided to reveal it to her, I can't stop. I add on, John was there too. And well, he agreed after discussing more. With the father son leading that discussion other people followed suit in making terrible and harsh decisions in choosing which children to send. I didn't agree completely what they did, but I disagree too. It was what it was. If I had known about you back then, maybe I would have been in favor of you. Then I realize it wasn't the truth. It was just a biased view after years of experience with Catherine.

She understood my intention, thanks. You don't have to give excuses for them. I understand it wasn't an easy decision a parent needed to make. With a crestfallen voice she asks, was my mother there. I shook my head. She sighs a little, that’s a little relief. She would have gone ballistic at dad. She would have argued to send both of us. Maybe dad didn't want her there to begin with. After a few seconds of silence her accepting this cruel realization she asks, what else. You wouldn't keep it hidden if that was it. I am sure many people faced cruel decisions to make. Even Vanessa was sent instead of her own brother.

If only she knew the whole truth about that family. But that’s irrelevant to Catherine. I tell, yes. Theres more. I got my memories a year back, but there have been gaps that were still foggy for me. Particularity on the last day of Medrine. A lot happened that day. I have PTSD from that single day alone. My time in therapy helped me make sense of them. With time I began to recall memories much clearly. Things which I had to assume earlier became clearer. One of them was about Bradon and John.

She pulls out another nervous look. I gather my wits and continue, that last day, I was being carried by someone to the ship. The name you read, Hansen. He was another mentor of mine. Not academically like Brandon. But outside my life in campus. I rather not talk about him though. Its complicated. Anyways, when we both crossed the barricade and made it to the ship, I met Brandon there. John wasn't with him. He said John couldn't make it in time and instead sending you in place of him. He was worried about you being alone, so he, um, asked me to look over you. And I promised him. At least that was my actual intention at the time.

Catherine becomes anxious, hold on. He asked you, a skinny kid who didn't have kuret instead of, well anyone on that ship. I understood her confusion and shock. I answer, trust me. It wasn't lost on me he was asking something crazy of me. I don't fully understand his reasoning. Maybe because we kept close over the years made him greatly trust in me. Or maybe something else entirely. I take a short beath, but doesn't matter. I promised something to person who helped me for years and then completely failed at it by loosing my memories arriving on Earth.

Her expression turn downcast hearing about it. I say, there's more. After making that promise, we were attacked by Echos. In the struggle, Bradon gave his life protecting me and Hanson. And recently a new memory resurfaced that John was there during that same attack too. And just like his father, he died protecting a friend. A feel slight tremble passing though my body. I tighten my hand on my knees to calm my nervous. Zakerine is like a landmine for my mental emotional state right now. The memories of their dead bodies come into my mind. This triggered other memories of Zakerine trying to revive John.

I forced myself to not get sucked into another spiral of darkness. I don't know how long I was zoned out. But Catherines voice zapped me out. She asked concerned, David. Are you okay. I look up to he nervous face. I take long breathes and say, yeah. Sorry. But now you see why I am in therapy. A lot of my issues have sprouted from that day. I hid it because I don't want sympathy from people. Everyone has gone through something. My body feels better now. I pour another glass of water from the jug. Even with the winds, I am sweating a little. This is bad, I have no clue on curing this before midnight.

Catherine asks with her softened tone, you saw them die. He eyes feels hazy, like she is trying to see something beyond this view. I nod, yes. I was there when they both died. Someone else also died there. Someone I was close with. The death broke me. So much so that I forgot all about the promises I made with others, including Brandons, and decided to loose my memories. It was cowardly, and complete disrespect to all the people who died saving me. And that’s why after a decade of guilt living, it has impacted me emotionally. When my memories returned, we were in the middle of a war. So I didn't notice it then. But soon after I felt it, the burden of knowing I threw away my responsibilities selfishly.

I began to breath a little fast from my rantings. Shit. I lost some control and spoke too much. I shouldn't be telling this to Catherine just after telling something so awful. She bows her head down, away from me. With a quite tone she asks, so, this is why didn't tell me earlier. She mumbles something to herself a little more. She suddenly faces me back, is that why you kept pushing me to break up with Ned also. She finally understands my reasons, yes. I was guilt driven and trying to look out for you. But it went too far. I added my own personal mess into it. When I found out you and Ned were still together, I went overboard. I felt like I was letting down Brandon all over again. He and John gave their life, and somehow only I made it out among them. You breaking your promise with me was like how I broke mine with Brandon. And I know it doesn't make sense, there is no real connection between the two. But that’s how my screwed up mind process it.

I thought I would feel better telling this to Catherine. But it felt even worse. I could have lied, maybe made something up about how I knew Brandon and John. I could have spared her and my feelings. But I am tired of keeping it from her. Catherine remained silent for a long time. I was worrying every second of her silence. What is she thinking. Does she hate me. Her dad and brother died saving me. Who wouldn't. And then I go butt in her relationship thinking that’s not what Brandon would have wanted.

As I waited patiently for her to speak, I hoped this wasn't a giant mistake. Maybe I should have really kept quite. She finally speaks up, I had no idea you and dad were so close. I don't think you made that part too. He was always got lost in his work. He never once allowed me in his home office or at his work. I actually jealous you saw more sides of him I knew about. I think I am angry about it too. It was a natural response. Knowing some other person was involved with him closely. It must be painful. I wasn't going to add more on by involving shadows here.

She asks me, is my relationship with Robb , something dad would never approve. Or was it just you. He asked me a very difficult question. It was a very complicated one to answer. I answer honestly, both. Like I said, I didn't you well enough back in Medrine. But I knew Brandon very well. He loved you, in spite of the decisions he made. He wouldn't have wanted you to be in a doomed relationship. She fires a question immediately, you think that’s what dad thought about me. She got mad, and perhaps even justified. But I was sure, I am sure. He was very vocal about his bloodline and family. I spent years with him, I know him well enough to know what he would have wanted for you. And I want to believe, I do to.

Her anger simmers down a bit, dammit. How could dad do all of this. Make you responsible for me. This is not fair at all. Treating me like I can't make any good decisions. I rebuked, I didn't say that. I only wanted what was best for you. Brandon played a key role in this, but remember, I told you and Robb years back that one day you both will have to end your relationship. She got frustrated at that, you keep reminding me that. I keep telling you, this isn't like Cristyn. Robb and I have been together for years. We both know about each other.

I raise my hand before we argued further, let me stop you hear. We had this argument last time. Its pointless. That triggered another emotional reaction from Catherine. She probably got even angrier. But I wanted to say my final piece here, look. I can't explain why, but I am not going to interfere with you both anymore. That stopped her from getting mad. Instead confusion washed over her, what. What do you mean. I explained, I always knew this isn't like Cristyn and me. And you both can make your own decisions. Good or bad ones. But it was my mistake to keep pressuring you break up with Robb.

She asks flabbergasted, what's going on. You were so adamant I was making a mistake all this time. I now that I know the whole story, you are going to back off now. I simply nod yes. I will. I made a mistake. So I apologies on how poorly I handled myself. I was guilt ridden and wasn't thinking straight then. It doesn't matter what Brandon would have wanted. He made me promise to watch over you. And if that means if you don't agree with what he would have wanted, I will have to take your side. I misjudged my responsibilities with my emotions.

I had been thinking about it for a while that I didn't handle this correctly. But somehow after learning the entire truth of what happened that day, it changed me a little. Zakerine died because she couldn't give up on John. Regardless of what I believed, I was helpless and couldn't do anything. Something Drew told me had been bothering me. That somehow my actions were subconsciously influenced due to this even when I didn't remember it. Maybe it was also when I argued with Catherine.

Meanwhile, Catherine was dumbstruck at this. She says, I don't believe you. You really would back off me now. I reply, that’s the true. I shouldn't have interfered in the first place. Who am I to judge who you should love. I wasn’t in right mindset back then. I still am not. But I at least I can recognize Brandon wanted you to be happy and safe. Doesn't matter how or with whom. So I promise I won't bother you about it anymore. You were always free to do whatever you want.

I still harbored reservations about their tenuis relationship between an omega Medrone and a human. Maybe that will never change. But I have learnt I was displacing my frustrations of keeping my promise to Brandon for something else. Maybe something to do with Hansens claim I will become strong. Or maybe its about Zakerine. I am not sure about that.

I thought Catherine wouldn't believe me. I wouldn't blame her. Its not something I thought I would come to realize now. But I am glad I did. At least now she knows everything. Well, not everything. But what's really relevant to her. She says, okay. I believe you. I, hum, well I just, she was lost of words. I think I know her hesitations. I say, its fine. It was my fault to being with misinterpreting a promise. And I also hope you don't believe Brandon didn't love you or something like that. He made a decision, not made from malice but a cold, harsh logic. I know it probably doesn't help much, but that’s all I got. You loved you and John. So did your brother. I didn't want to tarnish your memories of them like this. So I decided selfishly not to share this.

With a subtle nod she says, thanks. I know you are right. But I just need some time. I never thought you kept something like this from me all this time. I understand why you did. She fidgets a little, I am sorry how I came at you earlier. I knew you wouldn't have kept something from me if it wasn't for a good reason. But its hard when its about my own family. I say, you don't have to apologies to me. But I do wonder if I made the right call by telling you all this. What do you think. Its an old story and about people long dead. Should I have never told you this. Or is it better to know.

She didn't answer such a emotional question for a while. After some thinking she says, I don't know. I can't decide. Maybe you were right to keep it from me. But that would have meant I would be cross with you all the time. A smile appear at the corner of my mouth, I can make peace with that. Because at least you wouldn't have to worry about things people long gone thought about you. Even if you were mad at me, at least it would spare you the pain.

She looked disheartened. I couldn't imagine the turmoil she would be in. The one I put her in now. I heard a ping from M, boss. I hope your talk with miss Catherine is over. The cruise carrying Citradel officials will be leaving in 30 minutes. I didn't want to intrude earlier, but its time now. Her timing was accurately intuited, yeah. We are pretty much done here. I push my chair back and got up on my feet. I tell Catherine, lets end this now. I know you have a lot to talk. And I don't want to be rude, but I have important things to do.

Catherine also got up, its okay. I understand. You are heading to the port now. I reply, yes. I need to meet Charles before he leaves. I also need to talk to the officers. Actually, everyone. I have been out of touch for a almost 24 hours now. It wouldn't look good to Island people me being sideline for so long. She knows what I meant since she was busy dealing with Citradel guests last night. She asks, I like to tag with you as well. I turned to her with a hesitant look, are you sure.

She sighs, I won't deny I am a little unsure how I feel about you. But at least I understand why you did it. So for now lets table it for later. Like you said, its important to show yourself to everyone. I was relieved to know she isn't angry with me like before. I couldn't think about it now. We both walk inside the room, one more thing. She answered before I asked, yeah. I won't tell anyone about your therapy or about this house. Don't worry about it.

I showed my appreciation to her, thanks. I still didn't feel any better sharing this secret to Catherine. But I learnt something from our discussion. I never figured it out before, but that hint from Drew has made me reevaluate few things. Some decisions and choices I was too afraid to make. Maybe there is something here that I could understand and fix my kuret block.

Blake (Chapter 55)

Thursday, October 2, 2025 23:25

Today has to be a normal day. I wanted it to be. No more excitement or surprises. Okay, maybe some, but not many. I got enough to deal with Heraknus moving. I had to wake up early today, so I asked everyone to leave around 12:30 AM. For Matt and Marina, I had to kick them. They were having way too much fun. Between sharpening a drunk Marina and Cassandra's sudden alter ego bursts, the party became more about blowing some steam rather than enjoying our victory. I didn't mind though, because I enjoyed it more than I excepted. For months, we had been training and managing the tournament. It has been mentally taxing. I even told other officers to the night take time off. Some did. However, sone didn't want off, they kept on working believing its not the time to celebrate. They weren't necessarily wrong, because it wished the moral would be more relaxed this accomplishment.

Fortunately, I had enough sleep last night. The kuret alcohol didn't give me too much hangover. By the time I was ready and finished breakfast, the last effects of the numbness was gone. I messaged on the network that I and some officers will meet the Citradel officers and escort them to the south shore. Everyone responded within minutes, save for one. Catherine didn't respond. I assumed she was just running late. Last night she said she was too tired. So I am sure she had late start.

When I reached the Citradel guest houses, I still didn't hear from her. Now I am getting a little worried. I shared somethings about David to her. Did that have to do something. Other officers arrived near the entrance after few minutes of my arrival. Luther and Jess were the first ones. They both had worn the special uniform we prepared. I myself had worn my royal attire. Luther had messaged last night to everyone that we should wear them to show our authority from David's victory. I wasn't sure if we call it victory, but I got convinced by him that this would make the statement that we are beginning of new sovereignty, a new city.

I was waiting by guest house entrance lobby. Jess says impressed, so that’s your new royal dress. Its exquisite. I smile, thanks. I was just happy it fits. It doesn't look too tight, right. Luther laughs, you look great. Perfect for a royal dignitary. I spat, lets hope Nathan and Freya don't get offended. Jess replies, I already spoke with them. They don’t mind. Truth be told I wasn't worried about it, I just said to let her know I am aware of her family and loyalties. But nevertheless, it was good to know it wasn't an issue. Luther asks, I don't see Catherine here. She is only one still not reported yet. Do you know if she is late.

I say, I have been trying to reach her. But she isn't picking up. Jess says, she messaged me early in the morning that if she couldn't make it, I should step take her role. So should I oversee the Citradel officials transitioning. At that’s good some good news. I look at Luther to confirm our decisions. I nod, yeah, that would be good. Thanks. Luther asks, so you what all you have to do. Jess nods with confidence, its just showing hospitality and managing their exit procedures. And, she pulls out her tablet, I got the roster of those cleared to moving today. Catherine and I had gone through all the checklists yesterday. So I am good.

Luther nods, all right. I will let others know you will be arriving instead of Catherine. Luther walks outside to talk to others. Jess says, all right. See in later. I wave her off as she walks inside past the gate. It was 8:00 AM, so we had an hour before they will leave. It was the time we needed organize and move our officers. I coordinated with Tina and others to confirm the route and keep the rood closed until the Citradel conveys leave. I got a report from Tessa that she and Nathan had arrived at the shore around 8:30 AM. They were setting up the barricade around the pier and should be done in few minutes.

But then we had another officer late. It was Vanessa. All though, she had at least messaged that she is running late. Unlike Catherine, who still hasn't reported in. I asked around few people if they knew if Catherine contacted them. No one had any idea. I can only hope she is late like Vanessa. Soon we got a message from Jess that the first group of officials with their guards will be coming out. We gathered around the entrance gate and had the cars pulled into the lot.

Tina reports to me, that’s all the cars. The last one is for Charles and his family. As you wanted, you and Jess will ride with them. Me and others will be riding with the rest of the officials. I nod, and what about the Heraknus group. Are they still requesting for no one to go with them. She got nervous, yeah. They are insisting they don't need any escorts. I sigh, its not just that simple. We can't have them ride alone. I turn up my tablet and view the convey arrangement. There were 7 Heraknus people. We had them in an 2 SUV. But they kept wanting to take everyone in one alone by not having any officers. I didn't see any issue with them riding on their own, but they are not yet citizens of this city. They were only our guests.

Luther approaches to Tina and me. He looks over my shoulder the contents of the screen. He immediately understood, so they still won't budge huh. Tina nods to him. I say to him, I don't like the idea of having unchaperoned Heraknus people moving in the city. Even if they will become residents soon, they are not yet one. And plus, they are in a very peculiar position. He nods, no need to explain. I agree with you. Personally, I would I have like to be them, but they don't want anyone with them. I stop once I scrolled to a name. Yeah, that could work.

I face Tina, lets make a small change. If they don't want us, fine. Lets have a Citradel official we trust with them instead. If we move Chancellor Reyas, they wouldn't object. And we can put Luther in place of him. Tina says after taking the tablet from me, I have heard about him. Do we trust him. I nod, yes. I have met him few times. He is actually in support of them moving here. He may not openly support it, but he told me in confidence when we met. Luther is in agreement with me, yeah. I know about him too. That’s a good choice. He will make sure no one causes any trouble to either from or to Heraknus.

Tina eyes to the screen, all right. I'll make the changes. She give me the tablet back and leaves to pass the change to others. Luther says, I guess there will some issues with Heraknus once they join. They don't trust us enough. It did look like that. I say, we were expecting it, right. We even prepared for it. But not with a mythical bloodline. Nor them moving here so fast. I think we should expedite our expansion plans immediately. We will soon have to treat them as domestic problems soon. Luther nods, I will take a note of that in our today's meeting.

They were taking some time, then Jess messages that the officials were discussing something and will be getting delayed for a while. I messaged her that Its not a problem since we have planned for a delay of up to an hour before any real issues happen. I wondered what they might be talking just minutes before leaving. A strong hunch was that it was about the Heraknus moving here. Could Kafar be trying to do make a play. But how that work after the conference last night. It has to be about something not to do with him then.

Few minutes later the officials began coming out. Me and Luther begin greeting them. The first one was Geisha. She smiles, good morning prince Blake. You look the part of royals now. I smile in return, morning chancellor. Thanks. I hope you get to see lot of it soon. I flashed a bigger smile hinting the possibility that they all will be moving here. She smirks amused, someone is getting ahead of himself. I don't deny the possibility though. Good chance we will soon be neighbors.

I nod, counting the days. You and your bodyguards can take that car. See you again soon. She replies, thanks Blake. Luther lets them guide to their vehicle. With that, one by one I showed my presence to the officials. When Reyas approached to me, he whispers, you moved me with Heraknus specially didn't you. I nod, apologies for the change. But they wouldn't let any officer with them. I don't want to presume, but is something more going on here than simple not being able to trust us. Reyas thinks for a bit before answering, I am not exactly sure. I knew about their existence in Citradel, but never met them. Kafar had exclusively met them every time. But I spent some time last at dinner. If I had to guess, its just probably that they are wary of others. They didn't expect to more here so unexpectedly. I am sure their attitude will change once they start living here.

It might be like he suggested. But if it were that simple, they wouldn't refuse us to have an officer with them. If Reyas didn't know, then maybe only Kafar would know. But I am not going to poke that bear. I say, thanks for listening to me. I hope its just that. Anyways, thanks for staying with us. I hope your visit was enjoyable. He shakes hands with me smiling, that it was. I loved the open air and freedom here. I will try my best to get others to listen to me and move here as soon as possible. I smiles, that’s very gracious of you. Before he leaves with his guards he says, by the way, you owe me one for this. No, two if the other thing also happens.

I laugh and wave at him. The other officials come and go into their vehicles. The cars in the lot waited to load their luggage's in the trunk. Meanwhile, the last of the Citradel people came out. The first few people were the Heraknus people. I met with 4 men and 3 women. I shook hands with each one, and every time I sensed their aura to be wavering a little. Its like they were intimated by me. I wasn't planning to come out looking like that. But they were polite and enjoying my company. One lady says, first time meeting a Volta royal terra. Another guy says, thanks for having us. I reply, nice to meet you all.

They didn't look any different from rest of Medrones. That goes to show how much the myth has twisted the reality. I took extra caution not to show any sign of treating them any different. Hopefully they can learn to trust me soon. Once they leave, the man of the hour comes in. Charles and his family were accompanied by Jess. I recognized Melinda beside him. The other two must be his children. Only Kafar, Marina and Derek were remaining. They should be with them, but I don't see them anywhere. Regardless, I signal to Luther that we are ready to move out soon.

Charles was wearing a track pants and a v-cut shirt. He spoke first, hey Blake. Looking sharp. I reply, morning to you too. Melinda, who wore a simple dress, beside him says, hello prince Blake. Nice to meet you. We both behave as though this is our first time meeting. Charles says, meet my son and daughter. They both introduce themselves as Rory and Tory. They both chose to wear the traditional Citradel uniforms. I answer, glad to meet you all. Hope you enjoyed the island. Tory was a tad bit more energetic than anyone says, I did. Its an awesome place. Citradel is cool and all, but the vibe here is on another level. But you guys have so much space and yet so little used. Rory interjects, sis, be more respectful. He is the leader of this place.

Seems he is more sensible than her sister. Melinda cuts in, not now you two. I don't want to hear complaining. Not with your first public appearance. I didn't want to be in the middle of this, so I ended by saying, when you come back in a month, we will expand the island's infrastructure. Tory says excited, awesome. I have a request then, I need a big arena for training. Like for a 100 of Heraknus people. And a ground too. We got some equipment and tech that. Rory cuts in, that’s enough. We don't need to discuss that. Tory made an irritating expression. I was glad he himself stop her. Melinda also scolded her daughter a little pulling her to the side. I wasn't sure how to deal with a requests like that. Should I lie or keep it vague.

Charles puts one arm in air, don't take it seriously Blake. She is just excited. We are not going to make any exorbitant demands. With a subtle nod I guided them to their car. The guards with them carried the luggage before us and began placing in the trunk. I turned and waited for Marina and Derek to arrive. Kafar comes out alone next. He had a little scowl as he approached us. I say, morning Kafar. Did you get enough rest. Kafar scoffs, hey Blake. I did as much as I could. Your sneaky stunt last night made some stir, I had to work extra to extinguish that.

I only smiled in response. I better not make any scene here. I made sure to be cordial to him so that he doesn't retaliate in any unexpected way, especially right now. He asks, how is our new champion doing anyway. I haven't heard anything about him since the match. I momentary was amused to hear him say that. He didn't show it, but his aura showed me a little tinge of irritation. I reply, he is fine. I haven't gotten a chance to speak to him, but rest assured, I am told he is just resting. Kafar nods ever so slowly pondering if I was lying. Technically I was, I had to make sure he never picks up on David's actual condition.

Kafar finally gives in, well, that’s good. Is he going to be at the pier. Even Charles perks up hearing that question and eyes me. Honestly, I had no clue. But I can't say that. So instead I say, we will see if he is, won't we. I played it safe, keeping it amusingly ambiguous. Charles laughs, no matter. We got we wanted from him, so its no problem. He is probably mentioning about Melinda approaching us about the questions he had. I didn't know if Kafar was in the know or he just ignoring it, but he says, in any case we have one last business to care of.

Huh, what could he be talking about it now. He says, after some discussion we decided to let Marina remain here and act us our emissary. So she won't be coming with us to Citradel. That was a sudden and strange development. I ask, what. Why is that. Charles answers this time, I proposed it to the officials. She has an extensive knowledge and skills to build our infrastructure here. Of course, it will a joint project with you, not just ours. But since I am making Heraknus move here early, I had to take my peoples consideration. We are used to the setup in Citradel, and we would like a similar one here. Marina didn't know about our existence, but she designed the buildings and infrastructure we lived and used.

That made sense. They were delaying to discuss this then. Actually, this is even a good news for us. I bet Marina is thrilled. She has been ready for this for a long time. Before I get excited I give an anxious look to Kafar, are you sure though. Marina is still your second strongest person. I wouldn't have thought you would let her live here even before Heraknus moved. Kafar nods, I know how it looks. But I had to change my thinking ever since the Charles made the deal. I actually supported this when Charles told us. I know exactly what's going to happen next. When we go back, people will be thrilled to see Heraknus as their secret guardian. And when the time comes, they will have no choice but to move with them. Others may seem hesitant and vague about moving here with Heraknus, but I am not.

Its more weird to seem him given up and accepting this. His attitude has reversed completely. He says, and since that is going to eventually happen, I thought we prepare for it now anyways. Marina could get started integrating the city immediately. We can remotely discuss with your team on what changes and new infrastructure to have in place. We have those initial plans you shared before the start of the tournament. Certain things will be approved immediately for Marina to start working on. Others, we will take some time discussing with you all. Our goal will be to get at least 10 to 15% of the development before Heraknus move. From then the progress will be rapid since people will be coming in soon from Citradel and other small communities.

He is already on top of this. This was probably the best thing I could have heard today. He sees my surprised look, don't look so shocked when you already know it was going to happen. I shook away my confusion, I didn't expect you would be so propellent. I did think we should start discussing it, but not day one. I would have contacted you once you reach Citradel. Kafar replies with a snarky tone, yeah. I know what hand I am delt with. Best to go with what I can control. I turn to Charles who smiles and nods to me.

I smile, Marina must be enjoying. Where is then. Charles says, when Kafar told her she frantically took her stuff from her room to someplace before you came. I couldn't help a laugh when I imagined seeing her rushing. My guess, she dropped her stuff at my place. I gave her the codes to my home, plus she did mention once she was going to use my place for temporary stay. I say, I suppose we should start looking a place for her as well. Kafar says annoyed, that capricious women left without wasting a second. I waited for her to discuss everything, but without me realizing, she had already left the guest houses. She even dragged Derek to help her out. What kind of stuff she has that she couldn't carry herself.

I knew what Marina was keeping with her. She could have carried everything herself, but having Derek with her just speeds things up. I look around the other waiting cars filled with the officials, so I am thinking Derek will meet us on the pier. Charles nods, yes. He told me not to wait and meet at the ship. I reply, okay then. So we can leave then. I signal to Luther and Tina that we are ready. Jess says, everyone and their luggage's are all set. I held the door as Charles and Kafar get in. The guards got in from the back side.

Jess took the driver seat and I went to the passenger seat. A minute later all the 7 cars left the guest house and on route to the pier. I was thrilled to have Marina move here so suddenly. The chances of all Citradel moving here took a big leap now. Jess whispers to me from the side, I heard what you were talking. So its true, Marina is moving here already. I nod. She smiles and cheers with slight gesture of her fist in air. Behind us the Heraknus kids were discussing with their parents about the islands features and places they licked. I get the feeling that Melinda and Charles didn't get much outside exposure. Considering the important work Melinda does, and the squad of people protecting her, she couldn't move around easily.

Neither could Charles. Jess asks Charles, Charles, if can please humor me with a question. Where would you like to live. Charles says, that’s a good question. As you know, didn't got to see much of island. But my kids have. And I heard the eastern parts of section 4 is a good spot. She glances me for a second with a confused look. I understood why she looked at me. I answer, so you prefer to live near the mountains. Charles nods, its not like the one's we had in Medrine. But its quite reminiscent of our lost history. I know it will never be back, but I think we can make it work with what we got.

I understood their sentiments. At this point Rory cuts in, I don't remember much about our homes. Gina, our older sister who stayed back in Citradel with the twins, remembers the most among us. When I showed her some pics few weeks back, she immediately asked us to check if anyone already took the place. Jess asks hesitant about something, she asked about a potential place to live here even before knowing you all will be moving here. That seems, she lost her words. It wasn't just her. It was strange Charles own daughter would think Charles would be loosing.

Rory went silent for some reason, like he thought of something unpleasant. Charles makes a funny expression, Gina is probably the biggest fan of David in whole of Citradel. She will always deny it, but we can tell. She has been tracking all his exploits and accomplishments. Before I left, she told me if I never got to fight you or Vanessa, David is probably the next likely to defeat me. I didn't think much of it, that is, until David came to the finals. She must be going ecstatic seeing David kicking her fathers ass.

I tried so hard to stifle a laugh. This is way too funny. Of all the people who could be supporting David, who would have guessed a mythical alpha's daughter. I saw Jess trying her best not to show her teeth. Tory says, hey that’s not true dad. Gina was just teasing you. Charles scoffs, don't defend her. I am not that stupid. Melinda, didn't Gina say that to you as well. Melinda flashes a smile, I am not going to get between the two of you.

It was complicated, and yet a normal family. No one would believe that they were from a mythical bloodline. Its quite a coincidence though. At the beginning of the final match, Ned had shown the peoples win stats which showed 8% for David. One of the supporters must have been Gina. Charles must be really conflicted to know her daughters prediction came true. David's grow strong during the tournament, but before that, he worked mostly in obscurity. For humans, we was just a criminal. For Medrones, he was a menace who fought for the right reasons. Even though he was framed by Nathan, not many could have supported David from Citradel. I wonder what kind of women Gina was.

We chatted a bit more about the Island development plan. That was the only time Kafar pitched in with his thoughts. After 10 minutes we reached the south shore. A swarm of people had gathered here. Jess had to slow down to be careful avoiding them. The barricade helped people keep at bay, but the kuritine drones with cameras fly over us towards the windows. They must be trying to get glimpses of Charles or any Heraknus. Jess says, guys. Apologies for all this commotion, but we couldn't keep people away far enough. Charles says nervously, the attention is little unsettling, I am not going to lie. Like all Heraknus, I am also not used to such scrutiny.

I advised him, better get used to it. When you come live here, there will be some challenges on both sides. And for a while, you will have to handle little bit of fame. Charles nods anxiously. His kids didn't faze much. I guess, they are now used to it after growing up with others on an alien planet. Melinda says, come on Charles. Don't let this get to you. I am also feeling a little bit of pressure now. But we knew this was going to happen ever since you decided to enter the tournament.

Charles says, knowing and experiencing are different things. Besides, I am not letting it get to me. I am the first Heraknus alpha they get to see in after than a two centuries. Its just a little bit of anxiety. Its understandable he feeling a little bit of pressure. The stadium was a little different, people were cheering for him, not approaching him like this to answer their questions. Some officers came by our side and pulled people a little further away from the road. With their help, we finally reach the shore parking lot.

I say, all right. Lets get you all on that boat. Once Jess parks the SUV, we all climb out. The cheering of the people became louder and the heat was felt from their voices. The guards begin unloading the bags from trunk. Ahead of us, I saw aura of Tessa and Vanessa near the pier entrance. I saw Nathan pacing around the pier, walking and speaking with officials as they climb on the cruisers. Since we were delayed, they got some time to push the barricade further back keeping the reporters from interfering too much.

Kafar says, since we some time until others go ahead, I want to talk to some people here. The pleasant mood turn sour hearing that. Kafar didn't wait for me to say anything and left us. I put my eyes on Jess pointing her to him. She nods, yeah, I'll just go with him. You know, so that he doesn't take too long. I hope she could somehow keep any of his usual antics away as much as possible. Rory approaches me, I don't see David here. So he really didn't come. I was hopping he be here. I didn't answer him and shrug giving him the impression that it is what it is.

Well, I was hoping to avoid this conversation all together. I had a small hope that he would be here. But I am little worried that Catherine is also not here. If was wasn't going to come, she would have at least told us. Both these absent people is making me worrisome.

Vanessa (Chapter 56)

Wednesday, October 1, 2025 17:28

Last night I couldn't get a lot of sleep. I kept thinking about my brother, my idol, my hero. I refuse to believe he would risk harming children. And when I did try to push those thoughts out, I kept thinking why Ned behaved differently to me all of a sudden. I thought we were in a good place in our relationship. I don't know how we got here, the argument we had in the VIP room started it. But it silently grew into a complete mess whenever I see him ignoring me or not talking.

My eyes were still heavy as I lay in my bed. The morning alarm had been snoozed twice already. I didn't want to face others in my current state. The third time it rang, Siera knocked on the door, Vanessa, wake up. You are going to get late. I didn't answer her right away. She knocks a couple more time. I sigh, yeah. I am awake. You know I can get up on my own. Siera says, then stop acting like a kid. You have work to do. I don't like to keep reminding you like this. Even if were late last night, you can't become lazy.

I rebottle at that, I wasn't late out for fun you know. Catherine, Tessa and I had to prepare security for Citradel guests for the night. It took a while to get all the shifts and manage personal. She scoffs behind the door, don't think I know you didn't get sleep because of that. I know you had a lot to deal yesterday. But you need to shake it off. Citradel officials are leaving soon. And your presence is necessary. So hurry up. If she weren't right I would have chided her for being so pushy.

With a laxed movement, I got out my bed, yeah. I got it. I will be out in 30 minutes. I turned towards the mirror and saw my face all flushed and heavy. This is what I get for obsessing so much about boys. Siera is right, I need to focus on today. A quick scroll through the network messages in my phone showed that Citradel officials are going to leave from the south shore 2 hours from now. All the top officers are required to be present by 8:30 AM. I had already assigned the guards for this morning around the south port, but I should still arrive a bit early. There were no new messages. Not from Ned or David.

David has been missing all night. After meeting Catherine last night, she told he is okay as Marina is able to check up on him. So assuming nothing happened, he is just hiding out somewhere. Many people went to his home, but he wasn't there. Blake told is he someplace secure, so maybe he is somewhere out of eyes of Citradel. Maybe there will be more news about him today. I am tiered of telling people I don't where is his or if his is okay. He better show up today to officers building. I have so much to ask him about Wagner.

Another guy I am anger is Ned. Last we spoke, I told him I needed space. I don't know what's going to happen to us. This is our first fight, its odd how long it took to finally happen. It started with him not supporting me when were betting the winner. But slowly it imploded. Even after thinking about most of the night I don't understand why he became so cold. But one thing is sure, I don't want to speak him today also. I want more time to sort out my feelings.

It took me longer to get out of shower today. I thought bathing more would help me relax, it didn't help as much I wanted. I pulled out the officer clothes from my rack and put it on. We were supposed to wear this for when we won the tournament, to show our victory. I don't know if it we really won or not. But Blake messaged last night to wear this anyways. I fashioned my hair into a pony tail. Then I put on my badge on my chest. I thought of applying a little moisturizer to hide any signs of sleep deprivation. I decided not to. It would look excessive effort, like I am trying to hide something.

One I was prepared, I walked out from my room. Siera was already sitting in the dining table and eating her breakfast. She was wearing regular clothes. I ask, you are not going to join us. She turns to me and gazes at my uniform, looks good on you. And no, Blake only wants you top officers there. I will come with you, but I will stay in the back. I took a chair and begin eating the food she prepared. I felt a little guilty for her having to make breakfast alone. I say, you should have woke me a earlier. I even skipped morning workout.

She smiles, its fine. I figured you deserve a day off after yesterday. But don't get complacent. You will have to put in more workout time this evening. And no excuses. You shouldn't let yourself get bothered by your relationship issues so much you can't sleep. You hear me. She was clearly in her soldier mode today. I'll admit that I feel more relaxed now than her mothering attitude. I nod, yes mam. Won't happen again. That was my hope rather than determination. Truth be told, I wasn't sure how I react to Ned. Or David, if he ever shows his face today.

After finishing our breakfast, we got ready to move out. Siera says, you go on ahead. Because of certain someone, we are late. I will follow you in the public trolley. I felt more guilt on my tardy attitude this morning, I can carry you. She scoffs, I rather not get my daughter to fly me like that, especially for a trivial thing like this. I am fine with a ground transport. She looked a little embarrassed about it. I guess anyone would be. I reply, okay then. See you later.

I step into the middle of road. Few of our neighbors are out and walking. Some are probably heading to the south port. Others getting on with their normal routine. I gather my Kuret around me and force the winds to pull me up. The draft begins to pull in more momentum and soon it pushes me up. A moment later I zipped through to the sky and flying in the air. Once I had enough altitude, I turned towards the southern part of the island. I saw more people on the ground converging into the port.

After about 5 minutes I reach my destination. A small crowed had gathered now. The officers had built a small barricade of kuritine border to keep civilians out. I look for a safe spot to land. I found one near the right side of the barricade. I gradually slowed my decent and land on the concrete payment. Around me some officers stepped a little back giving me space to land. I make the winds around me slip away back into the air. I see three officers walking to me. It was my team, Ruther, Deni and Somers.

Deni asks, you are late. She sounded anxious. I figured they were a little worried, even when I messaged them earlier this morning. I wave my hand at her, sorry. I was more tired than I thought. Somers says, I told you she was okay. You were worried for nothing. Deni gasps, I wasn't worried. But she was supposed be here 30 minutes ago. Ruther interrupts, settle down you two. She is here now. And anyways, Citradel people are late too. So there's no harm. Cut her some slack. He is probably the most sensible here. I am grateful to him backing me, no. Its my fault. I shouldn't have been later no matter what happened. I turn me neck around to check out the security lineup.

After inspecting it, I faced them again, I promise it won't happen again. So lets get back to work. Citradel officials will be here anytime. Somers says, we just got a message that the last of Citradel people are finished having their breakfast. They will be here in another 10 minutes. I reply, then that’s all the time we have. I point to the barricade, lets line it further back. I saw more people coming here. We need to create some more space from the shore. Somers says irritated, I should have known. It wasn't enough. Deni replies, hey, I said we will move it back if needed.

We got to work. I ordered the officers to their tasks. The security guys asked people to walk back more. I saw few drones and cameras pointed towards us. They were going to broadcast this over the network. Ruther beside me says, they were here before us. I couldn't ask them to leave, so I kind of had no choice and leave them be. I nod, it will be okay as long as they don't break the line. Have someone ask them to cover from other sides of the barricade, having all those reporters in one place might create some chaos later on. He agrees, will do. He goes to talk to them.

15 minutes go by and we got messages that Citradel officials are on the move. We managed to push back the barricade further away from the shore. I feel better seeing the extra space now. While I worked other top officers who were already here saw me. Tessa and Nathan were the first to walk by me. They were also wearing their uniform and badges. Tessa asks, good. You are here. You have any idea where Catherine is. When I didn't see you both here, I thought you both had some other emergencies I didn't know about.

That’s the first time I heard about this. I reply, no. I am not sure. I thought for sure she was here. I came here 20 minutes ago, when I didn't see her here, I thought she was with the Citradel guests. Nathen says, no. She is not with them. I spoke to Jess a while ago, only she, Blake, Luther and Ned are accompanying them. That’s wired. I opened my phone and checked for any messages from her. She hadn't reached out me. Tessa says, I tried calling her, but it never connected. This is a troubling. I tell them, the last time I saw her was when she left to the dining building. Did something happen after that.

Tessa recalls for a little bit, I can't think of anything. She said she wouldn't be joining us at Blakes place and went back home. I remembered the message from last time. Turns out few people went to party at Blakes house to celebrate the victory. I wasn't in the mood, so I declined. Catherine also didn't go. Nathan interjects, its sad I wasn't invited. I would have loved to join in the party. Tessa smirks, no you don't. You would have brought down the vibes, like Marina said. She was right, Nathen tagging them along would be a disaster to their celebration.

Nathen mocks us with a hurt expression, that’s not true. He smiles then, well. Anyway. I was anyway enjoying the company I was with, so no harm done. I got back to the conversation, don't tell me Catherine is still sleeping off. She looked overworked yesterday. Tessa replies, that’s not likely. No one would miss this out for an excuse like that. Internally, I was hurt by her comment. Siera was right, I shouldn't have been so distracted. Nathan saw me hiding something. I thought for sure he would point it out, but instead he says, its all right. I sent someone to her house. No one responded. I don't think she is there, so she is definitely somewhere. Try not to be worried for no reason.

Its easy for him to say that. I reply, we can't have another person missing. Nathan eyes me for a moment, so David is still missing huh. That’s actually bit more troubling. I hoped he would at least show up here, before Citradel leaves. It wouldn't look good if the Citradel thought he is still resting. Or hiding. He stressed the last part like he was implying something. Does he know something. Before I could ask, two more people came from the side. Matt and Cass wave their hands to us, morning guys. Looks like everyone is here. Cass looks around us seeing anyone else nearby. They both were in their regular officer uniforms.

Cass replies, so, who's still hiding. Tessa replies, hey guys. Its nothing. Nathan just likes to create smokes. Nathan laughs lightly at her jab. I ask them, have either of you heard from Catherine. She is the only one not here. Matt and Cass look at each other confused. Cass says, she isn't here. Maybe she is just late. It was becoming more worrisome that it wasn't just a simple reason as that. Matt says seeing us anxious, is there something we should be worried about. She must be running later, right.

I reply, lets hope so. Matt says, you missed out big time Vanessa. It was a good to let some steam off after so long. You didn't get to see drunk Marina. He starts to laugh recalling the memories of last night, I never knew she couldn't had such a low tolerance. That made me smile. The thought of seeing a drunk Marina was something quite intriguing. Cass clicks her mouth, stop spreading rumors like that. If Marina hears about it, she will get you back at you. Tessa smiling says, I don't know about that. It was hilarious to see Matt and Blake restraining Marina from a drunk casting.

Cass sighs, not you too. Matt laughs becomes louder now, see. It was funny. Besides, she won't care. I didn't agree with him, really. You think a shadow will be okay with that. That made a dent in his joy. His laughter dies down abruptly, shit. I forgot. Dammit. Seeing a normal woman like her made me forgot about that. I must still have a bigger hangover than I thought to forget about that. He then turns a little anxious, you know what. I was joking. I don't remember Marina drunk at all. I might have confused her with, yeah. Cassandra here. Seeing him blame her shamelessly, Cass rebukes, don't drag me into it.

Nathan smiles, thanks for that titbit. Nice to know Marina has such a trivial weakness. The mood suddenly turn downer hearing him say like that. I don't think he was serious, but no can be sure of that. He looked at our

quite expressions and says, lighten up. I am only messing you all. What kind of person you think of me. I reply, you don't want to know that, trust me. Nathen turns to me amused, oh really. I'll admit I am complex. Unlike the simple problem going on between you and your boyfriend.

He is obviously goading me into anger here. I tighten my first annoyed at his attempt to get a raise out of me, you want to try that attitude again. I take one step towards him. He didn't back down, hit a nerve did I. I suppose you were late because of him too, isn't that right. My anger rose quickly at his correct deduction. Ned wasn't the only reason, but yeah, I couldn't get him out of my mind all night. Matt suddenly comes in between us and puts his arms on both of us, okay, lets just take a beat guys.

Cass says in a hushed voice, there are camera here. You don't want to show dissension among us. Do you. Nathan and I didn't budge. I didn't care about people seeing us. I already had to endure so much crap yesterday, and on top of that my lack of sleep is effecting my judgement. Tessa comes in, all the officers are here too. Don't make a fuss here. Do it somewhere else. Finally Nathan sighs, my bad. I got carried away. He takes a step back, you might want to check that temper of yours. So quick to react. He turns his back to us, I am going to check to double check the cruise ships. See you later. Without any more of consideration on goading me so much, he dashes away to the ships arched on the pier.

My anger didn't have an out anymore. I got annoyed being called out like this, especially from him. Cass says, settle down Vanessa. Forgot about him. Matt says, yeah. His is only good at provoking others. I knew Nathan the best, so I understood that. But even after all this time, he can get under my skin so easily. I can't wait to punch him. Tessa sensed my thoughts, leave it alone. Citradel officials are going to be here any second. Get a hold of yourself. She was persuading with enough force that made me shook my annoyance. I answer, sorry. I don't know what's gotten to me today. I am used to Nathans antics.

Matt offers, its all cool. Everyone has bad timings. Though, you could have told you and Ned still haven't patched things up. I remained quite at that. Cass asks, did you even talk to him. All I could do was shook my head slightly. Its embarrassing to show them this side of me. Its discomforting to know people see me like this. I didn't want this to go any further, guys. I appreciate the help, but I don't want to talk about it right now. I have job right now. We all do. So lets just forgot what you saw, all right.

They all no choice but to agree to it. I didn't want them to make big fuss about it. Doesn't matter how I was feeling right now. We are surrounded by people and cameras. Even if I don't care about how I would appear to them, I didn't want others to get dragged into this drama. Tessa says, that’s settles it. Its good, because they are here now. So game face on people. She points to the incoming convoy of vehicles noise coming. Matt and Cass go back to their posts near the barricade.

Tessa and I walk to the middle of the barricade where the officials will be entering. I pass by Ruther and ask him, everything is ready. He responds, yes. We are ready here. Soon the cars begin to arrive in the parking lot. I count 6 cars here. I ask Tessa, is there any change in the personal counts. She pulls out her tablet from her pocket and takes a look. After scrolling she says, no. They are sticking with the 23 people, 11 officials and 12 guards, the same lineup we know. So there's no change needed in our transportation schedule.

The doors open and people began coming out. I saw Blake, Luther and Jess coming out from first car. I peeked at the other cars around them. No sign of Catherine. So she really wasn't with them. This isn't good, she missed her post this morning. What could have hold her up from coming here. The kuret drones with cameras began circling around the people walking towards us. Officers kept guard around people and gave way for the Citradel people to us.

A stream of Citradel people wearing their traditional uniforms walk by us. The guards walked beside them carrying backpacks and luggage's. The first person was the elderly lady, Geisha, the who was in the conference broadcast yesterday. I welcomed her, good morning Geisha. She smiles and we shake hands, morning kid. I ask, hope you are well rested, the ride over the ocean is a little bumpy. She laughs a little, yeah. It was a long day for us. But don't worry about such things. I believe, we are in good hands. She points to all the guards around her.

I nod to the guards around her. She faces Tessa next, and your hospitality was great. We felt safe our two week stay. They both shake hands. Tessa says, that’s good to know. Its too bad you are leaving already. We had planned another 3 day of stay initially. Geisha chuckles, trust me, I was looking forward for it. I guess that’s just life on Earth now. You can't expect everything goes according to how we want. I smile at her. She was referring right now at the deal David and Charles made. I never thought about it too much, but it probably threw a big wrench in their plans.

Behind them, I saw more officials coming at us. So I had to cut short this, lets hope we meet again. Ruther, please escort her to the ships. Ruther nods, please follow the sighs we laid out. He guides her and the guards to their assigned ship. Geisha waves us, see you kids soon. With her departure, officials begin entering the barricade with their guards. Tessa and I make brief exchanges as they walk by us. Deni and Somers fill in the roles whenever Ruther is not here.

Soon half of the Citradel officials boarded their ships. I saw some officials giving interviews with the reports at the edge of the barricade. I look at Tessa asking silently if it was really okay. She nods, its fine. You were right to have them spread out so they don't all cluster around a single person. Even if it delays a bit, its fine. After being assured I agreed to wait for them until they finished giving their interviews. I finally saw Charles at the back. He was surrounded by few people. I recognized Melinda. And there were two young people also. The guards around them were wearing different clothes. They must be the Heraknus people. I found Blake and Luther with them. They were talking. But I didn't see Marina or Derek with them. I didn't see the two of them anywhere. They must be running late.

I didn't want to intrude, so I kept waiting at my post. 10 minutes go by and almost all the Citradels had boarded. The next official was Kafar. He wasn't as excited as others, I would even say he looked distraught. He sees me eyeing him, you don't need to pity me. I know how I look. I hesitantly say, I didn't say anything. He says, you didn't need to. You and your friend's expression says everything. Tessa was also quite, but maybe we both showed too much on our faces.

Tessa says trying to diffuse any possible situation, we didn't mean to be rude. I know you are not happy with this outcome. But I am glad you at least accepted it. He smirks hearing that remark, I didn't think it would turn out like this. I wanted Citradel to win the tournament. I really believe hiding in that city is how we will survive. But now regardless of who wins, we will be moving here. Its wired how he himself has recognized it. I ask, so you already believe everyone will want to live here. He nods, I am not stupid Vanessa. Once I realized Charles had no intention of listening to me anymore, I knew we lost. There is no way we can stay in Citradel anymore without their protection.

Tessa and I share a look of surprise. Neither of us thought Kafar would have accepted it so easily. Tessa faces him again, it’s a little wired to see you say that yourself. But considering you couldn't change this even after taking whole day to decide, I guess you also had to give in. He chuckles, I wanted more continuums, to take another day to hash it more. We hadn't initially confirmed to give our decision last night, even though we said we would. But that rally and Blakes scheming put us in a hard position. Thanks to him, we had to give up. I had to give up.

He sounded defeated now. I don't believe he is faking it too. But I can't say for sure. Quite a bit transformation from his bolstering from yesterday. I smile recalling that, so in the end we won. The bet we made might still be going on, but like you said, the final match doesn't matter. I probably shouldn't have said that. Perhaps I still was riled up from Nathan earlier and seeing Kafar's face made me feel like that again. Kafar stares at me silently with anger. What, is he trying to intimidate me. I wasn't going to back down from this guy. He spewed so much non-sense about David yesterday to discredit him.

Thankfully Tessa was with me. She took a step forward, anyways. Chancellor Kafar, you can go ahead with them. They will show where to board. Tessa points to Deni. Kafar's gaze finally leaves me. Without saying anything more, he walks away with his guards. I thought that would be it, however, he says with his back to us, I haven't see David here. Actually, I haven't seen anywhere since his match. Makes one wonder if he is still resting. Maybe he is hiding because he is too injured to show his face.

Even without his face I could tell he was smiling still throwing bullshit around. Tessa saw my anxiousness, don't go after him. I could tell he still hasn't accepted it completely. He is just trying to throw some dirt around hoping something would stick. I calm down knowing Tessa also didn't buy his attitude. I bark, even after all this, he still believe there is a chance. Tessa says, you are talking about a guy who has been boasting for long about his undefeated his champion. His pride has been hurt too much. But even he can't do make selfish decisions alone.

I reply, I understand all that, but what he said about David missing is true. And now Catherine is also not here. It doesn't look good. I bet he gave interviews with those reporters back there trying to make us believe David can't fight. Tessa becomes anxious, I can't deny that. But we can't do anything about it now. Lets just focus on getting everyone onboard now. I had to push the worrying thoughts aside and greet the remaining officials. Another few minutes went by and only the Heraknus group were remaining.

They finally began moving to us from the parking area. The Heraknus people first came with Melinda and those two young people. I had to act like I never met her before. Melinda says, morning to you all. I am Melinda. She shakes hands with Tessa and me. Tessa smiles saying, morning. So I guess you must be Charles family. Her intuition was right on the money. She nods, yes. Its nice to meet you two as well. And these are my kids, Rory and Tory. These were the kids she mentioned earlier. Charles and his first wife's kids. They both looked our age. The guy had strong features similar to his fathers. The girl was actually quite well built. She was probably strong too.

They both take turns greeting us, hi there, Tory says. She held a strong grip. I had a vague feeling like she is trying to measure me. I wasn't going to let her make this a wired competition, so I took my hands away swiftly. She had a similar interaction with Tessa. Was this a common behavior of her. She felt aggressor than her brother. He was more polite, nice to finally meet you. We were impressed with both of your matches. He felt opposite of her sister, he was probably the older and mature one. Tessa says, thanks. We don't hear enough of this after our matches.

I smiled agreeing with her, yeah. Its nice to hear Citradel people are impressed, especially after my performance. He shook his head, you don't have to feel bad. Marina is quite special. She would even give Dad a run for his money. Tory says, who knows how it might have turned out if dad had entered normally. I would have loved to see him fight you guys too. I couldn't tell if she find it amusing or was serious about it. Melinda cuts in, come on kids. We shouldn't keep them busy. You'll have plenty of time to chat later.

Tory bulges a little, come on. We weren't allowed to talk to other warriors till now. We got to meet them finally just as we are leaving. Melinda chides her daughter, you already got to speak with Blake and Jess. That was already enough, so don't get greedy. She wasn't going to let it go. So Tessa helped out here, let me go with you. I am happy to talk to you while we wait for Charles to board. She smiles happily, thanks a bunch. I have so much to ask. Tessa faces me, I'll take them.

Rory instead asks, let me talk to Vanessa for a minute. You guys go on ahead. Melinda says before leaving, don't keep us waiting too long. With Tory and Tessa chatting up, they left us behind. I signaled Somers to follow behind the guards. Rory says, thanks for sticking with me for a while. I just had a question. He looks around, like he is searching for someone and then asks, I don't see David. Is he not here. I didn't realize he was looking for him. I reply, unfortunately no. He isn't here. He looks a little upset, I really wanted to meet him. I was a little amused to know Charles son was a fan of David.

But then he became serious all of a sudden. He comes closer to me and speaks in a low voice, since you are here, tell me. Did David really cheated when he fought my dad. I was astounded hearing the rumor that was

spreading yesterday from his mouth. I immediately denied it, no matter what Kafar and other officials say, David wouldn't cheat in such an important match. Rory still had the same serious expression, I am not so gullible like my dad. He always has been a little simple minded. Its not that I don't like that positive attitude, but I am protective of him. He believes David wasn't tricking him using those weird kuret attacks. But I am suspicious. I think once David realized he couldn't win, he resorted to cheating. No way my father, an alpha of Heraknus, could be pushed to use his overdrive to defeat a guy like him.

My initial image of him began to disappear. He was only pretending earlier in front of other. I didn't want to make a scene so I calmly responded, what do you mean when you say guy like him. He says, you know what I mean. Its no secret his background is suspicious. The only thing we know he is from the old MARS project. He doesn't even heal, but somehow he is able to defeat alphas and omegas. And even a freaking terra. I don't buy it. Something is going on with him. I hoped he would show up here and explain it.

He had drink Kafar's propaganda about discrediting David. He continuous, and its no surprise he is crafty. I heard stories about him scheming and gullible people getting tricked. It wouldn't be out of the realm that would cheat so brazenly and still get away. The more I heard, the more I tried to not get annoyed. I reply, look. Its easy to speculate from sidelines. He haven't seen my up close. Yes, he uses tricks and other things to win. But he wouldn't try it in a tournament. He answers, then why isn't he here. I keep hearing rumors about him. Like he may be trying to hide evidence of cheating. No one has seen him. Is he really just resting as everyone keeps saying. I don't buy it.

This guy is getting on my last nerves now. The other officers around me didn't see it, but our conversation was one short fuse away from me shouting at him.

Vanessa (Chapter 57)

Wednesday, October 1, 2025 22:59

I didn't have to deal with him for long. Behind us, Blake's group approached us. Charles sees me talking with his son, morning Vanessa. Its good to see you again. His face was all healed up now. I swallowed by emotions about Rory and pulled a weak smile, hey Charles. You are all healed now.

Charles touches a part of his chin, not fully. Just on the surface. His eyes lays on Rory, what are you talking. You looked so serious. He feigns ignorance, nothing much. Just check if she knew if she knows where David is. I am almost impressed how easily he switched back to politeness. Blake, dressed in his full royal dress, comes ahead, it is what it is. I don't know why, I felt that was rushed. Maybe he overheard our discussion. No, Charles didn't hear it.

Charles says, Oh well, I guess the next time I meet is when we move here. Blake steps beside me, hey. All good here. I nod, yes. Deni has confirmed all of them have boarded. The only one left are you guys. I wave towards Charles, his son and the guards around us. And of course Marina and Derek. Blake says, good. I have to tell you something though. There is a slight change in the list of people leaving after all. I just spoke with Charles and Kafar officials about it.

I was expecting a change. Since Heraknus are moving here ahead of plan, there is bound to be changes. Blake says, Marina will staying here permanently. I gasp, what. Isn't she important to the officials. Blake nods, true. But something else came up. They decided that she should overview the construction of expanding and other home requests for Heraknus house. We didn't anticipate any of the Citradel people permanently moving so soon. So they need her help to expedite this and other potential bloodlines moving here. Even with just 4 weeks of additional planning will make the progress fast.

That’s amazing. I was thrilled to know Marina would start living us. Even with all her flimsy attitude, having a powerhouse like here is a serious boast to our moral and strength. Her staying here would help Heraknus move here easily. I had a question, that's great news. But then what about her stuff back in Citradel. Doesn't she need it for a longer stay. Blake becomes a little hesitant at my question. He whispers to me, it seems in an anticipation of our loss, she already had all brought her essential stuff here. Whatever was left in Citradel, Derek can bring it with him. That made me laugh a little. Others saw me confused, sorry. Its just sounds so much like her. Did she really prepared it so early. I mean, she couldn't have known who won in the end.

Blake replies, yeah. In that case, she was going to take all her stuff back with her. Rory asks, you knew about it. Didn't you. You two shadows would do things like that. Blakes smiles, maybe I knew. Melinda says, regardless, Marina was fully prepared when she came here 4 months ago. So its not problem. In fact she was relieved to not travel when they told her this. She and Derek are right now moving her stuff from the guest house to a temporary location. That’s why the two of them are not with us.

Rory says, Derek just messages me a while ago, they both will be here soon. I turn to Ruther, tell others there is one less occupant now. Marina is going to stay with us now. He got excited at that news and walks to the other officers near the ships. I speak to Charles, well. Lets get you seated on the ship at least. He nods. Since his was the last group, I tag along with the group to his designated boat. Blake asks me separately, have seen Catherine. She was supposed to meet us at the guest houses. I whispered back, no clue. I thought for sure you knew where she was.

Blake sounded a little worried. I ask, I am sure she is fine. Just late. He answers, if only that was it. I have tried pinging her phones GPS location, but she has turned it off. That was strange. I didn't think she would do something like that by mistake. I ask, so she is doing her thing. Like espionage or something like that. He shots me a look, where exactly. All the officials are with us. Would she spy among the other Citradel warriors and civilians. And what for. Theres nothing for her to spy on there. He was even more worried than me.

I offered, once we get them boarded, I'll look for her. Blake nods, you and me both. I have a feeling she might be doing something I told her not to. I wondered what it could be. We couldn't chat more once we reach the bridge. The guards carrying the luggage's went abord first. Deni came running behind me, Vanessa. There is something you should know. She looked panicked about something. She tried to hide from Charles and other Heraknus around us. She points to the side shore of the bridge. I see a person walking from the side.

Blake shocked says, Catherine. Speak of the devil. It was her. She finally made it here. Where was she all this time. She was walking fast and hurrying towards us. She was in her officers uniform like me. Once she approached us, others also recognized her. She says, apologies for my tardiness everyone. Especially you Charles. Charles gives a surprised look, its quite all right. I was told I would be meeting you before breakfast. She nods frantically, sorry. I had an emergency that ran far too long than I expected. And by the time it was over, I was already late to meet you. I hope Jess was able to help out in my place. I gave her all the instructions.

That’s why Jess was with others. Charles smiles, yes. She was very helpful. So its fine. I do hope everything is okay with you. She nods, yes. Its been sorted out. Blake steps forwards, we will talk later. But did you ran all the way from the shore. I didn't see you coming from the barricade. Catherine nervously says, I had to use a boat to come here. I was in other part of the island. I'll explain later. Blake and I exchanged looks and understood we shouldn't go in detail here. I turn to Deni and we spoke quietly, how come you just noticed her boat. We are supposed to have a tight security.

Deni looked frantic and anxious, I don't know. We picked up a signature out of nowhere. Soon as someone noticed her in a boat I told you. This is bit disappointing to know our lack of security here. Catherine herself didn't say anything to help explain this. Blake cuts in, anyways. Lets get you two settle in. He points to Charles and Rory. Rory says, yeah. I am worried Tory would be causing trouble to mom and Tessa. Its ironic he would say when he himself was causing me trouble.

They both board inside the cruise ship. Blake followed behind them. I told Deni to inform me once Derek shows up. She agrees with a nervous expression to Catherine. I bet she was wondering how she appeared without anyone knowing. I begin climbing inside the cruise behind others. I get close to Catherine who was looking a little distraught, is everything okay. You look a little out of it. Catherine tried to hide with a poker face. She is usually much better than this, but I could tell she is a little troubled. She replies, something did happen. Its fine though. Nothing you should be concerned with right now. But lets not talk about it now. I reply, its bad enough David is still awol. I didn't want to add you as well.

Catherine chuckles a little, yeah. Sorry. I just caught up in it. She then leans forward and looks a little suspicious, and David is also not missing. You'll see him soon. I got stunned hearing about his reveal. I ask her, you met him. She didn't reply soon immediately. She stayed quite for few seconds. Then says, just wait for it. You'll know soon enough. She wasn't making sense, what's going on with the two of them. I didn't ask her further, we just walked behind the ground navigating the corridor inside the ship. We were walking to the deck on the top where we would take the final gathering of officers before the departure.

I am sure others are already up there. The sky opens up as I cross the stairs to the lower deck. I saw all the officers gathered near the center. Kafar and three other officials were here along with the Heraknus people. Nathan, Tessa were talking with Tory and Melinda. Luther and Jess were chatting with some guards. Everyone scatter around as we approach them. Charles says, looks like everyone is here. Others hadn't met Charles personally, so they were amazed and a little star struck to him. Even Nathan was little formal being near him.

A Heraknus guy came forward to Charles, yes. We are just waiting for Derek. He looked like a regular person. It would be hard to tell he was a Heraknus. I gather a little bit of kuret in my eyes, and yet I couldn't see even a little bit of Kuret from him. I could see some from Charles. But nothing from the other Heraknus. It was a little jarring to see how their bloodline was effected from coming to Earth. I am sure others are also trying to gauge them here. For many of us, this is first time seeing other Heraknus along with Charles in one place.

I got a message in my phone. I put it to my ears. After hearing the message, I relayed it to others, Derek and Marina just arrived to the shore. He will be here in a minute. Blake nods, well. That’s makes everyone. We hoped to get you all leave exactly at 9:00 AM. But I suppose a 20 minutes delay was going to happen no matter what. Charles says, I should have mentioned about Marina earlier. But she wasn't available last night to talk. I hear she was out partying with you.

All eyes feel on Blake. He didn't seem troubled by it, instead, he was a bit amused, yeah well. If you knew her, you would know that she doesn't hold back. She always supporting her stay here. And her wish came unexpectedly like this. Charles smiles, that it did. I can't blame her for supporting David. There are others like her who are happy that they might be moving here soon. So I don't find it wired people are already celebrating your victory. Rory mumbles from my side, if I was participating I would have won. I don't think anyone else heard it. I couldn't help but be amused at his confidence. I don't know how powerful he was, but I don't think it would have been easy. Charles told other Heraknus were effected even worse than him. And judging by the kuret I saw, or rather didn't see, he is not yet at alpha level.

He catches me from the side looking at me. Instead of getting anxious, he pulls out a big smile. This guy, he has an arrogant side bigger than her sister. Catherine from my other side asks, sorry to ask now. But I thought you had other children Charles. They didn't come with you here. I hadn't noticed that at all. I remembered he has 3 other kids. Charles says, my eldest child, Gina is with other two back in Citradel. I wanted them bring them too, but. Melinda cuts in, I didn't want them here. They are only 8. They are very energetic at that age. They would only create more trouble for us and others. Charles looks like he was just scolded and waves his hand to her, well, you heard her. So I had to keep Gina keep an eye on them.

Catherine says, oh that’s fine. I was just wondering. I am sure they will like living here. Charles looks hesitant, hold that thought till you meet the twins. That made us all laugh a little bit. Behind me I hear footsteps from the stairs. Derek popped out from the stairs below and Marina followed suit. Derek had a slightly tensed expression. Marina was excited to be here. What's more interesting that she was now wearing our officers uniform. When the hell she made one for herself. She didn't have a badge though. Marina laughs saying, morning everyone. Sorry we kept you all waiting. Derek says, morning. He looked a bit weary of Marina. I can guess he was because he had to carry her stuff and also wait to let her get dressed or something like that.

Marina walks towards Charles straight head. She must be excited to see him after all this time. Marina says, Charles. Nice to meet you after all this time. Charles and her shook hands. Charles says, same here. Its a little disappointing to know we never got to meet. I hope you understand, it wasn't a decision made lightly. For many reasons, I couldn't tell you about me. She answers, its cool. At least I got to see in person now. She was giddy all the time, but then she turns a little sour noticing Melinda beside him. She says, your wife though is different. In all the time we worked, she conveniently never mentioned she was married, let alone to you.

She is still salty from yesterday. Melinda just let out a little giggle. Charles shares a glance at both of them, you two have a lot to talk about. I am sure. Derek comes to my side now, so you had a busy morning. He sighs, you can say that. I told her she didn't need to wear that uniform now. But she didn't back off. We were late anyway, so I figured another few minutes wouldn't hurt. But man, does that women take time to dress up. Hard to know if she was doing it on purpose or was she planning to make an appearance like this. His was voicing his reluctance, but I figured he didn't mind too much since he offered to help her move her stuff.

Blake asks, when did you get that dress. I didn't issue a badge yet. Marina says, I already had prepared it a while back. And since now that I am officially moved here, I figured I would dress up accordingly. He says, but weren't you told just an hour back. She smiles and shrugs, I was too excited I guess. We should have known since we know how she is. Marina says, forgot about that. But drink in this juicy fact. Finally all 3 overdrive users are in place at the same time.

So that’s what got her excited the most. People laugh around us realizing that fact. Charles enjoys it, true. It is quite surreal to had the 3 of us here. Even Blake was enjoying himself now, its quite a group we got here. I don't I have heard a gathering like this back in Medrine. I am sure they have, but can't put my finger on when. Marina says, it happens rarely. People began chattering amongst about this momentous occasion. Derek sighs, should have known this would happen. We are going to be even more delayed now.

I tell him, its fine. That’s why we planned it ahead of time. Even if you leave by 10:00 its going to fine. You will make to the other ferries and airports well in advance. Derek says, I know. Its just, I want to sleep. I had to be awake till very late last night. The whole day was already tiering from being looked in the conference room. I think I would doze off any second now. So that’s what been bothering him. Its weird that both us security heads are sleep deprived. Though, my reasons are more personal.

Blake says, sorry to call out here everyone. But I think its time. Marina beside him seemed reluctant. He eyes her, we are already late. Maybe if you didn't waste time moving and trying to impress with your uniform, you would have gotten more time with us. But lets not keep them waiting anymore. Marina backed down after being singled out like this. Then suddenly a certain voice came hey now. Spare a little bit of more time for me too. Marina isn't the only one waiting for a chance to meet Charles. It came from the upper deck. That voice. Everyone recognized it immediately. Everyone turn their gazes to the above deck. Soon the footsteps came to the stairs.

David nonchalantly climbs down the stairs. The freak is he doing here. How did he get passed no one knowing. Everyone were too stunned to speak. David walks slowly, making a show of his grand entrance. He was wearing his special officers uniform. His bruises and wounds were stitched. His was smiling ear to ear seeing our stunned faces. I was too shocked to remember that I am crossed with him. He says, what. Did you all think I would miss out this. I was here all this time, hoping someone would find me. No one noticed me. I am a little hurt. The gall of him. I can't believe he was implying he has been here all this time. We did sweep of entire ships, no one saw him.

I turn to Catherine who had a slight smile on her face. She knew. Dammit it. Did the both of them plan this. David walks to us gawking crowd. Marina is the first person to say, Wow. You really made an entrance. David laughs, sorry to steal your thunder like this. I didn't know you were planning to do something similar. Marina laughs, clearly I should have known you would try to one up me. He says, not my intention. As he walks around us glancing around, I found something weird. His is acting very wired. I thought it would be tense between us, but he didn't faze a bit when we locked eyes. In fact, he showed the same expression when meeting others gaze. This all feels too mechanical. Was it just me or did others can also see that.

He halts near Charles, sorry to keep to waiting like this. It embarrassing, but once I had rested enough to move, I left the infirmary, and slept through till the night. I was too tiered than I assumed. I hopped to meet you earlier, but something came up. I sure didn't want to be this late. Charles shakes off his surprise, I am glad to see you here now. You made a lot of buzz though. I heard you weren't in your home. It made your own people worry. David nods, yeah. About that, I didn't want to be bothered by people, so I went someplace I could have more peace.

He is being purposefully vague about things. He seems different than the last time I saw him. He was acting a bit wired then, but this feels a different kind. Like this is too rigid. He is showing emotions, but like its rehearsed. People who didn't know him wouldn't know any difference, but something is off about him. Charles says, I guess that’s one way to do it. So, you all good now. David laughs, I am. I know people were worried about me, but I wanted to surprise you all here first. I am sure I will face some backlash for my poor decisions. But that’s nothing you need to be concerned with. I wanted to show my face once at least to you and tell I will be waiting for our fight.

Charles quietly glances David top to bottom, you do appear better than yesterday. And even without your kuret healing, your wounds don't look too bad. I guess, the rumors of your injuries were greatly exaugurated. He eyes everyone here. But many people stole glances at Kafar, who was most definitely the culprit of spreading those rumors. David smiles, glad I could clear that up. Everyone finally relaxed now after David made his speech. Charles says, I like you to meet my family. He introduces Melinda and his kids to him, my wife Melinda and these are Tory and Rory. He shakes hands with each of them. David peeks at Melinda, pleasure to meet you. Melinda flashes a smile, nice to meet you as well. You know, you gave Charles a lot of trouble yesterday. No one has pushed him so much, not even Echos.

David shrugs in return. He turns to Charles, you probably had some trouble when you got home. Sorry, but not sorry. That quip made everyone snicker. Even Melinda. Jeez, he is still the same arrogant guy I saw yesterday. His behavior might be some suspect, but his intentions are still clear. Everyone here were slowly getting sucked into his blatant swaggering. This must his way to clear the many rumors floating around due to his disappearance.

Rory intervenes here, hey. I have a favor to ask of you. Actually, everyone wants to know this. His enthusiasm caught everyone's attention. He asks, can you show how you were able to create so many kurets. I am sure you know that made a lot of stirs. His face showed excitement, but I knew underneath he was trying to expose David abelites as fraud. That was the first time since he came in that David felt a little troubled. His eyes wonder around everyone here, like he was trying to hide something.

Before David answered, Catherine cuts in, sorry guys. But lets not delay it any longer. You all will have plenty of time to chat once you return back. Then David can show it. Rory kept his smile, come on. It won't take much time. He really is out to get David. Others maybe be seeing something harmless, but I knew what exactly was going on. I turned to David who remained quite and still thinking. I think he doesn't want to show it now. Maybe that’s what I saw him trying to hide.

Others were also excited to see it. Tory asks, I want to see it too. That gave dad so much trouble, he was losing. Charles scoffs, I wouldn't say I was losing. Maybe just a stalemate. Melinda chuckles, no, you were definitely on the short end there. People were whispering now. I could sense everyone wanted to know about it. David was getting pressured now. Blake comes to his defense, everyone, its not the time or the place. If you all remember, David takes a long time to use that ability. And like Catherine said, it would just delay you all that more.

Rory ignored both Blake and Catherine, what you say David. Don't you want show your ultimate trick. Catherine says, Rory, lets not trouble David. Then suddenly David cuts in, its fine Catherine. I am game Rory. I have no issues showing it here. I was taken aback. But Catherine looked shocked even more so than me or Blake. Rory's eyes widen and he gets excited. So were others. But I am sure he was animated for a different reason than others. Rory says, awesome. Then lets pick a kuret, how about.

David puts his hand up, hold on. I don't mind showing my ace here. But I like something a favor in return. Rory's smile disappear halfway, huh. David smiles, I'll begin preparing it now. I'll even take any kuret request, provided I know about it. But while we wait, I want to see your kuret form. That came out of nowhere. What's David's angle here. Rory was puzzled, my kuret form. You want to see it. Why. David shrugs, just curious. Its not like I am asking to tell me about Charles overdrive. I just want to see yours. It may help me give some hints on how to right Charles later.

What is he babbling on about. How are Charles overdrive and Rory's kuret form connected. It would make sense if it was to compare their regular kuret forms. How will he get clues about Charles overdrive from Rory. Everyone here were amused by David's claim. Charles asks, huh. How does that help you. David didn't reply, he just made a menacing smile. Rory, who was until now being pushy, suddenly became hesitant, I don't understand as well. How will you learn hints about dad's overdrive.

David says, don't worry about it. Its just something I read in the university back in Medrine. I thought since I am going to show you my tricks up close, I'll get some clues about Charles overdrive in return. I have no clue what he is talking about. But somehow it changed the air to suspense and mystery. David makes a show of seeing everyone's puzzled looks. He says, okay. Fine. I'll explain. There was a theory written by this famous researcher, Igotus ouker, he did study on how alphas with their overdrive effect the genes passed to their children. This study wasn't that popular than his other works, but I found it interesting. He thinks the RNA passed from same gender parent and child would show characteristics that would be different when the parent cannot overdrive. Since there weren't many overdrive users to study much from, he didn't get funded to research enough. But he postulates his hypothesis is sound.

I wasn't expecting to be hit with such an academic response here. But it’s a very common occurrence with David. Is this what he was thinking a minute ago. Everyone were either amazed or too stunned to speak. David says, I think it would be a great chance for me to use his study and get clues since Charles refuses to share his overdrive to anyone. The only overdrive users with children is Charles, the author must be rolling in his grave having missed this opportunity. Not me though. So, how about it. A favor for favor. Tit for tat.

The ball was thrown to Rory now. The zeal he had was completely vanished. Against David sudden academic curiosity, he remained frozen. After thinking a bit he laughs a little, I give up. I don't know what you were going on about, but if its true, I can't give any advantage for the fight. David smiles suspiciously, you sure. Well, next time maybe. David completely shut down Rory's agenda with his textbook knowledge. David faces Charles, I guess it will remain a surprise until the day of the match. Charles laughs, he got you good Rory. What I tell you, he is clever guy.

Rory nods in quite acceptance. That was a skillful manipulation from David. He got to keep his kuret abilities a secret while also flaunting his knowledge. Blake chips now, well, that was quite something. But seriously, its time. David, I think you have shown everyone here you are all ready for the match, right. So let's not keep them any longer. David replies, yeah. I got it. Charles, the next time we see each other, it will be on the field. Hope you weren't exaggerating the warnings about your overdrive. I am eager to see it.

Charles says showing his teeth, don't you worry. It will be an epic battle. Those two share a look at each other, measuring each others resolve. Marina puts her shoulder on David, come on now. That’s enough. Marina pulls David out of the crowed. Blake turns to the Citradel officials, save travels everyone. I hope we see you all soon. Everyone began shaking hands and seeing each other off. I turn to Derek on my side, see you Derek. Derek nods, back at you. I will contact you with updates on our progress. We can work on travel plan later.

I answer, sure. Derek walks to say bye to other officers here. After some time, everyone begin climbing down the stairs. I followed behind Catherine, waiting for her to finish her byes. I whisper to her, you both planned it together, didn't you. David was lying about being here all this time. Catherine eyes our surrounding and then nods, yeah. We both actually came together from the shoreside. Getting here from the road would take too long, so we took the ocean route.

That actually made me more curious, why were you two together in the first place. I thought he was hiding someplace secure. She looks a bit hesitant, I wanted to talk to him urgently. So I found out where David was. I waited for her explain what she meant. She sighs, it’s a personal matter. So once I heard from Blake about his actual home, I took an early stroll in the morning and miraculously found it. That’s the emergency I was telling earlier. We didn't realize how long it went on. So I just taggled along with him on his house.

There is so much to unpack here. I was so lost I didn't understand much of what she said. But the thing that stuck me the most, what do you mean his actual home. Isn't his house on the outskirts of section 3. She scoffs, trust me, everyone reacted the same as you. But that's just his decoy house. He actually lives in a much more sophisticated house. I am sure others are grilling him about it. I can't believe David would even hid his real home.

Catherine says, that’s right. You weren't eating with us last night. Blake told us about it then. He and Marina moved to his house. That’s the secure place everyone keeps talking about. Even when I have seen it with my own eyes, I can't believe he lives in such a place. From her attitude, I could tell she was very impressed by Davids home. Its crazy, and yet on brand. Only David would be so paranoid to have a secondary home as a smokescreen.

Soon we climb out of the cruise. All the other officers were now gathered near the middle of the pier. Ruther and Somers came to my side, all good to go. I nod, yes. Everyone is counted for, well, except for Marina. But as you have seen, she is now one of us. So go ahead, give the signal for the captains. They both take a quick look at Marina. Ruther says, that was a surprise. Somers says, not as much as David coming off the boat. I am telling you guys, I had people sweep the boats earlier. No one saw him. And nothing came from the continuous scanning we have running. Its like he just appeared out of nowhere from the water.

Their confusion was obvious. They both scatter to give the all green signal to others. I ask Catherine, how exactly did you both hid his presence. Catherine says, I don't know how exactly. He dropped me near the other side of the shore, but its probably that house of his. Its probably undetectable. That didn't any sense, I ask, but you said you came from his place. Catherine replies, I did. She looks at me with a nervous smile, his house is a like a submarine sort of thing, it moves around the island, climb on cliffs or dives underwater.

My jaw drop a little hearing something so outrageous. I almost shout, are you kidding. He lives in a submarine. She shook her head, not like that. Hum, more like his house transform into a submarine. I spat out, that’s nuts. When did he build such a thing. I didn't get to hear her answer because we were now approaching others. Everyone here had now ganged up on David, surrounded him like they were trying to entrap inside. I hear Nathan speaking, anything about it. That’s some bullshit.

I lean in closer to the discussion. David was more nervous than facing the Citradel people, yeah. I get that. Like I have been saying, I will show it later. Its just a prototype. I had remained passive until now since David had appeared. I didn't want to draw attention to me, but now that its just us, I spoke out, so its true. You really do live in a different place. He turns to me with a hesitation. For a second I thought it was about the last time we spoke where I was pleading him to not accept the deal.

But it wasn't about that. No, more like he was avoiding it. He says, Catherine told you. Yeah, I do have a different house. But its not what you think. Marina shrieks, what the hell. So Catherine saw it before me. That's not fair. Of course she would be the one to be most agitated one here. Everyone eyes Catherine. She says, don't look at me. I only got to see some of it. We were in a hurry, so I didn't saw all of it. Blake asks, what where you doing with him. Marina says, forget about that. We want to see it.

The way she said it was amusing. But everyone were stunned to hear that. He can call his house from anywhere. What the hell is this place. David says, listen guys. I promise, I will show it when its ready. Like I keep saying, it's a prototype. And I mean quite literally, it can't handle too many people right now. Its operating system isn't configured completely to manage more than 3 people at a time. Blake asks, what does that mean. Its a house in the end right, why it can't manage couple of people inside.

David says, its not a really a house. That's what I keep telling you. Think of it like those an Echo battle ground vehicles. A very dumb downed grounded version. Sure, its built like a house, but many of its components are not compatible with Medrone DNA. One or two people, it can currently handle. But more than that, it might shut down or miscalculate some of it operations. This one time, it took an extreme response. It treated as the Medrone DNA I introduced as hostile and executed an attack. I was locked in my own room until the system rebooted. I fixed that issue, but there are tons of other problems I have yet fix. For humans and me, its inert, but trust me, its like the Echo tech gets a mind of its own when too many Medrone are introduced inside. And I still haven't found which part is causing this or how to stop this entirely.

He explained all that in one breath. It was hard to believe he was living in such a suspicious looking place. Nathan asks, as unbelieve it may sound, it does make sense. Its possible that Echo ships have been Medrone proofed. I am sure that's one of the reasons why its hard for us to study it. The nano materials don't respond to traditional kuritine approaches. But I never knew it was immune to Humans. I suppose that's how you were able to make it work.

Blake asks, if its about Medrone DNA, how come you are okay. David says, I told you. One or two it can handle. That includes me. Obviously, I had my DNA configured as non hostile from the beginning. And after living for months, the Echo tech considers me as primary user. Like I told you, I may think its a home, but its not there yet. I will sure to invite you guys once I worked out the kinks. Why do you think I never told you all, it would create a panic if people heard I was living in a place where it potentially treats Medrones as enemy. And I didn't want to show it to anyone until its completed.

He made sense. Even Marine was pondering hard, so those sphere drones and killer robots, they were jumped on us because we were Medrone. David says, that's right. For humans, it would had a different response. A more simpler and less threatening. I couldn't keep it in, killer robots. You have those too. David smirks, I do. But what Marina was not them. They were just prototypes I am programmed as an initial line of defense. When I am inside, those are never deployed. I never thought for a second you two would somehow move me there. I would have advice against it, because its not ready for outside exposure, especially when I am not awake.

Marina back down more after being called out like this. David says, I showed you because you helped design it, and I knew you wouldn't let it go until you see it yourself. But I never knew you stole my remote. It was an outdated tech. You both are lucky that somehow it didn't treat you as hostiles. No, that's not true. I am actually the lucky one. Marina asks, what does that mean. David sighs, I don't know to how much extent, but it would have kept attacking you. And in response you both would have no choice but to destroy those bots and my house along with it. I have invested lot of money and time building that prototype tech house not to be destroyed in such a pathetic way.

His arguments made sense. But one thing I couldn't shake, why did you even build it then. If its so dangerous, why do it. David answers, because I could. That's the simple answer. The complicated one is that once its fully operational, it will become an exhibit A for Medrones to use Human knowledge and science. I don't know how advance Citradel is, but I am sure we can't complete with Echo tech right now. We have enough wreckages and stolen Echo tech to reprogram for our use. But its not going to happen fast enough. We need all the available technology, no matter where it comes from. Its not lost on me that its not simple to merge Echo and Human tech. There will be political and social considerations. But first step is getting there before worrying about it.

Nathen says, you got that right. We had a civil war due to opposing views on mixing Human and Medrone DNA. He loves to keep reminding us about it. David scoffs, but that's going to happen again. Nathan smirks, oh really. And why is that. David answers with a straight face, because this time I am the one leading it. Not a half baked plan from a spoiled and attention craving royal. That sharp verbal jab pointed straight at Nathan made his lose his composure. He says, touché.

David nods, and that's why no is to talk about it. At least not until its ready. He singles out Marina and eyes her, you will know when its ready. Trust me, now that its no longer a secret I know how you feel. But think to the first you saw, when I was there. And when I wasn't there. Now think what happens when it gets somehow gets worse during reprogramming. Marina sighs, yeah. I understand. You don't need to keep explaining it to me. I suspected you were just nervous showing me the first time, but I think you were worried it was going to malfunction. I misinterpreted that whole thing. That won't again.

David says, I was worried about that. I didn't want your first impression be about me trying to build something dangerous out of Echo tech. Marina then faces Catherine, if I can't see it yet. At least I can get some scoop from you. Tell me later all about it, okay. He intense pressure caused Catherine to raise her hands, I will. Blake cuts in, well. That's good we settled this. The boats will move out soon. We all fan out and stand in a line facing the ocean.

Blake was whispering something to David. Whatever they spoke, it was short. After few minutes the pier siren filled the air. Soon the boats engine turn on and moments later they left our island. Technically, we are to remain here until they cross the 10 km radius. That's the range we agreed to track them. From there on, the Citradel will be taking care of themselves. After they travel few distance into the ocean, Tessa asks, you know David. People have been asking about you now. The news has spread that you are here.

David says, I am well aware. I plan to talk to the reporters now. Blake asks, you won't give it in the officers building. David says, sorry. I got a start preparing for my fight. I know I was showing confidence, but that doesn't mean I have it all figured out. I have to start my training immediately. Especially today. I am sort on a deadline I can't miss. Something that will help me, well, with my kuret. As always, he was being vague about it. But I am at least glad to see him being careful about it.

He seemed to have simmer down his attitude now that Citradel people aren't watching. Maybe then that strange behavior on the match yesterday was just him getting carried away. No. I am not letting him off easy. He has showed me no indication to explain his behavior back then. He refused all my pleas to not take the deal. Ultimately he abandoned all reasoning when he heard Wagner. He has to explain how he knows Wagner. But I am scared. What if he knows about what Melinda told. I can't handle if David also believed that to be true.

My thoughts gets interrupted by Blake saying, I see. If you have believe that's for the best, then I don't have any issues. Though, before you speak to the people. Lets be sure we are on same page about certain things. I'll like to discuss with you now once the Citradel boats leaves a little farther. David agrees, sure thing. Jess says, before you go, can you explain that overdrive DNA theory to us. That was out of nowhere and I have been wondering about it for some time.

Nathan gets a little giddy, damn. I almost forgot. I would like to hear that as well. I don't know anything about this. What was the name. Catherine says, Igotus ouker. Marina says, what a weird name. I didn't know there was anyone like that. Tessa says, wouldn't anyone researching a subject like overdrive users be obscure because of a very less candidate pool. I can understand why no one heard about this. Nathan asks incredibly, so you know this research. She reacts, no. I never heard about it. Maybe one of our scientists knows about it.

Meanwhile, David was keeping to himself. He was fidgeting with his lips and tongue a bit. What's with that reaction. Blake asks, so. Lets hear it. I am curious about it also. David looks to everyone with a suspicious look. When I met his eyes, something clicks in my head. I sigh realizing what he did. That's so him. He didn't want to show us his ace, so he did it to keep Rory out.

David finally blurts out, sorry guys. I didn't want to reveal that kuret trick to anyone. I felt that Heraknus guy wouldn't leave me alone if I don't come up with something. So I made the whole thing. Its all bullshit. There is no study like that. Actually, names also just something I pulled out on the spot. If you stick the two names together, it spells out I got you sucker.

David (Chapter 58)

Friday, October 3, 2025 22:41

We are seriously late. I just hope we make in time. It didn't hit me that so many people were going to the pier until M told me that going via road will take more time. I didn't want this, but I had ART carry us over the ocean to the southern part of the island. Catherine didn't had her officers uniform with her, so I had to use the clothes synthesizer for her. The badge will be fake though. I just changed into my inform. Applied some gel to my hair and removed bandages wrapped on my hand.

M chimes in, boss, we will be there in 5 minutes. I have located a spot for dropping miss Catherine. I walk out to the window covered deck. Cathrine follows behind me a second later. She fixes the newly printed clothes and puts the badge on her chest. While she fixes her hair she asks, isn't this synthesizer from one in Citradel. Of course she knows about it. I nod, yeah. They had a spare one which was old. I retrieved it a while ago and replaced the kuritine mixer with an artificial compound that resembles human clothes.

She asks, and by retrieved, you mean you stole it. She suspects me the obvious thing, its not stolen if no one reports it. They had enough of them, and this was going to be broken down for parts. I just replaced it with a dummy one before it got destroyed. Catherine smirks, and how did you get it. I don't think you just strolled into Citradel at the exact time it was going to be destroyed. I didn't want to say my source, if your thinking I got it from someone. You are right. But its not Marina or Derek. I do have other contacts. Lets just leave at it. She is still suspicious of me, but doesn't dig deeper.

I sigh, That synthesizer uses too much material. I had kept it for emergency purpose. Never thought I would have to use it for you. Next time, think before you decide spy on me naked. She was a tiny bit embarrassed at her reckless decision. Theres nothing we can do now, so I just l let it go. I tell, what will tell others if they ask why you are late or we were together. She replies, I will I had a emergency and personal matter to discuss with you. Blake told me about this place, so I found it by luck while I took a stroll in the morning.

It was a weak excuse, but we didn't have any time to come up with a better one. Its a little vague, even if it was partially true. I nod, fine. But please try not to make it sound like we were being suspicious. I don't want to explain people if they found out you were naked with me. It was a joke to help with our anxiety, but she shot me a look of disgust. Okay, I didn't think it warranted a reaction like that. She scoffs, yeah right. Like anyone would believe that. Okay, now she is being mean.

M pings after a while, we are here now. Leveling up to the unattended boat I detected. From here, it should just be a minute ride. ART begins to go vertically up underwater. I show Catherine the path to the door of the right glass wall. As soon as the top part of ART comes out of water, the wall splits in two and opens up. A motor boat was lying in wait on the other side. Catherine steps out, see you in a minute. I reply, I will be there on the boat Charles is in. Others will be there two. Do me a favor and don't tell anyone I am there.

She steps out of edge onto the boat. She asks, let me guess. You want to do something like shock and awe. I just smile in response. The glass wall closes immediately and ART dives down back. M says, 3 minutes to the Citradel boat. To avoid detection of ART, we will be traveling at very slow speed. I ask, ART, instead of leveling to the ocean surface, shift the top of the roof into a 10 meter bridge for me to climb out of. M says, obtaining specs from a class 2 submarine model. Reconfiguring now.

I take the stairs to the first floor room. The rumbling and electricity noise fills the upper roof. While I wait, I go to the mirror hanging on the side wall. I stare at my face and begin prepping for the performance of a lifetime. I can't let anyone see how much screwed up I am right now. Catherine knows a lot about my condition, but she agreed to not share. Blake and Marina know a little about my issues, they will suspect me more than others, but they should know not to draw any attention to my behavior. Nathan, Jess and whoever other officers will some odd behavior, but may also attribute to stress or something like that.

The problem is Vanessa. She knows me the longest and the best as well. There is a good chance she will notice my behavior and maybe even call me out. I don't know how or when, but she will. And I don't want that to be in front of others. I had avoided thinking about her too much because I am anxious her about knowing what I am going through. How will she react, will she be empathetic. No, she will be angry. Mad that I kept it from her many things. And she be justified for it. I do want to tell her the truth, but she will hate me for it. I can handle being hated by others, but not from her.

My thoughts suddenly fill with visions of Zakerine. The life we thought we would have, the plans we made together. And how it finally ended. I felt my pulse increasing. Freaking hell. I did a little paced breathing to calm down. Okay, no more thoughts about Vanessa or Zakerine. I don't want to have a panic attack in the middle of high ranking officers and officials. So the new plan is to keep my mind focused on thinking nothing but three goals. Talking to Charles and any other officials to show the rumors about me are wrong. I need to make others believe I don't have any issues. And finally, give an interview with the reporters. There is a good chance I will have emotional triggers on unexpected times. I sure hope Blake, Marina or Catherine help me out when I suddenly become weird.

To reduce the chances of getting exposed, I will use this sudden appearance as a distraction in the beginning. They will be too occupied by my appearance to see anything else. That will last only few minutes. Then I have to talk to others without mentioning anything about the plans for the match, be as vague as possible. The interview will be rockiest. I can already imagine all sorts of questions that I can't answer completely. I have prepared the answer as best I could.

M says, boss. We are here. I have analyzed the signatures on the boat directly above us. There are 3 Citradel officials, 5 bodyguards, 6 officers. And 2 people heading to the boat. I didn't have time to figure out who is who, so I just climbed the ladder ART prepared on the vertical bridge. My body still had few stiches so I carefully made slow movements to avoid opening the wounds. I also needed to make as less sound I could. The other end opens to the upper deck of the boat as planned. So far no had noticed the tall metal tube sticking out of the boat. The tube was just large enough to fit one person, and I had the outside surface change the color to match the cruise. That and the fact that most would be watching the other side of the cruise made it possible to climb on board undetected.

With a very slow and gradual movement, I take a step into the deck. My shoes make a little sneaking noise in contact with the smooth surface around the edges. I grab hold of the railing and cross over without rocking the boat. I signal M to dive off. The metal tube slowly submerges back into the water, using the subtle waves as cover to hide the noise. I tip toe as I make my way to the side stairs and crouch down on one knee. I hear people talking on the below deck. I hear Charles taking about his twins.

I couldn't tell where everyone was standing without using my kuret. But no one had pointed out me boarding the cruise, so either no saw me or were kept it themselves. Either way, infiltration complete. I don't think they are ready to leave just yet. Good, now to wait and see the best time to come down. I listened into their conversation. Everyone seems to be enjoying. He heard Blake and Jess's laugh the closest. A moment later I hear Marina and Derek coming to the stairs. So they were the two people walking outside.

For some reason everyone were surprised. Then I pieced it together, Marina has moved here, officially. That's a complete surprise. I was too busy with Drew and Catherine that I forgot to check in with M about any news on the network. That's a very good news. Sending her here means officials are more than likely going to move here along with Heraknus. Everyone must be enjoying this epic development. They must need Marina here for the developing the islands infrastructure. I can hear from Marina's voice how thrilled she was. Good for her, she wanted to move her all along.

Turns out, she had another agenda, a gathering of the only known and maybe even alive overdrive users. If I wasn't having a mental crisis, I would have been delighted to see Medrones greatest weapons. But with the impeding fight with one of them looming, I couldn't realize the full scope of this. Anyways, I focus back on my first goal. I gather up my wits and prepare to bluff my way. I caught a good moment to drop in when Blake says they are late. This is it. I take a long breadth to compose myself. No matter what happens, I shouldn't panic. Fake my usual composed self.

My entrance was as planned. No one had any idea I was here. Few where very confused on how I circumvented the security and defenses. The bodyguards around the deck looked tensed, but I kept my smile up. There was a little uptick of my heartbeat when I see Vanessa. With all the mental strength, I didn't let her see it. My movements were laxed. I could feel it. I was completely focused, like a machine. After a witty banter with Marina, I walked straight to Charles and made my presence known up close.

My phony smile and attitude seem to do the trick. It was a relief when Charles seemed satisfied about me. I kept my word short and kept reminding him that I am all good for the fight. Inside, I could feel conflicted and a little angrier at myself that I have to lie to everyone about this. I should be feeling guilty, but all I was masking was anxiety and anger. I didn't let any wondered thought come apart from the present moment. Analyze like I am watching them on a screen. Fake my emotions with just enough truth.

Behind him was his wife. I had only heard on Marinas recording earlier. With a face to it, I felt a sense of scientist vibe from here, it wasn't just a guess, she is in charge of Citradels space projects. Their children were quite normal. I don't know why, but I was expecting them to be buffed. Maybe I was stereotyping a little bit after seeing Charles Kuret form. The women Tory was actually beefier than Rory. But physical appearance doesn't mean a thing for Heraknus. Since he was older, his kuret might be stronger. Wish I had my kuret with me to check them all out. No, no thoughts like that.

I was making good progress by being humorous with Charles and his family. Then came my first curve ball. This young Heraknus asked me for a favor, something I am incapable of doing. That momentarily made cracks in my self made composure. Cathrine saw me panicking internally, and attempts to defend me. But Rory isn't backing down. This isn't good. I peak a glance at Kafar, who was eyeing me like a hawk. He has to be waiting to pounce at any chance he sees. If I deny him, they will think I am hiding it selfishly. After my very public display, it doesn't make a good defense to say I am hiding my secrete ace. On the other hand, I obviously can't do it. So I don't want to deny it, but can't agree to it too.

I get some pushy behavior from Rory by much he kept insisting. Initially I thought it was just a curiosity, but his intensity showed something more. I didn't have time to figure what it was. I realized a third option when I raced my thoughts to get out this dilemma. He had asked me as a favor, so I can ask one in return. Trying to come up ways to back him down, I decided to flaunt a little bit of my intelligence. I decided to make a whole shit of academia. When I said I was going to do it, Catherine eyes me confused. I could sense behind me Marina and Blake were also keeping a close look on me. And I could swear Kafar's eyes lit up and sparked. Is he really thinking he could expose me a cheat here.

Then I bluffed my way to get him to back down. Thankfully, it worked. I didn't wait to check if he bought it or not. I focus back on Charles and bring it to a close before anyone else tries to trip me up. I can't really tell if Charles really felt I was okay, but at least he wasn't going to get distracted by my rumors. Blake also felt necessary to break this up. And Marina pulls me out of the group safely. Once I was out of their eyelines, my face melts down. I sigh with relief that I made it without anyone suspecting me. She whispers to me as we cross the corridor, dude, you need to start explaining.

I nod subtly, and I will. Just go with me for now. Thanks for the save. I didn't want to leave myself. She smiles, I didn't do it just for you know. I figured she didn't, but still, I was glad it was over. Behind me Nathan sneaks up, so our brave warrior finally decides to show his face. So, are you all goof after your beauty sleep. I grit my teeth a little nervous when I didn't notice him. Not having Kuret in a group is really making me uncomfortable. I say, yeah. I just woke up this morning.

Nathan whistles, you slept for almost a day. You don't seem to be that injured. I reply, that was my first time in nano chamber tank. It has to calibrate the nano bots with accurate precision, otherwise it will cause even more damage. The first time was going to be a long one. Jess and Tessa join in the conversation as well. I saw Vanessa and Catherine talking at the far end and following us behind were Blake with Luther. Jess asks, how are you now. I lie, its all good now. I have few stiches, but they won't be a problem for much long.

Marina couldn't keep it anymore, so we are not going to talk about the elephant in the room. We cross the cruises door and walk down the bridge to the pier. I felt her frustration, actually everyone was a little curious about it. I don't think they know about my therapy, so she must be talking about ART. But I needed to confirm, about what specifically. At that point she clicks her tongue not amused, jeez, what could I be talking about. I don't know, oh, how about that fact that you live in that Echo tech modified house.

I felt a little relief knowing I was right. I didn't see others being surprised, so I was right thinking Blake must have told others. She didn't say anything about it to others while wearing M's watch. I couldn't help but a smile seeing her being flustered. We come to a stop after walking some distance away from the pier. Everyone gather around me and see me like a specimen. I say, does everyone know about it. They all nod. Nathan says, I was not sure when Jess told me. But now, I have to believe its true. You really are something keeping this for everyone.

He maybe be talking about that. This is not related to that, he knows that, yet he feels cheated. I don't know why he would assume I would tell about ART which has nothing to do with him. I ignore him and face others, I am sorry to keep it a secret, but I had a good reason. And why are you Marina getting so bothered, you knew about it too for months. Everyone gaze now fell upon Marina. She had a look of betrayal for me. Sorry, but I am not going to get accused alone. She gawks a little before say, really. You want to pin this on me.

I tell her, now you know how it feels. And I am not pinning this on you. I am just clearing the air, since you and Blake decided to blab about it to everyone. Marina twitches her mouth a little annoyed. I saw Blake coming towards us. Luther broke off to a different route to other officers. Jess asks, you knew about it. Nathan adds on, and didn't feel the need to share it. Marina wasn't someone who was going to back down so easily, come on guys. This isn't about me, its him. He told me to not talk about it. He was very suspicious about it, but I agreed. Because I am very good friend. Unlike him.

That little minx. She smiles with her teeth out as she emotionally blackmails me. The gaze fell back on me. I remained quite before figuring out what I should revel now. Blake joins in, guys, it’s a little tense here. He takes one look at me and scoffs, see now you know why its not good to keep secrets from friends. He is subtly implying about my therapy. So far Marina was mostly pre-occupied about the tech, but now I have to worry that they don't suddenly reveal anything about it.

I saw Catherine and Vanessa joining in now. I didn't want to keep them surround me for long. But I have to make them believe my intentions weren't malice. I say, its not the time yet. I didn't want to reveal it, because its not ready yet. Its still a prototype. An unstable one currently. To call it a home is not completely accurate. Nathan says, so instead you decided not to say anything about it. That’s some bullshit. I didn't owe him any explanation. Vanessa speaks immediately and accuses me as well.

I tried hard to remain poised. Just having her here is effecting me subtly. No, don't go there. I kept trying them to understand that it wasn't ready. I realized until I calm down Marina, the main instigator, it won't matter how much I explain. So with great reluctance I reveled the dangers of ART. They were slowly realizing why I kept it hidden. Marina who had been looking at me contempt was finally backing down. I made to keep reminding that this is a prototype. And like any potentially dangerous project, you don't reveal it until its safe and completed.

I finally persuaded Marina about why I was nervous showing her the initial model of ART. I made a critical mistake back then by not telling the whole truth back then. But I didn’t think she stole from me and even bring me to ART themselves. Blake backed me up in the end and we resolved this quickly. As we wait for the cruise to sail away he whispers to me, don't think this is over. Me and Marina have got a lot other questions for you. Once you finish talking with the reporters, you owe us answers.

I whisper back, I know. I will explain what I can. Unlike Marina, he was more reasonable. He knew I was being pressured my Marina and didn't push me further. I was grateful for his support. He was right to explain my decisions. I kept a lot from him and others. My only excuse is the reason why I am in therapy. I contemplate on how much I will have to reveal to them. Then Jess's question about the made up research puts in an uncomfortable position. I fidget a bit as I decided its best to be honest with them.

Nathan's the first to voice his shock, you bluffed in front of all those people. All those important people. You sure you didn't hit your head in the fight. He doesn't know how true that was. Jess shook her head. Blake gasps, that's crazy man. Tessa becomes a little betrayed, no doubt cause she almost believed it. I think Vanessa may have caught on because she wasn't reacting to it. Marina yells, dude, the hell kind of lie was that. Catherine was also stunned, but probably the only one who understood why I did it.

I sigh, I don't know what his deal was. And I didn't have time to figure it out. So I choose to show even a bigger arrogance. I wasn't going to give Kafar or him any idea about my Kuret abilities. And especially not Charles. But I couldn't refuse it outright too, that would have been rude. I didn't want to lie this others, but it’s the closest to the truth. I continue, none of us are scientists. But everyone has some impression of me. I used that fact to my advantage. I didn't want to drag it long, otherwise people will be suspicious. And it worked. He backed off immediately.

Vanessa says, you could have done that by not provoking others with that very blatant name word play. What happens when they search for it in their database. I scoff, even if they do, would they believe I was wrong just because its not their limited database. Yeah, I don't see that happening. Everyone one here is interested because we are warriors. They are not. Some will believe it, I eye at Tessa who looked a little mortified falling to my trick, and some won't. Either way, I guarantee they will forget all about it by the time the cross international borders. And if anyone does figure out I tricked them with the name, they won't be angry about it. They just assume I was being evasive and arrogant. That I can handle. What I absolutely cared was not show to my kuret abilities at that moment, when everyone in watching.

Others were gawking at me like I had lost it. But I had no other choice. Having a panic attack of or an episode in trying to bring out my Kuret was going to waste all my efforts. Jess asks, what would have done if Rory kept insisting or even agreed to show his Kuret form. I shrug, I don't know. Maybe stall for more time until it becomes clear I wasn't going to budge and have them decide to leave to avoid being more late. Marina whistles, crazy and clever. Your normal mix of behavior. She smiles, you must be already be feeling back to yourself.

I unconsciously smile at her response. I actually didn't realize before, but I when I was backed in that corner, emotionally speaking, I was in my own element. I wasn't worried about my mental state. I analyzed the situation like I always do. I handled it like I normally do. This was the first time today since I talked to Drew that I was hopeful. I recall the words she said about me, not stable, but not delusional as well. I beginning to believe I could figure it out. I just need to be figure out my shit, like I do if I was doing it for others. Its terrifying thought, I can't be bias. But maybe there is some way.

Blake tells, I hope for your sake no gets offended if they realize this joke. After making so much effort, I don't want it to go to waste all because you had to be clever. His worry was justified, but I wasn't. Kafar who is skeptical of me, wouldn't believe me, but he also won't figure that it out. Rory seemed a little enthused about seeing it, so he might look for it even if its just to satisfy the curiosity. Derek is quite sharp and probably the only who will get is Derek. I reply back, I couldn't help that in front of Rory and Kafar. But I promise, no more of that. With Citradel finally on board with the Heraknus permanent relocation, I also don't want to risk anything.

He nods. Nathan whispers something to Jess, probably saying I am not done yet. If I am being honest, that’s probably true. Not that I will admit that to anyone. But that did make me feel that I didn't others to keep observing me anymore. They might figure out I am not my usual self. So I pulled the card I kept just to open at the right moment. I say, lets forget about that. Instead, lets congratulate Marina on becoming our newest member. I show a gesture of applauding. That made others shook off me and realize they didn't speak to her directly yet.

Marina also becomes her usual self. She laughs, yeah. That’s pretty unexpected. Tessa and Jess take turns congratulating her. Catherine and Vanessa goes next. Vanessa says, you wanted this even when you had Kafar breathing down your neck. You finally got your wish. They both high five each other. Marina says, thanks Vanessa. You are not wrong. I was honestly shocked that the officials agreed. Blake laughs, I am more surprised that you didn't even wait for me to get you your badge and came in with that, pointing to her unform. Marina kept smiling happily at his amused expression.

Soon everyone break into a conversation about her, where she will live, what about her stuff in Citradel. Blake and I know Marina had planned things well in advance. I happily took a step back and relaxed from being freed from the constant attention. Catherine saw me being quite, but remained engaged in others conversation. Blake comes to my side and signals to move some steps away. I gladly left others gaze. He asks in a serious tone, we a lot to talk. But right now, lets get you prepped for the reporters.

I knew the solace was brief and the trickiest part is yet to happen. I nod. He calls to Luther who was some distance away. Luther dashes in, hey David. Good to see you finally. You had some of us worried. I answer, I believe you. And that’s why, I want to talk to people. Right now. Luther eyes became sharp on me, are you sure you want to do it here. Blake nods, yes. What better time when Citradel just left. I think people will be relieved to know he is here with us. That explanation got through to him immediately, that’s true. He turns to me, I am sure you already know, but I still have to ask. Do you know what all has happened.

He was worried that I wasn't aware about what has been going on the city since I have been away. With take a quick glance from the crowd behind him, I say, I have been catching up with the news since I woke up. I know almost everything I need to know. The admins and Citradel long meeting that went whole day. The Heraknus meeting with them. You and Blake organizing the rally. And in the same time allowing people to put pressure on Citradel instead of you all. And I have seen Charles and Admins broadcast from last night.

He smiles, silly question. You wouldn't come here straight after waking up. Great. I actually wanted to have you remain hear while we explain things, but this makes it much simpler. So you will go on live right now. I wasn't showing on my face, but I was a little unformattable. They questions I will be asked will be an emotional land mine. Nonetheless, I have to do this. I nod, that’s right. I am ready to go any minute. He becomes excited, that’s great to hear. The let me go first. I will tell about Citradel leaving with no issues, Marina's becoming the latest member of Citradel joining us. That gotta boast our moral and show we have won. And then I will tell them you are ready to answer peoples questions. You good with this.

I didn't have any issues, sounds good. Blake says, don't let Marina get near a camera yet. Get someone to brief her. I don't want to go and make some statement I can't promise. I have a hunch she will ask a place of her on a very pricy place. I am not denying it, but I can't just let her decide on her own. Luther smiles, good idea. I goes to talk to Marina next. I made an observation, you are getting good at this. Politics I mean. He smiles, nah. That’s just because I know Marina.

He was being modest, but that’s a quality he is slowly developing. He then says, there's more than just what you saw on the network and news. When your were sleeping, we were approached my Melinda. And I need to tell you certain rumors that are floating in the public. You should know about it before speaking. So this is what he wanted to tell me. Before he starts explaining, I raise my hand to him, its fine Blake. I already know all about it. His eyes widen, ah, say what.

I smiled a little, I know all about Charles using her to get my take on certain things before he made his decision. Blake remained skeptical, like he believed I was just guessing. I get into specifics, Citradel, or rather Kafar trying to discredit me using my history. They accused of cheating, sabotaging the tournament by poisoning Marina. I know it all. Yesterday those rumors just among higher ups, and now it might have reached to people ears. You all defended me quite excessively, thanks. But you didn't need to that. Its just rumors.

Blake eyes twitches, how in the world do you know about it. Not even Catherine knows about it. And you two seem to spent some time this morning. Mind telling me what that was about. I say, I know you told her about Dr. Drew. I don't know why you did, but because of that she followed Drew from her home, spied on me and learned few things. He became flabbergasted. He turns behind to see a laughing Catherine speaking to Vanessa something about Marina.

He turns to me a with a softened expression, ah. So its what I feared. She didn't listen to me. Look, I told her to. I stop him and answers, doesn't matter. I had to talk with her, about some private things. Had to even reveal some of my mental issues with her. I hadn't plan to tell anyone about it, and somehow more people are learning about it. The bigger joke is that she knows more about me currently than you both. So best to ask her rather than me about it. I am letting her decide whatever she wants now.

I didn't want to drag this part for long. I already decided I won't interfere with Catherine on personal thing anymore. My promise to Brandon has somehow jeopardized my friendship with her daughter. Blake thinks for a bit and says, I got it. Lets focus back on the topic. If you know about that, then you also know about the other thing. The thing about. I abruptly stop him, don't say his name. I don't know if will have another episode. I am trying very hard to not get sucked into that right now. Lets just say I know. And I don't particularly care what he did.

Blake swallows hard seeing me so jumpy. I could imagine how he must be seeing me. He finally speaks up, you really know everything. How did you. This wasn't the time to bring the fact that I was bugging Marina. So I just eyed him gesturing as if to ask, who is he talking to. He nods, I should have known you are a step ahead already. Well, that’s all I had to tell you. I thought you needed to know that before answering any of their questions. He chuckles realizing how futile this was, you must have bugged me.

He caught that pretty quickly. I have become very predictable. Well, at least he didn't realize its Marina actually. Blake says, in that case, should I be knowing something. You know, in case I have to get in front of the camera too. I had a bunch of things to speak with him. With Marina too. But there's only one important thing he absolutely needs to know. I look around us to see if no was eavesdropping. I wished I was using my Kuret to check this. I say in low tone, for reasons unknown, I can't use my kuret right now. I am tiring to figure that out with Dr. Drew. Catherine knows about it too. So I want you to understand that it will be very bad if I was asked to show my new kuret abilities.

Blake becomes troubled hearing this. I had no choice but to rely on him now. I can't predict what's going to happen. So I need someone reliable if I had another episode. Yesterday, it was on a stadium with few people. Now, I am live on TV. The stakes are higher, even a small weakness will be blown to chaotic proportion. I continue, Also, any questions about, the person, is also bad for me in a crowd. So I if the questions get anywhere near them, pull me out. Doesn't matter how, even you have lie or throw someone to the wolfs. I don't care how, just don't let anyone see if I have a panic attack.

I knew I asking a lot from him. But he is the only one here who is in a position to help me out. Blake doesn't reply immediately. He thinks for long time and says, I got you. I'll take care of it if anything happens. But freak man, you are in worse shape than I ever imagined. That hurt me to my core, but it’s the truth.

David (Chapter 59)

Saturday, October 4, 2025 19:17

I waited with Blake until Luther finished speaking to the reporters. He had spoken to Marina before explaining some ground rules. From the distance it she seems to understood not to prematurely make any claims or statements. She isn't used to it, so I do feel sorry for her. Her greatest quality is to be unburdened from anything weighing her down. Well, she has to learn more than just shadow skills now. Meanwhile, Blake and I talk about appropriate answers to possible questions. We also agreed to some signals to alert him if I crash out. It was weird and embarrassing to talk my insecurities with him. But I had to push the embarrassment and self pity down. I am in this position, because I put myself. I can't wuss out on asking for help, not now in front of everyone.

After we discussed for 5 minutes, he was approached by Luther to speak next. He wanted Blake to tell about the match. So far only Citradel had talked about it. Now, we need to tell our side. Luther asks me in the middle of their discussion, Citradel hasn't told us the specifics of this overdrive match. Since you both were there, what can we reveal about it without causing any issues with Citradel. I ask Blake, do we tell everyone about the whole dangers of Charles overdrive.

Blake thinks about it for a second, no. We wait. It was his decision, but I wanted to know his reasons. He explains, it won't look good if we tell without Charles. I know its an important detail, and people should know about it. But if I alone say it, it might come across demeaning or even derogatory to Charles. No matter what the truth, its best to leave it alone. We have yet to set a specific time or talk about the security. I nod after understanding his reasoning. Personally, I would have told people some more if not more. But its his decision. He says to Luther, lets tell people the match is warrants more caution. Luther was curious about what we were talking, but ignores it, that’s fine then. Try to bring the conversation to compare with your match with Marina. Overdrive power is too much to be contained and we will make do everything to make it safer.

Blake nods, that’s good. I am also in agreement. Its good idea to bring their attention to previous matches to show the severity of clashes. They resume discussing amongst themselves. Marina was almost done speaking. She was having the time of her life speaking about moving her. While I was conflicted and preparing myself for a hurdle. Someone sneaks up from behind. Hey, you have a second. When I heard the voice unexpected, it broke my concentration and I shook my shoulders away.

Vanessa looks at me with a stare that got me swallow hard. I can't believe I am such a mess, I can't behave normally around her. She says, what was that. I pull out a nervous smile at the corner of my mouth, sorry. I was just preparing for the interview. I guess I was so engrossed I didn't notice you. She looks suspicious of me. This isn't good. Earlier, I was thinking how much I was in my element on the boat. But all that confidence is lost. She says, ah. Okay. I need to talk to you about something. Where are others. I recall they all scattered sometime ago and went back to work. I thought Vanessa had also left. She came to talk alone, so it had to be about one thing only.

Freak this. She is the last person I should talk to. I felt my brain getting hotter. I probably sweating all over as well. She didn't notice that, but I know she sensed something off. I nervously say, yeah. Sure. I kicked myself mentally, I shouldn't have agreed. I know what's she going to ask me. She asks me, before you left the stadium yesterday. You said something about. I took over from her, your brother right. I pushed ahead. I was too eager, she saw it too. But I wanted to take over the conversation and end it fast before I get worse.

I pull out a apologetic smile, yeah. That would seem an odd behavior. No, to you it most definitely was. Vanessa remains silent, probably weirded out by my overeagerness to share. But I was on a roll, since the middle of the match, I had been carried away after seeing the effectiveness of my new Kuret abilities. I think I just became overzealous when I heard even the previous crown couldn't beat Charles. I know powerful crowns are, so I agreed to the deal immediately thinking I have a shot too.

Vanessa asks, that’s what I thought too. But before that you asked Charles somethings about my brother. How do you know that. I knew I had to lie here. I even had thought of a solution before. But seeing her in person had made me judging if its alright to lie. But I didn't have a choice. I can't tell her the truth. I say, he used to visit the university frequently and gave a speech to us in our classroom. He was a idol to many of us, so someone asked what's his favorite fighting style. He wasn't going to reveal his tricks to a bunch of kids, so instead he told us his quirk. Something he likes during a fight. I was there too, so I remember what Charles mentioned and that when I realized he was telling the truth.

Vanessa stare intensifies. I can't tell if she bought that. The truth is he did gave speeches, but he never talked about that. No one here is either alive or remembers about it. So neither should Vanessa know. She says, you remember a conversation from that long ago when you were a child. And even after forgetting your life for a decade. Her skepticism was going to a different direction. That’s a little relief. I answer, I do. My memories returning, also filled up some the memory place I built. You know that’s the.

She cuts in, I know what it is. You have told me enough times. Its just so random to memorize it. I make a fake gesture of being offended, he was popular you know. I remember all the important bits. I was hampered by my brittle body back then, so learning was all I could do. Vanessa subtly nods. I think I am getting through to her. I wave of relief washes over to me. She says, I think I understand now. I nervously smiled relaxing the tension in my face, I didn't think it was a big deal. So I didn't think to tell you.

Vanessa says, its fine. And so, that whole Kuret overflowing thing and getting exhausted suddenly. I blurt out, I was trying to look not exhausted, but in really I had dead tiered. And that last hyped emotion got me passing out. Its little unsettling that I thought I could fight in that condition. Clearly, I wasn't thinking straight. I was too emotional. This was actually the truth. I never intend to show her or anyone that side of me. Vanessa says with a small smile, you admit it yourself huh. That’s good to know you realize it.

I think we are good now. Her suspicions are getting cleared. She doesn't seem to be that agitated. Compared to her voice I heard when she and Melinda were talking, she seems calmer. Wait. She is too calm. Then a nagging feeling came, why didn't she say anything about the whole truth Melinda told her. She doesn't know that I know, so she should tell me. Right when I realized something was not right. Her smile broke away. Then came a glare that was complete opposite to what was now. Freak.

She says, everything you said is a complete lie. I know it is. I gave you a chance to come clean to me. But you lied. It was a mistake to think that I would get a straight answer from you. Shit. She didn't believe any of it. My stress level jumps to a whole new level instantly. She says, whenever I talk about my brother, you weirdly become silent. Like you are hiding something. No, I am now sure. I tried to gather some wit, what are you saying. I told you. She cuts me off, I know how you operate. You say truth and cleverly add lies to it. I don't know which is which. But I know you didn't tell me anything useful.

She saw through me so thoroughly. The last thing on my mind was being impressed. My sweats begin forming again. Vanessa looks upset now, I thought you trusted me. But you don't. All the time we spent together in the capture flag game. I thought we becoming close enough that you didn't need to hide things from me. But you not only did that, but kept important things from me. About my brother. And for what, because you don't trust me. Don't you. Shit. Shit. She looked distraught now. I try to form words, no. That’s not true.

She shook her head, no you don't. And I understand. I have betrayed you many times. And I thought you forgave me for the whole fiasco in the valley. I thought searching you for months gave me some reprieve. It was dumb of me thinking you forgave me. I spat out, that’s not true Vanessa. She wasn't budging, how can I believe you. I remained silent trying to figure out how to get out of the hole I just dig. But Vanessa was done listening to me. She raises her hand, I am done. I don't want to talk to you. Do what you want with you match with Charles. You seem eager to prove you are stronger than my brother. You'll even risk your life. So have at it. I am no longer going to stop you from it.

And just like that, her outraged tone stops. She turns back suddenly into her stoic expression she had in the beginning. Her look of disappointment at me was so obvious, that I felt anger at myself for choosing to lie. But I had no choice. And that reasoning has to led to this. She says in monotone voice, good luck with your interview. Hope you show people how strong you really are. With that parting jab at me, she turned her back to me and walks away. I wanted to stop her. I even slightly moved my arms in air to stop her. But I froze over. This isn't good. I could feel a panic attack coming.

My body begins to become heavy. Shit. Freak. Not this again. I saw images of dead people. Shadows. Wagner's corpse flashed over my eyes. Then Zakerine. I keep making the mistakes. I am still helpless as before. All the normal emotions I had, was now turned upside down. I felt I was about to fall down. This is worst place to have a nervous breakdown. My vision was getting blurry. I hear someone's voice, David. What's going on. You look pale. It was Catherine. No, not her. Anyone else, but not her. Images of Brandon and John came to me. Zakerine crying.

Catherine puts her arm on my shoulder. My head was crouch down, leaning away from her. I didn't respond to her. But she leans and whispers, Blake messaged me what you discussed a while ago. I was keeping an eye on you when I saw Vanessa talking to you. Come on Blake, why do you keep telling her about things I don't want others to know. Using her arm, I take support. She becomes worried seeing my weak body, what the hell happened. I had no choice, I blurt outed out, panic attack. She leans away little in shock. Then leans forward, what. Now. Why, you were okay just a second ago.

My breathing becomes ragged. With trembling hands I open the button around my neck of the uniform. It didn't help. I was sweating feverishly now. I couldn't answer her. My mouth was gasping for air uncontrollably. My other hand covers my pounding chest. It felt I was about to burst any second. Catherine says whispers loudly freaked out, pull it together David. You have to give an interview in just few minutes. I blurt out, I lied to Vanessa. She found out. I can't do it.

With no coherent thoughts, I was sharing her things. Catherine turns to look away at the direction Vanessa left. She looks back, seriously. You lied to her too. You got a serious problem. I don't need that now. I manage to say, I know that. Do you think I enjoy being like this. I almost shouted at her. My anger made my vein pop in my forehead. It was already visible from my heating brain. That made Catherine become less angry at me. She says, this is messed up. I didn't need to hear from her. With trembling finger, I point to the pocket on my right leg. She looks down and after a second realizes what I meant.

She slips her free hand to the pocket and pulls out a syringe. She asks, is this what I think it is. I managed a furious nod. That the modified sedative from Drew. I kept one on me for an emergency, just like this. She didn't wait a second, just jams the needle into my thigh. I felt a sharp sting when I am pricked. She pushed down the liquid into my body. Then with swift movement pulls it out, once its emptied. Another sharp pain surges through me. She puts the syringe her own pocket. She asks, tell me if its working.

I was still breathing hard. But the cold drug spreads fast all over my body. I felt chills and tingles all over my body. My body stops trembling. My breathing becomes stable. After a minute I felt my strength back. Catherine had a tensed expression all the time she waited for the sedative to work. Another minute goes by and my mind becomes clearer. She lets go of my shoulder once I got my balance back. She says, that was fast. What the hell was that. I sighed, a special doze from Drew. Made just for me.

Finally, I was able to think clearly again. I wiped off the sweat on my head. I looked around us to check if anyone saw my meltdown. She says, no one saw. I made sure it looked like we were just talking. I reply, you saved me. Thanks a lot. I felt like myself soon. And now I could tell how worried she really was. She says, you have been dealing with this for a year. I reply, not as much as before. I made good progress. I thought I did. Turns out I have just been bottling it. To quote Drew, I have hit rock bottom.

She says, you got that right. You almost collapsed in the middle of this pier with everyone watching. She didn't need to point the obvious and make me feel even more shit. She asks, what do you say to Vanessa. She looked cold and angry at the same time. That was probably the right mix of emotion she was going through. I close my eyes trying to figure out a way to explain to Vanessa. But nothing came. She completely believes I don't trust her and lied to her. I can't deny that. There are things I don't trust her with, like having information about Wagner. But that doesn't mean I don't trust her.

I open my eyes, same shit as you. I know somethings about her brother. She was taken aback. It was weird joke that I kept things about their family to both of them. I wasn't going to get for sympathy from either of them. She asks nervously, is this just a coincidence. Or a pattern with you. She was thinking the same as me. She asks, what happened then. I answer, she realized somehow I was lying. Then she accused me of, stuff. I couldn't take that. She looks at me with pity. I don't know if she really felt that, considering I put her through something similar. She asks, so what will you do now.

I answer, about Vanessa. Nothing. Not until I can speak to her without having a meltdown. I'll focus on the interview now. I keep wiping the sweat off my head. I was so worried about the questions I would be getting, never thought I had an attack before I even answered the first question. Catherine says, that's good. Because you are up now. I see Luther is ready for you now. I turn following her eyeline and see him signaling an index finger. One minute. I tell, thanks again. I'll be fine now.

Catherine looks hesitant to leave me alone. I assure her, the sedative you gave me is pretty hardcore. It hardens my emotions, I won't have another one again anytime soon. She nods understanding, okay. Good luck. I appreciated her concern, however, I can't dwell on it longer. I approach to a make shift interview setup with 4 reporters sitting on a chairs with kuritine drones flying in the air. Blake was siting in a single chair opposite to them. Luther and Marina stood beside them a little steps away, enough to be out of the camera.

Marina had a concerned face when she asks, you good. Saw you discussing something with Catherine. Looked important. Blake must have filled her on few things about it. With Luther beside, I didn't have much choice. I waved my hand in air, its nothing. Just talking about what to do with the remaining Citradel people. Whether they will be leaving as scheduled or is that changed now. We decided, its something Blake has to decide. Luther bought it completely since I know Blake was talking about it to the reporters now.

He says, she isn't alone wondering about it. Blake just told people that nothings changed for that. Citradel citizens will be travelling back just as planned. What happens after, is entirely up to the Citradel officials. I nod half-heartedly. My thoughts were still a little clouded from the nervous break I just experienced. Without anyone noticing, I took deep breathes. Luther was concentrating on the questions being asked to Blake. He didn't pay any attention to me. I was vaguely hearing conversation between Blake and with them. I was making all effort to not get distracted by anything. This is the final hurdle and probably the first step in preparing to bring people here. If I can't show confidence to our own people, Citradel and other communities won't believe it either.

Marina whispers to me, Blake told me. Don't worry about it now. I got you. Just focus on this, nothing else. Did she and Blake saw my meltdown earlier. No, Catherine hide it well. I think she is just backing me up. I felt a bit of hope hearing her, thanks Marina. I will need it. But promise me you or Blake won't do anything unless absolutely necessary. She nods, I will.

My mental preparedness comes to a close when Blake steps out of the hot seat. Blake walks to me and his smile vanishes halfway when he sees me. Luther says, that was good. We got to cover most of what we could tell. Blake turns his gaze to him, they didn't ask some of the question we thought they ask. I think they were eager to get it directly from the horses mouth. He was implying I will have to take over the majority of the stuff. I nod, I got this. I'm not sure if I'm reaffirming it to him or myself. Blake waves his hand to the chair, all yours.

As soon as I get in the view of the camera, the people behind the barricade started to shout in excitement. I put a forced smile for everyone, waving them and took my seat. The kuritine drones glide near me for a close up. I tuned everything out of my mind and laser focused on the interview now. In the first row was the primary reporter, Sasha. She had been covering news all about her. Beside her was Keith, he was from Citradel. The two beside them, Geina and Terry were representing the other communities.

I preemptively started the conversation, good morning everyone. Nice to meet you all. I kept a mechanical smile all the while talking. Sasha says, hello David. Thanks you for joining us. Have your injuries healed. Its been almost whole day since we saw you. I cross my legs and interlock my fingers, getting comfortable with them. I reply, they have. I apologies for worrying everyone, its wasn't my intention to be away for such long suddenly. Vance asks, I have to ask, where were you all the time. You left the stadium without letting anyone know. And you weren't at your home also.

We had prepared for this obvious question, as you all know. I can't heal like others. But I do have nano bot chamber designed for superficial and small surgeries. That's the one I was in after the match. Its a prototype, and its not at fully optimized. It was my first time using actually. It was slow and time taking procedure since it had to calibrate for me the first time. When I woke up yesterday after the match, I still needed to get back inside to complete tending my injuries. With Blakes discretion, I moved to safehouse in section 4 and I have been there all this time. I just woke up early this morning. And came straight here hoping to surprise Citradel officials before they left.

Sasha says, its still an impressive recovery. You seem back to your usual self. I laugh amused, mostly because they don't have a clue. They however would see me as someone being modest. Geina asks, people want to know about your fight with Heraknus alpha. You have fought before with alphas and omegas. Tell us how you felt when you saw your opponent the first time. I reply, I was shocked, like everyone. I never imagined in my wildest dreams that Citradels secret warrior and champion would be a mythical bloodline. Whatever battle plans I had, were all crushed. How does one fight when you don't know about their kuret. Once he introduced himself, the real challenge begin. And as you saw, it was one tough battle from the very first clash.

Vance asks, during the fight, was there ever a time you thought about giving up. I chuckle, oh man. You have no idea. Every time I came this close to resigning. The first half was brutal, none of my attacks were working on Charles. I was lucky he was slow, because of that I could run around to stall for time. And even after I got my bearing and fought head on, I couldn't budge that Heraknus guy. Each time I thought I figured out something about him, he switches his attack style. No was has made me think this hard in the tournament. I am actually very lucky Charles humanization backlash happed when they did, otherwise the outcome of the match would have been different.

Geina asks, I am sure it was not just luck. You woke just in the nick of time when you were knocked unconscious. And as you said, the game changed around the middle of the match. Your kuret armer, the barrier braking and lastly, variety of kuret attacks. You were slowly beginning to dominate the match. How much was it part of your strategy. I answer, first of all. Thanks for the compliment. Keep them coming. I laugh and so does other 4 amused by my ego. I continue, it didn't go entirely how I wanted. But the important bits, that went as I wanted it. I had no intention in scaring any of the audiences in the stadium. Chalk that overzealous moment to adrenaline rush. Thankfully, no was hurt. Then my smile grew acting suspiciously, but in my defense, I didn't think that Charles would be blown away. He should have been able to stop it. Don't you all think. Does that size was only for show.

I took shots at Charles to show a little bit of hubris. That made the them feel delighted at my attitude towards Charles. Sasha asks with light giggle, this comes to my next question. Do you have any protest over the prolonged Charles countdown. Everyone had almost believed you won then. That was almost a 10 minute break for Charles to get back up. I reply simply, no, I don't have any objection. No rules were broken. If fact, in retrospect, that gave me the opportunity to lunch a bigger attach. Sure, I do feel a little discontent, knowing I could have won the match. But because of that, I got to chance to show my full kuret. So I can't complain.

Terry asks, throughout the tournament, you have shown brilliant strategies. You went from the underdog to potential contender for the finals. And yet, you shocked everyone again with your kuret abilities. People want to know how your anti-kuret could do such a thing. I flighted slightly knowing this is one of the trickiest question. I purposely made it look like I was thinking about it for a moment. Then I say, sorry. I can't reveal it. Not just yet. You heard Charles yesterday, right. He also doesn't want to give my any advantage. Neither do I. All I want to say is that it was something I developed during the tournament. I grew stronger seeing other warriors participants.

Vance asks, have you heard about the allegations against you about you fight. Allegedly, you employed deception and trick to use that mind blowing ability. What do you have to say about it. I had long known how I was going to respond to this. Blake insisted that I deny it. But I had other ideas. I say, they are just rumors. I haven't been accused of anything. I don't feel any need to worry about it. I chose to remain neutral about it. Vance looked a little bit perplexed, are you denying it. I reply, I am saying, admins didn't find any proof to make them believe I did anything wrong. Until someone officially asks me to give justify my actions, there are no problem. My objectivity didn't budge even at his insistence.

Geina asks a bit confused, just for clarification, you aren't denying it. I just give my smile as response. I wasn't going to let them continue this line of questioning, like I said, I am not worried. They are just rumors. That shut down any further talk of this. Sasha smiling asks, creating suspense and being mysteries. Just the brand adore portraying others. Her candor made me feel better. Terry asks, okay. Lets talk about the deal you made with Charles. What prompted it exactly.

I cleared my throat replying, as you saw. Once I had Charles bound by his own kuret, I was able to pull out some information from him. The quickest way to overcome his tremendous kuret endurance was to make him use his overdrive. I wasn't thrilled to know I had to fight him in his overdrive state. But I wasn't going to back down also. I was prepared to compel him and use it forcefully. Once he realized what I plan to do, he stopped me. The rest you all know, we talked for it. He proposed me a condition for allowing to fight him in his overdrive. And I accepted it.

Sasha asks, but not before adding in the condition to move Heraknus here. What made you make this, a genius move if I say so, a part of it. Because Charles didn't mention that he himself made it, I realized Kafar had to make him say that. He didn't want to show that Charles was the one who came up. But that doesn't mean I should claim it myself. Blake agreed with me that we shouldn't call out who proposed it. I answer, both me and Charles felt this would be fair. He was going to give us both a month to prepare. He needs to regain his kuret, but I could also train in this time. While it looked fair, it wasn't. Since we did agree to allow him as a wild entry at the finals. Using the final match like this isn't fair. To make up the difference, we decided it was crucial to treat this as my win. And that resulted in his promise to relocate his family here.

With careful wording, I asserted that it wasn't a sole decision. Vance says, that was a big win for you all. Citradel lost their most important warriors, well apart from the recently gained Marina Ozarek. But we are curious though. It's such a big risk. Charles has told his overdrive is unstable and he can't control it well. He said it will be very dangerous for you. Its a very perilous situation. What made you decide you it was worth the risk. I swallowed hard here. I had to think long on what I was going to say to this. Blake wanted me to just say this, and I agreed, I am under no delusion that this isn't dangerous. But after weighing the benefits, it's clear I want to secure our future. Me, Blake and everyone here have always stated its important that we come together in this Island. Not in Citradel, in then middle of human society. I had no choice but to accept the risk.

I lied through my teeth. Only few people know the real reason I did. But no way in hell was I ever going to admit that I did it because of a selfish and unstable emotions packed reason. Vance continues, that's admirable. Risking your life on the line. I thought this line of questions were done. I showed how serious I was. He says, however, there are now new information from one of the Citradel officials, that you were influenced by someone. A person we all know.

My smile broke in half. No. no. Don't you say it. Don't freaking mention that guy to me. He generates a small suspense and says, Wagner, the previous crown was mentioned in you talk with the alpha. And it seems even he couldn't defeat Charles. A slight tremor suddenly appears in my toes and arms. This can't be happening.

Blake (Chapter 60)

Monday, October 6, 2025 21:26

I had been a little worried about David and Catherine missing. But then she finally showed up just when were boarding the cruise. Vanessa and other officers were a little disturbed on how she came undetected. I assumed she had assumed she just morphed into a bird or something to fly here. I wanted to immediately ask her what she was doing. And if my fears were true. But I stayed focused on seeing off the Citradel officials. They were getting delayed. And later, Marina and Derek shows up. Seeing her so excited to talk to Charles made me almost forgive her for delaying us further with such an ostensions show of her uniform.

When David showed up, I was amazed to see him so lively and being his usual self. But then I saw how Vanessa was shocked he was also avoided detection. I peeked at Catherine who was amused slightly. I saw her aura to confirm. She wasn't wavering like others. I internally sighed. What I feared did came true, she went to look for him. She was late because they both came together. That's the only reason why she isn't surprised to see him. But what could have kept both of them this long. I don't think I would get an answer now.

I knew from the moment he spoke that he is straight up bluffing. His body language, behavior and speech, all seem like his is just flowing through the motions. The last time I saw was him was in his nano chamber getting carried into his house by those robots. He was having a panic attack before, but, you can't tell he had a nervous breakdown. When Rory asked to show his kuret, I saw David eyeing for help. That was the first time he showed a hint of panicking. It broke the mirage he had me in that he was really fine. No way he would be fine after that crash from yesterday. Catherin spoke in his defense before I could. She also saw he didn't want to show his kuret.

It was odd how he asked for Rory to show his Kuret. Obviously, he didn't want to share his tricks without something in return. But throwing that study at us. What was he trying to accomplish by that. Thankfully nothing came of it and I secretly signaled to Marina. She understood and pulled away from others. I had a hunch she was more interested to ask him other things, like his house, than hide his mental condition. It was okay, as long as we get him clear of the eyes of Charles and officials.

Once we cross the bridge and step into the pier, I tell Luther, I need to talk to David for a bit. He nods, I get it. He needs to be filled in a lot of stuff. We have some time until Citradel boats leave. Do me a favor and ask David to come to the officers building. He needs to be in front of a camera pronto. People will be coming for our heads asking about him. Yesterday it was all a mess, I don't want a repeat for that here. I reply, boy do I know. I will let him know. He takes off to meet some officers.

I can't really tell if he is okay to talk in his condition. When I came to others, it was a one sided crusade to get to the truth out of David. He should have expected people are going to demand answers why he hide his Echo tech house a secrete. I was more concerned about his mental state, but, I can't deny I was interested to know about it. After hearing his explanation, I felt satisfied. It wasn't because he wanted to keep the tech all to himself, he didn't want a potential dangerous tech to harm anyone.

Then he revealed his bluff to Rory. I am shocked to know how he choose to lie so boldly. I agree with Marina that he feels like himself, crazy and clever. No one aside from Marina and I could ever guessed he was in the middle of a phycological crisis. Is he really going to therapy. I think I understand how he was able to fool everyone for long so good. He is quite excellent in manipulating and deceiving. I didn't think he would be like this after yesterday. I did reprimand him a little and asked to not make any more trouble for us. He has to know how tenuous the situation is. Until Heraknus move here, no matter how many Citradel citizens move here, nothing is certain.

But even David had limit, he made everyone's attention to Marina. I used the chance to talk to him. Luther and I wanted to get him up to speed before he speaks to anyone. However, I should have known better. This guy already knew everything. Detail only me and Marina knew. Maybe Vanessa know some of it. But he didn't speak much to her. He correctly deduced I talked to Catherine about his therapy. I should have better to ask how a shadow strategist knows so much while he was unconscious. The only logical guess was he bugged us. He didn't confirm it exactly, but he didn't need to.

He told me that Catherine found about him. Dammit, she actually followed Drew. She even spied on David. I could tell David wasn't happy about it. He didn't want to be exposed by her so suddenly. I felt a pang of guilt. Maybe I really shouldn't have told Catherine. But she was angry with Daivd. I thought it was the right thing to tell her about it. I really think there is some connection to his behavior on opposing her and Robb like this. Though, it does look like they talked and settled their argument. I want to ask Catherine about it, but this isn't the time or the place.

When he told me his condition is actually worse, I almost yelled out. Poor guy, somehow he is even in a stranger mental state. Can't use his kuret for unknown reasons. What the hell does that mean. Since he asked me to help in case anything happens, I was glad he is cognizant about his current condition. It gave me confidence he was still able to operate normally at some level. We discussed what he will say to others, making especially sure we don't say anything to offend anyone.

After some time, I left him alone to give my interview. Marina just came out from her seat, that was not satisfying. I wanted to say much more. They mostly just asked me about Heraknus moving and Davids match. Then they asked about my thoughts on who will win. I avoided taking sides in front of people. I just said no matter who wins, they both are strong. Then they asked if I could beat Charles. I am going to be honest, I was not sure what to say here. I too was amused by this. I didn't her interview, so I waited for her to talk. She sighs, I wish I could say what I really wanted to. But I remained impartial and said who knows.

She made the right call. Better not to provoke by saying anything. I had a thought, do you think you can take Charles. She smiles, everyone thinks so. You too. They said we both might have better chance. Honestly, I think that also. I am not being conceited, but I think we could take him. Sure, maybe we would have some trouble in beginning. Like David had. But we also have a chance. Don't you think. I reply, you know what. I feel the same. I don't want to kick down David, but I would be more happy if you or I were fighting Charles. I may not have admitted this before. But after learning about David's condition, I also believe we could take on Charles.

She says, yeah. But I know we can't say something so vain. But I so told them I am excited to be the city's newest infrastructure designer. I wanted to talk so much about my job, but weren't interested in knowing that. Her enthusiasm about this wasn't appreciated here, wait for at least a day. We will get it sorted out soon. Once people understand, you will have a lot to talk about. And I feel people She nods slightly disappointed, yeah, I got that. Well, its fine. Important thing is that I am staying here from now on. Nothing keeps her down. She leans in and whispers, what about David. Is he going to be okay. I seems a different. She also caught on. She looks a little offended sensing my realization, hey. I noticed it. But I wasn't going to say anything. So I just asked him the next most important thing I wanted to know.

I smile, no need to explain. I know you also want to help him. But for now, lets not make it obvious by talking about it. I don't want to know what would happen if had another panic attack here. She says, he sometimes behaves his usual self, but some times he just, becomes blank. You know what I am talking about it. I reply, I do. I just hope others didn't pay much attention to it. She asks, is he going to be okay with the interview. Shouldn't we wait for some more time.

I say, he decided it himself. And so far he hasn't shown any signs of issues. Its actually important he speaks to people now. I was okay with it being later, but now that he has shown here, we can't delay. It won't look good on us. She says, I guess. Her fears weren't satisfied. To be honest, neither was mine. Marina says, Dr. Drew made it pretty clear he shouldn't be doing this. But maybe its fine now. Did they both already spoke. I had the same thought sometime before, they have. David mentioned they met. She did say she wanted to talk to him first when he wakes up. Lets hope she assessed him that he was good enough. She says, they did. That's good. She thinks a moment before asking, so I take it you both agreed on what to tell people. I saw you both talking for a while before.

I answer, I did. I will answer some question before him. To ease into it. I turn sideways to see David talking to Vanessa. He looks a little flustered talking to her. And her aura. What's that about. Maybe she is asking about Wagner and if he knows him. I was curious about that too, but I didn't think much about it. Marina sees me eyeing him, you worried about something. I wasn't sure why, but Vanessa aura was flickering like crazy. She appears calm on the outside, but her body speaks differently.

I was a beginning to get worried. He is too open and if he gets a panic attack now, everyone will see it. I saw Catherine moving around the edge talking to some officers. I get an idea. I open my phone and type in a message. Marina asks, what are you got there. You have an interview in a minute. I say, making a backup plan. I am telling Catherine to keep an eye on David. She looks puzzled. She didn't know that Catherine knows. So I explained it to her. She sighs, come on dude. Even I know when to keep a big secret like this.

What was worse than David frustration at me was Marina being right. She knows when and what to keep something from others for right reasons. I felt again the weird feeling about sharing it with Catherine. I say, I know I screwed up a little. But it had to say something to her. She shook her head, that's why they both were late together. She must have gone to talk to him earlier. She figured out the rest. I nod, yes. But since she also knows about it, maybe even more than us, she can help. The more people can keep an eye on him, that much better.

Marina reluctantly says, well, now that she knows and hasn't revealed it to anyone, I guess its fine. I finished my message and sent it to her. I saw Catherine grabbing her phone from her pocket. After a while she turns to me and slightly nods agreeing to it. With that settled, I felt more secured. I say, that's done. Marina says, I'll also help keep an eye on him. He seems fine though. I say, don't be fooled by his appearance. He is good at hiding it. He told me he can't use his kuret for some reason. She freaks out, say what. That's terrible. Did he explain why. I shrug, take a pick. Drew said he was suffering from multiple things. One of them might be causing it. All I we can do right now is keep anyone knowing about it.

She sighs, that's why he pulled that stunt with Rory. I thought he was just being secretive. I say, I had the same thought. We both look at David, who was still talking to Vanessa. Marina says, that poor bastard's got it rough at the worst possible time. Maybe I shouldn't have gone at him like that earlier about his house. She felt guilty knowing the whole truth. I say, I don't know it would make any difference. David is somehow keeping up his usual appearance. She makes a pity expression.

A while later Luther calls me. Its time to talk to the people. Marina and Luther stayed on the sidelines as I walk to the interview chair next. Sasha and Vanse asks me few questions about what's are plan next and will more Citradel people will be joining like Marina. Most of my answers were centered around expediting our infrastructure for Heraknus arrival. We didn't have any indication that any other people are going to come. Terry asked about the other communities and how we plan to bring them. I told him they should decide for themselves, but I did highlight that when Heraknus moves here, its for their sake to relocate here. We can provide protection much better with Heraknus here.

I didn't want to speculate on anything else. Giana asks questions about their role and contributions. I told as much as I could. More will be revealed when we start talking to Heraknus once they are back in Citradel. Few more questions came around the topic of David. I deferred those to have them ask David directly. They didn't ask me few things, like the rumors floating about David's supposedly cheating. Or the part about Charles overdrive dangers. They must want to talk to David about it.

Soon my time was up and David was next. The reporters thanked me and I left the hot seat. David, Marina and Luther were watching me. And after a small exchange from David, he took the seat. I now stand beside Marina whispering, anything I need to be worried about. She shrugs, I can't say for sure. He and Catherine were talking for some time. They looked suspicious. He said it wasn't anything. I saw them before, hopefully it didn't escalate to anything. I looked around, Catherine was no where around us. She must be busy with Tessa and Vanessa managing security from the barricade. Few people had also begin to leave. Officers are going to be soon back into their normal routine.

The reports asked David pretty basic questions. And he didn't waste any opportunity to make jokes and show his cocky attitude. I got a say, for a guy with mental issues, he has hide it very well. The best poker face I have ever seen. The topic then switched to the rumors about him cheating. Luther turns confused hearing David's answer, wait. Why isn't he denying it. I shook my head dismayed, I told him to deny it unequivocally. I don't know why he would confirm it or deny it. Marina offers, maybe he doesn't want to share any clues by talking about it. I couldn't understand that logic, what good will it be if he doesn't outright say he didn't cheat. He must have a good reason. But no one here knows it.

Thankfully the reports didn't pursue this topic for long. Then they asked about Heraknus moving as part of the deal. David stuck to the script this time by not mentioning who came up with that condition. Marina asks, you don't want them to Charles brought this offer himself. Luther says, it's the right call though. If we say Charles did it, Citradel will not like it. Their prized bloodline making unilateral decisions like that may cause some unintended issues. Its best if everyone believes either David made him do it or they both did. Citradel probably wants the same since Charles also didn't mention it. As always, his political savvy mind picked up the same reasons we were thinking.

When Vance asked him the question why David accepted such a risky deal. I hoped he wouldn't go off script. Its important they he conveys our ideology to all the communities. I relaxed when he responded as we wanted. When we talked about it, he was little distracted. I know what was going on his head. His reasons weren't as noble as the words he spoke. Since I was there physically, I could tell he accepted for different reasons. Perhaps reckless and selfish reasons. Who knows, something else entirely. But the next question tripped all of us. Vance revealed about Wagner being mentioned during the deal.

Marina says hesitantly, hey, is it just me or did his mood suddenly change. I answer, you aren't alone. Luther asks, what happened. What's Wagner got to do with this. Luther was bamboozled at this question. But I had other things in my mind. Like how David image was cracking. His eyes were twitching slightly. His smile was melting away and he was fidgeting. Marina saw it too, this doesn't look good. I know I promised him, but should we barge in stop the interview.

Anything, but that. Not in the middle of the questions. From their aura's I can see the reporters also felt Davids subtle change in attitude. David remained silent for few seconds. Luther asks hesitant, hey what's going on. Did something happen to him. I couldn't answer him. Marina says impatiently, 10 more seconds and I am going in. Marina had up her mind. I wanted to stop her, but should I. What if he having another episode right now on live TV, in front of all Medrone population. That's a disaster. If that's the case, we should just risk it and pull the plug now.

Marina takes a step ahead. But then David clears his throat. He regains his smile and eyes Marina for a moment. Marina understood and steps back. David says, apologies. That caught me of guard. His mouth spoke words normally, but he was now clutching his fingers more tightly. I think I see a bit of blood. Did he just dig his nails into the back of his hands to snap out of it. Is he that desperate to stay in control. David continues, I wasn't sure how to answer this, and needed a moment to think.

Vance asks, I hope it was okay to ask this. Neither Charles or any Citradel officials have any comments about it. We just want to know if that's true. David chuckles, this was definitely a nervous one, I think I understand. I was wondering how this got out. You have a good source to get such an information, even when Citradel themselves haven't shared it. Vanse looked smug about it. No one from our side must have told him. That leaves Marina, Derek and Kafar. No, really its just Kafar. Is he willing to leak details of things he asked Citradel to hide himself. That guy is incorrigible.

Marina girts her teeth beside me, that rat bastard. There is nothing he wouldn't try to stop this, huh. Apparently, she seemed to arrive in the same conclusion. Sasha asks, so its really true that Wagner Wecker, the last crown, fought Charles. Giana asks, can you tell us how and why. Terry asks, if even the crown couldn't defeat Charles, do you think you can do what he couldn't. I swear I saw David digging his fingers deeper in his skin with each question thrown at him.

The last time someone spoke about Wagner, he had a panic attack. What's going to happen now. I doubt he would recover enough in a day. I could hear David breathing quietly to calm down. Even with such self control, he is showing signs of a nervous breakdown. David kept up his outward composure in all this, let me be assure everyone. I don't know the reasons. Charles didn't talk about it. He only confirmed that he once fought the crown for some reason. He laughs, no, more like a halfway between a whimper and laugh. He says, you should ask your source the how or why. Because I was shocked to know he knew about Heraknus existence. I don't have a clue how he knew or why he fought Charles.

Sasha asks, I do think that it pretty strange no one ever mentioned it after the match. Can you at least tell us why. David answers, I can't say for sure why Citradel didn't. However, I can tell why we didn't. Talking about it without any evidence wouldn't make sense. I mean, apart from Charles testimony, where's the actual evidence. I am not saying they lied, but anyone can say they fought the crown. And then claiming he couldn't defeat them is even a bigger one. So we thought its best not to reveal it, at least until we confirm it.

Vance asks, did Wagner's sister reveal any details about it. She must have some information. David struggles a little to answer this, Vanessa was too young back then. She doesn't know about it. I suspect the crown didn't mention this to anyone. Before there was another question, he added, I want to be clear about this. We didn't want people to get discouraged by such a unverified statement. Regardless of whether Charles fought or not, won or not, I would still taken the deal. If anything, it probably fired me up and gave me another reason to accept it. The thought of fighting at the level the crown was too enticing. I may have been selfish, but I hope people can understand that it wasn't a decision I made lightly. I weighed the pros and cons of taking the deal before accepting it. It was always the future of Medrones and our fight with Echo on my mind, not about the crown.

David's little ranting ran out as he begins to breath a little faster. I think he was overcompensating his selfish desire by reaffirming our goals. Thankfully, the Sasha and Giana interpreted the way David wanted. Sasha says, that was well said. I am sure anyone in your position would have been also tempted to fight someone the crown couldn't defeat. Giana says, absolutely, a warrior has to be confident in himself to take on a Heraknus overdrive. Looks like David made the right impression on them. He manipulated them, using this to his advantage.

Vance switches the question, as impressive your resolve is, do you have plan on how to fight Charle's overdrive. He hasn't reveled anything about it. But he has seen your kuret abilities. David chuckles menacingly, I was hoping you ask that. What you all saw was me not at 100%. But once I am, overdrive or not, Charles will feel what its like to taste dirt. Whatever I plan is irrelevant, because his first defeat on Earth will be my hands. You can quote me on that. Jeez, I know he is being cocky to hide his mental state, but instead of weaning off slowly, the guy is doubling down on his arrogance. He said it with zero hesitation. I can't tell if people will think he is delusional or just ego talking. Either way, the impression he was making was too strong and it resonated among the reporters. Their aura even showed slight admiration.

David handled it nicely. But it wasn't going to last for much. His hands were bleeding visibly now. The reporters can't see from their seats, but we could see it. I want to get him out of here soon. Marina had been wavering for a little while, she kept taking a step in front and back. But with Luther beside us, we weren't going to take any chance showing this side of David. David finally said, and I am afraid that's all the time I have guys. I have a lots to prepare. While I am sure I will win, that doesn't mean I don't need to work for it. I have to start planning strategies immediately.

David had the good sense to back off now, before he becomes worse. The reporters seem not fully satisfied. I am sure they had other tons of information. But David has done his bit. Theres nothing more I or Luther want him to say. Shasa says, Thanks for being here. Good luck David. Other give their appreciation as well. David stands up, covering his bleeding left hand with his right one on top. He shakes his head to the reporters and to the crowd behind him. With no expression of any discomfort, he walks to us.

Luther asks, that was great David. You showed how confident you are with your victory. I am a little worried it was a bit too much, but that's okay. This should raise our morale, and pressure Citradel at the same time. David smile was gone now. He seemed exhausted, yet he keeps a pleasant attitude, thanks Luther. I could have handled it better, I know now. Well, anyways. This was just to show I am okay and not going to back down. Other things were just me getting a big head. Luther waves his hand to him, I told you. Its fine. The important thing was like you said, your presence.

David replies, great. So we are done here right. Because I wasn't exaggerating that I had work to do for my fight with Charles. Luther says, all right. Unless you have anything to discuss Blake, we are good here. I immediately reply, no. I think we got everything we need. Let me talk to him for a sec. I will be just behind you. Luther walks away after that. David suddenly leans towards and grabs Marina by her arm whispering loudly, get my the freak out of here.

We both were ready for this. With a quick look around us in our vicinity, I signaled Marina to walk with us towards the far east end of the shore. I don't see any aura nearby there. She nods and grabs on Davids arm supporting him. Few officers turn their gaze at us as we walk briskly, but we both spoke to David like we were in deep discussion. We make random remarks about David being too confident and ask his plans. David meanwhile remained silent, the guy even closed his eyes.

It feels déjà vu, carrying him like this again. Thankfully, he wasn't passing out. He was walking properly. As soon as we arrive at the isolated part of the shore, David began gasping for air, like he was holding his breath. He opens the buttons around his neck. He crouches down on one knee and pants heavily. He places his beading hand on the wooden planks to support his body. Marina puts her hand on his shoulder, are you okay, David.

David didn't reply. His face was flushed with blood and red appeared on the skin. I could see sweat shining from the sun behind his neck. He did nod his head after a while signaling he is recovering slowly. I look to Marina and we both shared a relief signs on our face. I ask, man. When I said you have problems, it was understatement, you are a real mess. Marina puts on a scowl expression towards me. I shrug, what. She remains silent, like she was telling me not to say the obvious. Maybe she was right, I shouldn't kick him down when he is quite literally on the ground.

David moves finally. He turns and sits on the wooden floor with his back against the railing. He looks much better than a minute ago. He sighs, its fine Marina. What he said was just a fact. Marina shape gaze cuts me deeper. Maybe I really shouldn't have said it. Marina crouches down on her legs, are you really okay. Do you need water. He says, no. I got it under control now. His ragged breathing was slowing down. I had to ask, I know I shouldn't say this. But this the second time we had to carry you out in two days. This is not a good sign.

Marina was giving me a warning expression to shut it. But I had to ask him, I hate to ask this. But I need to know. Its important. What did Dr. Drew say. Marina realizing what I am getting at faces him again. David glances at both of us. He grits his teeth, shit. This is so embarrassing. I never wanted you both to be worried about me like this. I know I made the right call telling you both about my therapy, but it still so hard for me to see you guys like this. Marina scoffs, you are worried about us. Dude, you need to take a look in the mirror. I was a little angry in the beginning, but after sleeping on it, I get how it must have been suffering through it. You should have told at least me. I would have kept it a secret.

I didn't like her implying that I couldn't. Well, hard to argue since I did share it with Catherine. David smiles a little, I really thought I had it under control. I hadn't relapsed for months. I was sure that all of it was behind me. I was planning to tell you all, after the tournament. I didn't want to you or me to get distracted. And Drew also made me promise not to tell about this. Her condition was not to reveal her involvement, but she knew that if it got out I was in therapy, eventually she would be found out as well. It made sense for various reasons to not tell you. I am really sorry about it.

His expression was not at all what it was during the interview. His confidence and arrogance had been stripped down, replaced with pity and humiliation. Just how much was he bluffing back then. Whatever I felt about him went up in smoke. I say, it must have been a struggle. But I understand your reasons. If I had known you had so much going on, I would have not pushed you to win our match. He scoffs, only I need to take responsibility for it. Not you. When I entered the tournament, I accepted the risks. Besides, even if you did let me win in the end, I could have backed off anytime during our own match. I didn't. We both knew with your overdrive had taken a

major hit from Marina, I was the best chance for the finals.

Just because it made sense, doesn't mean it was the right. I say, honestly, me and Marina were just talking about how we might have better chances than you right now. Marina gets flustered, no. I mean, yeah. But listen, we were just joking around. I didn't mean to say you couldn't win. She was trying to console him. David snorts, no. That’s true. You guys might have better chances. At least, the way I am right now. There a slight hope still in him. That’s good, he hasn't given up completely.

Marina asks, right now. So does that mean you still intend to win. David remained silent, but that gave us the answer anyways. I ask, so you still believe that. Did talking to Drew helped out. Because I am concerned more than ever about your mental health. He replies, she agreed to waive her decision until midnight. The deadline I was talking about earlier was that. She told she has a way to help me, but there's a condition. I need get my kuret under control without loosing my mind. Marina asks, how does that makes sense.

He then explains how Drew believed that if David couldn't do it, it would mean he will not recover fast enough for the fight. Drew was testing him and only if he could use his Kuret, would she even administer this treatment. I ask incredulously, is she really a psychiatrist. Isn't she supposed to remove your stress, not add more. Marina says, this sounds a little crazy David. He says, I question it too. But she is my doctor. She knows the best. Maybe she is right to question my ability to recover. All I know is that if I don't figure it out before midnight, I will get no help from Drew. And I would be fighting like this. Which would end in most likely my defeat. Or worse, my life.

Marina and I remained quite learning of this ridiculous deadline. David slowly beings to stand up. Marina gives offers her hand to him, which he gladly accepts. She pulls him up. David pulls out his hand and wipes the drops of the blood tricking down. He asks us, did anyone see this. I made sure to hide it well. But I felt as maybe some officers saw it. I don't know. I was too focused on getting him out of there. Marina says, I don't think so. Even I didn't see it until it you moved it in the end. He nods, okay. If anyone does ask, just say one of my stiches opened up.

I say, is that something you do whenever you feel having an attack. He shook his head, no. I never had so intense in front of anyone before. I took a sedative just minutes before, I can't believe I had another one so soon. My body must be building up immunity to it. Drew told me this trick for situation like this. I never thought it would work, since I have been hurt much worse before. But my head felt like it was about to explode. I desperately thought for anything to keep me from breaking down in front of the whole world. I tried my best to salvage my image near the end. I wasn't planning to be so conceited. But I had to hide it by using a stronger emotion.

Marina says, boy did it work. Your ego felt it had no limit. She nervously smiles. I didn't it that amusing, only you would be fine to be vain enough just to hide your illness. There will be some people who will question your big head. He nods, I know. Can't deny it. I didn't want it to take it too far. I felt like I was back in the middle of the match with Charles. The situation was different, but it felt, well. Forget it. I wasn't in my right mind then or now. But what[s done is done. I have achieved all I wanted coming here. Even with so many unexpected and harrowing things along the way. The damage I caused to others, I can't undo it.

What damage is he talking about. Me and Marina look each other confused. But neither one of us were going to ask him to explain. He might be thinking of Catherine or his interview. David then turns to the center of the pier where officers were mobilizing to clear the place. He says, I should go back now. Tell anyone who asks that I am busy preparing or something at my home inside the city. Marina asks, wait. You are already leaving. You sure that’s a good idea. I was with her on this, I don't think its okay to leave you alone for today. What if you have another episode.

David turns to us, that’s why I should leave. I have a less chance of triggering if I am alone. And I have asked a lot from you two already. Marina, you just relocated here today. You will be busy settling down, permanently this time, I don't want to became a burden for you. And Blake, you are soon going to be swamped with work. With so much going on, other officers need you. So trust me, right now I need time and space. He argued about the situation, which was hard to dismiss. He was right, both us don't have the time to keep an eye on him.

I ask, what about Catherine. She could help out. She already knows about you now. Most of her work is done with the officials gone. The only people left in the guest houses are the Citradel regular citizen and warriors. Jess could take over her. David becomes sullen at that suggestion. He closes his eyes and shaking his head like he was trying to forgot a memory. A moment later he opens them back, yeah. That’s not going to happen. We maybe talking now, but things aren't resolved between us. I already shared too much today. Things I still believe I shouldn't have. And she helped out already. I can't ask her more.

I didn't know what he meant. I recall they were talking before his interview. Did something happen. Marina says, then we will get someone. Hell, maybe you go to your doctors house. David sighs, that’s not happening. I don't want to be analyzed or scrutinized like a patient right now. I feel it might do the opposite of helping. Trust me, its best if I figure out this alone for sometime. I was conflicted here. Can't we get anyone to watch over him. Marina says, I don't know if this would work. But what if we told Vanessa about your condition. She is also freed up now. And I am sure once she understand, she would help you.

David vehemently shakes his head, absolutely not. The ferocity of his rejection was hard not to notice. He sighs realizing his rection, sorry. It just that she is little mad at me for not explaining how I know Wagner. I kind of lied and she somehow knows I lied. So she is a bit cross at me. I stare at him trying best to understand this absurdity. Marina mocks him, is every women mat at you. David grunts, I know. I don't want you to be the latest one. So, you know how much I am messing things. Guys, the bottle line is that I will cause trouble for anyone around me right now. Whether they know about my illness or not. Its best for everyone that I get out of everyone's way. Figure it out without having to worry about a panic attack when I talk to anyone.

At this point we had no choice but to trust him. Theres only so much help we can give him without anyone knowing. With reluctance I said, okay. I get it. Lets trust him Marina. Marina wasn't satisfied with this, are we really not going to do anything. I shrug, if you have any idea, I am all ears. What else can we do, but trust him to be okay. Marina faces him. After a brief stare she says, fine. This isn't over though David. You hear me. You got still a lot to explain. The secret to be able to use multiple kurets. How you know Wagner. What's the deal with Catherine. And now Vanessa.

I agreed with her, yeah. We got a lot questions you need to answer. He nods, and I will. Just not today. His shoulders slump down, like he lost all his strength. He walks between us towards the forest, I will be taking the long way to my place. I need to clear my head anyways. So I need the walk. I ask nervously, seriously. If don't want to ride with anyone, at least take the trolley from the nearest stop. Marina backs me up, its almost 12 miles from here. That’s too much for you. It will take around 4 hours. David doesn't budge, he says, that’s good. It will give me some workout to release my stress.

He walked towards the forest line near the shore. Once he was away from us, Marina asks me, he is going to be okay, Right. I had no words of encouragement.

Vanessa (Chapter 61)

Wednesday, October 8, 2025 18:29

This was my chance for an answer. When I saw Blake leaving David for a moment, I knew this was the only time I might get to talk to him. I approached him from behind, Hey, you have a second. I didn't expect him to be on such edge. Was giving the interview making him anxious. I have seen him fought off worse things than this. I can't believe he would be lost in thoughts so much that he wouldn't notice me. He is clearly hot himself right now. But I set it aside and got to the real matter in hand.

He surprised me again with how eager and forth going he was revealing how he knows my brother. I listened to him justifying his actions to me. I was glad that he understood how pompously he was behaving yesterday during the match. Maybe he really is telling me the truth. It made sense how he knows about it. Derek did say David's university is Wagner's also. But why would he not tell this before. I never once told he met Wagner before. He had enough chances to tell, yet he chose not to.

I noticed him slowly getting calmer as we spoke. Its almost like he was panicking when we spoke. I don't know how, but I had a nagging feeling he isn't telling the truth. He has the same expression I have seen countless times. When is lying. Maybe I am wrong. Its not like I can be certain of it. He maybe just stressed right now. I shook away the thoughts. That's what is going on. This guy is manipulating me. I was slowly getting more certain of it. This realization crushed me. Why can't he tell just me the truth. I wanted him to tell me what Melinda told me was a lie. But I couldn't even utter a single word about it. Because I knew he would twist it, like everything he does.

I blurted out and accused him of lying the whole time. He tried to rebuke it, but deep down I know he was lying. He always does it so effortlessly. After getting close this year, I really thought he didn't need to behave this way with me. I thought he trust me completely. I thought he has forgiven me for the things I did in the past. But I was wrong. He hasn't changed. Its the opposite, he has been keeping a lot more. He just let me believe there was nothing. My anger was getting out of hand. I recalled Siera methods to cope and pushed it down. I usually do this only when I am in an argument or fighting. But I couldn't take it. I slowly push away the distracting thoughts, centering my senses.

The half hearted smile was not needed anymore. I could tell David saw my attitude changing. I say, I am done. I don't want to talk to you. I basically told him to freak off. I don't care about his match anymore. Whether he wins or not, is not going to change anything for me. He will always be like this. He didn't even try to stop me from leaving. Actually, I was grateful for that. He is nothing but efficient, sparing us both any further pain. I didn't even once looked back to him.

With a stoic expression I approached the small shed where we setup our surveillance equipment's and satellite link. Inside few officers were talking over the phone and monitoring the situation. I found Ruther seating in front of a monitor that showed a satellite view, everything all right with the Citradel boats. Everything on schedule. Ruther looks at me strange, like something was weird on my face. I was making painful attempts to hide my emotions. He says, ah. Yeah. They just crossed the international borders. I nod satisfied. I take a seat beside him and watch the monitors that showed 7 boats crossing a border line.

Ruther asks, you don't need to keep watch here. We got it covered. I reply, I don't have anything else for now. I spoke to other officers to begin removing the barricades and get back to their posts. I will keep an eye on these boats, in case of any emergencies. Ruthers asks hesitantly, okay. You are the boss. He takes the side beside me. I whisper to him, let me know if there is any issue with the words or number on the screen. I don't want to guess if anything goes wrong. Ruthers nods in agreement, I got you.

We stare at the 3 monitors in silence. Others were talking and coordinating resuming the security of the island. I wasn't listening to them. I wasn't listening to anything. I didn't want my emotions to waver even a little. Otherwise I might either shout in anger or cry. That's what I am feeling right now. After a while, I heard a voice I couldn't ignore. Deni says, hey guys. Davids on the TV. Others gather around her enthusiastically. I remained motionless. In the corner of my eye I saw Ruther tilting his head towards the screen.

He asks, you don't want to check it out. I wave him off, I don't. Besides, why don't you all see him in person. You all should just go and watch yourselves. He is just 200 meters away. Somers, who came in a while ago, says, Luther told us not to interfere. Otherwise we would have gone. Deni says, besides, this is much better. With all the people shouting, you wouldn't hear much anyways. She wasn't wrong about the crowd going wild. David's presence lit an even more fire after Marina and Blakes interview.

I, on the other hand, didn't want to hear his voice. A voice filled with deception and lies. I wanted to leave, but where would I even go. Right now, the entire Medrone community is watching this. Even the Citradel people on the boats are getting this. Wherever I go, his voice will be looming. Reminding me that I am untrustworthy by him. I try to tune out the discussion. But it was so hard to be composed. I kept forcing my thoughts not to listen to his laughter. The nerve of the guy to behave like thing happened just now. He was so casual in his answers, like he wasn't bothered a bit about Charles overdrive.

My fist tighten when he evasively skipped over any details of how dangerous the match was in reality. Is no one going to talk about it. Neither Charles or him said even a word about it. They both are crazy to conveniently leave it out. Then came a I expected the least. I couldn't keep myself in check now, I rotate the chair and view the screen. David was sitting in the middle of a platform in front of 4 reports with their back to us. David became silent for several seconds.

Everyone here were confused but this. Ruthers asks, hey. Any idea why David became so quite. I didn't offer any explanation. In fact, I was going to see what lies he would spew to get of this. People were slowly becoming nervous about his odd behavior. Then he finally spoke, bringing back his usual attitude. The answer was carefully crafted. In fact, I don't he lied about anything. Just that he never mentioned about knowing Wagner. Other perceived his behavior like he was caught off guard. But I knew something more was going on. He was rushing things, being more egotistical to a point I wonder if he is faking it. But people were eating it all up. The officers here cheered him as he left his chair.

Deni says smiling, damn that confidence. I got say, that's hot. Seriously, what was she even thinking. Is she talking about the same guy here. Somers says, calm down women. He is just getting cocky knowing he gets to be stronger than the crown. I couldn't listen to them, guys. If it all the same to you, get back to work. The interview is over. I took a strict stance here. Others gave a confused look, nonetheless, complied. Everyone got back to their work. Ruther who was also enjoying the show went back to his work mode with me and asks, hey, about your brother. Did you know.

I cut him off, did I know he fought Charles. No. I didn't. Didn't you hear David. He nods tensed, yeah. But. Its just a little crazy. Wagner knew about Heraknus existence and never told anyone. Don't you think that's very strange. I gave a disgruntled look. He immediately backed off whatever else he was going to ask of me. I turned back to stare at the boats. There was nothing new, just the boat crossing on endless water. Ruther didn't spoke to me after that. He got the hint I gave him, loud and clear that I was done talking about it.

Things went monotonously then. I kept up ignoring the issue with David and instead just went through the work. After an hour, the Citradel boats had gone beyond our surveillance. From now on, we will only be communicating through the network sporadically. We begin wrapping up our stuff from the pier. Everyone got a message from Blake that there will a long meeting today at 12:00 and we should all get an early lunch. His message mentioned meetings and plans for city expansion. Everyone knew that this was coming. Since last night, we knew today was going to be full of discussion. Now that the officials have left, we need set aside the tournament stuff for a while and focus on the city.

We had an hour and half till we meet. Ruther and others offered me to join them to grab something to eat. I declined saying I wasn't hungry. I know I should eat properly. But I didn't want to relax. Because then I think about David. So instead I choose to go the officers building alone. After talking to few officers, I left. I had some time to kill, so I looked for Siera. She must have stayed behind. But I couldn't find her. She must have left for the school already. She said the morning was off due this, but I guess she already left.

I wished she was here to talk. She doesn't judge me or lies to me when I speak my mind. But then I chided myself. Didn't I just talk to her yesterday. I can't keep running back to her, whenever things doesn't go my way. I need to show her that I can take care of my feelings all on my own. When those thoughts in mind, I took the trolley ride to the officers building. There were hardly any people riding it now. Most people already left the shore and must be back into their normal day routine.

In another 15 minutes I arrived at the officer building. I saw few people also here, maybe they too wanted to have a jump start on things. I was thinking where to go. Maybe my office, but then being alone would make me go crazy a little. I already experienced it yesterday. That neither helped nor was it productive. So instead I walked to the 4th floor to the big conference room. I hoped someone would be here like me. I didn't know if anyone would be here an hour early, but I heard few hustling noises coming from inside.

When the door opened as I walk closer, the voices becomes clear. They were a group of officers already inside. I recognize most of them. They were the regular administration department. People had hurdled together and discussing various topics. I didn't have to listen to close to know what it was. They were commenting about David's interview. I wanted to talk to people, but not about him. So I took a seat at the far end from the stage. I put my tablet on the desk and started the message board over the network.

There wasn't anything new here. Blake said this was going to be a long discussion, so I am guessing everyone went to eat before spending hours here. After passing some time I heard familiar voices from the door, Matt and Cassandra. Cass says, see. I told you there will people here. Matt sighs, you were right. I just didn't want to be here so early. Can't we just get that parfait before it begins. Cass says, you saw the line. Its going to be a long one. I don't to be late again and make a scene. You know people expect us to be here always. Matt rebukes, I say this again, just because we know those the top ranking officers, it doesn't mean they expect too much from us.

Seems that's been going on for a while. Matt then notices me sitting alone, Vanessa, so you got here early too. They begin walking towards me. Cass makes a big smile, see. Like minds. Best to take this seriously. I didn't want to correct her with my actual reasoning. The tournament is over, we can't flaunt our broken ass ranking anymore. I smile at that, don't worry. No one is saying that.

Matt clicks her tongue, you think that, but that's also bad. Last week, we made loads of impression. But since the semis, and now the Heraknus reveal. All that fame is gone up in smoke. I was happy and enjoying for all of us yesterday, but after a while it becomes apparent we need to step up our game. We need to get stronger. Otherwise we become irrelevant.

Its probably not just him who is feeling this. After the final match and celebration from yesterday, people will gradually become inspired to get stronger. Cass scoffs, yeah. We get it. You don't need to remind me of that. You were at least were in top 1000. I lost even before the capture flag round. Matt smirks, that's just dumb luck. We both got beat by Citradel people in the end. They both take seats around me. Matt asks, back me up here Vanessa. How much do you think we have a chance of getting promoted.

I laugh at the nice change of scenery. I didn't have to worry about the problems I had with them. I answer, you really want me to be honest. I don't think he wanted me to be this honest. His eyes widen and then says, see Cass. Even she doesn't want to say it. Cass snorts, yeah well. Did you honestly think she say it outright. We both are at the low end of the raking in our group. Just accept it and don't keep whining about it. Her eyes were lighting up with her Kuret.

Matt and I got anxious over Cass's alter ego taking over. So Matt diffused the situation, okay. Calm down. We will talk about it later. Don't lose control here. That relaxed Cass before she used her Kuret. I offered my opinion, look. I may not be the best person to look for advice, given my history. But don't get discouraged. The tournament was just the beginning. Once everything settles down with Citradel and everyone moving here, you both will have chances to train now.

Matt sighs, we know. Its just everyone keeps looking at us with such expectation. With people also gather and stay for a long time, they begin to realize how odd our presence is. He looks around us to check if no one was listening in. He whispers, truth be told. I have been a little tensed about it since yesterday's match. That's why I offered to party at Blakes place. I wanted to feel how we used to be. Just us. Or well, at least us doing our own thing. But now, we got so many responsibilities. Stuff we never had to care about. And I know it's a good thing, but I miss it.

I could tell he had been wrestling with this for a while. I recalled he was hesitant to jump into the stadium yesterday. He was acting brave, offering to help out. But he was feeling the pressure. I understood his view, I felt it too. David becoming so strong and Charles being so strong, it changed my view about myself a lot. Cass comforts him by placing her hand on his, you aren't alone you know. Just because I don't say it much, doesn't mean I don't feel it too. Imagine me, who has known David on Earth the longest, being compared to. Just thinking how far he has gone, its slowly gnawing at me too.

It was weird that she felt exactly like me about it. She knew him longer than me on Earth, and had to see him rise up so far, to become on same levels as omegas, and now overdrive users. She must have her own insecurities she doesn't show us. Matt nods somberly knowing he isn't alone. Its not their fault though. It be friends with us, makes it difficult to be in a proper society now. I didn't have any other way to encourage them. Especially, when I feel the same as them.

Matt shakes his head, ah, leave this depressing topic. Lets talk about you Vanessa. He turns away their attention to me. He asks, did you really not know about Wagner and Heraknus. We didn't get to ask that yesterday. Cass asks, or why they fought. I wished it was about something else. But I should have known it will come up more often now. Thankfully, after spending some time away from others, I had calmed down enough to talk about it. I say, yeah, I have no clue. My brother wasn't going to tell me something that even royals were secretive about. You remember what Charles said, very select group of people know about him. So I figure he was made to keep quite too. My lips were going to be sealed about the slander against him. I still get angered thinking about it sometimes.

Matt chuckles, yeah. That's probably it. But man, that was surprise. Even David chocked up a little when asked. How did that guy from Citradel found about it. Cass says, who else. Kafar's the only one who would do something like this. I agreed with her. Matt remains unconvinced, I thought too. But it doesn't make sense. I heard him talking to the reporters before leaving, he almost given up trying to convince Charles or try anything to break the deal. He was more looking forward to joining us now. He mentioned it multiple times he was a little disappointed that Charles gave up such a way. But how he looking forward to live here now. I can't think of a reason why he would try to leak something like this. What would he even gain by doing it. Heraknus already decided to move here.

His suspicion made me reexamine Kafar's motives. Its true he doesn't have any other moves left. But I can't believe his last provocation to me was just a vain attempt to rile me up. Cass says, who cares. If not him, someone from Citradel did. No one here would benefit from leaking it. The morale would go down here. David save it being so recklessly overconfident. I mean, did you saw him getting so fired up. Only he wouldn't be cornered by this. Matt smirks, I know. Me and Vanessa has seen this side of him before anyone.

He was referring to the time we caught him after the barrier broke. I got curious about something, did you get a chance to talk to him. Cass sighs, no. I wanted to, but after the interview, I was told he already left. Matt says annoyed, only we both didn't get to meet him. That's not fair you know. I was surprised he crashed the party, but then again he likes to do this sort of thing. He didn't even explain to us about his secret house. Always being mysterious and stuff. He makes an gesture with his hands in air to show spookiness. Cass says, I asked Tessa. She said he went back to his home.

I just wanted to know he spoke about me to anyone. That's the only reason I even cared to bring it up. Blake might be only person he probably talk to later. But that's the extent of my curiosity. I wasn't going to ask him now. Matt asks, do you mean the secret one or his usual home. Cass chuckles, she said he went to section 2. I guess, If he goes missing again, people will become more agitated and concerned. I could have revealed about why he kept his house a secret. But I want to stay clear of David.

I had other things in my mind. I wasn't going to talk to anyone about it. But right now its just us. And these two can help me out in ways Siera can't. I hesitantly switch the topic, guys, I have something I want to ask the both of you. Its a kind of personal, so I appreciate it if you keep this between us. That got their attention. The two of them eye me waiting. I nervously blurted, do you guys ever fight. That bamboozled them with a blank stare for few seconds. Cass finally breaks the silence with a whisper, is this about you and Ned. I didn't want to say that, but what other excuse I could make here. I already embarrassed myself by asking this, might as well go through with it. I slowly nod. Matt asks, you guys are still arguing. I thought for sure it was just a disagreement.

I was too flustered to comment on this, I just want to know how to fix it. I thought I get some tips from you two. You two don't argue a lot, so you must be good enough to avoid any fights. Matt scoffs, don't get fooled. We fight over everything. Just a week ago, I got two different kinds of tart, because Cass and Mel like different ones. I thought it was the right gesture. You know, an thoughtful boyfriend. But hell nah. Cass got angry why I thought it was okay to bring one for Mel. Then I had to physically fight Mel when I told why I got for Cass. Can you imagine we fought for such a ridiculous reason. She didn't talk to me for that whole day. I still don't understand what I did wrong.

Cass flinched away from Matt, are you still hung up on that. You know why I am mad. Matt yells quietly, no I don't. I don't give me that crap about not being considerate of your feelings. I did that because of it. They both glare at each other. I can't tell if this was normal for them, or are they projecting out because I am here. Cass sighs, whatever. It isn't about us. Matt snorts, yeah fine. But we will circle back to it. He turns to me, Vanessa, is it about the bet in the VIP room. I nod in response.

Cass asks, did you guys not talk later. Its painfully humiliating to talk about this. I never had to deal with this, probably because I wasn't in a proper relationship before. I meekly reply, no. He has had ignoring me several times yesterday, so I got so mad that I didn't want to speak to him. He did try to talk before I left the stadium, but I was too angry with him then. Somewhere back in mind I know he tried again by texting Siera. But I was furious at him to mention that indirect attempt. Matt asks, so, you two didn't spoke not today too. I shook my head, I noticed the admins are busy. So I assumed he was too. Probably why he didn't even bother to show up at the pier this morning.

They both look to each other for a moment, then to me. Cass asks, you do know that you won't get anywhere without talking. I answer, I know that. But every time I think of talking, I get angry. Its not just that he didn't back me, he got angry at me. You heard him. He is usually keeps a pleasant demeanor. That's what I like about him. But he got mad just because I wouldn't take his side. That's preposterous. Cass says, look, because we were there, I know what happened. But didn't you also expect the same from him. You wanted his unconditional agreement. So I believe you both are arguing about not taking each others side. Right.

I say, no. He should have taken my side. We supported for David, so he should agree with me. But he got mad at me for choosing something I thought was completely idiotic. In my exasperation, I said out the stuff I wasn't thinking too deeply. They both quietly stare at me. The realization hit me immediately once I understood what I just said. This is the first time I said it out aloud. My anger dissipated suddenly by a somber thoughts. Matt says, don't you think that's a little bit unfair. To Ned I mean. I told us why he thought David was going to lose, right. I mean, I wasn't happy with his explanation, but was just harmless bet.

My thoughts became dismayed wondering what I just said. Was I really so arrogant, wanting him to agree with me always. Regardless of the issue. Cass adds, yeah. I think that's a little harsh. I'll admit, Ned might have been a little out of line. He told why he chose Charles, because of those stats. I didn't like that too. Still, he explained his reasons. Not like it was any intent to discourage or persuade you. I don't think your boyfriend has to agree with you all the time. Like Matt said, it was just a bet to pass the time.

I can't believe I never thought of this. They were making sense. I have been judging him too harshly. Siera also said similar things, he doesn't do things without good reason. Was I really hung up due to this. Matt says, cut the guy some slack, will you. He was a little dramatic, but that shouldn't lead to you not talking for so long. Cass agreed, yeah. Just talk to him. Tell him what you really felt, let him apologies to you and be done with this. Matt scoffs, hold on. Why should he be apologizing. Obviously Vanessa should do it first. Cass snaps at him, ah. No. Ned was too angry when he talked to Vanessa like that. Its obviously his fault. The boyfriend should apologies always.

Matt gets annoyed, says who. If the girlfriend is being unreasonable, she should do it. Cass leans forward, she isn't being unreasonable. The guy didn't understand how she felt. Matt says, how in the hell is going to understand that. He just did what felt right. That's what we always try to do. Cass got infuriated, is this still about that stupid tart. Matt says, tarts, as in two. And its not stupid. It was a nice gesture. She didn't believe that, oh you still think that, don't you. Listen here you.

I zoned out from their conversation. Honestly, I don't think they even realize I asked for their help anymore. They kept arguing about things I wasn't paying attention to anymore. There is obviously still tension about that between them. But then I started to wonder about my feelings. How could I not see this. I was so engrossed with blaming him, I didn't realize I was being unreasonable too. Like Cass said, he was way more angry than me at the moment, but I made it him that way by being unreasonable myself. Uh, god. How can we both mess this up so badly. Is this why he doesn't talk to me. No, its not just about talking. He ignores me.

I think I understand I was in the wrong too. But his attitude on how he handled was heavy handed. Getting mad and then giving me the cold shoulder. Thanks to talking to both of them, I got somewhere. Then I got depressed realizing that something so simple I couldn't see before. All because I couldn't talk to Siera like this before. It really is best to talk to friends about this. I thought I thank them, but they were still arguing. So instead I mentally thanked them.

After few minutes people began to pour into the conference room. After getting some gaze from others, Matt and Cass finally stop arguing. They settle down in their seats with angry silence. I couldn't tell who conceded, or if it was even resolved. A moment later Cass whispers to me, sorry you had to witness that. We kind of got distracted. I smile, its fine. Now I see why Matt said not to get fooled. I was fooled, I thought you both had a steady relationship. She get a little offended, we do. We just know how to navigate it better. Trust me, in the beginning it was worse. David used to help out back then, like mediating for my sake. But he also soon gave up. She chuckles remembering something.

She then says, besides, its probably your first fight. I don't know about others, but I think its always about something silly. I felt a little better hearing that. Because I was mentally kicking myself for not seeing it. She continuous, a tip though. If things gets messy for whatever reason, its not about that. Its about something else. Trust me on that. I was angry about many things at Matt, that was actually towards Mel. So who knows, it might be good to talk about that too with Ned.

This advice turned me upside down. I was just accepting the fact that I was being too judgmental. Now I got to figure out if it had any other reasons. Ah, this is so infuriating. Cass read my expression, you got angry about something, didn't you. Well, before you use it against Ned, just talk to him. Be honest when talking to him, like you did with us. And then, if there is still a need, get angry at him. Do whatever you need to just get it out of your system. I know its not that simple, but its what helps. Don't keep it in for long, otherwise things will spiral of out of control.

She was right. Rationally, that was the right thing to do. But I couldn't do it. Not yet. I nod, thanks Cass. And thank Matt too. I should have talked to someone sooner. She says, don't worry. That kind of thing happens. If you want, you can talk to me whenever you want. She was being generous. I might take up her on that offer. Maybe I ask about David as well. Would she know why David doesn't think I should know about Wagner or why he still doesn't trust me. No, I should stop now. I already shamed myself by asking their help on Ned. I can't ask for more.

I gazed around the room to distract myself. Its half full now. Even though we have over 30 minutes left, people came in early. I guess everyone is anxious to get started. Ruthers, Deni and Somers come in. They notice me and waved siting beside us. Ruther says, hey. Did you have anything to eat, or did you just came over here. He greets Matt and Cass sitting in the front. I sigh, I wasn't hungry. I thought to get some work done here. That wasn't a complete lie, but I am not going to explain the real reason to him. He doesn't dig further, okay. Since you are here, I wanted to give you some reports.

We discussed some minor details about the securities of Citradel guest houses. Without the officials there now, we could lower the number of people assigned. Went over the assigned groups and their shifts. We talked just long enough to hit 12:00. During that time, the seats began filling. Nathan and Jess came in next. Then 10 minutes before, Tessa and Catherine. Then I caught a person coming alone. It was Ned. As we he walked, our gaze met. I thought I should approach him.

What about the meeting. Theres is no time. But he wasn't fazed even a little. The same cold look he gave me yesterday was on him. I thought he would be at least cordial since the last time we talked, he wanted to try talking. But he remained silent, no expression, no gestures. Just an empty stare. Then he walks to the literal opposite side of the room and takes a seat, like it was nothing.

This pissed me off. Screw him. I had thought of asking him to meet later. I was even going to make amends for my part. But he was being cold again. What the hell is wrong with him. He doesn't even want to sit with me. Did he gave up. Does he want me to go begging to him. No, that’s not happening. You and David should just freak off. I didn't want to get angry here, with everyone around me. But I was too distracted. But I can't leave either, that would be just rude. What if someone notices that I left because of him. No, I am not going to him that satisfaction. So I controlled the anger in me and pushed it way down.

5 minutes before Blake, Luther and Marina in tow crossed the doors. With him entering, people stopped their discussion. Luther takes his usual seat near the edge of the podium, managing the conference rooms systems. Marina sits in the front between few officers. They shook hands her congratulating on becoming the latest citizen. Blake takes the center stage after talking for a while with Luther. The room dims and lights focus on Blake. The room system boots up and turns on the mini lights around us. The 3D wire systems turns on with our logo in levitating in the middle of the room. Blake walks in front of it and says, is this everyone. Luther says, I count all 84 are here. Blake nods and faces us.

He says, thanks everyone for waiting. I am sure you know what discussion we need to have today. Its the first day in a soon long days to come. And I not understating it when I say, it’s a beginning of a new era.

Blake (Chapter 62)

Thursday, October 9, 2025 21:51

After leaving David, I had messaged everyone about the meeting. I am worried about David, but there's very little help I can offer him. So instead, I should focus on what I can do. I didn't want to waste any time getting to work. Me, Marina and Luther went to grab some bite from the dining building. Its too early to have lunch, but they had few snacks still left from morning. Usually they don't serve people at this time, but I got a pass. Plus I think the crew understood how busy I was.

Marina was still a little nervous about leaving David alone. She tried to broach the subject few more times, but with Luther around she didn't get far. I understood it was hard not to think about it. But I didn't want her to dwell on it for long. So instead I distracted her by asking what her demands are. Instantly she perks up, really. You will listen to it now. I sigh, yeah, of course. I just didn't want you to talk anyone before me. Her somber expression turn bright and excited.

Luther interjects, just don't ask too much. I know you are very important, but it would show very bad precedent. She nods frantically, yeah I know that. I am not that unreasonable. We both laugh at that. She asks, what. That’s true. Luther says, if that were really true, you would have waited to get our own badge before putting on that uniform. I appreciate your initiative, but you could have waited a day at least. She shook her head, that was an impromptu move. I got excited. Didn't want to waste the opportunity and rub it on Kafar. Or even Melinda.

Luther gives me a curious look, don't ask. Its a long story. Luther heard Marina talking to Melinda on the boat, but he probably didn't understood everything. I say, we will get it issued soon. I already left a message to Tina. You will get it tonight or tomorrow. After you are sworn in as our new citizen. She smiles with stuffing a sandwich in her mouth, nice. She chews fast and says, okay. So here's what I need. I already selected a place in section 1. Near the river. The same line your house is in.

I figured she would want that area. After thinking about it I say, okay. I will have to ask to see if anyone contends to it, or if anyone already claimed it. She says, don't worry about that. No one would have picked it. The ground around the place isn't level. So I bet with what you have already have around the area, it would be difficult to go digging, leveling the foundation and build a house. Luther asks, but you don't have a problem. She says, nope. With the designs I have, and the help we are going from Citradel, those ground inconsistencies are easy to rectify.

I say, that’s all well and good. But we will still ask, just in case. Luther says, even if someone did issue an order to occupy it, I am sure they will back off once they see Marina on the list. Marina smiles gleefully. I scoff, don't encourage her please. I know she may look impressive, but you will soon realize how impulsive she is. Marina tried to say something, but stops herself realizing I was telling the truth. Luther smiles, probably already realizing that too. I ask, what else. She says, I will need a office room in your building. I don't mind getting any floor there. But it would be good if it was on 3rd floor.

It was becoming a trend of her to basically leach of anywhere I work or stay. Its not bad though, being closer meant we could work better. Even if its for our shadow activities. I nod, there is an south wing we planed to open. You can pick a room there. She replies, north wing. That one opens to the city view. I am an architect you know. Need inspiration and work space. She wasn't being unreasonable, so I let it slide. She says, oh, who should I talk to get some home appliances. The ones I have are all Medrone tech based and they don't run properly without consistent kuretines. I think its best to have a backup of your Earth influenced techs.

Luther says, I will share you the contact of team that handles it. Prepare a list of things you want and I will setup a meeting with them. I ask, if there is something very specific, you go to David. He handles all the unique and experimental stuff. She becomes a little nervous when I mentioned him, yeah, I do have some specific things. But he is busy right now, so I will just stick with some basic stuff. We both were worried about David's current state. He probably won't be able to take any new work for a while.

Marina shakes off the quite tone, and finally I want to be enlisted as the high ranking officer. Luther and I already knew that she was going to join us directly at that level. I say, don't worry about it. We already discussed and agreed its best you, Derek, June and the alpha twins join as high ranking officers. They may have not yet officially been matriculated in our city, but when they do, the role is theirs. Marina says a little shocked, wow. I thought there will be some pushbacks, making Citradel people high ranking officers immediately.

Luther scoffs, who said immediately. We agreed those people are best suited to the high roles. But not straight away. To make your and our transition smother, there will be adjustment period. You know, sort of like an intern learning the ropes. You will have conditional authorities. You can make the decisions, but someone else will supervise you and have the final say. Its unreasonable to ask you all to immediately do your jobs here, which is a lot different than Citradel.

Marina takes that in for a moment. She then says, yeah, that makes sense. Then, who is going to be my training supervisor. I answer, that burden falls to me. I would have preferred David to do it, since he also knows you well, but he is occupied right now. Maybe he will take over me later. But for the time being, you and me work together for a while. She nods, sounds good. Then she smiles, boss. I liked the sound of that, but I know she was just teasing. I ask, anything else. She thinks for a long time before saying, I am good. These were my immediate concerns.

I nod, I am sure there will be more. She didn't deny that. After that discussion, me and Luther spent some time discussing about the topics we want to highlight today. After an hour and half we decided to leave for the meeting. Along the way, people were congratulating Marina. She was basking in all this glory. She isn't the only one from Citradel who will move in, but she is the first one. And she knows this, enjoying peoples praises while it lasts.

With 5 minutes to go, we arrived at the conference room. Everyone were here now. I clocked all the essential personals aura. I wanted to check on Catherine and Vanessa. But I can't do it now. So I decided to wait out the meeting first. After Luther setup the rooms system. We got down to business as I take the center stage, first order of business. Give an applaud for Marina, our latest citizen and officer from Citradel. Everyone cheers and claps excited.

Marina got up on her seat, smiling and waving around, thanks everyone. Its finally good to be here, with you all finally. After she settles back down I say, I know everyone is delighted to have her here. In fact everyone in the island is. However, don't forget this is just the start. So we will immediately starting our integration process. There are other candidates for the same job as Marina, so like we discussed, there will be temporary supervisors. Right now, I am going work with Marina. Once other Citradel people join, we will decide who gets them.

People were quite, but I am sure they were wondering who will be picked along with me. I wasn't going to share that right now. So I moved to next topic, lets now talk about the big changes. I think all of us know to some degree what's going to happen. But let me be clear to everyone. I signal to Luther, he changes the 3D hologram to shape of Charles and 9 other Heraknus. I waited for the rendering to complete and say, you know Charles. But we have now confirmed other Heraknus. I point to the holograms, 7 of them, we don't know much about them. No, actually, we don't know anything about them. But these two, I point to Rory and Tory, are his kids.

Some of you saw them this morning, others didn't realize who they are. And apart from this two, Charles has 3 other kids back in Citradel. And other 62 or so Heraknus. Take a note of them, they will be coming here soon. And we don’t want to give them even a single reason of doubt or problem when they arrive. They are vital to get all of Citradel and other communities here. Everyone's been asking if Heraknus coming here also means everyone else are also coming or not. The answer is not that simple.

I let a pause so that it sinks in everyone. Then say, personally, I am 99% sure they would follow. That elicit a range of whispers among the people. I continued, some have talked to the officials. I talked to almost all the officials. They may say they will wait until the next match with David and Charles. Or may show doubt. But I believe its inevitable. Soon enough they are going to realize that deal was the best thing happening to us. The Heraknus alpha was supposed to their undefeated champion. But they couldn't have imagined David's resilience. The alpha even admitted himself. So yeah, with the trust they kept on Heraknus for this long, I don't doubt they will move here. Its just a matter of time.

I see people nodding in agreement. Some were still not sure. Their auras show doubt. But that’s okay. Its to be expected. I continue, I don't want you all to celebrate achieving our goals just yet. Because here comes the crucial part. We had made plans to bring people in course of 4 to 6 months, but not in a month. I can't say for sure if Citradel will send other people or bloodlines by then. But at least some will. So we need to expedite the expansion plan we had. Its not going to be easy. But it is necessary and we have to do it.

I signal Luther to step in now. He walks up beside me and says, take a look here. He pulls out a remote and changes the hologram. The scene changes to the birds eye view of the island. The island was shaded in 3 colors. He say pointing the green one, this where the habitable zone is. We occupy around 30% of it. He then points to orange parts, these are the agricultural lands, water and air treatment with kuretines and other essential factories. Only 15 % operational of this is operational. And finally, he points to the red parts, these are all forest around the edges of the island. We have only developed 2% of this. Considering most of the security lies here, its still manual. We want to make it automated with our tech.

With that explained, Luther leaves and goes back to his chair. I take over, its not realistically possible to develop all these colored regions within a month or so. But we have to make progress in all areas. However, we will focus on each of them differently. We will prioritizing the green zone where we can live. I say about 70 % of our efforts should be on that. Then we will focus on expanding our orange zone, I say roughly 25% and the rest efforts on the red zone.

At that point, someone asked me, shouldn't our efforts be on the red zone be more. More people coming in means we need to increase our defenses. I nodded the guys, that is true. I like to double down here too. But there are two reasons, we can't. Our defense system is not yet operational. We have the tech, but its slow going. If we want it to develop faster, we need new assets. Not just the science and tech, but people too. Citradel is full of more scientists. They joining us will make our progress fast.

After learning about Melinda, I am sure many people we don't even know are going to pop out from Citradel. Some of them should have the means to accelerate our defenses. I wasn't sure about it yet, so that part I kept to myself. I continue, second reason. Right now, the Echo invasion on Earth is in a little bit of scattered. They lost their commander. Either they are waiting for backup, or hiding or both. But in any case, their activity is low if not none. Even Citradel agrees. This was why the tournament was possible in the first place. So what it means is that we have a breathing room. We can hunker down, get ourselves sorted out first before worrying about Echo.

A women asks, that could change any moment. They might arrive before we can detect them. Luther answers this one, if something like that happens, the problem we will face is the same for all others. If we were the ones moving to Citradel, they would also take time to expand their defenses. Just like us. So there's no real solution to that problem, we just have to believe if that happens, we face it together. I nod, exactly. Look, the threat is always there. There is no doubt about it. But its also true for almost a year, we hadn't fought Echos in the scale as the war we just did. The reality is that they are not as active they used to. Is it risk to assume that, yes. But we will take it anyways, because this opportunity is important too.

That may not ease the doubts of everyone, but at least no one asked further about it. I say, instead of worrying about it, lets focus on developing our city. So I was saying before about focusing our efforts, we will prioritize our living zones first. Now, a month time is not enough. But we will start just for Heraknus. Until Citradel tell us, we are confirming only they are coming. So I want them to have a place to live, regardless if any one else comes along and don't have a place.

I clear my throat, now, its just my opinion, but I talked to Charles family and they might want to live in the mountains of section 4. Now, that's not really confirmed. It was just a causal talk. But lets start there. We got Marina now, as you know, she isn't just a warrior, she is an architect. So Citradel sent her to help us fast track the development. In coming days, Citradel will contact us and give us more resources. I heard from a official that they might send a crew to us soon. Once they arrive, we can immediately get down to construction and revamping our infrastructure.

Luther says, simultaneously, we will develop other areas in preparation of other arrivals. But that is a secondary goal, so we will not work on it until we complete Heraknus houses or bloodlines from Citradel come here. I add on, so we are going to split into 3 groups of development team. One focusing on Heraknus housing and one working on the secondary goal. The last team will be working on the revamping of the existing city infrastructure. Before the start of the tournament, Citradel had shared their plans to improve the society. The last team will start working on it immediately. Luther says, we will assign the team soon. But if anyone wants to put up their names, you let me know.

After a few seconds of pause I continue, moving on to the orange and red zones. Like I told earlier, they are not going to be our top priority. We will start working on them after 3 weeks. Once we build up enough of the city's habitable zone, we will expand our manufacturing industry. This team will work on preparing, analysis and procuring assets or resources until then. We may not have any meaningful changes in our defenses. One guy says, not that it matters. With two overdrive users and bunch of omegas here now, we can secure the additional people arriving.

That cheered up many people. Marina laughs too on that comment. I couldn't stop one myself. Luther says, he has a point. Back in Medrine, an existence of an overdrive user is like having a personal army for your country. Hardly there was ever a time in our history where two existed in same country at the same time. And don't forget Charles is coming too. He may not be able to use his overdrive, but his other bloodline members are powerful enough to keep Echo away for a decade. So we decided not to focus on our defenses just yet. And I am sure Citradel will agree with us too.

That encouraged few people here and probably helped understand our reasons. This must be enough to convince others of this course of plan. I continue, after we conclude this meeting, we will immediate start our preparation. Before the end of day, I want teams assigned, ideas outlined and plans listed. We will take suggestions from anyone to advance our goals. I expect it will be a challenge, but it is necessary. Many people nod after hearing my resolve.

I clear my throat, now. There is one last thing I want to discuss. We have talked about Heraknus, Citradel and our city development. But there is one more thing we have to be aware of. Its about the match between David and Charles. Few people get a bit excited to hear about this. I wasn't sharing the same enthusiasm. Because no one knows the true dangers of this. And unfortunately, I can't reveal it to them too. I explain, after talking to the admins a while ago, we concluded that we are not going to treat as part of the tournament. The actual tournament is over with David as the winner. That is undeniable, no matter how much Citradel spin it.

The suspense fills the air in the room, from now on, whoever we talk to, we say we won the tournament when Charles gave up. There will be fight. Now, while Citradel considers David to be a technical winner, its just what they claim. However, I never agreed to it. Did I. For us, David is the true winner. People shout in agreement. I add, The admins have changed the second half of the final match to an exhibition fight. Making it separate from the actual tournament. Reinhart didn't have the entire details when he made the announcement yesterday. But after spending the whole day with Citradel, he understands it better now.

Luther adds, the rally we formed yesterday pushed Citradel to make a decision, but it also pressured admins to not hear our side of it. And after spending the morning discussing, they come to proper resolution. A women asks, won't that just contradict what Citradel said. I answer, a little bit, yeah. That's why admins won't be making that announcement to people until Citradel agrees to it. Honestly, I wanted to tell the reporters this too, but they never asked me about it and I didn't bring it up. I am telling about it now, because it doesn't matter if Citradel argue over it or not. The fact is Heraknus are moving here. They have already lost the tournament. The exhibition match is now really just about David and Charles. That's the undeniable reality.

Luther says, even if David loses, it doesn't change anything. The course we are on remains the same. This deal between the two of them, has effectively ended the tournaments goal to decide which city will be moving where. So there's no point in calling it a tournament match. I say, and this is what I want everyone to say to others once admin announces it. Whether is to other communities, our people or even if they are Citradel citizens. We want to bolster the idea that David already won, and this is just an exhibition match now. There are some things Charles didn't tell anyone yet. So I personally know its more than just a simple fight. I want Charles to explain them once he arrives here.

People began whispering amongst them. I won't share the actual danger to other people not just David. That I leave it to Charles handle it. I say, take some time, think over this and what we talked before. If anyone has question or doubts about this, I'll hear it after the meeting. Does everyone understand this. I didn't see any aura showing any big confusion. So I guess that its time to end it. I say, all right. That's all we had to say. We are get down to work immediately. We will take a break around 4:00 to 4:45, and work until we finalize the points I highlighted earlier. All right, thanks everyone.

I got off the stage while the 3d wire hologram turns off and lights turn on. Luther gets up from his chair, that went well. Not many had issues with this. I answer, yeah. I look towards the officers exiting the conference room. I saw Catherine and Vanessa leaving too. Dang it, I missed talking to them again. I sigh a little. Well, I can't be hypocritical here when I just told everyone we will have busy days ahead. Luther goes to talk to Marina. He got someone to show her the north wing.

I went to my office downstairs and began working on the team goals and requirements. Once Luther and Tina came by to my office, we talked on forming several team options. We had a challenge to make sure we don't make teams bigger than we need. Or making the team too small for the secondary projects. We then began planning the targets and deadlines. Hours flew by on the clock like seconds the more we talked. Around 3:30 PM, Marina dropped by my office. Luther and Tina were typing up the teams on the board at the end, so I signaled her to take the couch on the opposite side. I heard she went to my place to get some stuff after taking a look around the building.

Marina and me sat down. She asks, busy work huh. I scoff, don't worry. From tomorrow, you will be too. She laughs nervously, yeah. I gather. Since the tournament, this building hadn't been buzzing with so many people. But today I got to see everyone working. I knew you guys were working here, but seeing it with my own eyes is different. Decisions are made by high ranked people and others follow. Everything goes fast, but no larger discussion like we have to ensure everything is smooth. You know, make sure no unintended consequences happen. Its almost like you are a company workers.

I laugh at that, you are not that far off. Unlike Citradel, we don't have experience in proper policy making of a actual city council. So we make it work the way can for now. All that changes when Citradel comes on. We will finally have a proper civil infrastructure. She nods in agreement, that it will. I am sure it will be changes and hopefully for the better. I say, yeah. So, you got your office setup. She nods, not completely. Just enough to get started. I wanted to make sure no one takes it, so I added my name to the wall outside. I laugh, of course you did. You had prepared for that too already.

She chuckles, anyways. I know you are busy, so I won't take too much of your time. I do have one thing to pass on. She pulls out her phone and hands it to me. The screen was displaying some list of items. I read them aloud, concrete, crushed stone, slag,, alloys - iron, nickel, aluminum, Fiber - Reinforced Polymers, Hempcrete, Geosynthetics. Is this what I think it is. There were more things written after I scroll down. Each item had the amount needed to next of them.

She answers, yeah. Its the list of things I know we need immediately to get started with Heraknus houses on the mountains. I read few other items that I read with my eyes widening, huh, Platinum 0.5k ton, Palladium 1k ton, Carbon fiber 20k ton, Titanium 2k ton. Aren't these insane amount and very costly. She says, that they are. We need those for enriching them with kuretines. Lower grade elements don't have stability to combine with kuritine. We need some of it for direct applications, some for catalyst.

I put down the phone confused, how did you get this. You are just an architect, right. She smiles, I can pick up other things also. Mom taught me about designing things, but after coming to Earth I had learn other things too. I don't know everything about the process or the tech used, but I know these are some the raw things we need to get started before Citradel sends those specialists people arrive to help us. I am sure they will demand a similar list if not everything. Since you kept saying we need to hurry up, I made this list in anticipation of the things to come.

I was impressed with her, wow. Seems you are already getting down to work. She leans back on the sofa, what do you take me for. I know how important this is. I chuckle, but these things are very hard to come by. We maybe have what, barely any of it. She says, why do I think I came to you instead of anyone else. Theres only one person who can get these in short amount of time from humans without causing too much suspicion. I sigh, realizing she was right. David, he has connections everywhere. To corporations and criminal world. I don't think anyone else has enough pull with Humans to get these things in such bulk quantities.

I say, so we need to talk to him. She shrugs, considering the beaten state he was this morning, I didn't want to add this on top of it. I shared the same concern. She says, he is the only one I know who can get these, but that's still very difficult to procure in short time. I ask, is there anything we can cut down. She nods, I already thought of that. Some things we maybe push it for a later time, but not the ones I listed at the end. They are essential to the kuritine enrichment. This is a problem. I can't find a way around it. I didn't have any clue in this domain. I can talk to the team we have, but if Marina says even David will have hard time, they might not have any luck too. I ask, how soon do you need these.

She says, depends when Citradel sends those people. I nod, okay. I have to assume Citradel wants to fast track that, similar to us. So we can expect people arriving in what a week. She says, maybe less than that. The officials don't need to in Citradel to decide this. I am sure they are already discussing it on the travel. The boats might have reached the mainland by now, but they had hours to talk through. She had a point. There is a good possibility we need this stuff in less than 4 or 5 days.

I sigh realizing there is only thing we can do in such a short time. I say, if we had more time, we could have had our team get it. Maybe they would have to steal from some ore deposit. David's the only one I know who could buy it legally or at least without much detection. I also don't want him distracted. He has already enough to deal this. She nods, I had the same thought. If you also think the same, then maybe its time do it ourselves. I stare at her for a moment. Then I figured out what she said. I take a quick glance at Luther and Tina talking. They weren't listening us, engrossed in their own discussion.

I shook my head slightly whispering, no. Its too early for that. You know as well. We are not ready for an outside excursion. She quietly says, we don't have a choice, do we. I know its still early. But I don't see any other way. I understood the problem here, but this is not the solution. Things are not so dire enough to risk getting exposed. I say, even if we do it. There is no way that no one notices how we were able to get so much materials in short time. I mean, I have no idea how to explain that. Do you.

Her silence told me she also didn't know how. I sigh, we have no choice. We need to ask David. She leans forward, I don't want to. I nod, trust me. Neither do I. We got no choice. Knowing him, he must have a way to pull it off. He build a whole Echo fortress for himself, he has the resources to do it. She wasn't agreeing, but I know she knows it's the only way. I got up from the couch, listen, if there is any other way, we will do it. But for now, David's the only option right now. I don't want to add more troubles to the guy, but he should know how desperate we are.

Marina remained silent. I didn't want her to get distraught more by convincing her, so I left and went to Tina interrupting up their work. I ask, Tina, I need your help with something. She turns to me, sure. What's up. I hand over Marinas phone to her and showed her the list of raw materials on it. I explained her the problem and conclude, we need David's help. I need someone to go over his house and give it to him. Tina takes a moment to go over the list and the last items invoke a similar reaction as I did earlier.

Holy shit. Is this right. Luther looks over her shoulder, are they something difficult to get. She scoffs, try impossible. Getting these things in a month, no, less than a week is simply not possible. I don't know if even David can get it. I know Palladium and Platinum are highly regulated by Humans. There aren't any such mineral deposits lying freely around we can steal from. Hearing from her on the difficultly added to my guilt on taking David's help. Luther says, I didn't know Citradel had access to such resources. Won't they have it, we can ask them to had over.

I shrug, maybe. But I doubt they have everything or the amount we need, otherwise Marina would have mentioned it. Tina gives back the phone to me with a conflicted expression, this is just nuts. Is kuritine enrichment that difficult with materials. Luther says thinking hard, well, we are only doing to the ground, water and air. Logically, it makes sense its hard on things we can't do. Tina says, so we have to have David get these. But won't that make it difficult on him to focus on preparing his fight.

I nod with a somber expression, I know. But we have no choice. Like I said earlier, it will be a challenge. This is the first one. She nods ever so slightly, okay. I guess. Luther asks me, why don't you just send this to David on the network. The reason was not obvious to him. I am very sure he won't be checking his messages or anything else. He must be home by now, but has to be working on getting his kuret to work. I say, I want to make sure he gets it. He must be busy with his, ah, preparation. He might miss out the message. And I know him. Even sending a priority alert may not work, he may turn off the communications on the network. Any other day, I wouldn't worry, but today is a bit different. So trust me, I want to be sure he gets it and see its importance.

They didn't ask for details, probably assumed it was something to do with his dedication to win. Tine says, okay. Ask Marina to send me that list. I will have someone go to his place. I answer, thanks. I turn back to Marina still trying hard to find another way. She looks up to me, I can't think of any way. The team we have in Citradel wouldn't get it either in time. Plus, it wouldn't look good on us if we ask for their help already even before they offer. She is already acting like one of us now.

I gave her phone, I see. Well, there's no options left. Send this to Tina, I have explained her everything. Someone will get in touch with David. She gets up from the couch and says, shouldn't I take it to him. I answer, no. You need to visit the site around the mountain immediately. Survey the land and get some rudimentary blueprints started. Besides, either of us visiting him will stress him out even more. She thinks about it for a moment and says, you maybe to right. Okay. I will send it to her. I say, thanks for taking the initiative so early, getting hit with this later would have been bad. She nods with a small smile and heads out. don't know how David will take this. He might even refuse it. Its possible even he couldn't do it.

I can't think about it now. We resume our work on planning the teams and outlining objectives. Soon the brake came, but I decided to remain in the office. I did tell Luther to get somethings for me to eat later. I spent the entire day toiling in my office and others whenever I needed to. Few issues pops out ever so often. Like we didn't have enough people with some skills. Or people not having enough time to get it done. Some gave suggestion to streamline it. Some worked, some didn't. Wherever we could, I told others to put a pin on it. I didn't want peoples enthusiasm get hampered for too long. We pressed through the discussions, despite some obvious challenges and some not so obvious ones.

However, we were making good progress. By 6:30 PM, we already had confirmed teams with their objectives. Some even offered to join based on their expertise or their kuret effectiveness. In middle of all this, my thoughts kept drifting off to David. I was concerned about the deadline initially, but after Marina told about that issue, I am more agitated now. Around 7:00 PM, Luther comes in to my office. I was working on my laptop, drafting up the team assignment details. He takes the seat in front of me, how's it going. I answer, its slow. I don't know we can do it by tonight. Luther nods, I feel the same. You can never tell the issues that pops out until you see it.

I sigh, we still have some time. Lets try to finish it. I don't want people to leave just yet. We can ease a little bit from tomorrow. He says, that’s what I also been saying to others. We need to get our objectives and timeline set today. He then says, by the way. I got a message earlier about David. That made me stop typing. I close my laptop and focused all my attention on him. He says, apparently Matt and Cass somehow heard we needed to get David a message and they volunteered. They were quite eager, even when it took time from their break. They got back a while ago, but we didn't hear because you and me were both busy in a meeting.

I smile a little knowing the two of them were the only one not talking to him in the morning. I say, I should have told people to let me know immediately. Anyways, what was David take on this. Luther says with a half smile, I am not sure how, but he said he will get it done. He told it will be very difficult, but he can get it in 6 days, counting from tomorrow. He didn't explain how, and they didn't ask. Honestly, neither do I. My tensed body relaxes after hearing that. I slump back into my chair, that’s a relief. I don't know what miracle he will pull off, but lets trust it to him for now.

Then I became even more worried. He already has a more pressing deadline tonight. How does David plan to do it in his current condition. I ask, did Matt and Cass talk anything about how he was doing. He was being cocky in the morning for peoples sake, but I know he is stressed out. Luther says, I don't think they mentioned anything concerning. So I guess David is okay. Is there something else going on with him. I wave my hand, no. Just curious. Either David figured it out his kuret. Or he hid it from them. Well, either way I can't do much about it. I can only hope he recovers from his hang ups.

I didn't even leave for dinner, had it delivered to me instead. I didn't want to relax until I got everything done. After three more hours of grueling work, we finally got everything sorted out. I stretch my body in the conference room. I was in a discussion with Luther, Tina and 8 other officers we selected to be in charge of managing the teams. I take the seat on the front row and straighten out my legs, its finally done. Luther says exhausted, well, not completely, but its enough for now. Tina says, thanks guys. You now know your teams and assignments. We will meet tomorrow again for a short briefing. Everyone were tiered, but they all agreed. One guy asks, we made some good progress today, didn't we.

I answer with a smile, yeah. We did. Its going to a rough start for few days, but it will get easier. Even I can't keep up like this for long. Tina chuckles, no one can. I nod cracking my neck and shoulders, have others left the building. Luther nods, yeah. The last group of people left around 20 minutes ago. I nod, okay. I guess that about does it. Thanks everyone for being here. I will see you all tomorrow. With a quick back and forth byes, only I remain in the conference alone. I hoped to meet at least Catherine before leaving. But I guess its not in the cards.

I couldn't meet Vanessa as well. She was called for something an hour ago. Some people had a brawl in section 3. She was called because one was an alpha. This is not what I needed to hear. More problems, something not even related to Citradel, Heraknus or David. I turned on my phone. As soon as I opened it, I saw bunch of miscalls. I sat up straight and unmuted my phone. There were dozens of messages and voice messages from Vanessa and Tessa. I got concerned. I quickly dialed up Vanessa on speaker.

After few ringing tones, it connects. I ask, Vanessa, I just saw your calls. I had to keep my phone muted. She sounded a little bit distracted, you still in the officers building. I answer, yeah. I just finished my work. There were hustling in the background. I heard people talking and lot of noises. She says, I figured that was the case. I was waiting for you to call me. Since you are done with your work, we need you for some time. I got curious, for a brawl. I heard there was some alpha involved, but is it really important. Can't we do it tomorrow. Everyone is exhausted.

She was exasperated for some reason, believe me, I also didn't want to involve you. But it escalated more than just a brawl. I ask puzzled, what the hell happened in just an hour. She says, it didn't happen now. The patrols initially reported noises and kurets sparks in section 3's water treatment plant. They thought it was just a brawl with an alpha they assumed from the kuret levels. But by the time I arrived there, it wasn't just that. We have dozens of people lying unconscious in the basement. Among them are 2 alphas and one dual kuret user. All 3 were warriors from the tournament.

I jump out from my chair, what. I can't believe this happened tonight. She adds, and I got to know from Tessa some time ago, there appears to be some sort of smuggling also involved now. Freaking shit. The hell is going on.

Blake (Chapter 63)

Saturday, October 11, 2025 01:05

A thin line of people were surrounding the kuritine barrier around the plant building. People have already heard about it. I should have been here earlier. Hopefully, others have taken appropriate measures. I can't believe such a thing happened just a day after the tournament ended. The only good news was that the Citradel officials left this morning. We can't have any sort of domestic problems involving warriors now. And based on the very little details I heard from Vanessa, this also involves smuggling. I girt my teeth, we did have some reports about things sneaked in the island, but this is the first time so many people are hurt because of it.

I glide in the air to the entrance where couple of officers were guarding the doors. With a swift decent, I land in front of my and dispel my kuret. I hurry and cross the thin barrier separating the people and the door. Two officers were in front of the door. They were patrol officers in their uniform. One of the them says, Thanks for coming, Blake. He points to the door, Tessa and Roland are inside. Adam, take him to the basement. I nod while going inside, thanks. Adam takes the lead in front of me and we walk inside.

We both walk to the right end of the ground floor and take the stairs. As we walked, I saw signs of struggle, broken crates, crack on walls and the floor. The destruction wasn't severe, but I could tell that people fought aggressively. It wasn't a small fight. I ask, tell me what happened. I only got a very brief report. Adam replies, all I know that there were 13 people lying unconscious when we arrived. All of them in the basement. Apart from 3 warriors, rest everyone were regular citizens. Additionally, there was a small kid was the one who alerted us. I saw a broken railings as we cross the lower basement stairs exit doors. The room opens to a big subbasement with machineries places all around the area. The damages were more severe here. Shattered glassed across on the floor, some walls were broken with holes in it.

The scene was chaotic here. This was a whole gang figh. We cross the first room and entered the second one that was humming with noise and vibrations. He says, I don't know who they are. But I did hear on the secure network that everyone have been taken to the detention center. We have been asked to secure the place until the security team finishes analyzing the main area.

This wasn't the place where it started. Just how big of a fight was this. I had so many questions, but I had to wait until I arrive where others are. A while later we reached the origin of the chaos, a large empty room with a hanger on the other side. There weren't any machines here, just a underground hanger and a driveway. This room is probably where we carried and installed machines from outside. There are several kuritine drones in the air flying and throwing a scanner light on large room. Several officers were moving and using their kuret all over the place.

The fight clearly started here, because the place is destroyed. The side pillars were broken, debris all over the place. I stepped around the debris and blood stains on the ground. The floor had cracks spreading out from a corner. People had surrounded it with some equipment stands that were throwing lights over it. I finally approach to Tessa, who was talking to some officers. She notices me and dismisses others, Blake. Thanks for coming. I know you are already tiered from all those meetings. I wave my hand a little frustrated, never mind that. Fill me in.

She nods and points me to 3 crates standing near the hanger driveway. She says, I assume you already heard about the unconscious people we found. We suspect that they all came with this. We walk over the opened crates. I peek inside them. All three have the same items stacked inside. I ask incredulously after seeing the contents, are you telling me this all was caused because of this. Boxes of smuggled booze. This must be a joke. I hurriedly inspected the other ones. They also have bottles of alcohols inside filled with hay to protect it.

A mans voice looms, its not what you think. I turn to the guy walking to us. Tessa says, Blake, meet Roland. He is the primary on this. We both shake hands, thanks Roland for taking point. He smiles a little, its not everyday I get to see this. This might the biggest incident we have seen ever in the past year. I ask, this is madness. I still am confused on how this could cause a fight. You said something earlier, what is it. He picks one of the bottle and gives it me. From the scotch label and year model 1850, I made a guess, is this some expensive bottle or something.

He says, or something. Do you see anything. I don't know what he means. I took a closer look, even used aura to search for any kuret influence. But there were none. Its a plain human scotch bottle. Roland says, we also didn't see anything wired about it. Then we tested the contents from the broken bottle there. He points to a wet pillar that had broken pieces of bottle lying on the bottom. He explains, its not just alcohol. It has a bunch of drugs dissolved in gel.

My eyes sharpen at that. I take glances on the wet surface and then to the bottle. I ask, what kind of drugs. Tessa answers, the human kind, Methamphetamines. They are can be used to make variety of drugs. I got curious, but what's the point smuggling this inside. This doesn't produce the same effect on us like it does on Humans. Tessa nods, most drugs just has a temporary numbness before out bodies dissolve it. Roland says, we don't know the reasons. But seeing the quantity, its probably the reason why people fought. I ask, are all the bottles filled with it. I place the one in my hand back inside the crate.

Roland says, we haven't checked, but a cursory glance shows that some are actually genuine. One of the officer used his kuret to enhance his smelling sense and found a couple of bottle on the top row with no drugs. So I believe they smuggled the drug, using the actual bottles as cover. No bottle shows any abnormality when scanned with our usual kuret detection, they carefully added to this fool in case of actual liquid inspection. I take a quick look at the size of the crate, how much drugs are here. Tessa says, we have to check the boxes, but if we assume 2/3rd are actual drug bottles, and in all 3 boxes, its probably around 130 pounds.

I shook my head in distraught, all this for a bunch of drugs. I never imagined there be what, a drug war here. Roland says, that’s not the case. What kind of war ends with the merchandise being left behind and everyone knocked lying on the ground. When you came from the front door, you saw all the destruction along the way, right. The fight long the exit path, not the kind you see in a gang war. Most likely people were trying to escape, but they were dragged inside. We found drag marks on the floors nearby.

I say, maybe something else was stolen then. Did you check the entire place. Tessa says, we did. We have been scanning the entire plant, all the rooms, the control center, the machinery room, everywhere. Nothing is stolen. And these crates are filled to brim with bottles, there is no space to hide anything. Rolands adds, we did x-ray of the box and found no any evidence of disturbance to the lower parts. I ask, so nothing was else hidden or stolen from the create. Nothings missing from the plant too.

This doesn't make any sense. I look around the place seeing the debris, and yet there was a big fight here. This is a mess. Tessa says, we don't know who were fighting whom. This area is not under any camera surveillance. Besides the people we know, we can't tell how many were here. Roland says, we found the kuret signatures of all the 13 people all over the plant. But that’s it. We didn't find anyone else. I ask confused, does that mean those people fought among themselves.

Tessa nervously smiles, the evidence seems to say that. I ask, what about the kid. Could he have done this. Roland shook his head, he is 13. He isn't even a alpha. There were two alphas and one dual kuret user. He couldn't have done it. I didn't want to tell him there were exceptions. A shadow at his age could do it. Tessa says, he was the one who reported it. When the first patrols got here, we was saying to save her sister. He wasn't injured, but his sister had a major one. He and his sister are also in the detention center until we figure out how they are involved here.

Nothing makes sense. Roland says, I do have a theory. We both look to him. He says, its possible a sudden internal conflict happened. The kid was worried about her sister, so we didn't get much out of him. But he said few things like deals and breaking. I think a group within the people rebelled for some reason. And I think some escaped. Somehow they hid their kuret imprints. His theory had some ground, those people fought 3 warriors. All decently powerful people.

I pondered on this. Some powerful Medrones were involved in a strange drug smuggling gone wrong. Its more likely than a gang war. I ask Tessa, I am sure you have the videos of the scene from the patrol officers. Show it to me. Tessa pulls out her tablet from her pocket and hands it to me, they entered through the same way you did. I hit the start button. The video begins with officers running in the front door. The kid was also with them, the other officer was carrying him. They followed the exact same path I took. The kid was telling them the direction, hurry. She is bleeding out, he wails.

The officers rush to the scene. One says, shit. What happened here. Quick, report in. We need get others here immediately. All around people in jackets and hoodies were lying on the ground. The place I am standing now was littered with unconscious people on the ground. The kid breaks away from the officer and drags himself down to a bloodied body. He cries out, Elina. Wake up. Come on. I brought help. The other goes to inspect the area, check her. I will look around for any other person.

The officer crouches down and moves around on the women lying on the ground. There was a big cut on her left shoulder, where she bled all over herself. The officer says, what happened Ryan. How did your sister get injured. But the kid ignored him and kept trying to push Elina's unconscious body, no. no. Please. Wake up. Come on, do something. The officer begins inspecting her body. The camera views changes to her entire body. Then he pulls out the dress from the shoulder wound. The stained cloth was sticking to her body, but he slowly cleared that part. The camera catches a large wound, scaring from her collar bone to her neck. The women wasn't moving, however, the wound wasn't pouring out blood now.

The officer says, thank the kuret. This is good. Ryan, your sister will be fine. She is already healing. The would is not healed, but she isn't bleeding. Your sister is just sleeping. Ryan cries louder now hugging her sisters neck, Elina, you are going to be okay. You are going to be okay. The kid remained hugging her sister. The officer stands up and takes a look around. He walks around, shining a kuret light on the ground. The people lying on the ground were scattered everywhere. He looked around the entire room, but no one else was awake.

☐Soon the other officer comes in. He asks him, did you find anything. The other officer says, I checked the entire plant, there's no one else. Is she okay. He answers, yes. Thankfully her heal steady. The other one says, what in the hell happened here. Did the kid say anything. He says, he didn't. He isn't leaving her sister. We might have to wait for a while before he tells us. Suddenly the other officer says, hey. Isn't this cory, the alpha. What is he doing here. The camera points to a body. They roll him on his back and clear the dirt on his face.

It is him. I also vaguely recognized him. He says, holy shit. Yeah. It is him. They checked his pulse, just unconscious. What is going on here. The other says, no clue man. Quick, check the others. They both began checking the other unconscious people. Their big breaths were filling the muffled Ryans sobbing noises in the background. Some were lying in uncomfortable positions, they didn't move them much, just their heads. The camera points to another familiar faces. The officers bellows, I know this one too. He is Quinten, he is an alpha from Citradel.

After a while, the third person is also identified by the other officer, freaking shit. I know this lady. Polly, the dual kuret user. What is she doing mixed up in this. I recalled her too. She is someone who came from outside community. They continues checking the other identities. But like them, I didn't recognize anyone else. Nor there were any other alphas here. Just those 3 people among everyone were warriors. I stopped the video here. I ask, nothing changes since then.

Roland says, yes. We closed off the plant. No non-essential person has been in or not. And like I said, nothing missed either. This just gets crazier. I say, that alpha Cory. Isn't he the one that can manipulate light. Tessa says, yes. And the other one, Quinten, he is from a bloodline that can rot anything with kuret. Polly can control temperature around a place, make it lava hot or ice cold. All of them were in the tournament, in top 1000. So not so easy people to knock out.

Roland says, as you saw, their faces and bodies have physical altercations. So whoever was fighting them were not using any metaphysical kuret. I ask, and no other Kuret signature on them. He says, we moved them to the hospital immediately, so we can't definitely say. But a preliminary kuret scans showed only kuret signatures of the other people involved. That’s why I believe they fought each other. Tessa says, I still can't believe those 3 were knocked out, even if they were fighting 9 normal people. And what about the women, she was hurt badly. How is she or her brother mixed up in this. Roland says, we will know more when those guys wake up.

I have a proper understanding of the situation now. I hand over the tablet to Tessa, you said we don't have surveillance here. What about the area outside. Tessa says, still canvasing. So far we haven't found anything. IDF are reviewing the recordings as we speak. We should have something in some time. I take a look around the place. The people lying on the ground from the video left body prints all around us. I ask, since no one saying it, let me say it. Do we think people were stopping a drug gang or they were one themselves.

They both remained quite. Tessa says in a low tone, only the these people can tell us. I am here just taking control of the scene. You should head to IDF if you want to talk to them. Some of them may be awake by now. I nod, that's probably the only thing we can do right now. I turn to Roland, tell me what your plan to do next. He clears his throat, we scan the entire plant, leave no room unchecked. Look for any other kuret signatures. Then I will take these crates to the IDF and have them analyzed. We are going to find out if its one drug or others also mixed in. Then we will be expanding our search area. This part of the section 3 is a little remote from population. We will check the roads leading here, see if can figure out where these crates came from and who brought it.

He then turns a little hesitant. He looks to Tessa who stares with a question in mind. I ask, what. He says, I need your permission to search their homes of these 13 people. It may be a little presumptuous, but either these people smuggled drugged in or at least knew about it. That's a big ask. I understood why Tessa and Vanessa wanted me to come here first. They wanted me to see this myself. I gave this a long thought. I arrived at a decision, okay. But only question their family or the neighbors. No intrusive search. I will allow for only questioning. I don't want this to blow up until we know more.

Roland nods, that's fair. We have noted all the 6 bloodlines the people belong to. Their home addresses and their jobs, we will hit all those places. Most of the places would be closed. Can we at least search them. I thought about it. Then say, only if you find evidence. Like a surveillance camera, DNA or their exact kuret signature. Otherwise, just close it off for the night. He agrees with me, we can do that. I turn to Tessa, anything else you want to tell me. She says, that's all we got for now. I will keep you and IDF updated on anything we find.

I okay, thanks. Send me the names, kurets, and their jobs to me. I want to know exactly who the other guys are. She says, done. I moment later, a message pops in my phone. I check to confirm. All 14 identities are listed here. I push it back in my pocket, I will go to IDF and see if anyone is awake. I leave them both here and head out. While I climb up the stairs I try to figure out how to deal with this mess. One silver thing is that most people are in their home right now. So we have time before this news spreads to the entire island. We need to resolve this before sun comes up.

I step out of the plants door and immediately took off. I felt a little bit of my kuret wavering. My mind and body was tiered from working all day. Personally, I was so ready to sleep. But the rush is pushing me on. This complicated situation has to be resolved immediately, maybe even before Citradel hears about it. There are still many Citradel people here, they can easily report it to them. I sigh thinking of the issues we will have to face if they use this incident to stop Heraknus from moving here. Since both the communities were involved, the chances of that is not exactly low.

In 10 minutes I reach the IDF building. From above I could see many auras moving around the building. I land near the road. The people outside see me and give way. I climb up the stairs to the main building. I recognized one officer, Somers. He comes rushing in, Blake. I heard from Tessa you were on your way here. I will take you to others. I nod and follow his way. We crossed rooms where people were walking around and working on their desks. I asked, I am up to speed with the situation. So is anyone awake.

He answers, yes. We forced the 3 main people to wake up. They are being questioned for some time now. I was a little relieved and anxious at the same time. I ask, what are they saying. He says nervously, we have them in sperate rooms because they refuse to explain. I shout back, seriously. A depressed thoughts loomed on me. Are they really involved in those smuggled drugs. He says, they only said they don't know anything. I yell, what the hell. Did they loose memories or something.

He shrugs, I am not exactly sure. Vanessa and Ruthers would know more. This is spiraling out of hand. A while later we reached the detention center. Somers says, they are inside the room. Just head straight in. I nod. He begins to leave, but I stop him, wait a second. Sorry, but I need a favor. He turns to me. I ask, I had a very long day. I need something to drink to keep me focused. Bring me some coffee kuritine or something if you have here. He frantically says, absolutely. I got you. There is one in the cafeteria. I'll get it for you. I appreciated that, thanks. Sorry for the trouble. He waves off saying, not a problem.

I head inside the room. I haven't been here from quite some time. Stuff have been changed around, new offices and desks have been pulled inside. There are less people here compared to outer rooms. I guess only higher ranked officers are allowed here now. I caught sight of Vanessa standing in front of a kuritine blue barrier. I hurried to her. She notices me approaching, removes her crossed arms, Blake. Glad you are here. I scoff, trust me, I would rather be sleeping. She nods, you and me both. We had a long day already. She turns to the barrier, but we can't ignore this.

I follow her gaze and see the person sitting inside. Its Quinten. He was sitting in a single chair with her arms bound on top of the table in front. His arms were bound by kuritine cuffs. I immediately yell, why is he detained. She says, believe me, I had no choice. There was an incident before you came. Cory woke up and was being uncooperative. He actually tried to escape. The guy actually had the gall to attack the nurses and guards In his room. Sommers tried to him, but there's was a brief struggle. So I had to step in and rough him up.

I shouted, freak, this escalated too quickly. Vanessa says nervously, I didn't wanted to do this, but I can't have a rouge alpha running out of here. So I ordered to tie him down. I clutch my hands to my head. The drowsiness I was feeling was completely gone. This can't be happening. I ask her, and that's why Quinten is locked up too. She nods, they also weren't being cooperative, but since Cory tried to escape, I didn't want another incident. So I have them tied all up.

I pull out hands and shook my head. This is bad. No, its worse now. The small hope I had to resolve this peacefully was gone. I ask, did you try talking to him. She sighs, I tried. None of them is talking. And since they are warriors, I am not letting anyone else inside with them. Right now, only me, Ruther or you can handle them. I sigh, this isn't what I was hoping to hear. We both silently stare at the imprisoned Quinten. If they aren't going to talk, then there is someone else we can talk to.

I ask, what about the kid Ryan. His sister should be okay now. Is he talking. Vanessa says, we tried. But he isn't leaving her until she wakes up. He is refusing to explain too, saying he doesn't know anything. I cursed internally, look. I know its not ideal, but we need to talk to him. She nods, I know. I also tried, but he wasn't listening. She then thinks for a bit, maybe you'll have a better luck. I nod, yeah. I will do take anything I get right now. We need clarity.

She leads me to the adjoining room where the siblings were resting. The women, Elina was now in a kuritine gown which was stimulating her healing. Ryan was sitting beside her in a chair. Deni was also sitting in a corner chair. She stood up at our entrance. I ask her, any update. She says, nothing. She is just unconscious. Her wound is almost healed now. We didn't want to force her up, so for now we are just waiting. I gave a subtle nod and walk to Ryan. He was still wearing the same dress I saw him in the video. He looks up to me, gets a look of surprise. But doesn't say anything.

I say, Hi Ryan. I am Blake, but you already know that. Don't you. I tried a gentle prob, but he didn't respond. He turns back his gaze to his sister. I take a seat beside him, your sister will be fine. You know right. The doctors say she just sleeping. He doesn't reply to me. I make a tense look at Vanessa and Deni. They both had their own trepidation about this. I sigh, look Ryan. We just want to know what happened. That's all. People are anxious here, but you can help. So why don't you help me out here.

He remained silent yet. This isn't going anywhere. I stood back up and went to others. I signal Vanessa to follow me outside. Deni stays inside. Vanessa says, he is in a shock. Its not his fault. I reply, I know. I am not saying it is. But we can't just wait. Soon this will spread all over the island. We can't have people carelessly spreading rumors about a drug gang war. She asks, I am open to any suggestion. I take a peek inside the room to the woman unconscious.

I say, the 3 people we woke up are not cooperating. Neither is the kid. But what about her. Considering she was the only one injured, she must have some idea. She looks at Elina, you want to force her awake. I nod hesitantly, yes. If I wasn't desperate, I wouldn't ask this. But you all have been at this for almost 2 hours and still no clue. I can't let it delay like this much longer. Vanessa asks, I understand. Honestly, I wanted to this also. But I just felt concerned for the kid. He might resist us doing anything. He was struggling to remain outside when we carried her in. He isn't going to leave her side.

I nod, I saw the video of the scene. I can understand the shock he is in. But I am not going to wait this out more. His sister is fine, he is fine. His aura was already feeling exhausted. Lets make him asleep. You must have someone here who can do it without the kid knowing. Vanessa looks a little bit anxious about this. I felt her aura flicker a little. I wait for her to choose this too. I don't what she was concerned about. The talk of Wagner could be making her sentimental. A moment later she says, fine. I don't know what else we can do. The guy who can wake people up and also make them asleep.

I recalled this particular kuret, he is from that Zeld bloodline then. She says, yeah. I will get him. I saw him checking on the other unconscious people earlier. I reply, great. Thanks for understanding. She nods and leaves me to find the person. I decided to check the other two imprisoned people. They both were held in similar fashion. Polly was actually beaten the most. She had cuts and wounds all over her body. He clothes bloodied and torn. She was in the top 124. For her to be soundly beaten, they must have ganged up on her.

But that's what puzzling. Its not just her, Cory and Quintin were also roughed up pretty bad. Roland and Tessa didn't find any other people in the area, and the other people were also knocked out along with them. How did those group of people defeat them and remain undetected. How small of a group were they to do this to them. And a group who just left 3 boxes crate worth of drugs. My thoughts gets cut in when Somers approaches me with a cup in his hand, here you go.

I gladly took it from him, thanks a lot Somers. He waves, no sweat man. I didn't wait to see if it was hot or cold. Or even what it was. I just gulped it down my throat. It was a coffee at just the right temperature. The caffeine mixed with kuritine soothed my throat. The scent also helped me focus out a little. Somer says, hits the spot doesn't it. I laugh wiping off my lip, that it does. Suddenly, the door opens. Two people walk in. Its good that I just had a coffee to keep me awake, because the one of the two people who walked in were actually banned from this place.

Everyone here were curiously looking at the two of them. I dash in front of the person, Nathan, you are not allowed in here. His answer was just a smile.

Vanessa (Chapter 64)

Sunday, October 12, 2025 00:54

I was so ready to get back home. Spending whole day in the officers building was draining. Blake had given us orders for the day. I couldn't disobey his order when he himself was working till late. I didn't want to skimp out just because I had a rough day. Though I spent the whole day here, Ned and I somehow managed not speak a single word to each other. My anger towards him had never went down ever since he walked in the room. He kept giving me the cold shoulder. I can't believe he didn't even care to even try to approach me after the meeting was over. He just walked out with the same expression he came with this morning. I kept a small hope that we would talk it out, like Cass and Matt had suggested. But that never happened. I was about to loose it in the officers building when I stepped out the conference room.

Fortunately, work kept me going. I poured all my focus into assigning the teams and giving tasks to the IDF crew. I don't know what I would have done if wasn't keeping myself busy. When break came, I went with Tessa and Catherine to get some snacks in the dining building. I didn't even bother to seek out Ned or wait for him. I initially thought to decline Tessa's offer to join them. But then I thought it would be better to stay with people instead of being alone with my thoughts. Even if I didn't resolve my issues with Ned, talking to Matt and Cass helped me sort out some of my feelings. Honestly, I am still embarrassed that I had to talk about my relationship issues to others. But despite that uncomfortable feeling, it did help me.

Thankfully, those two didn't broach the subject of Ned or David with me. I was more than happy to discuss about the upcoming plans and the work that’s soon coming to pile up in our future. Tessa sighs after we finished eating, we were preparing for this for a long time, but its still all so sudden. Its surreal that we are already preparing to lunch a full scale expansion the day after the tournament is over. I am sure everyone was feeling the same as her. I say, but you know what, its actually good we are doing it without wasting any time. I was always skeptical how the this transition would be. Whether we were moving to Citradel or they were coming here. It would have been slow and long.

Tessa says, you say that, but I feel the same what the guy in the meeting called out, I am not sure how safe it will be without our security upgrades. We are going to let people in when our defenses are not yet fully operational. I understand the stakes and what Blake explained. But I am not sold on it. Echo might use this opportunity to attack us. We had been talking about it for a while now. Its not like I don't understand the risks, but I do feel it’s the correct move. I answer, we are taking a risk by rushing, I won't deny that. But we got strong people now. Like Luther said, we can protect the island ourselves.

Tessa remained unconvinced. She slumped back into her seat. Beside me, Catherine just silently looked at us, and didn't utter a word. She had been not participating in our discussion as her usual self. Something is going on with her. I tried to prod her, what do you think Catherine. You might know the situation much clearer than most. She looks up to me in a strange look. Like she was herself not sure. She answers, I am not sure. I leave it up to others to decide. I'll just follow Blakes lead here. He knows what he is doing.

That was probably the most impartial view she can have on this. I am sure something is bother her for some time. She and David spent time this morning, that I am sure of. Something must have happened then. She seems a little off, like she is just going with the flow. I am not going to question it though, since I am almost doing the same. Tessa says, don't get me wrong. I also will support whatever everyone decides. Its just my opinion. I nodded, its fine. I am sure many have the same concerns. All we can hope that nothing happens during this transition. I feel we deserve some break after dealing with so much crap from Echo and humans.

Tessa smiles and agrees. After talking a little bit more, Tessa got a call, it seems I have some stuff to get to before our break is over. I will see you all in a bit. We both see her off while we decide to head back to the officers building. There was an awkward silence between the two of us now. Tessa might have invited me, but I get the feeling Catherine didn't want to be here too. I decided to check up on her now since we were walking a bit away from anyone that could hear us.

I ask, Catherine. I didn't want to ask this before, but are you all right. You seem off the whole day. She didn't turn to me, just answered snarly, I could say the same for you. I can tell you wanted to be alone too. I wasn't expecting her to hit back like this. I felt a little prong in my throat. I shouldn't have asked her this. Of course she would also realize my sour mood. We both walk in silence now. A while later she speaks up, sorry. That didn't came out harsh. She felt a little guilt, but honestly, she was not wrong. Who am I to intrude on others when I don't want people to do it to me.

I shook my head, no its fine. Everyone has bad days. I hesitantly added, I just thought to ask since you and David met this morning. You did say yesterday during the match you were a little angry with David. Did he said anything to you to make you upset again. Honestly, I was hoping for it. I know that makes me a bad friend, but I wanted to commiserate in our shared anger at that bastard. She pulls a small smile, I'll tell you if you tell me what he said to you that made you mad at him just before his interview.

She got me. I wasn't paying attention to others when I was catching David lying to me. I might have made a scene in front of others without realizing. Now I was the one who shut down. I have zero mental capacity to talk about David and his constant need for secrets and distrust. She picked up on that, just like you, I don't want to talk about it. She pauses for a bit, at least not yet. I completely understand her emotions. It was a weird situation that both of us have issues going on with the same person.

She then spoke up, but I will at least tell this. She turns to face me with a serious expression and says, I am not mad at David anymore. We did talk yes, he told me things maybe I shouldn't have known. I was surprised she opened up a little. But what does that mean. I ask curious, I don't understand. She doesn't clarify it, I am just saying he doesn't hide things from others for no reason. I am not justifying the way he did it, but I at least understand it now that he was being considerate. I am clueless now. I thought she was still angry at David like me. But instead she says it’s the opposite, she is defending him for whatever r believe a word he says. He lies so cleverly that you never realize he is manipulating you. He just said what you wanted to hear. Catherine makes a exhausted laugh, I would have actually preferred that to be true. She closes her eyes for a second and then opens them to me, I don’t think he lied. I get you what you mean, he does that often. So its like the boy who cried wolf. I think he didn't tell me everything. She ponders hard for a second, no. I know he was still holding back some things from me. But after mulling over it for some time now, I think its better to not know. I don't know how I might feel if he told me everything.

This made me angry. David got to her. I shook my head, don't just forgive him. He doesn't deserve that. I spat out that without hesitation. She look a little shocked seeing me this vile. She says in a quite tone, I am not completely sure what's going on between you two, but all I can say is give him a chance. I shook my head, I already did. He never learns. And its not just about me and him. You know the whole truth about the deal between David and Charles. He didn't listen to me or Blake before deciding to take it. He didn't ask anyone else's opinion. As soon as he heard my brothers name, it flipped a switch in him. And then I hear ridiculous lies about my brother, which I am sure David knows about it.

I realized I went on a rant and disclosed something I shouldn't have. Catherine eyebrows raises at me, what about your brother ?. I stop myself from saying anything more. I don't want to dishonor my brother's memories. I quickly added, its something personal. Lets just leave it at that. She must have understood my feeling because she didn't ask about it. I continue, what I mean is David has changed. He thinks its okay to lie if its for good reason. That’s just crazy. You might have forgiven him. I will not. I am sure he is keeping stuff from us we don't even know about. He hid his house, his reasons for accepting the deal, and keeping things from both of us. That’s beyond kindness. He doesn't trust us one bit.

Catherine remained stunned by my claim. She didn't refute it, but she didn't defend him too. I blabbed too much again. Without talking to Siera, I have been using others as an outlet to blow off some steam. I should be a little guilty, but I don't feel it. I need to warn her David doesn't trust her with truth also. She didn't spoke up again. She was probably too shocked to see me so agitated. I also remained silent, not wanting to embarrass myself further showing her my pitiful state. In a way she was being considerate by not taking anyone's side anymore. We both never spoke again all the way back to the officers building. I thought she would say something encouraging to me, instead we just waved bye without saying anything.

I don't know what I feel about her silence, but at least I was grateful she didn't say anything to stir my emotions again. Once I came back into my office, my focus shifted to my work, which was the distraction I needed to remain functional. Tessa joined us after a while. I had to push my emotions away to make sure she or others don't see my pitiful state. The last thing IDF crew needs is to see their chief going through a personal issue. I continued discussing with Somers and others about the new changes we will be implementing in the IDF for the city. Without progress in our defense capabilities, we need add more patrols and continuous shifts. Everyone knew that meant more working hours, but it can't be helped. All of us signed up for this.

Our discussing and planning went on late till 7:30 PM. That’s when Somers got a alert from some patrol officers about a fight near the plant. I sigh, really. Are people so stupid that they would start causing problems on the first day. I just can't. Somers smirks, I feel you. I still gotta check it out though. It might just be some drunk people enjoying and got carried away. We did get some reports from bars and clubs. Tessa scoffs, but at a treatment plant. What kind of drunk people would choose that location to cause disturbance.
☐Somers shrugs his shoulders, like Vanessa said. Stupid people. I'll take a small team and check it out. Its probably nothing serious. I nod, thanks. And you know what, why don't you all head close to dinner time. And we have pretty much covered all the topics for today. Somers smiles, well, I will take up on that offer. Thanks. Tessa laughs, I was waiting for you to say that. Let me join you Somers. Can't believe today was getting to Tessa too. Well, there was a lot to work today for her too. I agreed seeing I didn't have any issues, sure. Send me the report. Detain those people to the detention center. We will sort that out tomorrow.

With that concluded, Tessa and Somers took 3 people with them and head to the site. Meanwhile I was wrapping up the discussion with the other crew here. Deni comes up to me after a while, hey. Did you hear from Tessa ?. I am not able to reach to her or Somers for a while. I checked the time, huh, its already been an hour. Time flew when all of us were busy. I quickly took out my phone and search for any messages from him. I say, nothing. That’s weird, just how many much time it would take to detain few people.

Deni shook her head, I don't know. I had a report for Somers. I wanted to catch him before he left home, but he or his team hasn't even come to the detention center. This is strange, I thought for sure they already went back home by now. What could have happened at the site that they haven't come back yet. I quickly rang up Somers. He didn't pick up. Then I tried Tessa. After a few rings the line connects, Tessa, what happened. Are you guys still at the treatment plant.

The other side of the line had a lot of hushed noise in the background, the hum of the machines. Tessa says, there's been a development. It wasn't a simple fight like the alert we got. Its much worse. Her serious tone jarred me out of my seat. I shout, what. What's going on. Other's nearby me were surprised to see me react this way. Deni also came closer. Tessa says, I didn't want to contact you until I got some more clarity on the situation. But I guess its best to tell you now.

Then she explained everything to me. My jaw shook loose as I heard about a dozen people lying unconscious and among them were 3 warriors. This is nuts. Tessa says, I called up IDF to send someone here to help investigate. There is signs of damages and struggle all around the place. It wasn't one or two people fighting, there are multiple Kuret signatures all over the place. There are no camera's or any witnesses apart from the people here. We got no clue, so we are going to move all the people involved to IDF. Somers is with them. I suggest you also head over there too.

I click my tongue in frustration. So much for a peaceful sleep. I respond, I'll head there now. I disconnect the call and turn to others, guys, there's been an incident. Everyone had their eyes on me already since I had been so vocal. One women asks, is it about the alert we got. I sigh, yes. Its not looking good. I need everyone to delay their dinner plans for a while and head to IDF. People were whispering and some were cursing. But I couldn't appease them. It was an emergency, we had to handle it.

I already started to walk to the deck. Deni comes behind me, yeah, you go ahead. I am going to gather all the people on the shifts to IDF. I answer back, see if you can send some people to the treatment plant too. She nods,

will do. See you there. I pushed the window door open and immediately gather wind on my feet with my Kuret. In few seconds I took off to the cold night sky and head to IDF. I was mulling over the scattered details I got from Tessa in my mind on the way. We can't let people know about this incident, because it involves both Citradel and Island people. This could effect the Heraknus transition.

Its actually the worst possible time this could happen. Could Kafar be behind it. He did seem like he hadn't given up on his agenda. But why involve his own people then. Best not to jump to conclusion about this right now. Few minutes later I arrive at IDF. I land near the entrance, which was had 4 trucks in front now. Ruther saw me coming, and came from the IDF building, great timing. We just got all the people to the clinic and detention center.

I nod as we walk inside. I ask, is anyone injured. He hesitantly says, well, everyone are hurt, expect for a kid. My eyes widen at that, what. There's a kid mixed up in this too. He sighs, he is. I don't know how though. He did call for help. This just kept getting worse. He then hands me a pad with a video paused, this is the footage of the patrol officers arriving on the scene. I played the whole video from the start. My shock continues to add on as I see so many people lying unconscious. Then finally I learned the names of the 3 warriors.

I spat out incredulously, is this a joke. Two alpha warriors and a dual kuret user. All in or around top 100 ranking of the tournament. How did they all get knocked out. Who attacked them. He says, we have no clue. But Somers says they have Kuret signature of each other on their wounds, so as ridiculous as it sounds, they fought each other. I scoff at that idea, what possible reason could they have. Ruther then pulls out his phone and shows me a picture of the scene, its possible its about this.

It was a image of some creates lying in the middle of the concrete floor. One of them was opened and showed liquor bottles stacked inside. That just added more confusion to the scene. He then says, its not what you think. He proceeded to explain about the drugs mixed in with actual bottles. At this point I put my hand on my chin and close my eyes exasperated. Are we really dealing with a drug smuggling in the middle of an important Medrone society formation.

At that point I had no choice but to call Blake. I pulled up my phone and called him. But he didn't pick up. I tried again, Ruther says, if you are calling Blake or Luther, forget it. They all still in a meeting. We checked. We wanted to first loop you in before them. Well, that’s probably the right call. As I walked into the inner room of IDF I hear a commotion from inside. There was a lot of noise and loud pounding noise. Ruther and me almost sprinted towards the source. He shouts, what the hell.

Just then I caught strands of Kurets coming from the wall. The door opens with loud bang and two people come out. It was Somers and Cory . I scream, what is, but my voice cuts off when I see both of them fighting. Cory was using his Kuret on Sommers. The air between them was turning grey and dull. Wait, that’s his Kuret that rots. Somers in return uses his Kuret to harden himself to avoid the rot hurting him. I rush to them with my Kuret ready. I shout out, what the hell is going on here.

My loud voice caught both their attention. Cory was injured. Did Somers to that. No, I just saw the video recording. He had injured when he was unconscious. Is he for real. He is trying to fight in his state. He takes one look at me and says, shit. He immediately changes his posture and turns his back to me. Somers seeing this dashed ahead, he is trying to escape. Stop him. I understood what happened. This crazy guy woke up and trying to escape.

Sommers puts his arm on Cory's shoulder, but he got an elbow shoved on his face. Somers staggers back shouting. Shit. I saw Sommers face bleeding from the side. Even with his Kuret strengthening his skin, Cory hurt him. This alpha is still so strong despite his injuries. I decided its not safe for anyone else to try and stop Cory . I need to do it myself. I rushed in with a blast of wind on my back. Cory knew he was cornered when he saw me. He stopped fighting and instead was trying to run away.

I wasn't going to let him. I halt in front of him blocking his escape through the door. He looked visibly troubled. I shout, you got no where to go Cory . He got agitated, shut up bitch. He suddenly got mad and make a reckless attack on me. He coated both his hands with his rot Kuret and tried to grab me by the arms. I saw it coming, so I discharged a short blast of lightening at his arms. He shrieks when the lightening hits his arm. However, his rotting Kuret was still there.

Damn. He is still this strong. I recalled his fight with June. Whatever his reasons are trying to escape, he is still one of the top warriors. Even injured he can probably do some damage. I took a peak around the room. People were rushing out from the inside room. Others came after hearing us. I can't let this drag on. A thought came to my mind. If he is really serious and desperate, he might take someone hostage and try to escape. No one here is powerful enough to avoid getting hurt from his rotting Kuret.

I decided to finish this fast. Cory shook off my attack and then charged again. His Kuret now covering his whole arm. I prepared a layer of ice on my left arm and block his punches. I could have avoided it entirely, but I chose to make a close combat. I let out a shout and force my Kuret on my arm to grow. The ice begins to grow on Cory's right fist. He shouts in pain, but he doesn't relent. He instead increases the rot and tried to slow down the ice growing on his arm.

I knew this wasn't enough to stop him. I wanted him to focus on that for a moment. With my other arm I prepare a fist of fire and throw a fireball point blank on his face. Quintin saw in horror as a ball of fire, a size of fist struck his left face. I felt my attack connect physically. But he had somehow brought his rot Kuret to his face too. I felt a small sting on my knuckles on the contact. He got knocked back and smashed straight to the wall behind him.

I wriggle my right hand a little to shake off the pain. Dammit. Just how persistent he was to get away. I thought that was enough to stop him. But instead he was doubling down on escaping. He was letting his Kuret flow into the wall behind him. I saw that and rushed ahead. He won't be able to break the wall in time, but just in case I should avoid any more damage. At this point he probably had given up on fighting me because he was focused on spreading his rot.

I am done holding back. If he isn't going to stop, I need to ramp up the pressure. I began to prepare a wind assisted fire on my right hand. The fire begins to glow brighter and hotter. Cory begins to panic seeing me come at him with full force. But he is too slow to react. I land a huge blow to his abdomen and knock the wind out of him. Cory tried to grab on with his Kuret on my shoulders as he let out a big painful shout. I could feel more sharp pain surging on my skin at the contact. I stifled a small shout from the pain.

Damn him. He is still this strong. Its good I was here. Otherwise someone would have been hurt. I didn't stop my attack. The pain wasn't so strong that I need to back off. I let out a big wave of electricity from my elbow and struck him on face. This discharge was on the level I used when I fought Marina. No way he would walk away from this. And I was right. His face cracked in pain with the electricity penetrating his skin and bone. He lets out another shout as his clothes and skin begin to singe from the burn marks.

A moment later I see his Kuret subsiding. I back off from him. His eyes were rolled up and without any resistance he falls front in me to the ground. I wasn't going to take any chance. I bend down and grab on his unconscious body. I shove his arms back and then I lock them with a thick layer of ice. I kept continuing adding ice up to his elbow for good measure. He is an alpha, he will soon wake up and heal. I can't have him use his Kuret rot on others.

Once I was satisfied he can't easily break off I back from him. Behind me Somers comes in, is he down. I nod, yeah. Somers was bleeding and had a big swelling on his left eye, but he too was slowly healing. I shook his head in anger, freak this. What the hell was that. He just attacked a nurse and tried to ran off. I turn back to look the body lying down. I ask, he was so desperate to escape. I didn't want to involve others so I had to attack with some serious Kuret.

Behind us other came and were inspecting Cory. Ruther also rushes and says, what a mess. Was he really going to escape IDF. Someone take him to a prisoner cell this time. Others agreed and picked him up, carrying to the cells we have installed. We never had a use for it, until now. I say, its not enough. Add two guards around the box. Chain his hands and don't treat his wounds. He was even giving me trough despite the injuries he had. I looked around my arms and shoulder spots he touched. The unform I was wearing showed a little bit of my bare dark skin. It wasn't that bad because it was already healing. Thank god he wasn't at full capacity, I would have been more injured otherwise.

Somers on the other hand wasn't doing well. He was hurt all over and that last elbow to the face scarred him bad. I say, I got this. You should rest and focus on getting healing your wound. Somers was too agitated, no. I am good. It looks worse than it is. Ruther chips in, no dude. I can feel pain just by looking at you. You should rest. Somers wasn't backing down. I guess his alpha ego was hurting. I tell, just rest for a moment Somers. You were taken by surprise. Ruther nods, yeah. And the dude was on something. He was desperately trying to escape, no matter what. Somers looked like he was going to back down. I gave him a glare making him understand that it was order.

He closes one eye and sighs, fine. I will at least heal up face. It wouldn't look good if people saw me this hurt inside IDF. He then sighs exasperated as he begins to walk away. Ruther says, its not his fault. I say, I didn't say it was. It was lucky that I was here. He clicks his tongue, what made Cory behave like this. Is it really about the drugs we found. I ponder hard about it. I don't have a clue what could make him do this. His desperate attempts to lash out and escape suggests something else.

I realized something. I turn to Ruther, have other two warriors also move to prisoner cells. I don't know what happened, but something big must have happened. I can't let have another incident happen with Quintin and Polly. We just saw that even injured, these guys are strong. Even I won't be able to stop them if they all 3 band together while escaping. Ruther thinks about it for a moment. He then turns to others inside, are you sure. Maybe it was just Cory.

I shook my head, I am not sure. But I rather not risk it. And make sure no one talk to the warriors. Not until we will question the other people involved.

Blake (Chapter 65)

Sunday, January 4, 2026 21:56

Nathen was amused by my serious face. I wasn't. He says, calm down. I am here to help. I snicker, no. You don't. You and your companion should immediately leave this building. You will cause a lot of stir. If he was alone, I might listen to why he would offer to help. But he brought a troublesome women with her. She laughs, don't be like that Blake. I am here only to offer my assistance. I hear you have uncooperative people under locked up. You know I can question them.

I grit my teeth at her, we already have people from your bloodline here Rose. You aren't needed. She smiles at me with a slight annoyed look. She was wearing casual clothes. Actually, when I think about it, she was wearing her hospitality dress. She must have come directly from work. She raises her hand to me, please. I am an alpha, you need me to interrogate other alpha. My bloodline people can't do what I can. I don't know how she knows we got alphas in our holding. I turn to Nathan and glare at him.

He shrugs at me innocently. Damn him. I guess he still has people in IDF that inform him things. He says, don't look at me like that Blake. You know you need Rose and her Kuret. You are holding alpha and a dual kuret user. They are powerful warriors. Only rose can pry out information out of them. It's alarming he even knows who they are. At this point people all around us became aware of their presence. People were whispering and some gave strange gazes towards us.

This isn't the right place to discuss. But I can't just let them inside. I take a stand, it doesn't matter. We will try to do it our way first. If that doesn't work, then I might, think of asking Rose. But not you. Your presence will cause more problems we don't need. Nathan's smiles wears off and takes a look around the stares he has been getting. He then says to me, I don't mind the attention, if that's what you are worried about. The nerve of this guy. Before I force him out of here he continues, also. I can help too. If you recall, Cory was one of my guys back in the Valley. I know him and can help get information out of him. □ I scoff, that's a lie. If he was close to you, we would have kept an eye on him. He wasn't in your inner circle, like Rose here. I point to her. She makes a offended gesture. I ignore it and say, and even if that were true, it won't help much. We can interrogate him ourselves. Nathan replies, I don't doubt that. But its about not wasting time. I rushed here because I too want to resolve this faster. He then sighs a little, sure, Cory wasn't really my guy, but he was close enough. He has been beside me enough times to know his quirks, habits. Tells that he is lying or telling the truth.

I say, that goes both way. He knows you too then. So he will be more cautious and clamp up. He nods, that's also true. But I got another ace. I can read his aura. Better than you. I bet you are tired and handling multiple things. Are you sure you won't miss anything. A single misread and you might waste a lot of time going with a different line of questioning. You know me and Rose's Kuer combination of interrogation is very efficient. So why can't you make an exception just this once for us.

I grit my teeth a little. Not because of anger, but due to annoyance that he was right. I was just telling Vanessa that we don't have time to waste. Using these two would drastically make things go faster. I was thinking hard on what to do. Initially I wasn't going to let them in, but after hearing their reason, I am perplexed. In the corner of my I notice Vanessa and a guy coming. I shook my head knowing this is going to cause even more stir. I say to Nathan, since you both are so adamant. I will leave this decision to the chief. I waved to Vanessa. I have just dumped it on Vanessa just because I didn't want to force this.

Nathan and Rose instead were not happy. They became a little tense, like they know Vanessa will be a tough sell. Vanessa and the guy she brought to wake Elena walk to us. Vanessa says angered, what the hell are these two doing here. Someone get them out of here. The guy from Zeld bloodline looked around in confusion. I didn't want him to be delayed so I say, you should go to the sleeping women back there and wake her up. We will be behind you in a moment. He looks at Vanessa for a second for confirmation. She was staring hard at Nathan, yeah. Peter, you go on ahead. He nods and moves away from the tense looking people.

Nathan speaks first, listen to us before kicking us out. But she wasn't having it. She walks closer to him saying, I don't need another problem. There is a reason you are banned from this place. No one can trust you. She gives a quick glare to Rose, same goes to her too. Nathan replies, hate all you want, but you need us. You need us to interrogate your prisoners. We can help make it go faster. I am sure you would get truth out of them eventually, but how much time will that time.

Vanessa wasn't buying any of it, I don't care. We do it as long as it takes. We do it properly, without any interference from a nuisance duo. Rose cuts in, come on Vanessa. You are being unreasonable here. I sigh, she shouldn't have said that. The comment made Vanessa burst out a vein in her forehead. She yells at her, am I now. I think I need remind you the pain you caused me back in Valley. I saw her preparing her Kuret on her hand. Rose saw it too and became slightly terrified. Nathan also downed a very serious expression seeing the possibility of a getting blown away.

This escalated far too much. I cut in, stop. All of you. This is not productive, we can't waste time on this. The IDF crew around us also took a step back thinking a fight might break out. I don't think Vanessa wants that, she is getting way too angry. I asked Nathan, will you both agree to some conditions while you are inside this building. Vanessa looks at me with shock, Blake, you are joking right. These two are just looking for an angle, you can't trust them one bit.

I nod, yeah I also was ready to kick them out. But don't you think we should use them. Its not about trust, its about getting the truth and resolving this situation fast. We need only their Kurets, not them. So let me propose the rules and if you don't like it, feel free to kick them out. Vanessa glares at me with anger. Okay, that was unnecessary. She might really be a little unreasonable. I brought kuret to my eyes and made her feel like it was an order rather than a request. She finally backs down after a moment, fine. Lets listen to the conditions.

I take a small gulp relieved she didn't push me further. I turn to other two, you both will be monitored every second you are inside. Everything you do will be monitored, your actions, your Kuret, hell, you so much as sneeze, it will be seen. Second, no use of Kuret outside the cell. You use your Kuret outside anywhere, even for a second, and I will personally shove you both out. I turn to Rose to single out this condition just for her, especially you. If you are caught using your Kuret on anyone else, I won't just kick you out, I will penalize you. You will be suspended from your job or even fired.

Rose makes a annoyed look. But she doesn't say anything when Nathan waves at her. I continue, finally. Whatever you learn here, will remain inside. If you reveal it to anyone else and we found out about it later, there will be severe consequences. I am talking something between house arrest to even exile in extreme case. Agree to these conditions and I will allow you inside. My last harsh condition made them both flinch. Rose couldn't hold back anymore, hey now. That's too much. The details about this would be released to public eventually, so why ask to hide it.

I shook my head, we might not share it to the public. Or we just tell a water down version to avoid panic. Regardless of our choice you both will not share it to anyone. I mean it. Nathan had a relaxed expression until now. He was dead silent, no doubt contemplating if its better to avoid this. I won't deny their assistant will help us out greatly. But so is the risk. Vanessa actually smiles a little hearing these conditions, I like it. Gives me an public excuse when I have to kick them out.

Okay, what's up with her. She is taking way to much anger out on both of them. Nathan says to me, isn't this abuse of power. I scoff hard, I don't want to hear from a guy who ruled Valley like a dictatorship. I am not you. I will not unilaterally make decisions for you both. But rest assured, I will make sure you both don't escape the consequences of your selfish actions. Nathan asks, only if we break your conditions though. I answers, goes without saying. If you really only want to help, that's well and good.

Nathan then relaxes a bit, in that case I accept. My only objective is to help here. Nothing else. I don't think Vanessa and me believed it even for a second. We turn to Rose for her response. She looks nervously to Nathan, who just nods at her to help her decide. She takes a moment to think and says, fine. This is still unfair thought, but I guess I can't complain it. Now I am sure she is here not really to help but because Nathan called her. She must be still following Nathans lead on some level.

I ask Vanessa, so you good with this. Vanessa had a small smile in the corner of her mouth, I guess I have to. I don't like them here, but I can't deny their kurets are efficient. Nathan cocks his head, great. Since its decided, lets get setup right away. Vanessa puts her hand up in front of him, hold up. Not so fast. Ruther, she waves to Ruther from the side. She says, escort these people for a checkup before we have them meet anyone. Check for any Kuret device, or anything they have on them. Do a complete inspection. Once that's done, assign two people for each to watch over them. Ruther comes forward and looks around to the two alphas in front of him. He was a little out of place, but kept his face composed.

He speaks out, got it. Follow me. They both follow him obediently, thankfully. Vanessa says, on second thought, let me watch over the two of them for a while. I don't trust Rose to leave her alone with any guys. She follows behind them. Rose makes a mocking face, I am hurt that you think so little of me. Vanessa brushes her off, oh please. Like you haven't thought of it. Rose shook her head, No. I meant that you think I cannot influence women. Please, after that humiliation from all those years back, I have been improving my skills. I bet I can make you do stuff too now.

She makes a teasing wink at Vanessa. God, this women must have a screw loose to test Vanessa like this. Especially today. Vanessa was surprisingly calm about it, but her tone wasn't, try it bitch. I'll make you regret it. Nathan cuts in before it escalates, settle down ladies, keep it professional. They all walk through the door leading to secure rooms. I am starting to think this could be a mistake. But I can't think too much about it now. I need to get answers. Others finally free from the drama get back to work.

Behind me Deni comes up and says, is everything all right then? Good question, I wasn't sure how to answer. I say, lets hope so. I turn to face her, is Elena awake. Deni nods, yes. She is. I just thought to gave her a moment to settle down before we begin asking her questions. Peter says her mind is clear and the doctor says her injuries are not threatening. We can begin questioning her. That's good, I said. We both walk back to the room Elena was resting. Peter was beside Ryan with his hand on his head. Ryan was slumped back on a chair opposite to Elena, eyes closed and neck resting on the side.

I step inside the room and take a look at Elina. She had cuts and wounds around her neck. There was a big cut on her chest. I could see her aura flickering with some pain. Considering the extent of her wounds, it was probably not a good idea to wake her up like this. The doctor comes up to me and says, Blake. I understand the situation and I object to this in spite of it. She needs to recover first. Her concerns were valid, I get it. I only need few minutes. You can stand by in case anything happens. She wasn't convinced but, nonetheless she wasn't going to object my direct orders. She nods slightly and walks out of the room.

At the same time Somers comes in, hey Blake. Glad you are here too. I head from Vanessa before he was in scuffle with Quintin. She was putting it mildly. I could still see his cracked bruises on his face. Deni says, you good. He touches the bruises on his face, I am. It still stings, but I can't just sit on my ass just because of this. His aura wasn't flickering too much, so I guess he has recovered enough. I ask, I heard Quintin gave you and Vanessa trouble, thanks for handling it.

He smiles with a little embarrassment, I barely slowed him. The guy was not in his right mind. If Vanessa hadn't shown up when she did, I am not sure if we could have stopped him. I can only imagine. Even with his injuries, he would have been tough to handle. I turn to my side as Peter stands up finishing using his Kuret on Ryan. He says, its done. He is fully asleep. Deni says, that took a while. He nods, kids usually have less resistance to my Kuret. But he was too terrified and anxious. I needed to exert some more Kuret to make him sleep. Though I suspect it won't last long, he will wake up in just few hours.

I say, that's plenty. Thanks. Then I thought about others lying in the infirmary, since you are here. Can you tell me anything about the other dozen people unconscious. Were you able to wake anyone up. Peter expression turns a little sour, not much progress there. They are not hurt badly, but they are still in bad shape. I am waiting for their wounds to heal enough before I attempt to wake them. Somers ask, what happens if you wake them now. He answers, doing so will have some risk. They will be dizzy and may even have trouble remembering some stuff. Some may not be effected, but its not a good idea to do on regular people. Now if they were warriors, that would

be different.

I turn to a see a tense Elina silently gazing at us from her bed. I ask, what does that mean for her then. I didn't know there could be a side effect like this. Will she be okay. He answers after thinking for a second, she should be fine. Unlike others, she wasn't beaten down. She had only a single wound. Granted that it was severe, but now that its been treated, she shouldn't reel from the side effect very much. Considering her initial condition, it's a quite impressive she recovered. I was confused. I remembered from the her video that she was stable back then. I ask, what do you mean. I thought her injuries weren't life threatening.

He turns to Deni with look like he wasn't sure what he wanted to say. She then peeks to Elina behind me and whispers quietly, the doctor who was just here. She told me she was actually very badly hurt. Maybe, Ryan was not exaggerating when he making it look like Elina was in worse shape. Somers asks, huh. You mean should could have died. Deni gulphs hard and nods, the doctor didn't confirm that, but she subtly implied that. I turn to face Elina. With my full focus on her now, she averts her eyes. I saw a slight change in her aura.

I say, she is definitely hiding something. I don't know about what though. Somers says, thanks Peter. We will take it from here. Keep me apprised about other others. He says, will do and leaves us. Finally, time to get some answers. I ask, I assume its okay to proceed without Vanessa here. Somers replies, no worries. Everything is recording here, so shouldn't be a problem. I walk to Elina's bed and stand beside her. Somers and Deni take the other side of the bed.

Elina was intimated by my presence and kept averting my eyes. Clearly she is trying to avoid having a conversation. But is it because of guilt or something else. I ask, Elina. How are you feeling. I open with a harmless question to ease into first. I thought being direct at first, but I decided to be neutral initially and change my tone based on her being a victim or part of the smuggling gang. She finally looks up to me with her eyes. She's a little hazy, but shakes her head slightly.

I answer, good. First of all, I assure you Ryan is fine. He was very protective of you, so we just had to make him sleep before we could talk. He will remain beside you, so don't worry about him. She looks at her sleeping kid brother with eyes filled with anxiety. But her aura relaxes a little. I ask next, but you should know its not looking good. We found in the middle of what looks like a drug smuggling gone wrong. We got people beaten and unconscious, from Citradel and Island. Among them some strong warriors. And in the middle of this mess, only you appear to the victim. I am looking for answers.

She remain frozen at my prodding. She was terrified now, clearing showing in her aura. Somers asks, help us. We can help you then. What are those crates and what do you know about them. Deni piles on, and who attacked you all. Elina closes her eyes trying to avoid us. I was loosing patience here. We finally got a witness but she is being incorporative. She hasn't spoken a single word. Would a victim really feel this much fear. Especially when I am in her presence now.

I decided to approach more directly now. I take a step forward and ask her, if you are not going to talk. We will have to detain you. I don't want to do this, because I don't think a kid would be involved in such a thing. But you might are. I can't guarantee Ryan would be safe from the consequences. I threatened just slightly to aggravate her. She suddenly blurts out, no don't. I am all the family he has right now. That opened her up. Somers asks confused, what do you mean. You got an older brother. We haven't been able to find him though.

Elina shuts down again. Deni asks, you need to tell use what happened. Like Blake said, it's a mess our there right now. Elina turns to face me suddenly. Her aura brightens a little, promise me Ryan will not be arrested. This isn't good. She asking for this means somehow he is also involved in this. I looked at Somers to answer that question. He would know best what to say to this. He answers, we will do our best. But we can't promise though. Its very unlikely he did anything in the presence of 3 warriors. Still, we won't make any decisions until we hear the whole story. Until then, he remains with you and us.

Elina didn't like this answer. But he wasn't wrong also. After giving it a lot of thought she relents. Her tense expression falls into resignation, its all my fault. I shouldn't have been so gullible when I went with Paul's ridiculous plan. I asked, who. Somers answers, their older brother. He is involved in this too. Where is he then. Elina looks even more somber now, he isn't here. Now this isn't a good sign. I ask, you are telling me your bother was with you.

She nods. I sigh, Somers, what do you know of this. Somers and Deni were both just as shocked, first time I am hearing. We had people scour the scene, we didn't find any other Kuret signature. After a moment Deni says, if all three siblings were there, isn't it possible his Kuret signature would have been hidden among the other two ? She was right. Somers clicks his tongue, you got a point. We missed it. Call Tessa now and ask her to investigate their Kuret again. Deni pulls out her phone and walks out immediately.

We might have a suspect now, I assume he is on the run. Elina says, I don't know. I must have blacked out before he left. I ask, is he the only who attacked everyone and ran off. Elina shook her head vigorously, no way. Our Kuret is a not suited for battle. We can just change our Kuret color. She demonstrated by gathering her kuret on her palm. The Kuret swirl around her fingers and begins to radiate different colors, like almost a rainbow. She disperses it, I can make it strong enough to be visible to others. Same as Peter. Its not even enough to be used as a distraction. Peter can't fight, let alone 3 warriors.

I already knew about her Kuret before, when I got information from Tessa. I knew he couldn't be capable. But I still thought to ask. My expression harden. If he isn't responsible then, why is he on the run. Or his is missing. I tell Sommers, there is detective with Tessa on the site. He is looking into the families and work places of the people involved. Tell him to check if Peter is hiding in any of them. Somers nods, yeah. Good idea. Now he also leaves the room with his phone in hand. Now just me and Elina remained in the room. I ask, tell me then what happened. Elina looks a little apprehensive about revealing the story, but she knows she had no choice.

She clears her throat, I work in a bar. I don't make much, but its much better than being hiding among Humans. I have a health condition after arriving on Earth. I need constant medication. She sighs before saying, I have very less hemoglobin count in my blood. So even small cuts takes longer time to heal. The doctor told me it was a miracle I survived with my condition. That's why the doctor told me Deni about how lucky she was. As much as I sympathize with her about her condition, its not just her. So many people have medical condition that needs constant supervision.

I ask, I can only imagine the challenges you face. But how is this related to the smuggling or the fight. I had a guess the drugs were part of it, but I want to know if she knows about it. She says, it started due from this. Peter approached me and told me he is building a network in the island that will supply stuff legally inside. I ask, stuff like. She gulps hard before answering, you saw the crates then. I nod, I did. I want to know if you know about it. She takes a long breath, I knew I shouldn't have done it. But I was desperate and thought it was safe.

She looks at Ryan for a bit and then to me, there are different type of drugs shipped. Sometimes it is controlled human substances, sometimes more extra legal stuff. I don't know the whole details. Only Peter knows about it. I heard from them and pieced it together. I was confused about something, you said legally. How in the hell did you think smuggled goods were legal. She immediately shook her head, I had no idea they were shipping drugs, or being carried inside the liquor bottles I order. I never imagined they were using my using my shipments to carry drugs like this.

Slowly I was able to understand her involvement in this. I say, you were a patsy? She gets frustrated, I can't believe Peter was using me like this. He told me that in order to get me my medicines, it would be best to get it with my usual orders of the particular type of alcohols that we mix Kuret with. He said it would be efficient since it reduces the commission charges. I thought it was a good idea. I was there with him for the first shipment in the crate. It was all legal and shipped through proper channel, security guys inspected it and approved it. Since then I always place my medicines with the bulk order of the alcohols. I always sign the shipment under my name.

She leans back and grits her teeth, stupid. I should have inspected the bottles myself. Peter handles the inventory in out shop, so I never realized the number of bottles I ordered is more than the number of bottles shipped in. I have been blindly signing off on larger shipments without realizing all this time. She closed her eyes and tears rolls off her eyes. He aura didn't seem to flicker too much, instead it showed regret and anger. Something one would expect of a victim rather than a co-conspirator.

I ask, you say you didn't know. But you clearly know about the creates and drugs now. When did you find out and what were you doing there. It was probably rude of me to continue asking when she is crying, but I want to get the crux of this mess. She takes a moment to wipe her tears from her cheeks. She regains her composure a little before saying, Peter never told me the specifics of how he was creating his supply chain. I assumed it was done all through proper channels. Today, around 7, he came to our shop and was in a hurry. He told me that there is a problem with the last shipment and needed my help.

Her voice breaks, I was confused at the time how I was involved since I never worked with him on this. The picture was beginning to get clearer now on how she was involved. But then I turn to Ryan, why take him with you. She answers, I didn't want to. He should have stayed with our neighbors, but Peter insisted he came along too. He was being evasive on why, but at that time I just followed him without questioning. She turns to her brother with teary eyes, I shouldn't have brought him. He was so terrified. He was only a baby when we left Medrine, never saw the horrors or the violence. Even on Earth, we never saw a single Echo. We were in hiding, but at least safe from violence. I failed to protect him.

More tears roll down from her eyes. I turned around to pick up tissues from the side and offer some to her. She quietly accepts them and wipes some off her face. As she was speaking, I didn't see her aura being deceitful. So most of it must be the truth. At least, I am very sure that her guilt is real. After she settles down she continues, Peter brought me the treatment plant. I was getting terrified how Peter was behaving and the remote place he was taking us. When we arrived, those people were waiting for us inside. The creates I have for my shipment were also there. I kept asking Peter to explain, but he never did. Instead, he kept saying to just answer all the questions they have for me and Ryan.

I ask, did they think you had something to do with the drugs. She hesitantly nods, I was being questioned by a guy named Wyan. He seemed like he was the boss. I recalled the names from the unconscious people, one of them was named Wyan. Its a good sign we at least have the boss in custody. She says, he asked stuff about missing bottles from my shipment. I said I didn't know anything about. I was expecting it to come 2 days later, not today. They ignored my questions on how they intercepted my shipment and kept asking Ryan and me about missing products.

I had no clue what they were talking. But they were almost interrogating me after some time. I wanted to leave. Begged Peter to let me and Ryan go because we didn't have anything to do with this, but he didn't. No one did. They were certain I stole something from them. Then she shouts with anger, but I didn't. Her small outburst was consistent with her aura. I ask, they were accusing you of stealing their drugs. There are drugs missing too now. This is worse now. We need to track missing drugs.

She settles down a bit, I don't know. Maybe. The way they were talking, it sounded more like they cared about who stole it rather than what was stolen. I can't be sure about it though. Peter was trying to defend us that we didn't know anything and by bring us there should prove our innocence. I tilt my head a little trying to make more sense of this. She continues, that guy, Wyan. He didn't believe us. He was sure I stole it. Given my medical condition, he thought I had something to do with it. I tried to explain that I get my stuff separately, but that freakier doesn't understand. I can't use heroine or cocaine for my hemoglobin platelet treatment. I don't know if was purposefully being dumber or just plain cruel. Her anger recalling the incident was clearly shown on her face.

I ask, what happened then. How did it get physical. Did the warriors do something ?. She shook her head, those people weren't in the room. They were outside the room, I saw them when coming inside the building. They were guarding the people. I almost choke at that. Those people hired top ranking warriors as their bodyguards. Seriously. Who were they thinking they need protection from. I ask, do you think they know they were protecting illegal drugs. She answers, I don't know. Maybe. People inside the room were shouting and screaming. Sometimes at me or each other. I doubt those three didn't hear us.

If I assume they were part of this, then it makes sense why Quintin was trying so desperately to flee. He knows he is screwed when others wake up. I put my hand on my chin, so they were hired muscles. How much would they be paying to such powerful people to work for them. Did they say anything about them. She answers, no. I don't think even cared who was on the other side. They weren't discrete at all when they kept shouting at me or Peter. I felt a little despair, its almost looking like they were really part of it. That's bad. I had kept some hope that they were unknowingly being used or at least not completely complicit. Now we need to treat them as smugglers too.

Seeing my expression change she asks with her voice broken, please you have got to help me. I was being used, I had no idea this whole operation was going on. She begins to sob slowly now. I don't know if I can help her. Her brother is directly involved. If Peter isn't found it could be bad for her. Her name is on all the shipments. I didn't answer her but instead ask, how did you get injured. At this point they were just questioning you. Her tears were slow, but still there. She becomes grim when recalling.

She says, there was this another guy. Don't know his name. He was getting impatient more than others. He thought I was just acting and purposefully playing dumb. He tried to become more physical with me. But before he could, Peter tried to shake him off me. The guy pushed him away. Ryan was so terrified and confused about what was going on. He suddenly just went and kicked the guy. No one was expecting it from him. The guy got angry and I saw him preparing his Kuret. I don’t know what it was. All I know I he was about to hurt a my baby brother. So I rushed in front, pushed Ryan away and got hit. Whatever that Kuret did, it tore a hole in my chest. I blacked out from the pain and woke up here.

She finishes recounting her story while gazing with watery eyes at Ryan. I am almost certain she wasn't lying to me. So I assume this turn of events, something happened after she was cut down. I ask, you don't remember the in fighting or how they all were knocked out ? She shook her head in a panic, I have no idea how that happened. Next thing I know, I woke up here. I only got to know about other when that officer Deni told me.

This got a whole lot crazier. I just hope we can find this Peter guy to shed more light on how this happened. I tell her, I understand. Get some rest now. I will send the doctor in now. I know you are worrying about Ryan, but first rest up. We will decide what happens to you both later. She couldn't do anything but accept this for now. I turn my back on her and walk about. Just before I step out, I ask her, before I go, tell me one thing. You siblings are very close, I can tell that. Are you by any chance protecting Peter by not telling where he is.

She shook her head adamantly, I wouldn't do that. He needs to make this right. I want him found. She says that, but the only time her aura had flickered a tiny bit was when he heard Peter is missing. She felt relieved. I could have misread it. Maybe it was about being safe from him. I guess Nathan was right. He can read aura much better than me. I nod, I see. Well, we will find him no matter what. Thanks.

I walked out from the room letting her rest. I told someone to tell the doctor I am done. Well, at least with her. We got to find Peter. Maybe I should ask Vanessa to send more crew to Tessa. Just as I was thinking about the next action, Ruther rushed towards me with a anxious face, hey Blake. A guy just came back to the treatment plant and asked to be turned in. He says he was involved in the incident. His name is Peter, guess what. He is the brother of the injured lady.

A small smile came to my mouth and then a chuckle that made Ruther confused.

Vanessa (Chapter 66)

Monday, January 5, 2026 19:39

My eyes never left them, even for a second. I was doubly cautious of Rose. Her Kuret is invisible and can effect even with just scent. I could tell she wasn't using her Kuret. But I won't be taking any chance. I watched like a hawk when they were searched thoroughly for anything suspicious item. Fortunately they were clean. Rose was fidgety about being searched, deal with it, I said. She makes a scorn expression to me. I didn't care if this make her uncomfortable. Actually, I slightly enjoyed it.

Rose snaps, you are staring at me so hard. Did you accidently get a whiff of my Kuret. You know it might leak out accidently. I scoff at her. She has been just messing with me all the time. She kept goading me as we escort them to Cory. Nathan says, come on ladies. Focus. I am so annoyed at Nathan, acting like he is managing me. Like we are back in Valley. Before they walk inside the prison cell, I put an arm at the door. I sneer at him, you know the ground rules. Break it and I will be kicking you out of here. So please, I lean in closer to say, do break it. I am just waiting to get my hands on you both.

I basically threatened them. Nathan giggles a little and raises his arm surrendering, I promise I will behave. You need to relax a little Vanessa. We are in this together. I was still mad at him from this morning a little. Earlier when Blake forced me to listen, I realized I have been venting out my anger on others all day. Some may deserve it, but most don't. But its hard to feel any guilt or embarrassment with Rose here. She was getting on my nerves. I waited for her response.

She snickers saying, yeah fine. I will play along with you guys for a while. I drop my arm and allowed them inside. Nathan and his guard Dan first go in. I tell Dan, do not stop your Kuret on him, no matter what. Tell me immediately if he is using his Kuret other than reading auras. He replies, I got it covered. Won't let him do anything suspicious. His Kuret sensitivity is high, so he can pick up Kuret being used by anyone much better than others. Before Rose walks in, she asks me, tell me something. Why haven't you called David. I thought he would be here.

I got curious, why, you want to give it a shot and try controlling him again. Don't bother. He is beyond anyone's control now. I spat out angrily without meaning to. I thought how these days he can manipulate others, even without her Kuret. She mocks, wow. Someone's salty. He is my greatest adversary and an enigma at the same time. To this day, he is the only guy to ever resist me. I still don't know how he did it. I don't believe in that strong mind bullshit he told back then.

I was slightly amused by her irritation. I didn't offer her any answer. Actually, I myself don't know how he did it. He never told me how he did it. She grumbles a little, anyways, I saw him using my Kuret yesterday. I am not kidding when I say that I was horrified to see my Kuret used in the match. That Kuret was definitely like mine, but what a slopy control. Still, it would have worked. Why did Nathan brought me instead of him.

So that's what she meant. I wasn't going to give any an answer that would give hints about my issues with David, so I reply with a answer she will eat it without questioning, he can't control other Kurets. He can only direct and throw. Finner control is beyond him. Like you said, when he used your bloodline Kuret, it wasn't focused. Using him wouldn't be nearly as efficient as the original Medrones. That cleared her doubt, oh. Gotch ya. Makes sense now. Well, I suppose I should solace in the fact that I am still better at this than him.

I didn't pursue this topic any further. She sighs, but I did want to try my Kuret on him once again. You know, just to see how much I have leveled up. I yell at her, enough. Get inside, I say while grabbing her arm and shoving her inside, hey that's rude. The guard assigned to her walks behind her. I tell Errika, do not let her touch anyone except Cory. Not even you. She needs only a second to induce a thought control. She nods, I will box her in with my shield Kuret if she does anything.

I carefully chose these to be their guards because they would have the best chance of thwarting anything Nathan and Rose do. I closed the door and walk to the front of the transparent one sided wall. I whished I was inside with them, but I decided its best not to be in the vicinity of Rose while her Kuret is active. Nathan was already in discussion with Cory, disappoint me. You were always showed initiative, but not like this. He was sitting opposite to Cory, who had his hands tied behind on the chair.

Cory didn't speak, only snarled at Nathan. Nathen laughs, you sure did become more confident. You wouldn't dare do this sort of thing back in the Valley. I guess coming in the top ranking of the tournament gave you a ego boast, yeah. Then Rose came in and stood beside Cory. Seeing her appear with him made Cory agitated. He had to know what was coming. Rose says, hey Cory. Long time no see. She walked around him like a predator on hunt. She still hadn't used her Kuret. The two guards were now on the opposite side of the walls with their eyes and Kuret glued on the two interrogating.

Nathan asks, tell me how you became involved his smuggling drugs. Normally, I would have been impressed you had the guts to do this. But not now. We are in a middle of an important Medrone milestone. You screwed up big time. I bet you guys have been doing this for a while. And then you go and mess up somehow. And even get caught. That's just pathetic. Did you learn nothing from me. Cory had been trying to remain composed all this time. But Nathan was making him angry little by little. I might not like it, but Nathan was right. He knew which buttons would push for Cory.

Rose finally halts in front of Cory, you just didn't get caught. You got pretty beat up. I don't like it when strong guys get beaten, that's a turn off you know. I don't know what her angle was here. Did she thought that would make a rise out of him. Nathan slides his arm on the chair and turns to me, in case you are wondering, Cory here had a massive crush on Rose here. That clears it. Jealousy and shame, that's her angle. Cory's composure was slowly crumbling. I don't know why Rose isn't using her Kuret immediately.

Rose turns to Nathan, really. I didn't know. Well, she lights taps Cory's shoulder who jerked away in reflex, there are always people who are perusing me. I can't remember every one of them. She laughs. Cory veins starts to pop up. He glares at Rose with eyes that look like he was about to hit her. Rose says, wow. Just look at that stare. Don't tempt me Cory. I might accidently use too much Kuret and turn you into a drooling puppet. I sigh at this ridiculous performance. So far Nathan's asked only one obvious question. I know there are different interrogation ways, but this is seems like they are just insulting him where it hurts.

I knock at the wall a couple of times to signal them. Nathan shifts on his chair, whoops. Our chief is getting a little impatient. Rose smiles, don't worry Vanessa. We are professionals. Dealing something like this was like eating breakfast back in the Valley. I did not participate much in the internal Valleys businesses, so I admit I don't know their routines. But still, they should move on with the questioning. Nathan says, but you are in hospitality now. Your skills might have rusted for this. Rose touches Corys shoulders again. He shakes them off but Rose was more forceful this time and kept her grip.

She says, on the contrary, I get to perfect my craft on people even more now. A short breath escapes my mouth hearing that comment. The hell is she on about. She clarifies, my work in Valley was very focused, getting truth out of someone or just straightaway control their actions. But now I get to diversify my Kuret applications. She slides her tip of the fingers on his arms and necks. Its a pity I don't get to do big stuff, but I am happy focused on small stuff you know. Especially in this tournament, where I had various jobs, keeping angry people from going overboard, shutting down any in fighting. Some were alphas or omegas, so I had to level up my game.

Nathan smiles, I see. So that's where the confidence comes from. Cory was jerking around trying avoid contact from Rose, who still hadn't used her Kuret on him. Is this some kind of slow anticipation tactic, make him so nervous just by touching him like this. Nathan smiles, so you are stronger than when you were in Valley. Rosy finally beings to use her Kuret. She gathers some on her hands first. Erika on the other end takes one step ahead, keeping a much closer eye on her now.

She makes a teasing gesture by running her running her fingers on Cory's neck and cheeks. She grins saying, you bet I am. I have been training on my own way. She then grazes her hand on his hair. Corys composure was breaking down now. We had blocked his Kuret access, so he shouldn't be able to resist much longer. Then she comes face to face to him, even this is a training. I will not be satisfied until I tame him. I shook my head in disgust. Just how much obsessed is she with David.

Nathan snickers, you don't think Cory here is good enough for you. I mean, sure he got beat up, but he was still in upper echelon of warriors. Rose kept her eyes focused on a struggling Cory, I told earlier didn't I. I don't like strong guys who get beaten so easily. Cory's face became red, flushed with uncontrollable anger. At this point Rose lets loose a wave of her Kuret from her entire body and envelopes Cory's head. Erika takes two more steps towards Rose. Rose ignored her presence, puts her hands on Corys shoulders and says, you are nothing without me. Become stronger with me.

I step closer to the wall slightly anxiously. Rose's Kuret had actually become more potent. She wasn't kidding when she said she was training. The level of her Kuret spreading around the room was dangerous. Maybe this was a mistake, what if she infects Dan or Erika. What I get hit by it too. I was thinking of barging in, but then her Kuret suddenly stops spreading. Instead it was contained around her. I turn to Nathan who was using a bit of his Kuret to box in Rose's Kuret. This guy, he is already breaking the rules.

Dan was already a step ahead of me and walks to Nathan, stop this immediately. You are not allowed to use your Kuret here. Nathan now raised his palm towards Rose, really, you should thank me instead. If I hadn't done this Rose's Kuret would have effected everyone here. Dan makes a stern expression, we don't need your help, just because you are high ranking officers doesn't mean you get to do whatever inside IDF. I'll give you one last warning. Nathan smirks seeing Dan hovering him from the side. Nathan dispels his Kuret, all right. But happens when you become her slave.

Dan relaxes a little, and so did I when I see what happened on the other side of the room. Dan signals to look over there. Erika was already on the move, she had already used her Kuret to create a thin Kuret walls around Rose. She had her arms extended towards Rose from same position she was a second ago. Dan asks, you good. Erika didn't looked pressured, she nods, piece of cake. Nathan actually looked surprised to see that, impressive. I didn't even catch the speed of your reflexes. He then turns to Dan, apologies for my hasty behavior. I don't know you both, so I didn't know what your Kurets could do.

Nathan actually seemed shocked. Maybe he was really caught off guard. I turn to Rose and Cory. They both were still locked in what could only described as a mental battle. My eyes widen when I saw Cory with a pained expression. Huh, all the times I have seen her Kuret, wasn't it based on seduction and pleasure. What kind of BDSM tactic was this. Nathan cuts in, since I broke the rules, does that mean I have to leave. It was just a innocent mistake on my part though.

Dan turns towards me through the wall. I did threaten him that if he used his Kuret, I would kick him out. But seeing him and Rose halfway there already, it wouldn't make sense to kick him out now. Plus he only used his Kuret on Rose. I sigh and knocked the glass wall once. Dan got the message and says to Nathan, I guess you get one more chance. I suggest you don't waste it. He walks back to the same spot and resumes observing him from a distance. Nathan turns to face me, thanks Vanessa. And my word, you seem to have reliable people around you. He then chortles, I am happy at least someone learned from me.

My fist tighten unconsciously. Even when praising others he can't help but include himself. His narcissism knows no bound. Behind him Rose finally disperses her Kuret and let goes of Cory. She was visibly heaving. Did she just went for a brute approach rather than her usual ways. The Kuret around her begins to disappear and Errika removes her Kuret barrier. She yells, whoo. What a workout. Cory's stubborn face was gone, it was now replacing with a bright glow. He was staring at Rose, but not with hate, with admiration now.

He says, Rose, please, be my strength. He was completely love sick. I was confused seeing this complete opposite behavior from a second ago. He was in pain, but now he is in euphoria. What did she do to him. Rose walks and takes the seat beside Nathan, he was a challenge, I am not going to lie. I guess he really did become stronger than the last time I saw him. His internal Kuret was pushing back. I didn't expect him to resist so strongly, and so I had to go all out on him. She looks around the people in the room, sorry guys if I put you under my spell. She wasn't being apologetic, she was enjoying herself.

Nathan says, I suspected that was the case when you suddenly went berserker. But you know, if this lady wasn't here to stop it, we all would probably had been infected. What do you think Vanessa would have done then. Rose turns to me and says, I don't know. Maybe she would have knocked me out, or maybe she would have been my next target. I grit my teeth with annoyance. This bitch is not really afraid of me at all. I need to correct that. Nathan

says, playing with fire is fine, but you need to watch out, because this fire will burn you in more ways than one.

Rose got the message loud and clear because she backed off, just kidding. I would have stopped. She turns her back to me, but I could swear see her mouthing, probably. Nathan says, well, that was fun and all, but lets focus on our task. Cory was now swaying her head like he was high and kept his eyes glued to Rose. Nathan asks, I assume when he was hurting, he was actually enjoying it. And that turned him like this so quickly.

She says, just think of it as the fine line between pleasure and pain. The stronger the Kuret resistance, the more pain they feel. I just redirect that pain into pleasure. Doesn't work on all people. There are some weirdos with high tolerance for it. But most people are unexperienced and would succumb to it soon.

Even if she explains it like that, that's basically just a BDSM thing. Nathan says, you have are trying out various forms of seduction now. You went from an sweet angel to demon style dominatrix. She laughs, I can still do it like I used to. Its just on Cory I decided jealously would be much better emotion. Okay, now they are just enjoying themselves. This isn't a freaking torture chamber. I slam my fist on the glass hard. Rose says, okay. Okay. No need to get so feisty. I was just making small talk. Jeez, don't you know I work in hospitality now. This is how you make people like you. She had the nerve to question my authority here like this.

Nathan clears his throat, lets not make her more angry. He waves his hand to Cory, by all means Rose. She leans in forward to Cory and asks, what happened Cory. Tell me why you were involved in smuggling drugs. Cory hazy eyes didn't blink one answering, will that make you happy my love. Rose replies, very much. Cory nods like a dog wagging his tail, it was 4 months ago. I was approached my a guy named Wyan. He said he had plan to supply goods into the island. Wyan, huh, he is one of the people lying unconscious here.

Nathan asks, and what were these goods. Cory suddenly barks at Nathan, shut up you mongrel. You aren't worthy of seating beside Aphrodite reincarnated. He tries to wriggle out of his chair and shows his teeth to him. Nathan slumps back, what the hell. I had the same reaction. Its like a switch flipped from drunk to menacing. Rose says, I should mentioned before, because he is decently strong, his Kuret was inverted turned too much by mine. He will listen to me alone. Nathan shook his head but still smiled, I suppose will only be gesturing each other then.

Rose asks, tell me the whole story Cory. I would love to how a strong man such as yourself became a drug smuggler. Cory immediately settles down and answers, Wyan talked about how he wants to take control of the shipments channels and bring in stuff mixed with others. Rose asks, so this Wyan, he was using other people's shipment to get his own drugs delivered inside. Cory shook his head, it wasn't only drugs. The gets all kinds of things like, stolen artifacts that Medrones prefer, animals, things like that. Anything that people want and is possible for Wyna to get.

I see, so he is importing stuff we don't want. We banned these stuff on the island because we don't want to mix in with Medrone culture and instead promote on relearning our lost heritage. We have allowed simple harmless possession, like we definitely borrowed human technology, but not these things that impact Medrone culture. I didn't realize that there are people desperate enough to smuggle stuff here. Nathan signals something to Rose, she asks, do you also get something for your corporation Cory. You don't strike me as man in it for money.

Cory makes a gleeful smile, of course, I am not like the other two who were just in it for the money. I protect his shipments whenever it comes, from the security gate to the time its delivered to the client, in exchange I get the treatment for my condition. I see, that makes sense, If I remember correctly, coming to earth has burnt his taste buds. Back in Valley I vaguely remember him taking some sort of injections for a temporary sensation. Rose asks, I suppose it was difficult for you to live here with more Medrone cuisine culture coming back, but not able to taste it.

Cory replies, but don't worry. I don't give a crap about it, as long as I am with you, I don't want to taste anything, only you. My face distorts in disgust. She has turned him into a slobbering love sick freak. He is obsessed with her now. But Rose didn't mind at all. In fact she was enjoying the attention, oh my poor pet. You need to be spanked properly. Cory brights up with lust in his eyes. Nathan clears his throat and Rose asks, right, so who are these clients. He says, don't know. I never know their identities. I just keep guard at a certain drop points and when its picked up, my work is done. I never get to see who they were.

She asks, who has the information. Does you boss Wyan has. Cory immediately scoffs, that guy is careful, even he didn't want to know who the clients are. The only one who keeps a record is Jade. She keeps a digital file locked in somewhere, arranges for the communication between Wyan and clients. Only she knows their identities. Just like Wyna, Jade is also here in the detention center. That's good. With both of them in custody, we will get all the information about their smuggling network.

Seeing how undetectable they have been all this time, this incident actually helped us uncover a big smuggling operation like this. This is bad, but also good. Even if the timing is not ideal, we still got everything we need to dismantle their operation now. Nathan leans in closer whisper something to Rose. Cory becomes enraged as he got closer to Rose and begins to shout at him. I tuned out most it because it was same thing over an over again. Instead I mulled over the actions I will need to do with this information.

Rose then asks, what happened today. With such a carefully crafted organization, its so strange that so many would gather in one place. Cory nods, I never met so many people working with Wyan before today. But it was an emergency. I don't know what it was initially, they just wanted the 3 of us to guard them and some crates we had brought a week ago. Later I pieced it together that someone is steeling from the smuggled goods. We don't guarantee complete order to our clients, because there are always some risks, unforeseen accidents or issues in transport. But we still maintain a minimum. Lately, the drugs we smuggle were under the acceptable margin loss.

Someone was steeling from them. That must be enough of a reason to have them congregate together like this. Rose asks, someone was a tad bit greedy huh. Did you find out who it was. Cory shrug his shoulders, I don't know. I was only guarding the place, they all were talking inside. All though, I kept hearing people shouting or accusing someone time to time. So I guess they were still trying to figure it out. Nathan signals something to Rose. She asks, if they were trying to root out the traitor, does that mean that women Elina, the who was hurt was the culprit. Did they decide to eliminate her.

I gulp a little hearing this question. Nathan is basically asking if they would be bold enough to straight up murder the culprit. Cory replies, I don't know if she stole from us. But I could tell she wasn't a part of us. Rose asks, then what was she and her brother doing there. Cory says, I saw one of the guys, Peter, I think his name, left the treatment plant and brought back those two. I was hesitant to let outsiders in, but Quintin said Wyan summoned them.

Hold on, I took out the list of people we are holding and there is no one named Peter. Was this an alias. It could be. I don't like where this is heading though. Rose asks, why were they called. Cory answers, I didn't know initially. I was little anxious that a kid was brought here. So I stood a little closer to the window from the 1st floor and listened in. Turns out Peter brought his siblings to them. They were accusing them of steeling the drugs. That women kept denying, but everyone was sure it was one of them two for some reason.

This makes it even more confusing, we know Elina had a older brother, but he is not among the unconscious people we found. I quickly messaged Dan to confirm this. Rose was in middle of question to know if Cory had seen them before. Dan reads the message and says to Rose, chief wants to show him the list of the unconscious people faces and see if he recognized Peter among them. Cory immediately yells, get that hell away from her you freak. I will gut you and feed you to dogs. This a goddess and you are an eyesore.

Dan glared at Cory. He ignored him a second later, but I could tell he wanted to punch him. Cory says, oh, you want to go. Let me out and I will finish you in a second. Only I get to talk to my lady. Rose laughs hysterically, oh Cory. You are just too much. If I didn't find her voice to be useful to her Kuret, I would have just gagged her mouth. Nathan takes the tab from Dan and keeps it on the table in front of Cory. Rose says, Cory, be a dear and point out Peter among these.

Cory immediately yells, why. Am I enough. You don't need that rat. He is just a bottom feeder, I am more of use to you. She says, of course you are. I just want to know if he is an eyesore too. Cory was giddy by her comment and takes a look at the 11 people photos. A moment later he says, he isn't here. That rat must have escaped during the chaos. He is good at that. My suspicion was correct, he might be even responsible for Elina getting hurt. But would he hurt her own sister.

Nathan turns to me and says, Vanessa, if this guy isn't here. He might know what really happened. Cory was just a guard dog, but this one might have all the answers. I agreed with him. He then waves his hand to Rose. She asks, did he hurt Elina and ran ? Her own sister. Cory scoffs, the guy is nothing. He hasn't seen much fighting, let alone be violent. I couldn't see who actually hurt the women, but I ran inside when I heard her scream. The kid brother was bawling his eyes out beside her sister on the floor and I saw Peter covering at a corner.

Now we are getting to the real mystery of all they were knocked out. Rose asks, what happened then. Cory turns grim, its not important Rose. You shouldn't worry about stuff like this. Is he for real. I thought Rose would remain amused, but she wasn't. Her smile dropped and turn a little serious, you are resisting it. I must reassess my Kuret concentration. Nathan looks curiously at her. She answers, I could feel him pushing my Kuret a little, it could be because its getting weaker, but I suspect he is resisting about telling what happened to him. Its impressive he resisted this much even when I went all out.

Cory was a little subdued since he didn't shout at Nathan for speaking to Rose. Nathan asks, is that right. So I guess I also have to re examine him. What does mean for the interrogation though. Rose leans forward with her Kuret on her hand, not to worry. I just need to override his emotions again. She puts her palm on his jaws in an effort to make him love sick again. While it makes me happy that even Rose is struggling a little, it reminds me again that both he and Quintin are strong.

A while later Rose takes her hand off him, what. I could feel him fighting desperately. What a guy. He must really not want to tell us how he was beaten. She clicks her tongue in frustration. Nathan asks, no dice huh. She says, up until this point he didn't care too much about reveling about his organization. But I guess his warrior pride and ego is making him less suspectable to my Kuret. Seriously, he is clamping up about the real details. I waited for a little longer for Rose to try and get Cory talking.

But he kept resisting. I could tell even Rose was gradually becoming irritated. Nathen turns to me, looks like this might go longer. What should we do now Chief. I wonder about this. I messaged Dan and Errika with the next course of action. They both read the message and walk closer to them. Errika says, if we can't get answer from him right now. We can try to pry it from Quintin or Polly. Nathan says surprised, I thought for sure I would only get to talk to Cory. She is allowing to interrogate others too.

Dan says, that's right. Personally, I don't want to see this ridiculous performance, but I can't deny the results. Nathan nods while thinking. I didn't decide this lightly. I really didn't want him in IDF, but we already made an exception. While they both are annoying as hell, like Dan said, they were useful. Rose complains, yeah. No, I agreed for Cory. But not others. Errika says, why. You have somewhere more important need to be. Rose smiles, this place is depressing, kills my vibe.

She was being frivolous here. Nathan then says, it's a good opportunity to get some favors from them Rose. We were not allowed inside, but now we can open a line of communication. I was afraid he would think this way, but I guess I can't help it. Rose understood what it meant, really, like I might get to do this more often. That would be sweet. These two are getting ahead of themselves. Like hell I would make this a recurring thing. Dan cuts in, anyways. If we can't get more out of him, we will try with other two.

Nathan nods, sounds like a plan. This is good. I am so happy I got this opportunity to show our skills to you IDF people. I shook my head hopping I didn't do a mistake. After waiting for a while, someone steps into my viewing room. It was Somers. His face was still not fully healed, but he definitely looked better. He asks, any progress. I nod, yes. He was surprised, really. When I heard you allowed those two in, I thought it was a mistake. I raise my eyebrow at him.

He becomes defensive, no I just meant them being her caused a bit of stir. I understood his intention. I sigh, with Blake here I didn't want to seem petty. I felt a little guilty throwing the boss card, but I wasn't going to give any other excuse. Somers smiles, anyways. I wanted to tell what Elina just told us. I face him with anticipation. He briefly explained her story and how Peter was missing. I listened intently to him, aligning with the information I got

from Cory.

Then I told him about the smuggling operation they have been. He was shocked like me earlier, damn. So it wasn't just drugs. Elina must of heard or remembered only about the drugs. I say, this tracks with what I heard from Cory. We need to find Peter immediately. He says, Deni and I made the calls. We missed his Kuret earlier. But now I am sure Tessa must be on his trail. I answers, that’s good. But still we don't know how they were all knocked out.

We both waited as we listened to Rose grumbling when Cory would mumbles something to her questions, but nothing noteworthy. Then the door opens and Deni comes out, guys, I just got a call from Tessa that some guy named Peter just walked to the treatment site and wants to turn himself in. That made me and Somers anxious, but also hopeful. He says to me with a small smile, we got him.

Blake (Chapter 67)

Tuesday, January 6, 2026 21:53

I was very tiered, but the latest news about Peter kept me agitated. I sat on the lobby sofa waiting for Tessa to bring him in. I had another cup of coffee Kuritine to keep me going. Its 11:00 now. I didn't have much spare thoughts other than this chaos. But I took some time to think about the deadline David was talking about. I am very certain he was talking about something his discussion with Dr. Drew. Its going to be midnight soon. As much I want to go and check on David, I am needed here more. Besides, I can't do anything to help out David.

The door opens with Vanessa and Somers walking in. I get up from the couch anxious, is he here? Vanessa says, not yet. Tessa can't fly like us you know. Of course I know that, but I was too much agitated. I say, you heard about Elina's brother then. She nods while they both take a seat on the other couch. Vanessa then told me what she learned from Cory. I figured the scope of the organization may not be limited to just drugs.

I hesitantly ask, I am going to regret asking this, but did he say anything about weapons or anything close to fire power. She shook her head nervously, no. My expression became somber, so we can't rule that out. Somers says, but that doesn't mean they smuggled it. I mean why would you even want human weapons when we have Kuret. Vanessa answers for me, that's only if you talk about officers or warriors. Regular Medrones still would benefit from using guns.

I slump back on the couch thinking about the report Vanessa gave few months back. She probably recalled that as well, Blake, do you think the stash of weapons we found was given by Wyan too. That's exactly why I asked her. Somers says, wait I remember that now. Oh shit. Yeah, its possible. We found the weapons, but no Kuret signature, no one tying to it. I say, that's what worrying me. We need to get search Jades place and find that data and their clients.

Vanessa says, I just sent a team to Wyan and Jades home. We will find it soon. No matter how long it takes. I sigh, the silver lining of all this mess is that we uncovered a criminal gang. With the boss in custody and their very physical presence with a smuggled goods, they are caught red handed. They won't get away with this. Vanessa says, you got that right. We already have their Kuret signature all over the place, soon we will get forensic evidence with exact Kuret match too.

But it won't be so simple. I get a small headache thinking of all the backlash I would get from Citradel and other communities. We have to disclose this to public, no way I can keep a lid on this. If we can get all the clients and the smuggled goods, it will mitigate the uproar it would cause. Vanessa says, this is good Blake. We have a win here. I don't know how she was so optimistic here. But she did have a point. Its not a total loss. We caught this before Heraknus moved. Before Citradel or any other community moved.

I nod, yeah. I know. I was just thinking what I tell people. I don't want people to think we had no clue about this. Somers says, but we were all busy with the tournament. I shook my head, doesn't matter. There will always be things that keeps us busy. Echo attack, humans spy or whatever. We should always project strength for our Island city. Otherwise people will not come here. Vanessa says in low tone looking suddenly depressed, I didn't think that. Yeah, it would effect people morals too.

The mood was getting depressing. I jerk my body straight, its fine Vanessa. I wasn't accusing you or the IDF. Its just politics. People just need one flaw to assume the worst. But let me worry about it. You guys just focus on getting catching everyone involved. Vanessa aura flickered with a little guilt. I would tell her not to worry so much, but she is the chief of IDF, and would also share a little bit of burden. I don't want to make any promises to her so for now I just let her handle this on her own.

The door opens again. I jerked up again. Somers says, not yet Blake. I just asked for dinner. I had a chance to eat earlier while I was resting. So have most of the other crews. I am sure you both haven't eaten anything since our break. Two people come and place wrapped boxed on the table in front. I wasn't in any mood to eat, but I need to keep up my energy. Vanessa says, thanks guys. The people leave us to our dinner. I might not have been feeling hungry, but the first bite make me realize I was indeed hungry.

While we ate, I asked couple of things about Cory's interrogation. Then I realized Vanessa allowed Nathan and Rose to interrogate others. That momentarily made me amused, must have been tough to keep them both here. Vanessa makes a pouting face while she ate, you have no idea. I was never part of this back in Valley, so I never saw them in action before. But sheesh, they both were basically just hurling insults at him to rile him up. I thought it only works in theory, but they somehow made it work.

I could imagine. Its not just about riling up. Its getting to a point slowly where they will slip up the most. I ask, are you okay with them without your supervision then. She says, I left Dan and Errika to keep an eye on them. They are quite effective and because those two are behaving for now. Somers laughs, you were just annoyed with them and didn't want to deal with them more. She shot a look at him. Somers gets his smile cut down from her glare. That's probably true.

Vanessa sighs, I am worried about one thing though. They both going to cash in this favor for something. I don't know what though. And that terrifies me. I help her out, don't worry about that. Since I asked you to let them in, I will take care of it. Vanessa snickers, I was thinking about letting you handle them anyways. She really didn't want to manage Nathan or Rose. Its not her fault though, I am sure she must not want to recall her time with them in Valley.

About 10 minutes later Somers gets a ping his phone. This was it, finally. Somers check it and faces us, Tessa is here. They just arrived in a car outside. All of us wasted no time and prepared ourselves to get real answers. Vaness leads us into a separate interrogation room she asked earlier. This cell is similar to the one the warriors were put in, but was less secure. Didn't matter though, with me and Vanessa present inside and desperate for answers, there is nothing he could do.

Vanessa asked Somers to keep everyone out. She says, they are free to view from the window wall, but make sure no one disturb us while we talk to peter. Only in case of any emergency, Somers will come inside. Somers agrees with her and coordinates the crowd growing outside. I took the seat on the left and waiting for Peter to come in. Behind us I could see Nathan's aura coming from the other side. He was there too. I don't see Rose's Kuret though. Vanessa saw me looking at the wall.

She asks, you looking for something. I ask, Nathan's here. Can't see Rose. She is like prepping Peter or something like that. I don't think we need to do that since Peter came in willingly. She took a seat next to me, no. Rose got tiered and asked to take a break. She is resting in some room. Her expression becomes sour, I allowed one specific waiting room, but my god. Guys were gooning hard on her. They have been offering to help her, moving the couch or getting her food.

I know this was tense situation, but it was a little funny. I ask, I assume you have her surveilled though. She waves her hand, I wouldn't be here if I hadn't taken care of it. I was very cautious of them in the beginning. Setting aside their attitude, they are not causing problems. So I think its fine for now. The conditions you gave still apply though. They both are not allowed to use their Kuret. I guess they have garnered enough trust for this much from her.

With that out of the way, I gathered my thoughts about the task in hand. A minute later Peter was brought in. He was wearing casual jeans a T shirt. His hair was a mess,, face was covered in some light bruises, dirt on his clothes, but no wounds. I was expecting him to be more injured. He is not an alpha, so he wouldn't have healed already. So it means he wasn't injured to begin with. Did he really escape from a situation where 3 warriors were beaten.

Tessa was bringing him in. She had his arm grabbed as she brought her to the chair in front of us. Up close I could see his eyes agitated. His aura was completely drenched with guilt and fear. A little bit of shame too. Vanessa asks, any problem bringing him here. Tessa says, no. He never spoke a word on the ride here. Never gave a response to any questions I asked. He looks to the both of us with fear. Vanessa glared at him more closely than me. Tessa says, though he did ask about Elina and Ryan once we stepped inside the building. I didn't tell him anything, I didn't have the updates on her condition.

I nod, thanks Tessa. We will take it from here. She takes a final look at the fidgeting Peter and leaves us. Vanessa was still trying to figure him out. I say, Elina is fine. Ryan too. They both are resting in the infirmary. That made his aura less worried. He was visibly less tense too hearing about his sibling. Vanessa asks, you shouldn't have involved them. You knew your sisters has a medical condition. Yet you risked her. The doctor said she got lucky we got her in time.

His mouth twitches as he heard that. He says with a meek voice, I want to see her. Vanessa shook her head, she is sleeping right now. Besides, I have a feeling she doesn't want to see to you. His eyes avert us and he slouches her head a little. I ask, if you are so worried about her, why did you ran ? You should have stayed with your siblings. Your sister nearly died and you let your brother fending for himself. He didn't respond or made any movement, but his aura showed more shame.

Vanessa asks, we know all about the smuggling organization you are part of. Your criminal friends, including your boss Wyan is in our custody. Soon we get the records of all the things you illegally brought into the island and for whom. There is nothing you all can do now that we have caught you all literally five feet away from a smuggled drugs. Staying silent doesn't help you at all. Just tell us what happened and you might be able to some lighter punishment.

Our judicial system isn't really impartial right now, its more like a tribunal. We don't have lawyers or advocates for people to defend or make a case. I had hoped we be ready with a defined administration before we run into things like this. We have to consult with Citradel on how they handle this since their people are also mixed in this. Regardless, their crimes are now apparent. The only question is how much offense they did. Peter suddenly becomes grim. I see his aura changing.

He snaps quietly, It's easy for you all to judge me a coward. But what could I done then. His demeanor changes to anger and slams his fist on the table in front. I prepared a little bit of Kuret in my palm just he in case he got agitated and needed to be restrained. Vanessa saw me and raised her hand to me, no need. I release my Kuret realizing he was just frustrated not mad. He continues, you all have seen battle. Fought wars, seen people die. I have only heard stories. What could a normal person do in a situation like this. I ran because I didn't want to die.

I read his records. He and his siblings came from community that had remained hidden and safe for decades until coming here. I can imagine that it would be a normal reaction for civilians. But that's not the case. I say, don't give a weak excuse like that. I would understand if it were outside the island, where you had no one to help you. But here, you could have called for help. Alert some officer. Instead you ran, leaving your sisters in pool of her blood. Your brother Ryan, let me tell you, was even more terrified than you right now. But he did what you didn't. So don't sit here and give an excuse saying you are weak.

That shut his unreasonable anger down. Vanessa adds on, you ran because you didn't want to get caught. Plain and simple. He didn't have any counter to this. I sensed his aura shifting to more shame. At least he sees himself now. She asks, but lets leave your reasons for others to decide. We only want to know what happened tonight. I lean in closer, and why you turned yourself in. You had a headstart, we didn't know about you. So you could have

ran, though for how long that would have been is questionable.

He remained silent. We waited for few seconds, but the only thing filling up this room was his ragged breathing. I break the silence, your problems are not going away by being silent. Vanessa went with a different tactic, you know, its not just you that is in trouble. You sister is also in trouble. While she is a victim, it was her shipments that was used to smuggle products. Now, she didn't know, but she should have. Because she didn't inspect her own items carefully. No matter how much she defends, she will suffer some consequence of your actions.

She was purposefully singling Elina out. Its debatable whether Elina would be punished, but there no doubt that even if she was completely innocent, there will be some problems. Her brother is a criminal, and this is a relatively small society for people to forget that. Peter becomes anxious listening to her, she has nothing to do with this. Neither does Ryan. Vanessa says with stern voice, unfortunately its guilt by association. People can argue you both were in on it. Especially with the in fighting about the solen products.

He snarls, she was hurt. Shis is clearly the victim here. How can you going to blame this on her. Vanessa answers, you care for your siblings, however little it may be. I suggest you use that feeling to take the blame for everything. That’s the only way she remains safe. Vanessa was pushing him hard to take responsibility. I thought she was going a little to far, but she was just trying to get him to open up using his sister as a threat. Could have done a different way, but it works either way.

He grits his teeth hard thinking. I say, this is simple. You confess that it was your own idea to use Elina. She was just a patsy. You tell us everything what you know and what happened tonight. Leave nothing. Only then she will remain safe. He asks, can you promise. I turn to Vanessa. She says, no. But we can help reduce the damage. We have your boss, so you will not charged for the entire criminal operation. Maybe some, but not whole. That will also help lessen any punishment on Elina.

He thinks about it for long time. I was confused about something, isn't this why you turned yourself. To take responsibility. Or was it for something else. He closes his eyes like he was trying to hide away. But there is no place to hide. He just has cold feat, I can see it clearly from his aura. Soon his emotions crumble and becomes defeated. His eyes had lost the last hints of hope and says, did you talk to Wyan. Vanessa looks at me and gives a nod signaling he was done holding back.

She says, tell us your story. Forget what Wyan might have said. Its the right call to not tell him anything and here his version first. He shook his head, I thought I would make something of myself by joining him. I don't know how it came to this. He takes a deep breadth, 7 months ago he came to me in our shop. He heard from somewhere that I used to be a smuggler when we were staying in Alaska. He wanted my skills. I didn't believe him at first. I only did it because it was necessary for survival. We were living here, not just surviving. He told his vision and I believed, he chokes a little, no, I wanted to be more than what I was.

I got curious, was your life so unsatisfied that you wanted more, even if it was risky and unnecessary. He says, you don't understand. I was respected in my community. I made things happen. People would barter things in exchange of my skills. Things that I can do for Elina and Rory. He scoffs, all that changed when we came here. Suddenly we weren't alone. So many people, so many communities. Soon my own name was forgotten by the people who I came with.

I was realizing his motivation for this. Its sad that it was as basic as respect and power. I guess he was missing the life he used to have. Vanessa asks, so you joined Wyan. And came with a way to use Elina's shipment. He doesn't deny it, it was the best plan. She was always good with people and trusting. I didn't like lying to her. But she wasn't getting hurt. It didn't impact our business. No was getting hurt. His hands turns to first, must have realized that was not true anymore.

Vanessa asks, so for months you used Elina shipments to smuggle goods. Everything was running without anyone noticing. I am embarrassed to say even we didn't know about this. She pauses a little to hide the frustration she felt. I didn't want her to feel more of it so I help out, what changed. Why did someone steal from the smuggled goods. He turns slowly to me with a curious look. I answers, we know about that too. We know everyone was accusing Elina of steeling. That's how she got hurt.

He closed his eyes in anger, like trying to avoid taking about it. But there's no point in stopping now. A moment later he opens his eyes and says, I don't know. Wyan made sure everyone knew the risk of stealing from ourselves. No one would dare steal things that would spell doom. Vanessa scoffs, be honest. You stole it, didn't you. You used your family as a cover to hide it. And they paid it for your greed. The thought did cross my mind too. Several times. He just said that he ample experience with smuggling, won't be a stretch to find he has experience in steeling too.

That made him defensive, no. He puts his palm on the table to make a point, I might be a thief, but won't risk Elina and Ryan like that. I didn't steal anything. They all just zeroing to me always because I knew of the shipment time and place. But they were convinced I used Elina or Ryan to steal from them. They were very angry and so I had no choice but to bring her to them. I was trying to protect my family, who knows what they would have done I didn't do that. They could have sent Cory, Quintin or Polly to them. And not just to talk. I wasn't going to let that happen. So I had to make a tough decision.

Vanessa was half right then. He did use his siblings as cover, just not to lie but as truth. She looks at me to get a confirmation. His aura was clear, he was telling the truth. I nod in response. She asks him, then who stole it. He puts his hands on his temple, I have no freaking clue. Everyone kept accusing me, Elina, each other, but no one knows who stole it, and how they stole it. I ask, how can you be so sure it wasn't someone in your group. He answers, maybe. But what's the point in stealing drugs from us. We could always smuggle in more. Why risk it.

Honestly, he made a point. We also discussed about the reasons for this. I was hopping Peter would know more. But he is also doesn't know. Vanessa asks, fine. Lets table on who stole it. Lets revisit tonight's event. Explain what happened. And don't leave anything, for your and Elina's sake. She was right to move on from this topic. He becomes anxious when recalling the event, I tried to explain it wasn't Elina or Ryan. I wanted to clear that suspicion and let them go.

He grits his teeth, I didn't even care at that point on how I would make Elina explain this and not report us. I just didn't want them to hurt the two of them. I thought they would just scare her and once they saw she knew nothing, they would release her and Ryan. Then it went all wrong. The freakier Grover got angry after Ryan kicked him and used his Kuret on Elina. His Kuret isn't that powerful, but he was close enough to injure with his thread Kuret.

He slams his fist on the table in anger, the bastard. Not only he ignored the rules about not using Kuret and leave evidence. He also hurt someone not part of the operation. Everyone were panicking seeing Elina bleeding, Ryan crying over beside her. I was in shock, frozen, unable to do anything. He puts both his arm on top of his head as he slouches forward, people were shouting, confused, accusing Grover of messing up. All I could hear was Ryan crying in the background.

He dugs his finger into his hair and grabs it in anger, like trying to rip out the pain of the memory. He continues, that’s when all hell broke loose.

Vanessa (Chapter 68)

Wednesday, January 7, 2026 20:08

I should have remained calm when I heard Peter reasons to join Wyan. What he did was nothing short of arrogance and power hungry move. I felt betrayed thinking how I failed to make the city safe. I have been trying to protect people for more than a decade. And when we do finally achieve some semblance of stability, there still are people who aren't satisfied with this place. Before I get sucked into frustration, I pull myself together. Its only people like him, not everyone. There are many people who are happy that they are here now.

Then we got to know that Elina hurting was a rash and reckless move by this Grover character with no real meaning. We still don't know who stole from them. But I decided to instead focus on learning what happened next. I ask after listening to his somber voice, what do you mean by that. He takes a moment to answer, It became pitch black, like the light went out. And I started to hear people screaming and struggling. I slid to behind a pillar at the corner scared to hear someone was fighting.

I make a quick glance at Blake. He was also eager to this part. Peter says, I heard people crying out in pain and shouting. I even heard people dropping to the ground. He visibly shakes as he tugs on his hair. I ask, someone was fighting you guys? He raises his head back to us, no. It wasn't a fight, it was a slaughter. I couldn't see anything in the dark, even when I unconsciously used Kuret in my eyes, I didn't understand what was going on. I saw people attacking. Some begin to use their Kuret to protect, some used to fight, but one by one everyone we were getting cut down.

Blake asks with stern expression, how many people did you see. Peter says, I don't know man. It was crazy. I don't even know if we were attacked by others. It could have been 5 or 50. I could only see the Kurets of people I work with. This is not what I wanted to hear. I ask, then they were fighting each other. Peter gulps hard with confusion on his face, hell if I know. I just knew one thing, people were fighting with their Kuret and still getting knocked out.

Then I saw a Jade falling near me. She was close enough to see her wounded. It was too much, so I ran. I become enraged hearing that, you mean you left your sister and brother in the middle of a fight. He shows his teeth to me, I told you. I don't do violence. At the moment I just wanted to run away. I would have gotten her help once I was away.

I don’t know about that. But he did turn himself in, so maybe he wasn't a total wimp. Blake asks, I am still confused. Were people fighting each other or not. Did someone attack you all. Peter replies, like I told you, it was chaos. He looks away from us, but now that I think about it. Its possible some was double crossing us. Maybe seeing Elina hurt made them angry. My eyes sharpen at that and yell out, someone grew a consciousness after berating a defend less women. Ha, I don't think so. Stop lying.

He jerks at me, I am not. Some people were not happy how Wyan was handing this situation. Making me bring Elina and Ryan to them and exposing our operation. I know that the Citradel guy Tod wasn’t happy and kept accusing Wyan of not keeping his promise of no internal conflict. I told you right, people were accusing each other. So I don’t know, maybe some people lost it when Elina got hurt and they attacked others. Blake says, a dissention among the criminals. Not entirely impossible.

I shook my head, but how come everyone was knocked out then. Someone would have escaped. No way they would all knock each other out in a mutual destruction. Blake nods, that is also true. Somethings not adding up here then. I ask Peter, what about the 3 warriors then. They were supposed to be guarding you all. Even if no one come from outside, they would have stepped in and stop the fight. Peter somehow becomes even more somber. He says meekly, as I was crawling back to the exit I heard them rushing in and shouting something to us. I don’t know what they were saying, someone had started fighting with a Kuret that made lot of noise. But then.

He croaks a little now. I prod him, what. What happened to them. He says, I am not sure why, but they were also attacking each other. My head starts to hurt now. I lean back on my chair trying to understand what he just said. Blake shrieks, are you kidding me. You are saying not only you all, but the 3 warriors were fighting each other. Peter became frustrated, yes. I am telling the truth. I can't even begin to understand what I saw. Their kurets were clashing in the dark.

This is crazy, the warriors also turned on each other. Blake leans to me and whispers, do you think those 3 saw everyone fighting and started a brawl amongst themselves thinking a double cross was going on. As ridiculous as that sounds, it makes sense. Blake didn't mention that Peter was lying, so our sole witness did see people fighting amongst themselves. I shook my head and ask Peter still confused, again, how in the hell all 3 were lying unconscious in the end. It might be possible for all of you to knock each other out, however unlikely, its not impossible. But the same for the 3 high ranking warriors. Now that’s not incomprehensible. Someone must have attacked.

Peter didn't give an answer. He was silent and trembling slightly, likely recalling the fear he felt from hours ago. Blakes says, I can't believe that too. Someone must have intervened. That’s the only explanation. Peter answers, I don't know. I have no freaking clue who was fighting who. I got impatient, so let me get this straight. You don't know who attacked, or why or how. I don't like your chances in the tribunal. Peter gets angry, that’s the truth. What more do you want from me. Ask others when they wake up. Ask those 3 crazy warriors. Why do you keep asking me like I attacked them. I did nothing, I just ran.

His outburst ended him in heaving heavily. He even started to get sweat on his forehead. I turn to Blake. He was analyzing Peter for a long time. Then he turns to me and nods at me. Dammit. So he is telling the truth. Nothing about this makes sense. I ask Blake, we still didn't find any evidence anyone else involved. The only people we can account for here in this building. So someone attacked and still no one attacked. That's crazy. Blake ask, are there more members of your gang. It can't be only these many people.

Peter steadies himself a little, there are some more. But they don't know much about us. They are hired for intermediate work, getting supplies, choosing locations for drop offs, stuff like that. I ask, what about other warriors. Were there more than just 3. Peter stares hard at the table for a while, Wyan had called everyone important. He got all us, the main people in one place. He wouldn't risk our security in case something goes wrong. He trails off, I didn't think about it till now, but yeah. Its possible he had some more people he never told anyone. As an insurance. He does that sort thing, have backup plans.

He then immediately jerks to me, does that mean those freaks attacked us. I didn't know for sure. But seeing so much distrust amongst them, it would make sense their boss would also keep things. We will only get the truth from Wyan about this then. But then I had a thought, even if that’s true. Why they leave Wyan and others like this. Leave the drugs in the crates lying for us to find. At least they should have taken Jade, she was the one who keep tracks of all your criminal activities. Blake offers a theory, I don't know if this makes sense, but Ryan had called for help during all this chaos. Maybe realizing officers will be arriving, they left in a hurry.

He made a plausible argument. I say with a confused tone, so a group of people attacked them, without leaving a trace and left in hurry not caring about Wyan or drugs. Blake says, or maybe leaving it for us to find. Can't be sure of anything right now. The only thing we know for sure is fighting started when Elina got hurt and ended when all of them were unconscious. Maybe they took something else from them. Maybe something incriminating, like wiping off their identities.

I recalled the personal artifacts we got from the people here, more specifically what wasn't there. I say, they don't have phones on them. So yeah, its possible it was taken. Especially Wyans. His might have contact or at least give us clues about their identities. I turn to Peter, did they have phones with them when you met them. Peter thinks for a moment and then nods, yeah. We all had to shut it down and keep our phones in a sealed box. I say, we didn't find any box or phones on the scene Blake. It must be taken then.

Blake thinks for a moment, I thought they just didn't bring it with them for security reasons. But its more likely they were taken. He then turns to Peter, what else. They hid there presence so well. They either fought everyone or caused everyone to fight each other. They could have some other goals too. Peter shook his head, I can't think of anything that would be tied to us. The phones are encrypted. Wyan bragged a long time ago that even if it gets stolen, no one be able to crack the encryption. We brought nothing important with us in the end. He then takes a moment, except for the drugs.

And that’s the item still lying in that treatment plant. I ask Blake, does this make any sense. He makes a defeating laugh. He then stands up and walks to the other side of the wall, I can't make heads or tails of this. We are now suspecting someone attacked, but have zero evidence of anyone else. Peter says everything was dark, so I doubt others would say anything different when we wake them up. The warriors might enlighten us more, unless they also say that 3 of them fought each other. He then looks to others on the other side of the glass. Do you think that’s why Cory was refusing telling how he got beat. They fought each other.

I pushed my chair a little back and clasp my hands on one knee, maybe. Rose did say she that Cory might have hurt his pride and that makes it strong enough to resist her. If I got in a fight with 2 other warriors that somehow resulted in all of us knocking each other out, or someone intervened to take advantage of a wounded people, I would be pissed too. Blake rests on the wall on his back, true enough. Since the phones are disappeared, someone was definitely there. But that’s it. Nothing else.

I add, it could have been also taken before or after the fight. It was kept in a sealed box, so stealing it would be easy. Blake shrugs, could have happen anytime. He sighs, but it doesn't matter. Once they see that its encrypted, two things will happen. They will try to erase their names and anything incriminating after breaking into it. Or they just destroy it. We lose information either way. I shook my head, so it’s a dead end then. He says, unless we uncover who are these people. Lets hope someone can remember and tell us who they are.

He didn't seem confident. Actually, neither was I. Everyone were fighting each other and someone took advantage of it. We don't know if it were part of the criminal gang or not. I say, lets wake up Wyan and interrogate him. If he really hired others, we will make him tell us. Blake says, that’s well and good, but without them tying to the scene its just a blame game. No evidence, not a video of them outside, no eye witness. No way to prove they were ever in the fight. Whoever they are, they are really good at covering their tracks.

I had the same thoughts. I turn to check on Peter. He wasn't even listening to us. Just gazing down at the table, looking tense. Well, we aren't going to answer about that right now. I say, lets set aside that. I just have one last thing to ask you. You escaped successfully from the treatment plant. You weren't being chased or hunted by anyone. Why did you come back to the place you ran from, after hours. Peter looks at me with heavy eyes. He was so tiered, mentally, I could guess the reason before he said it. He says, guilt. I ran and hid at a construction site. I was there for long time. My thoughts gnawing at me. I knew it wouldn't be long until you come looking for me.

I kept seeing Elina on that dark floor. Ryan beside her. I didn't even know if she was made it alive from there. I thought of running so may times, but where would I even go. Even if I somehow scape the patrol borders in the sea, the island is far from any mainland. Fleeing wasn't an option. Hiding wasn't an option. I had nothing. I gave up in the end. If I was going to be caught, I at least make sure Elina and Ryan are safe. I don't know he was trying to get sympathy from us. But he did seem exhausted. And he wasn't wrong about no other option. Turning himself was the only non lethal option. He doesn't look like the suicidal type, not with family.

I glance at Blake. It didn't take much time for him to say, looks like the truth. It must have been eating at him until he couldn't bear it. I nod, a simple answer for this at least. I ask, so we still don't know who stole from them and who intervened. Is it possible they are the same people? Blakes laughs mockingly, wouldn't that make it much simpler for all of us. That was indeed wishful thinking on my part. Blake says, anyways. We made a lot of assumptions and theories. Lets not make it worse. We will wait for others to wake up and first confirm what Peter was said was the truth.

That’s was reasonable. Peter cuts in, what happens to me now. I answer, you go to a holding cell with others. We will move you all into individual cells. If they all were really fighting each other, its best to keep you all separated. He didn't resist or complain. He says, before I go, I want to see Elina and Ryan. I want to see for myself that they are okay. I turn to Blake. I didn't want to make any decision for this. Because my answer was already decided, he shouldn't be even near them.

Blake says, not tonight. Maybe tomorrow. I will ask Elina once she has recovered enough to make a decision. If she agrees, it will be under strict supervision and for few minutes only. You have traumatized your sister and brother enough for tonight, I don't want to hurt them further by showing your pitiful state. Best you also gather yourself before showing up in front of them. Blake was really being considerate of their feelings. I agreed to this as well.

Peter had no choice but to accept whatever Blake offered. He slouches back on his chair and relents, I can't believe all this happened because someone stole from us. He scorns, only if they left it alone, nothing like this would have ever happened. He was being delusional here, if it wasn't this incident, then something else would have happened. Be thankful that no one died. You say you haven't seen any fighting on the outside. This was quaint compared to real hell we some of us have been through. So don't think for a second this was not your fault.

He shook his head, our operation was air tight. You said it yourself didn't you, we went undetected for months. If the drugs weren't stolen this wouldn't have happened. I almost got up from my chair in anger, but I controlled myself. Because he was right. It hurt and he was just saying to spite us. But its clear we weren't paying enough attention. They used the perfect moment to do this, when all of us were busy with the tournament. He then faces me, I still can't believe some freakier had the balls to steal from us. I can't understand why. I don't even understand why steal these drugs. We could have just been hired to bring more of it. He grits his teeth, instead they go and steal some drugs that are not even that important. Just some weird drugs MCTL and Hetrox. I don't even know what they can be used for.

His anger was clear on his face and directly on the person who stole from them. I think we are done with him. I stand up from the chair, Blake, I think we are done with Peter now. Should we. I was interrupted by Blake, hold on. His voice was grim. I turn to him. His face had became suddenly serious. He asks, what was stolen. I was confused. What happened. Did he know something. Peter also confused says, I told you. Some other client had ordered these two drugs, MCTL and Hetrox. We were preparing for a scheduled drop off. But it went missing about 3 weeks from before. We only got to know now due a backlog. Nothing else was stolen, only.

Suddenly the table in front of me flew off. What the hell. Blake's demeanor changed a whole 180. He just used his Kuret to throw the table to the side. I took a few steps back from him when I saw how mad he got. His eyes fueled with Kuret and anger. The other person who was more shocked than me was Peter. He stumbles down along the chair and hits the ground. Before I asked Blake what happened he extended his arms and threw his Kuret around Peter. He picked up a terrified Peter and levitated him towards him.

I shout, Blake, what the hell are you doing. He ignored me. He had a murderous look on him. Peter struggling in the air flies straight into Blakes arms. Blakes catches Peter from the neck and slams him to the wall. Peter struggles under Blakes grip. I ran to him, what are you doing. Blake yells, tell me who that client was. Blakes grip tighten on Peter. What just happened. What's going on, I scream at him. Peter had wrapped his hand on Blakes arm, trying to push it away.

Its pointless. Blake was using his Kuret, at this rate Blake was going to crush him. I shout, let him go Blake. What's gotten into you. Blake turns to me with an angry expression, don't tell me you forgot. I ask, I don't understand. Forgot what. He turns to a now red flushed Peter, those two drugs were found in the poisoned drinks I and Marina got in our semi final matches. Its because of this guy that Marina almost died. If David hadn't warned her, the poison might have reached her heart.

It then hit me. I recalled the meeting we had with others when David said he found poison in their drinks. We were all confused as to how such sophisticated designer drug was created inside the island. Now I realized what really, happened. It wasn't created here, it was smuggled here. This made me mad. I shout, you. Because of you Marina had to use her overdrive. If it weren't for that poison, then. I don't know what I was going to say. I still lost to Marina. But what devasted me was learning that she only used her overdrive because she was poisoned. I might have still lost against her, but I wanted her to user overdrive to defeat me, not because she had no other choice.

Blake grips tightens on Peters neck. His skin was not getting bruised under the pressure Blake was putting him on, because of your selfish desire for making a name, someone used you to sabotage the tournament. They almost succeeded. One of my closest friend suffered from that poison. The one you gave. Peter begins to choke. Blake spats out, I was also almost poisoned with it. I somehow avoided it, Marina didn't. All because of you. I could just feel Blakes anger from his voice.

I was furious too. I should stop Blake before Peter gets hurt. But I couldn't do it. I wanted to him to show Peter some more terror. But then the door opens and people flood in. Blake, get off of him. It was Tessa who barged in. She came rushing with Somers behind her. Blake was not about to let him go, not before he tells me who that client is. Tessa says panicked, he doesn't know. Only Jade has that information. You know that already. He doesn't know anything.

Blake did know. He just didn't care. It was personal for him. It was for me too. Finally Blake listens to reason and let goes Peter. Peter slumps down and gasps for air. He hits the ground and tries to crawl away from the murderous look Blake was giving him. Somers comes from the side and grabs Peter, come on. Get up. Peter was choking on his own neck and trying to get away from Blake. So much so that he practically ran into Somers arms. Somers says firmly, settle down. You will be fine. Peter had teary eyes and horrified expression. Somers says to us, its not a good idea to have him here. I will take him to his cell.

I wish I also had the chance to wring his neck too. But I shouldn't. I managed a nod in my frustration. Somers carrying a whimpering Peter out of the room. Blake was pacing a little bit around the room with his hands turned to a fist, trying to calm down. Tessa says to me, are you good. I wasn't sure how to answer that. I was angry and irritated at this mess. But we all have a job to do. I centered myself and say, yeah. Sorry. I should have stopped Blake. But when I heard about the drugs, I got mad.

Tessa hesitantly looks at Blake who was trying to calm himself down. She says, its personal. I imagine it was hard not to blame him. I am surprised she was understanding instead of reprimanding our behavior. I am glad she didn't judge us. I say, I guess we aren't that different from Cory. We lost our mind when someone interferes with our fights. If it weren't for Peter, Marina wouldn't have been poisoned. She wouldn't have risked getting injured. My match would have been different. Same for Blake.

Tessa says, like I said. I understand why its personal. People like us can't forgive something like this. Blake takes the chair that was fallen and sits on it. We both approach him. Tessa asks, I know its not fair to ask, but lets not have another burst like this in front of entire IDF. Blake had visibly calmed down now. He turns towards the glass wall. I am sure many wouldn't have mind seeing more of it. But in the end, it's not good image for Blake. He sighs, I just lost it. We investigated the incident weeks ago, but when nothing came up and with the upcoming final match, I just sort of put it aside. Now realizing that these bunch of criminals were responsible for so many thing, I couldn't let it slide again.

Like me, he was frustrated with the outcome of the matches. Tessa says, no need to explain to me Blake. Like I told Vanessa here, when its personal for us, its not something we can control. He says, Marina almost died due that poison. Under my watch. Of course I am taking it personal. A moment later he says, though maybe I shouldn't shown my petty side in front of an audience. Especially when Nathan is among them. I totally forgot he was here too. Dammit, he would be having a laugh from this.

Tessa says, look guys. Its late. You all had long day, obviously tiered. Go home and rest. I will stay back and take control of the situation. I shook my head, no. I can't leave now. We still have so much to do. Talk to Wyan. Blake stood up now, and Jade. I need to find who was that client. Tessa raises her hand, and I will. But not when you are rearing to kill. You need rest. Both of you. Just then Nathan comes in. Great, another annoying guy just walked in. Behind him Dan walked.

Dan says worried, apologies chief. I tried to stop him, but he just barged in. I tried, but. Nathan says, don't blame the poor guy. He is good but not good enough to stop me. Besides, I only left your watchful eyes into a group of even more cautious looking people. So I traded into a more restrictive group of people. I didn't have the patience to talk to him, leave us Nathan. He says, not yet. I have something to say to you. Actually, all of you. He turns to Blake, it might be worth your while.

Blakes looks around us. Then he faces him back, is it so important that you would risk your temporary privilege. Nathan smiles, of course. Blake says, fine. Its not like you are causing issue to others. We are used to your antics anyways. He shook his head at me. I reluctantly agreed, yeah fine. Dan you can leave us. He can't do much here anyways. Dan looks a little nervous leaving but he does anyways. Nathan cuts in, also ask others to leave. Only for a few minutes. It weird he wants to keep it private. It didn't matter much though. Dan waited for me agree. I waved my hand signaling its fine. Dan leaves the three of us.

A minute later he says, that was the last person to leave. Now I can talk. Tessa asks, why not ask us in a officers room. Why here. Nathan says, I don't like those rooms. I laugh, you what. Why. Afraid of the décor. Nathan smiles, I don't. But that’s not the point, someone could hear us. Blake says, what, like some bugged the officers room. Paranoid much. Nathan says, you said it not me. I shook my head. We do routine sweeps of the place. There are no bugs.

Nathan says, lets leave it at that. I just want to salute your rare show of anger Blake. That even made me surprised. You keep you cool most the time, I get to see you like this after months. Blake didn't appreciate called out like this, do you have something actual to say or just want to me to throw you out. Nathan mocks, very touchy. Though I guess anyone would be. Tessa says, then get to the point. Nathans says, all right. Since none you seem to have realized, I want share my thoughts.

I ask, about what. He says, you both were not able to see what's right there in front of you. Huh. I got impatient, look. Its been a long day. I am tried, I don't have time to play your stupid games. Just tell us what you mean. I can other were also feeling the same. Nathan looks at with strange looks, really. Not one of you thought who was behind tonight's drama. Blake asks, what. You mean the client who ordered those drug. You know who it could be.

Nathan shook his head, not about that. I got no clue who it is. But I know for certain that the its not same as who stole the phones or made a mockery of criminals or the warriors. Teesa says, how can you be so sure. We have no evidence, no witness. Nothing. He must be just making things up. Or maybe he has some insider knowledge. Nathan clicks his tongue, the lack of evidence is the evidence itself. Come on, do I need to spell it out myself who was the orchestrator of tonight's fight.

Blake steps forward, don't tell me its you. I am in no mood for a joke. I had a strange feeling he was building up so much suspense to reveal himself as the culprit. He laughs, I am honored you think so highly of me. But no. It couldn't be me. Even I would really struggle to fight those 3. And even if I wasn't alone, no way I can avoid erasing any Kuret. At least not in short time I had. But since you asked, who do you think could do it. I am puzzled what does he mean.

Tessa asks, it would have to be a group of strong people. I don't know maybe. She looks to Blake, maybe shadows. I think they would have the skills and training to pull this off. She was right. They are a bunch of covert squad capable of pulling such a thing. I say, that’s not possible though. Only Marina and Blake remain. And we know they didn't do it. Nathan says, of course. My first suspect would have been them too. But they don't exist anymore. Sadly. He looks at Blake, who was now thinking deeply about something.

Nathan says, I am sure its not a group of people. He pulls out his index finger to us, one person. I suspect one person did this. I scoff, really now. That’s ridiculous. Nathan nods, normally yeah. Short of Marina or Blake, who are overdrive users, no one can orchestrate downfall of 3 top fighters. But even they can't do it undetected. So we are looking for someone else. Just then Blake says, shit. Why didn't I think of it earlier. Tessa and I turn to him. Did that really made him convinced it was one guy.

I ask, what. You also believe it now. Blake didn't respond. He just stared at Nathan who was now smiling, look who caught up. Don't worry cousin, you had a lot of things to deal with. I am sure eventually you would also realized it. Just what Nathan said that made sense. I ask, stop speaking in riddles. Just tell us why you think its one person and who it is. Nathan says, where's the fun in that. Just think what I said, lack of evidence was the biggest clue.

Someone with history to do something as bold as this. Someone who could make everyone believe they are fighting each other. And most of all, someone who is strong.

Just then it clicked for me. Holy shit. Tessa says, no way. But how. Why. Nathan laughs louder, I don't have a clue how or why. I know only its him. This guy has showed how he can manipulate a whole crowd, making a fool out of all of us, pitting us all against each other during the flag capture game, while securing own objective. He has fought all sorts of crazy strong people. And the cherry on top, he very recently showed he can duplicate others Kuret, even those of alphas. A master manipulator and an expert in warfare. Do you all deny he isn't capable of this.

No, he is right. I grit my teeth, its David. Only he is capable of this. I can't believe I didn't see it before. Like Nathan said, it was right in our face. Tessa say, hold on. Why would David do this and not tell us. Why hide from us. I ignored her. Because I couldn't believe I so distracted by Ned and by David himself that I never thought it about this. He has fought alphas, omegas, twin alphas. And won. He could take down Cory, Quintin and Polly all together. Nathan says, I don't have a darn clue. But isn't this exciting.

I can't believe what he was saying. Blake asks, what does you mean. He says, we have no to prove it. If its really him and he didn't tell us, then it means he doesn't want anyone to know. Whatever the reason it is, he would leave no trace, and remove any evidence of his involvement. You were worried about their identities being erased, you were right on the mark. We won't be able to prove it. He laughs, that’s what makes it interesting, what could he be thinking. Anyone wants to take a gander. No one had an answer. We were confused. I was more so.

Just then 4 pings sound in the room. It was our phones. We all got messages at the same time. Everyone took out their phone, I didn't. I was still trying to process this. Nathan whistles reading the message, freak. This guy. I thought I got one over him, but he is already two steps ahead of me. That jarred me out of my thoughts. I ask, what happened. Blake sighs, the theatrics with him. Listen to your message.

I open my phone and listen the voice transcribed, took you long enough to figure it out, sorry of the mess. The client who ordered those drugs, also stole it to cover their tracks. Leave that person to me, because I am on the hunt. After I listen the message disappears from my phone, leaving no trace that it was ever there.

David (Chapter 69)

Friday, January 9, 2026 12:27

I don't know what I am doing. Quite literally. I am currently sitting in my room with a digital board staring in front of me. I had written names of all people related my PTSD. Wagner, Zakerine, Hansan, Branden, John. I even wrote names of people who are less likely the cause of my condition, Istra and the last shadow whose identity I still don't know. Its not surprising they are all the shadow members. Because I was hanging with them the most. Even on the last day. It's a little morbid to say, but only these people death would make me so broken.

I connected each of their names with their relationship and mine, trying to understand the root cause. Why I am doing this. I have been questioning this ridiculous method of laying out dead people names like this. And the answer was always the same. I can't figure out just by thinking. I had whole 4 hours of walking, and yet in all that time I was only circling on same thing over and over. I blamed Wagner, then I blamed Zakerine. I even blamed Hansen for dumping me on that ship.

Even if I could somehow forgive Zakerine for dying the way she did, I can't bring myself to forgive or forget about Wagner. His corpse keeps hunting me like a bad smell. Refusing to leave completely from my mind. Once I reached my secondary house, I had exhausted my thinking and decided to just work through it by writing it on a visual board. Its pretty pathetic I need to write all my feelings and possible causes of PTSD below peoples name. But I don't have time. Half of the day is already gone. And I am no closer to figuring this out.

Then came frustration about how unproductive this has been. I keep gazing at the people's name and their relationship to me. How its connected to my panic attacks. Drew said I knew what I need to do. I even got some hint after with Catherine. My actions have been unconsciously being driving from memories I don't know. And now that I have recalled almost all my memory, I have been tracking all the missing memory and trying to figure which event had the most profound impact on me.

I toss the 3D digital pointer to the table and slump on my chair with eyes closed. This is driving me mad. Self therapy is hard. I had been making progress and having breakthroughs before because Drew was guiding me. But now she gave it to me figure it on my own. I thought of doing this thinking that's would therapists also do, make notes. I already knew that my own bias thoughts will not be impartial. Having to look at oneself impartially is not easy. At least not for me.

Some time later, while I was in the middle of my thoughts, M holograms comes from the wall projector, boss, Its 3:00. You haven't eaten since morning. Your energy levels are way down. I didn't realize it was this late. I can't let my health get worse by skipping meal, so I need to eat, begrudgingly. I don't have ART in this house, so I had to make lunch on my own. Surprisingly it was a little relaxing now that I distracted myself a little. I am a mess, because I was dragging out the cooking hoping to avoid the useless task of self reflection.

I finished eating around 4. I was a deadline, and no close to figuring out my block. I even tried numerous time to call on my Kuret. Every time I felt my body rejecting it. Its so damn frustrating. I don't know when, but I somehow dozed off a while I was siting on the sofa chair. No doubt due to my mental fatigue. Around 5 I head a ping from M. With lazy eyes I lean from my chair to M's hologram. What is it, I was annoyed. Mostly at my self, I slept when I had things to do. M says, boss, you visitors. Cass and Matt will be on your doorstep in few minutes.

What. They didn't tell call me before coming. I ask, what happened. Everything all right at the officers building. M says, nothing of importance. People have been busy all day with meetings and discussion. All though they have break right now. I couldn't meet the two of them this morning, so they must have come personally to meet. To be frank, I didn't want to talk to Cass right now. She might figure out I something wrong with me. With how was appearing to the public, I don't know if I can do it again. Not after what happened with Vanessa. That guilt has never left me. I could have handled it better. No. It would end the same way no matter what I said. She would stubbornly see through everything.

But I can't just send them away too. Reluctantly I changed the digital board to show a 3D view of the coliseum. Specifically when Charles and I were fighting. I had prepared this in case someone did visit me. I looked around the house that would gave me away. I didn't see anything that would reflect my mental state. After I cleaned myself a little, I waited for them. A minute later the door rings. I take a deep breath and open the door, hey guys. How is it. Matt interrupts me, dude. What the hell.

His annoyance was expected. Not just his though, Cass had a scowl too. She says, you couldn't have waited for us this morning. Their impatience in not letting me explain was apparent. I first tell them, come on inside first. Give me a chance to explain though. They both give me a sharp look, but still came in. I saw they didn't have anything with them, so they must be here to just talk. I close the door and then suddenly Matt looks around the house. Why is he searching, I answer, no ones here. Its just me.

Matt says, yeah duh. We know. I was looking for your hidden entrance to your actual house. I made a smile, I am sure you heard from others, its not here. Its. He waves his hand, I know, I know. Its somewhere in the ocean, but knowing how you think, I bet there is hidden door or escalator that goes underground to where its right now. I laugh amused at the thought, that's a little too much. Even for me. Cass scoffs, is it though. I haven't been able to talk to you since the match yesterday. But you have meet everyone else, do I you know how it feels that only two of us have been left out.

I could tell she was annoyed at my behavior. I nod, its not like I did it on purpose. I needed rest, and if Heraknus hadn't rushed moving back so suddenly, I would have stayed in my home all day. Matt shouts from the room inside, which home by the way. This one or your super secret one. Because you wouldn't even let anyone know where you were. I guess I will be in their dog house for a while. I reply, look, that's not my intention. Then I give them the same explanation I gave others in the morning.

After hearing it, Matt finally gives up searching for hidden passages under the bed or in the wall. Cass asks, that's crazy. It could attack us. I nod. Matt shook his head, only you would live in such a dangerous place. I had to agree a little with him, its safe for 1 or 2 people. Excluding myself. I want to get it fixed before showing anyone. My team is working on it, so wait until they fix it. They had no choice but to trust on my judgement on this. Cass asks, and this team of yours, you trust them with this technology.

Her concern was valid, I nod at her. I say, I carefully handpicked them. But its not like I am blindly trusting them. I am using standard protocol of information modulation. No one person knows everything, so its fine. I also have M tracking their activity as a safeguard, with their consent of course. So you don't need to worry about that. That makes her satisfied. She asks, okay. What about that multiple Kuret blasts, care to explain that as well. She and Matt glare with intent. But I wasn't going to disclose that. Not yet.

I smile, you heard what I said yesterday right. I want to keep that one secret until my match with Charles. Matt shrieks, really dude. We are in your house, you must have sound proof walls here. I reply, its not just here. I don't want to risk telling you and Kafar spies hear about it. Cass's eyes widen, spies. What do you mean. I answer, come on. You think we are the only ones who sent Catherine to spy on them. They must have too. Its not about trust, but more about recon and intel gathering. Though with the tournament finished, I doubt they are active now. But I rather not risk it.

Cass says, do you think we would just blab about it to anyone. Why keep it from us too. Matt says, come on. Spit it out. We won't leave until you do. I should have know that this would happen. Outside arena, my usual excuse fells apart. I ponder about it for a moment. Obviously I can't tell everything. I decided the part I can tell. I say, fine. Now try to keep an open mind about this, because it's a little wonky. They both got excited to hear me. I say, you know how light is split into a spectrum of colors when it goes through a prism, or through a stream a water. It works very similar to that.

They both looked confused. Matt asks, what does that mean. It would have been easier to show them, but I can't do that. So instead I continued this analogy, the pure Kuret I store inside my Kuret storm, I split a little piece of that into a Kuret I want. Cass asks, I don't understand a thing. How can you do that. I raised my palm, my hands works a prism. Actually, any part of my body would do, but its easier with my hand. If you recall my match, I pointed to the 3D view of the match behind me, you will see my hands always inside my Kuret storm. That's how I am doing it. In a normal scenario, Kuret coming in contact to my hand would just disperse, but in the right condition, like this, the pure kuret splits.

There dumbfounded looks were quite amusing. I continued, it was an arduous task. Trying to make use of the randomness of this Kuret splits into the Kuret I want. But after many trial and errors, I found a trick. But it renders my hand useless because I have to dip my hand to the Kuret storm to make it work. I could tell from their expression that this was too vague. And I agreed. But this all I could tell. I say, it would be easier to show you, but you can't actually see inside my Kuret storm. I can instead could show a mathematical simulation of how it works internally. M, open file S and run it.

Matt cuts in, wait. No, leave it dude. I only understood about half of what you said. I get a feeling you were going to show us some complicated science. I wasn't actually going to show it. I shouldn't make my friends feel like this, but I was just flaunting science in their face so that they believe its so complicated that its best to just ignore it.

He says, I am not even going to try to understand that with just my knowledge of medicine. I thought you had a Kuret related trick. This is, well, impressive, but. He couldn't find the response. Cass helps out, boring. I might not have told them the whole thing, but this caught me off guard. After spending whole afternoon in mental torture, I finally let out a hearty laugh, did you say it was boring. Do you any idea how complicated it is.

Matt elbow Cass to chide her. Cass says, what. I am not saying it's not incredible, but its just not related to Kuret. You said it's a mix of Earth and Medrone science. I expected it have a Kuret science. I understood her confusion. It could have been easier if I told the whole thing on how I am able to split the Kuret. I say, my biology. That the Kuret science. Math and Science of Earth. Its a combination of all if it. Cass shook her head, I think it was better when I didn't know. I am more confused now. Why didn't you want to reveal it to anyone. I doubt anyone can stop you from doing something non Kuret thing.

But its not. That's the part I can't tell. I gave a safe answer, right now the biggest weakness of this is the time it takes to prepare it. You saw that, nearly 3 to 5 minutes. That's just not practical. I got lucky to have be able to use twice in a same match. Only because Charles was relatively slower. But now he knows that. To remove this weakness I will have to work on making it work in seconds. Once that's done, my other weakness will be revealed. Matt asks, you mean somehow Charles can stop that kuret prism refract thing.
□Not exact, but he was close enough I nod, I got away this time because it was the first time. Everyone will focus on the biggest weakness, but the real strategists from Citradel will focus on a
That means not telling anyone how I can do it, not even you guys. Cass sighs, I kind of understand, but I don't even understand this. Forget telling anyone about it. Matt nods, same. But anyways, we are not going to tell anyone this.

At least they understood my reasons, even if they didn't the whole truth. Matt walks to the 3D hologram projected view of the battle, you are already planning for your next match. Dude, you should chill for at least a day. I laugh a little thinking if he knew what I was actually doing. Cass walks beside me, yeah. And your interview was quite something. You were so arrogant, it was quite a performance. My eye twitch at that word. What did she mean by that. Did she knew my mental condition. Someone already gave my condition away to her. No, she was smirking right now.

But I have to confirm, by the way. You both barged in demanding for explanation, but neither of you asked if my injuries ae healed. Gives friends you are. Matt gives a blank stare, I mean you don't have any wounds. Others said you were all right. So I just thought nothing of it. Cass laughs, are you embarrassed about passing out even though you were talking big about defeating Charles yesterday. I was right, you may not have physical wounds, but you were just showing off. You still haven't recovered, right.

That's clears it. For the time being only 4 people know about my therapy. Well, its still bad considering it was only one till yesterday. But the information leak didn't happen as of now. It looks like Cass thought I was hiding my

injuries, well she was right in a way. I nod, you caught me. I may not show it, but Charles still managed to leave my body sore. It wasn't a lie, but the acupuncture I got from ART removed the almost all of the soreness. Cass nods, I knew it. She gazes at Charles hologram that was currently of him jumping in mid air and me standing below.

She says, Charles is really strong, isn’t he. I take the sofa chair and turn to face them, extremely. I got lucky with Blake, he hadn't recovered from fighting Marina and his overdrive was not stable. But Charles is different. He has been alpha much longer and has finer control on his vast Kuret. And while he says his overdrive is also unstable, it still feels dangerous. Its going to be really tough match. Matt asks, I am still not sure why you agreed to take the deal. We were listening in to your discussion, and everyone's been talking about it. But isn't it too risky. Charles himself said he could kill you accidentally.

I need to tread carefully here. Obviously they saw me crash out when Wagners name was mentioned. Cass walks to me, I get it was a very tempting deal. You weren't sure you would win, and he was basically offering his house as a bargain. But its too dangerous. I didn't want to lie about my reason, but I can't just open that can of worms right now. I decided to say some truth. I close my eyes in resignation, it was my ego. Matt asks, say what. I clarify, when I heard even the crown couldn't defeat Charles, I got worked up. I have not been strong always, so I carried away and thought I could become stronger than the crown.

This was really the truth, I just didn't explain it in this word to anyone before. Not to Blake or Marina. Not to Catherine or Vanessa. Cass scoffs, you, the guy who is so careful that its almost a sickness, suddenly did a what, an emotional selfish decision. Matt says, that’s kind of hard to imagine. I open my eyes, mortified, I did. And you really think I don't have moments of selfishness. All I can say is that I was having a rush of excitement. Being able to push Charles to use his overdrive, and getting a time to master my Kuret. It may not be logical, but that’s what I did.

This is really what I feel. Having a panic attack was another factor, but I can tell this from objectively reflecting after spending hours on that PTSD board. Cass remains wide eyed. Matt clicks his tongue, damn. So I guess even you can be goaded into, huh. Cass nods, It's definitely strange behavior from you, but you are still a person. Flaws and all. She had no idea how true she was. I retorted, you say like I wasn't before. Cass fidgets a little, being hit like that. Matt smiles, yeah, what did you mean by that Cass. He was obviously teasing her.

Cass stares at the two of us, one at a time, no. that’s what I mean. I just. She was lost on words a little. She bits her lips, you know, I thought you didn't have flaws. This whole year, you been very different, more calculating. Thought you changed a little. I smile a little. I was right to believe she would notice my subtle change in behavior. I answers, I have told his before. Everyone has weaknesses. I am no exception, I just hide it well. But its not going to stay hidden much longer, I thought. My secrets are unravelling. One by one they are being revealed. First was my ability to see radiations, truth about my condition from Medrine and now my therapy.

It won't be surprise if somehow my shadow history will also get revealed. Either from me or someone else. Matt cuts in my thoughts, you can say that again. That over confidence you showed in your interview was so blatantly obvious. Was there a secret meaning behind it. Cass asks, that’s pretty obvious. You always have an angle. They knew my tactics well enough to claim this. I lied here because they don't know I was overcompensating for my panic attack.

I say, if you had met Kafar today you would know he wasn't done scheming. And there's the rumors about me cheating. There is still so many things that can go wrong before Heraknus arrive, showing a strong front was important, but I was also challenging him in a way. Trying to force him to do a mistake that I can use against him. Matt was confused, wait what. How does that make sense. I continue, he may or may not be the one who tried to sabotage Marina and Blake. And interrupting the my match with Charles. I didn't care about him earlier, but now he is unpredictable. And that’s dangerous. So I figured if that would make him pressured and make a mistake that I can show publicly.

This was a blatant lie, but it could still happen. I thought about this a little on my way over here. I was wondering if there was any positive side of my show. The chances of this coming to any fruition was almost zero, but who knows. Miracles happen. This was good enough reason for them to believe. Cass laughs, damn you. You really can't help scheming huh. Matt puts his hand on his jaw, yup. Classic. Its a little weak though. You didn't even mention Kafar in your interview. It was a weak lie to begin with.

I shrug, hey, my ideas can't be always diabolical. I just went ahead to kill two birds in one stone, show my resolve to everyone here and put pressure on Citradel. That was in part true and Luther was the one who suggested it. Matt wasn't fully convinced, but in the end nods, yeah I guess. I mean, if it really worked, you are a god damn genius. I am glad he thought of it, because I felt a complete sham. Tricking my friends like this. Cass walks around the hologram, ha, that was always true.

She faces me, can you imagine how far you have become. I mean, just years ago I used to visit in your hospital and later your guardians home. Even then you weren't strong enough to fight other humans, let alone alphas or overdrive users. I feel embarrassed knowing I fallen behind. I points to Matt, and he was even depressed this morning. Matt suddenly jerks and gets appalled, hey. I was not depressed. I was just feeling down a little. Cass scoffs, that’s the same thing.

This wasn't my intention to make them feel this way. Its completely normal to be even jealous. Its in the nature of people in a group. I say, its fine. You don't have to worried about it. I know very much how much a strange existence I am. Being a MARS child has its own way of making it very different. But trust me, you don’t need be so down. This is just the beginning. Once our cities merge things will change, everyone's real trainings will start. And depending on you, your ranking will change.

Cass asks, wait, training and ranking change. How. I nod, ask Blake or Luther or Tina. They have proposed a way. Me and some other were consulted about its feasibility. I agreed to it. I hope others also do it. Matt got excited, tell us more dude. He was more enthusiastic to improve. I answers, nah. This one is not my secret to give. Ask them. We don't want people to get wrong idea and influence the officers to change it. I like the idea. In fact I am looking forward to it. I think this had been looming on the two of them for a while, because they seem to welcome this idea very much.

Matt cheers, yes. I thought tournament was the only time we get to train seriously. Cass nods, but we can change our raking's that means we still have opportunity to grow. I just added in something to curb their expectation so that it doesn't lean in a single way, I'll just say this, it wouldn't be a tournament, so don't think it will have same rules. Matt glees, you mean there's no time limit. Cass runs her hand on her hair, what about weapons, we can use them too.

I was done telling anything else. I just smiled at them telling I am not going to tell what exactly. They both got excited. I was glad this seem to alleviate some hidden tension they been carrying since their defeats. I checked the time and say, I know you guys probably want to talk more, but aren't you on the clock. Your break ends in another 20 minutes. Matt says, oh shit. Yeah. I totally forgot. Wait, how did you know. I was hurt he had to ask that. I just raised my eyebrow gesturing that it wasn't worth asking how I know.

Cass says, duh. He probably has M keeping tab on everyone. We should go back soon. We both totally forgot what we came for. Matt nods and pulls out his tab. Oh, so they did have something for me. He gives me his tab. It showed a list of things, materials, minerals and compounds. And against them the amounts. I quickly did a cursory glance at it. When my eyes landed on the few of the items at bottom I became a concerned, what is this. Cass then explains that this list came from Marina. She prepared a list of things in preparation for a team to arrive from Citradel. She is concerned that without these materials, the Kuret enrichment will be slowed down and cause more delays in the infrastructure expansion.

I sigh, I had a rough guess of what Citradel used to make their buildings and infrastructure. I never imagined it was this expensive. Platinum and Titanium I knew, but I didn't know about Palladium. And she says we need it in a week. Matt nods, Actually, 5 or 6 days. My god, does Marina believe I am a magician that I can pull out this from a hat. This is something not even some countries can buy in one go. If I had more time, I could get it. But less than a week. I doubt anyone could. Cass says not everyone understands how difficult this is. When Tine told us, some clueless people who didn't study about human or Earth thought it wasn't an issue.

I bet they were people who hid in secluded places to avoid fighting Echo. Its not that uncommon that people will lack Earth knowledge with a growing crowd now. Matt asks, to be honest, even I didn't know some of it until Cass told me how rare or difficult some of it was to get. I got some vague idea when Tina explained its almost impossible. But hey, impossible for you is a daily snack right. Cass smack her palm to back of Matts head, knock it out. Don't just assume he can perform miracles.

I wished he wouldn't put me in such high pedestal. I answers, Cass is right. This, I raise the pad to him, is nearly impossible for me. Matt gives a angry stare at Cass and turns to me, you said nearly. So its not impossible right. Damn him, its just a phrase. I never say anything hundred percent. But that doesn't mean I can actually do it. Cass says, what about getting it illegally. I scoff, with this amount, nothing can be procured legally in a short time anyway. I do have some of these in bulk quantities prepared. But definitely not everything.

I ask, M, check this list against our inventory. Run a brief overview of how much we have right now. M says, running the list, boss. Matt asks, should I share this list to you on the network. I shook, no. As a precaution, any device in the vicinity of his place is hacked. Matt's jaw open in shock, huh. Dude, you are way too paranoid. Cass laughs, you should know its nothing new Matt. She closes his jaw with her hand. Matt gulps and whispers something to her. Her eyes immediately widens and then she glares at me.

I make a mischievous smile. Talking to them has been good for me, because I get to laugh rather than be gloomy and frustrated. I say, don't worry, flashing them my teeth. They both remain silent, whatever private things you have on your phone, its yours. M has a privacy screening. Only in extreme cases I can ask her to show it to me. So all your dirty stuff is safe. That didn't exactly lessen the glare they were throwing at me. Jeez, I shudder to think what kind of messages, photos, or maybe even videos they have on their phone.

I say, trust me. I am not interested in seeing anything you both kids do in your private time. But seriously, if you don't want things to leak, keep it in separate phones, unlinked to the network and encrypted. Cass says in a quite anxious voice, it is unlinked and encrypted. I nod, that’s good. Then you don't need to worry. Matt eyes me, dude. Not cool. You can still hack in it right. I didn't say anything just smiled. It was kind of a revenge for making me reveal so much of my secrets.

I left them both in a panicking state and turn to the result M showed in the wall screen on my right. M says, boss, we have about thirty percent of the total items with their required quantities. And an average of seventeen percent of the other items, ranging from eleven to twenty three percent. Honestly, I was expecting to be much lower. When did my contact in the east accumulate the additional supplies. Must be during the tournament when I wasn't looking. This is still not enough.

I began raking my brain for a solution. There are two things we must do get this done. One requires me to visit my European friend, its been long and we are due for a meet. And the other, well, I have to talk to Blake and Marina. If both things work out, I might get up to 80 to 90 percent of this list. That will have to do for now. I can get the rest next week, while they begin processing with the materials in hand. I say, it's going to be a rush, but it will be done. Cass looks at me doubtful at my claim, are you sure. I nod, tell others I will have it imported in 6 days. I will make it so that it in comes in multiple shipments for security. I will share the details of the shipments in a day or two.

Matt says, see. He got this. He probably had a little too much faith in my abilities. That only made me feel more like a sham. Cass was less confident, but a moment later nods, if you say so. Lets head back then. I followed them through the door as they step out. Cass says, don't go missing today again. Had dinner with us. I bet everyone wants meet you. Matt waves, yeah. Spare some time for us also dude. I wave them with a smile, not sure how tonight will turn out.

I resumed my analysis of my mental condition. Talking to them had alleviated some of the anxiety I had. I hopped it will look with fresh eyes. After two hours I threw the digital pointer into wall in anger, nothing. A damn waste of time. I thought I had to just accept Zakerine death as something I couldn't stop. I forced myself to believe it wasn't my fault, even mediated on it. But its still the same, my panic attacks are still coming when I use my Kuret. Just

what am I missing here. What about Wagners death, I wasn't even there though. And as much as I hate him, how can his death make me feel guilty.

My spiraling thoughts were driving me crazy. It was 7 now. Only 5 hours before I can show I have my panic attacks under control when I use my Kuret. My anger and frustration left my body after I drink a glass of water. I sigh realizing its no use. I won't make it in time. I had a dangerous thought then. What if can trick Drew into believing it I can use my Kuret. Immediately I dismiss the thought next moment. Setting aside the moral betrayal, she won't be fooled so easily.

I yell, dammit. I give up. At this point I had exhausted all the phycological avenues. I surrender myself to luck. I went to my bedroom and pull out a shirt and jacket I use for disguise. I say to M, begin protocol D. Give me all possible locations I go visit. M interjects from the wall monitor, boss, are you sure you want to leave now. The deadline with Dr. Drew is in 4 hours 53 minutes. As I put on my dress I say, just do it. I am mentally done. I need to get out and stay with people. Otherwise my own mind will drive me crazy.

M says, understood. Running the protocol. Scanning for suitable destinations. I went to the bathroom and pulled out the face net from the cabinet. Its been a while since I put it on. I last used it just after the flag capture game. As I prepare to set it on the skin, M says, found 4 locations with a balanced crowd. What is your preference, boss. A fast dining, central market, a bar or the recreation center. I thought for a moment. I wasn't in the mood for a drink, but I was interested in chatting with certain person.

I ask, what about my usual spot. Is that not suitable. M says, there is a little more crowd than usual. I pick up 37 GPS phones, and possibly a dozen more with switched off phones. I suggest to find a less crowded place if you really want to go there again. Once the face mask was done, I put on the blond hair wig. I say, its fine. As long I don't have to deal too much of riled up crowd I am good with it. Set a course and obscure all the available cameras in the path. Also, have ART send the car nearby the location as a backup. But keep it hidden. After a moment M says, all set boss.

I last touch to my disguise, I take my wide black spectacles and put it on. I look into the mirror checking if everything was okay. M says, facial recognizability, 12%. A little higher than usual. But its fine. No one would think I was crazy enough to walk in the city disguised. I smile at that thought, little did they know that I had been doing it for quite some time.

David (Chapter 70)

Sunday, January 11, 2026 14:20

I took the public trolley and in about 20 minutes, I arrive at my destination. It was almost dark now. Sun had already set down, and along with my brooding was growing. I am literally depending on my luck. Hoping that someone says or does something that will trigger something in me. Guh, its just crazy to think it come to this. But in the wise words of James, you get drunk when you don't know what to do. I was standing a little away from the new haunt bar. I can see a lot of people talking inside. I just hope that I can get a seat on the counter. My usual spot.

When I step in, the natural brew of booze fill my throat. Of course its mixed with Kuritines, but I can't smell it. Or see its glimmer. I saw about 50 people here, many in groups sitting around the table. The musician playing his tunes with his Kuret on the side. He remember him, he was here the last time also. So did he get hired permanently. I look for my seat, but unfortunately someone was already there. And the person I wanted to meet was here too, well, she is always here, its her family bar.

The guy I don't recognize sitting was an officer. He was happily talking to his other buddy beside him. Hmm, I could take the empty seats at the corner, but that's too cramped. I guess I just have to remove them from my place. I walk to them, hey guys, you mind if I take this seat. I am a regular here. I tried the carrot approach first. Their laughter died down and then turns to me, just take one in the corner man. You don't monopolize this place. Well, that's true. I stuck my hand in the coat pocket and pull out some cash. This is the stick approach. I put it on the counter in front of them. Their eyes widen at the amount of notes stacked, how about I get you both five more rounds of whatever you are having.

They obviously didn't think I was this adamant about this particular seat. The left guy says, someone is having a nice day. Well, I don't mind. But are you sure, we are celebrating tonight on our victory. We got special kuret drinks. The guy was getting cheeky with me. I smile in response, is that right. Well, in that case I guess there's nothing I can do, I put more cash on the counter from my pocket, expect recommend the 1970 Irish whiskey, more expensive, but tastes much better. You won't forget this night. The two were a little bit speechless at my ostentatious conduct. The guy on right laughs, we will take up on that offer. He knocks on the counter and the lady behind zooms into the view.

The guy said, this dude is buying is couple of rounds of drinks for us. 1970 Irish whiskey and keep them coming. He slides the money on the counter to her. She flashes a smile seeing me, is he now. Well it's a good choice. She turns to a kid behind her, I need 3 bottles of it. The kid disappears in the back room and the guys leave their seats enjoying much more of their unexpected delight. I gladly take the empty seat left behind. The women says to me laughing, you didn't need to do that. That is 3 times than the ones they were drinking.

I wave her gesturing its no big deal. I rest my hands on the counter, the usual. She raises her eyebrows to me standing still, that's all I get. I don't see you in 3 weeks and just like that. Jeez, you must think I am just a waitress huh. She was playing at me. I smile, oh please. You were just worried that if I don't come often enough, you won't get to buy that Kuretine bracelet you had your eye on. That caught her off guard. I remembered she said about it one of the times before. Just then someone called for her and she motioned me wait for a minute.

While I waited, I looked around the bar. There were more people today. I touch the end of my shades and boot up the interface. From the ends, a beep sound comes, which only I can hear. A moment later, the eye glass begins to scan all the people in the room. M says to my inner ear, all clear boss. No one important or anyone who could recognize you. The interface goes away and I turn back to the counter. Just then the kid comes out rushing with 3 bottles in his arms, careful Ryan. You don't want to drop them again.

He sneers at me, just forget about that will you. I did a mistake once. I say, yeah. And I covered for it. You want me tell your sister. That removed his scowl with a little annoyance as he carried more carefully now to guys at the corner. He then walks back to me, let me guess. You will have the same, your usual human scotch. That's so boring. Try this one. I raise my hand, I am not making the mistake of one having your made up drink. I'll stick with the ones I know.

He twitches his mouth, come on. This is better. Just try it. Its free. But the next one is going to cost you. He brings a deviant smile. I shook my head, I had made the mistake of buying expensive things twice from him that turned out to be shit. I remain unconvinced that this time would be any better. He then jumps up and leans on the counter bending towards me. He whispers, I am saving up money for buying something and surprise Peter and Elina. Ah, I see. His real intension was now apparent. I wouldn't mind buying it, but I can't just give it him. That would send wrong message about me to him.

I look around the place and whisper back, a bet then. If you can get just one person to buy your drink while I am here, I will buy a dozen of your new inventions. How about it. That made his eyes lit up. I interrupted his bliss, not counting the free drink. You get someone to buy after their first drink. Like how you just did it for me now. Do that, I am game. That put a stop to his chipper. Thought he would get one up on me. But he wasn't too much discouraged. In fact, he was little fired up. He nods, don't go back on your word Mack. And don't tell Elina about this.

I nod and we both briefly shook hands. He settles back on his feet and begins searching for his next victim. He is a good kid, and even a better brother. Much better than Peter, who is nowhere to be seen again. I guess his side hustle of imports is keeping him busy. Don't know if he is making any money out of it to balance out his absence here. Elina zips back to me after handing out drinks to others, what was that. Did he ask for your money again. I raise my hand surrendering, nope. I didn't give him anything.

She glares at me, you know what I mean. He offered his mix of cocktail again right. I didn't deny or confirm it. She clicks her tongue to her brother now going around and looking for gullible people. She sighs, you are a bad influence on him. Don't take more of his ridiculous Kuret drinks. She pulls out the scotch from underneath the counter and begins pouring it on a ice filled glass. She says, I don't need people to think this is an experimental bar like the one in sector 3.

I smile remembering her rivalry with that family. Honestly, I don't mind the experimental bar they have. I have visited them couple of times too. But they run out of the stuff I can drink very quickly, so its not always feasible for me. I grab the cold glass and say, its fine. He is the poster kid of your bar. She shook her head, you mean a bad sister who allows a minor to be here. I answer, you need the help. Without Peter, you either hire more staff or trust Ryan. She puts her elbows in front of me and sighs, yeah I guess.

I take my first sip of this in a month. The liquid warms my throat and chest with the familiar sensation. I put down the glass basking in the much needed bliss from this terrible day. I tell her, besides, your company more than makes up for it. Those sector 3 guys are just buffs from Citradel. You got the skills. She turns to me with an amused smile, just one sip and you are already drunk. I chuckle, I don't need to be drunk to say it. I didn't just think because hers was more profitable, she was very attractive too. A quality one needs to run a bar.

I didn't expect her to be good conversationalist when I was searching for good places to spend in my downtime. Obviously, she has to be good to fit her role in a bar. But she and I just clicked on many things. I liked that about us. I used to feel guilty about being a fake though, but after a while it just went away. I thought she was being the same with me and other customers. But I gradually helped open up more of her. And we became real friends. All though I only get to meet her in her here always. I kept it this way intentionally to keep her out of my life, separate from the drama and repercussions if she knew who I really was. It was nice to talk to someone without them knowing my sordid history.

She puts her head on the counter, hair black pony tail swaying on the side, these two days have been draining. Good for business though. I even hired 3 more temps. An hour ago it was damn crazy. You came in a good time. I take another sip. Of course I knew that. I had M run a prediction algorithm on finding the best time when she would have a little less customers. I look around the place. I had kept my eye on Ryan, who was just shot down the second time. I am very sure no one will buy his drink. At least he will get a good lesson from it.

She raises her head to me, so. What kept you all this time. I put the glass down, you know how it was. With the tournaments end approaching, they kept me on double time to use my software for the broadcast. I barely had 5 hours of sleep everyday. Even on off days. I think I told you last time too about it. She looks to the scaffolding trying to recall, oh right. You said that. I totally forgot. I thought you swore off drinking when you didn't swing by the 2nd week. I chuckle at that, ah, so you missed me. I didn't know you were thinking about me that much.

She says coly, please. I was just wondering where my usual drinker go. The amount of money you have spend all this time, and even paying for others. I sometimes feel you are not my customer, but my employer. I raise the glass to her, I am hurt. I thought I was your friend. She whispers, true. But you know, friends with benefits. That was too corny. I spilled a little while drinking. She laughs seeing me little agitated at that comment. I scoff, you know. If someone heard you, they be jealous. I get to hog all of your valuable time when I am here.

She makes a disapproving smile, come on. Don't say that. She looks around to see if anyone was watching them. No was doing it, I was just teasing her. She says, you still don't have a girlfriend, that's why you hang out with me, borrowing your sorrows in the same scotch, in the same place with just me. I smile, oh, who knows. I might have one and I still come here to watch you work. Its strangely satisfying to see you work your magic on other clueless people. And you do look good in that outfit. She laughs, you just a tease, no guts. You never made a move on me. I bet you still haven't asked out any of the girls you have a crush on.

Okay, that weirdly took a turn. I never told about this to her. She caught on when I didn't immediately say anything back, I knew it. You never asked me out, so there is a girl. You keep asking if I have a boyfriend, but you don't talk much about yourself. I say this as someone who can read people, you are a total wimp. Just ask her out. You got money and decent looks. And a big brain is a plus too. What's stopping you. I didn't like the fact that my brain was less important than money. She was just goading me by saying that. I scoff, calling me a coward huh. What would you say if I really asked you out.

She didn't waste a second to reply, hell no. I was expecting that, I don't need someone who has this much time and money to spend on just drinking. She mocks me by thinking for a second, now, if you weren't a customer. Then maybe. She shrugs like she was open to it. I too didn't hesitate to say, all right. That makes this simple. I will not be your customer anymore. That made her a little tense. Even if was only messing with her, I could tell she was blushing a little. Then she shook her head and says, yeah, no. Pass. I need us to be friends with benefits. At least for a little while longer. The last words were more hushed.

I take a slip laughing all the while noticing didn't hate the idea. Honestly, if my life wasn't mess right now, I would want like to try. Things with Vanessa is, well, complicated. I don't even have an inkling on how to fix that relationship, let alone think what's next for us. Plus she is with Ned. I shook my head and take another slip before I get distracted by how much my life sucks now. Elina says, by the way, did you watch todays interview of David. I try to stay clear of any conversation about myself for obvious reasons.

It was inevitable we would talk about people I know. The tournament went for months, it's going to be on peoples mind majority of the time. Like a sport event people bet on, enjoy on someone victory and curse on others loss. But whenever I spoke with Elina about this, I kept it general, without pointing out anyone. Otherwise it would be awkward, like it was now. I have especially avoided talking about me, because that will shatter my own persona of Mack and I begin speaking in third person. I also don't know how I will react when Elina says what she thinks about me. But today I was different, I was slightly drunk and feeling resentment and anger on myself. Not the best moment for self pity me, but I went with it anyways.

I say flatly, that guy has a bug up his ass. I get he is fighting that Heraknus guy, but he is being too cocky. A couple beside me were startled to hear me suddenly rant. I thought they would ignore me, but no, they joined in. The guy says, you are talking about David right. I don't know these two, but looks like Elina does, Dos, keep out of it. Don't anger my friend. I found it interesting she was defending me, or maybe Mack. Then she says to me with smile, he hasn't even finished his first drink. Wait until it's had bought for at least his 3rd or 4th.

I couldn't help but laugh. She knew me well enough to know I wasn't bothered by her blatant honestly. He says, you got it wrong Elina. I agree with him. That made me smile even more, when I should be pissed instead. His girlfriend says, he is being delusional if he thinks he will win so easily. Its not like I was expecting people to be on my side. I even heard it on news that some people's reaction. But its interesting to know what they think when not in front of a camera.

The women says, he was lucky to get a draw. But now he is just pushing it. I had to comment on this, I think he should not have taken the deal. The guy jumps in, yeah. Exactly, I was just telling earlier that he should have just continued the match. Instead they go and make an exhibition match out of it. I was weirdly having fun chatting shit about me. I have been blamed for many human crimes, knowing full well it was all fudged up to build my criminal reputation. But now I am blaming on my real self.

I mentally had a kick when thinking about my real self. Do I even know what it was. I have been thinking so much about this today when searching the answer for my condition, and yet no luck figuring it out. Elina says, don't start agitating people. I don't want to deal with this again like yesterday. So it wasn't the first time huh. Dos asks, what do you think Elina. You said yesterday he was a twerp for disappearing after the match. But what now, you saw his interview.

I could my heart beating slightly slowly in anticipation. Elina leans and says in low tone, you didn't hear from me, but I heard from an officer that he broke into the Citadel's boat and caused some problems when they were leaving. The guy thinks himself a hot shot. If I wasn't drunk a little, I would have either yelled at her or went to a corner to hide in shame. The girl says, jeez. I didn't hear about that. Guess he really does break rules and thinks he can get away with it.

Funny thing is she wasn't wrong. I do think I can break or at least skirt around the rules and still get away with this. I ask, what do guys think will happen. Elina leans away and shrugs, hard to say. He may be even cheating, maybe not. Still, he made it through the finals. I don’t know if he really as arrogant as he appears in the TV.

This is terrible. I don’t care what the other two think, but Elina is annoyed with me. She says, I don't care who wins, I just want more stability in our city. I guess normal people have their own priorities. Dos says, so true. This tournament was well and good, but I don't want to keep driving and giving tours to outsiders.

His girlfriend says, pays is good though. He nods, can't deny that. I finally bought a joint house for my family due to this. Elina adds, yeah, no matter who wins, we will soon have new residents. I am much more looking forward to meeting Heraknus. The women says, oh my god. You too. Some people are afraid, but I feel much safer with them here. Dos says, hey now, our officers are strong too. They were talking about Heraknus. I don't know when, but I tuned out the discussion because I finally learned what Elina thinks of me. I hurriedly finished the drink and asked for another.

I shouldn't have made the unreasonable hope that she was on my side. Its not like she is outright against me. And based on how I appear on a screen, its not her fault. But still, just because I understand it, doesn't mean it doesn't hurt of what she feels about me. This is exactly why I never wanted to talk about me. I just wanted to keep our conversations simple. I was on my third glass when Elina came back again serving another couple of guys, I think more officers will be coming in now. I heard they were stuck with work whole day.

I ask, dang it. That means I can't keep you to myself any longer. She opens her jaw like she was repulsed, but I know she liked it. She replies, come now, I can't be exclusive to anyone. This is prime time baby. I think I should hire more temp for tomorrow again. Its a good bet. The next few days it will be busier, so people won't have time to go back and instead come here or other places to eat. I didn't get to talk to her much today, M's prediction is just a probability in the end. I saw more people coming in.

I can't stay here any longer. I caught a few people whom I spent some time. They might recognize me. I shook my head, so this is all the time I get today huh. I should have came in earlier. I wished I stayed here much more. The company here is much more better to look instead of what I have been staring at whole day. I thought I was saying this in my mind, but turns out I was mumbling to myself. And Elina was close enough to hear it. She cocks her eyes at me, wow. That’s a compliment I never heard from you. Please tell me which other girl you were ogling today. And you gotta tell me how much prettier I am from her.

I was bursting out laugh from that. I have been staring at a digital board filled with dead people names. What kind of reaction will she have if I reveal that. She was waiting for my answer. I say, you are a 9 compared to 0's I have been seeing. She makes a disapproving face, I don't know what to say. Be angry that you don't think I am a 10 or that you are a natural enemy of women. She reminds me of Marina, but less whimsical. I scuffle in my pocket and pull put some cash on table.

I was moderately drunk, but not enough to lose my faculty. However, at this point I might just get loose lipped and say something I shouldn't. Elina says looking at the stack, Mack. I know I joke around, but this a little too much. I added a little extra than usual, actually I gave the remaining 5000 MDR I had with me. I finally got to know what she thinks of me. Not that its going to change anything. I guess even she feels guilty using me like this. Though I have used her more. So it’s a fair trade. I say, take it. It was a celebration for me too today. Buy that Kuritine bracelet you wanted.

She looks at me with a little guilt while talking the money, I really appreciate it. And you still remember that, I told you that months ago on a whim. I nod, whims can be sometimes good. You struggled a little opening this place. And I want to keep it going. So I can have you for even longer. I said it too seriously. Dammit, I was really getting too light headed. She laughs, you are just too much. Only you would get drunk from simple human drink. Your Kuret immunity is still impressively low.

One of the drawbacks of this was I couldn't get fully drunk. Because no ever does with normal human drink. This is pretty much the tolerance I have to stay sober without outing that I am really drunk. She sighs, I should seriously consider making you an investor, but what's the point. Funny enough is that you are almost already like one. I say, I'll take that action. How about 20 percent. She smiles, sorry. I rather have you as a friend than a partner. I don't want to mix business between us. I answer, I thought we were friends with benefit.

She scoffs, aren't you the clever one. She says after thinking about it, I just don't want to change anything between us. That makes two of us. This is what Dr. Drew had suggested months ago. She said to open up and talk to people outside my circle of friends. Having conversation with her helped my therapy. Its not just her, but talking to anyone without the burden of my history is what helped me. However, what Drew didn't know was that I am doing it incognito. I don't know if Drew knows doesn't know that I hid my identity like this.

We may keep flirting each other like this, but that’s all this will ever be. I wish it wasn't about money, but that’s the best way to not make it personal. Because once I step out, its done. We will never meet outside her bar. No, its more like I purposefully keep our lives separate. I have been lying to her big time. The money I give her is also a little incentive to keep her for asking more out of us. I know her family will be her priority always.

I say to her, well I tried. She then says, wait, that’s it. You won't even try to ask me out and convince me more. I look at her with a strange look. That came out of nowhere. I curse that today's the day when I can't see her glimmer to know if she was just flirting or for real. I played it safe, I don't want to take advantage of you. Not when you keep saying I pay you too much, but then you take it anyways. That made her laugh, such a cowards answer. See, this is why you always come in alone. You need to grab the opportunity when its coming, no matter where it comes from.

I still can't tell if she was for real. I laughed it off pushing myself out of the chair, message received. Will be on the lookout for more opportunity. I turn around to look for Ryan. But he was nowhere to be seen. Elina says, he went back inside. In the end no one tried his drink. I smile and pull out a little from my other pocket the separate cash I was keeping for him. It was just in case he actually got someone to drink it. Elina saw me trying to add more money on the table. She says, stop it Mack. You shouldn't spoil him. I reply, he is like you. He wants to get something for you and Peter. And he was trying hard to sell his product to people. It was quite impressive for kid his age.

Elina remained stunned, really. I didn't even see him among the crowd. You got some sharp eyes dude. It was out of habit to keep aware of my surrounding. Even when I don't have glimmers to see. Instead of putting this cash on the table, I grab her hand. It was warm and felt good. For a moment she was stunned. Damn, I was being rude to her. This is why I don't stay here when I am this drunk. I slide her the cash in her hand and take it away, I didn't want people to see me giving you more money. Didn't want to give trouble to you from others. Though, do me a favor and give it to Ryan.

She looked a little shocked, perhaps I really screwed up when I just grabbed her like that. She shook it off though and puts the money in her own pocket, I don't know how to thank you Mac. I feel I am using you too much. You sure you won't bankrupt. I hate to think I don't get to see you because of this. She shouldn't have said that, it just pains me knowing the reverse was going on. I just say, don't worry about it. I had a rough month, that’s why I didn't visit you. I'll be back next week.

Her smiles returns, well, that’s great to hear. I shouldn't toy with her emotions like this. Or maybe she was doing it to me. But I waved her bye and walked out. It was 7:30. I spent only about 45 minute with Elina, but it always feels longer and shorter at the same time. I wish I could talk to her outside of work. But that’s not fair to her. I would just create more troubles for her. As I walked to the next block, I saw a familiar jeep. It was Peters. He was racing through the streets recklessly. Beyond the normal limit. As he wooshes past me, I turn back and check him out for a moment. He didn't even park his jeep to the shed, he jumped out of jeep with its engine running and rushed inside the bar.

He was lucky there weren't wasn't a single officer in sight. They would scold him for driving like a mad man. I don't know what got him so worked up. I turn back and walked away, knowing nothing I could do. I won't get into their affairs once I am outside the bar. I have my own personal shit to figure out. After walking another block I stopped. I shook my head, no. Don't get involved. I mutter to myself. Peter is like this, brash and reckless. Maybe he came to just pick something. Or talk to Elina.

Then I recalled how suspicious the guy is. He used to manage the bar with Elina, but when he got some part time job he basically left everything to her. I mean everything. Elina said he was contributing to the family, so I just figured he wasn't interested in a bar job. What could make him rush into the bar like this at night. I shook my head, no. Stop it. Don't look for trouble. I thought I made up my mind. Then a moment later I started walking back to the bar.

Dammit. This is why I shouldn't be drunk. My sober mind is telling to just leave it. I somehow convinced myself that I just wanted to check on Peter for a second. I seriously need to find a better reason than just bad intuition. And that’s when I was frustrated that my suspicion actually come true. I saw hoards of people coming out from the bar. Huh, its not closing time. More like it’s the beginning. What happened. I found the two couple I was talking to before and ask, hey guys. What happened. Why is everyone leaving.

Dos says, don't know dude. Elina's brother came in asked everyone to leave. Elina almost kicked him out, but he was way to amped up. The girl interlocked on his arm says, Peter said something about some emergency and asked us all to leave. I didn't even get to finish my bowl of chips. I ask, there are some officers inside, did they just sat while Peter made a ruckus. Dos nodded, yeah. They were mad too. But then Elina apologized and asked us to leave. I guess you can't choose your family. Even if they are so rude like him.

That he was. I observed from a distance as people left the bar. I pulled my hoodie when I recognized some officers coming my way. I continued to watch from a street corner from the opposite. This is too much, I should leave. They might have some real emergency. Nothing suspicious except for Peter. Elina also agreed to this, so everything fine. I sigh, what am I even doing. I am already hiding my identity from them, now I am stalking them too. This is crazy.

I forced myself to wake and move on. There are other ways to keep an eye on them. I hit the button on my specs. I say, M, keep an eye on Peters jeep GPS. I don't want to know where its going, only if it is an outlier from his

usual places. Strictly passive observation. I turn my back and walked away. M says, will do boss. Isolating the GPS and running passive surveillance. I felt much better now. I should have done this from beginning instead of suspecting anything wrong here. My senses are inhibited.

A moment later M gives a warning sound, boss. There is something wrong. I can't find the GPS on the car. Its not just switched off, I don't find any signal of it. My legs stop when I heard that. I take in a big breath when I knew I landed myself into trouble.

David (Chapter 71)

Sunday, January 11, 2026 21:50

I positioned myself at a better spot in the alley to check what was happening inside the bar. With my specs I had zoomed in through the window. Dos was right, Peter was behavior very odd. He was anxious as hell. Elina and Ryan were now beside him and they were talking. No, more like a heated discussion. My earlier intuition was correct. When people become blind, there other senses gets stronger. Without my glimmer, I had a bad feeling. At least that's the excuse I was giving. Simpler answer was I was being nosy and didn't want to go back home. I already gave up on finding me a way to fix my panic attack. I could at least be more useful here since i have already broken my rule.

Every vehicle on the island needs a GPS tracker. Its a mandatory. Tampering or removing it was, well, a crime. A minor one, but it was still a crime nonetheless. Why would he need to remove it. I also don't have a GPS on my car, but that's because mine is ART and I used my own team to build it. What is he trying to hide. Isn't his work just some sort of supply chain for importing stuff from outside. A nasty thought came to my mind, but I didn't want to presume anything yet. I continued to watch them without hearing what they were talking about.

I could tell Elina was upset. Something is wrong here. And after a while all 3 of them came out. Elina turns off the lights and closes the bar. She is actually closing the bar early. It was really some sort of emergency. Soon everyone got into Peter's jeep. I took a step back hiding beside the alley wall. What's my game plan though. I could tail them, but the city streets are have too many corners and turns. Its a maze structure so that its easier to travel, but it also means you could spot a tail that much easier.

And without my Kuret, I can't exactly run behind them. I did have an idea. I come out of my hiding spot and cross the street. I tell M, bring the car at my current location. Also, turn on the GPS on this specs. M says, done. I take it off and fold it in my left hand. I hear the jeep's engine roaring. Before it starts moving, I stealthily throw it in the back of the jeep. Ryan was sitting behind, he didn't hear it dropping to the floor. He was very still and anxious. I didn't want them to know it was me walking, so I didn't turn to check on the front row seat.

Peter drives the car a second later out of the view. I opened my wrist watch and ask, we good. M mini hologram comes out, tracking signal acquired. ART's drove the car to my spot and I didn't waste time to take the driver seat. I tell M, keep the standard distance from them. The car takes me out of the crowded street and we began tailing them. M shows the map of the city on the window display.

He is going outside the city. ART drives the car exactly 200 meters away from them. I didn't want to push it any more since I am tracking them anyways. Soon we cross the sector 3 border. I ask M, anything important here I should know. M says, nothing out of the ordinary. There are mostly factories in this side of the sector. There are zero results on any high alert area watch list. Its possible they were just passing though this place. But then the GPS stops moving.

ART also parks beside the road. I saw the GPS marker close to a water treatment plant. Not at all suspicious, I say. Why did Peter bring them here. I ask M, is there any surveillance in the area. M says, very minimal boss. This area isn't high profile enough to warrant such need. City plans shows they have enough camera's to check the in and out from the street, but not in the plant it self. That's no surprise, the plant runs all the time, but there no crew in the night.

I ask, what about patrols. M responds, I see 5 patrols near this section. But none have this area in their path for the next few hours. Right, nothing suspicious about this too. This is officially now a secret hideout. This carefully chosen place doesn't have any other purpose. What has Peter gotten himself into. I really didn't want my earlier suspicion to be true. What's my next step. Alert the officers on patrol. But what exactly do I say, hey, I was just stalking someone while incognito. I could leave it anonymous, but what if it wasn't anything truly nefarious.

I already put my nose in their business, lets do it properly then. M, how many surveillance bots I got right now. M says, we have 3. ART has confirmed its operational capability is at 100 %. I thought about for a second and say, fine. Release them. But no engaging the target. This is a recon, map the area, look for any people. Nothing more. M says, deploying them now. I hear some gear turning behind the car. 3 spear bots are thrown into the air straight up. They glide in the air with mini propulsion.

All of them has camera, so M links them to the window display. M says, entering stealth mode. The speed decreases, so does the noise it was creating. With slow and hidden movements, it flew in different directions of the plant. One bot came closer to the empty jeep parked beside the plant. It was completely hidden from the street. If this was really some sort of secret meeting, is Elina mixed up in this. No, she can't be. Ryan is with them too. While I don't believe Elina is hiding something, bringing Ryan was very strange. Maybe that what she was upset about while pointing to Ryan back in the bar.

Few minutes later of surveillance revealed nothing. There is nothing disturbed or suspicious. No vehicles or presence. M says, scanning complete. Nothing visible on the outside. Should I proceed to check the inside too. I stop her, no. Don't. I have a bad feeling. Peter can't have brought them to an empty plant in the night. Are you positive, no one is visible. M says, its all clear boss. If there are people, all are inside the building. I decided what to do. I open the small compartment and take out the small bag inside.

It had some battle ready items like medications and surveillance equipment's. I usually don't need it, but I have no choice. I order M, do heavy heat signature detection. If there are people inside, I want to know how many and where they are. From this point on, everything is on stealth mode. I put the micro transmitter on my right ear. M turns my watch into a minimal black screen to reduce the light. M says, shall I bring the bots from ART as backup. I nod, yeah. Good idea. Keep them hidden, but ready. I don't know whats going to happen. I like to avoid any combat if all possible.

Actually, I should leave if the situation escalates. Without my Kuret, I am too easy of a target. But I should prepare for the worst case. I get out of the car and ART camouflages the outside to match the grassy land. With my backpack in tow, I stealthily walk in the land. Using the cover of trees and landscape, I close the distance to the plant's backside. A minute later I hear a vibration on my watch. M has an alert about the surveillance. I crawl down and take a look at the small hologram my watch shows.

Its an arial birds eye view of the plan first. My lean curiously as I see 10 people inside, hurdled in one spot. Dammit, I was right. There are other people inside. Aside from the 3 that entered a while ago, there are 7 close. Then I see 3 more separated from the large cluster. They were spread out in the building. Bodyguards came to mind. It had to be. All 3 were moving around, but not leaving far from their spot. I tap my watch to view the side view of the scanning.

I can see one was in the 1st floor, along side the glass railing. One in the basement and one was very close to the people grouped inside. I think they are guarding the entrance door to hanger area where people are present. I see a lot of movement from this angle in that group. There are something large also that the scanner picked up. What is going on here. Peter brought them to meet this people? What did he get mixed up in. Without ears inside, all these questions would keep piling up. But I know, whatever this is, it is very distressing. A secret meeting in a empty place with no surveillance camera and patrols nearby. This whole thing screams a criminal gang.

Now I should really alert the officers now. I was about to do it, but then I get another alert. The 3 sphere drones had snuck in close by to capture their faces. The watch changes the hologram to show me a view of a highly pixelated camera of their identities. My jaw became loose from the shock. Cory, Quintin and Polly. These are top tier warriors from the tournament. I remember Cory was one of Nathan's lackey in the Valley. Is he also mixed up in this. No, I have kept very close tabs on him. And he knows with me, Blake, Marina and Vanessa here, he be screwed if he pisses off any one of us.

Are these people really hired guns. It's good I didn't call the patrol officers, because they can't handle all these 3 people together. Just what kind of game these people are playing to hire these people as protection. I should call Blake and Marina. I whisper, call Blake, to my watch. While the line connects, I move a little closer to the back entrance. I hid behind a tree and pull out a spare shades I had from the bag. This was designed for tactical purpose. I wore it and turn on the night vision.

From this angle I could zoom in and see Cory walking alongside the railings. I zoom in to him. He doesn't appear to have any weapons. He is strong without it anyways. I lean away and look at my watch. I didn't get an answer from Blake. Was he busy with some meeting? Then I tried Marina hoping she would be available. But she was also not responding. This is not good. I didn't want to do this, but I tried calling Vanessa. She also had turned her phone off.

I slam my fist on the tree, what is going on. I can't reach any of them when I need them the most. What am I going to do now. I can't exactly storm into the place without my Kuret. The bots I have brought will be turned to scrap by the 3 people guarding this place. So the only logical thing is to get ears on inside. I should decide what to do after knowing more. I speak to my watch, M, use one drone to launch a listening bug inside the hanger area. Use the wall in the east side, the one which opens to the inner room beside the loading area. The wall must be thick, so shoot a very small and precise laser and drill the hole.

M says through the transmitter in my ear, boss, a much more optimal location is through the window from the west side. The glass will be easier to shoot through with no noise. I reply, no. Polly is guarding the room not 30 feet from that window. She can sense the changes in temperature around her. She won't hear the sound, but she will most definitely sense the laser heat in such a cold room. Look at her position, she is purposefully standing away from all the machinery that generates the heat. Use the east side, machines running nearby will mask the laser heat enough that she can't sense it.

I remember her fight in the tournament, she was hyper aware of her surrounding. Her dual Kuret skill is very good for detection in such situations. M says, adjustment made. I will also base scenario predictions using their Kuret as a risk factor. That's good, because we will need it. Using the shades I track two of the drones flying stealthily towards the east side. One soars to a minimum height without alerting Cory and other one takes a mid ground level height to drill the hole.

A minute later the drones position themselves and fire. I anxiously looked at the feed from the third drone to monitor the guards position. I don't see any rapid movement, so they must not have heard anything. Instead of becoming less anxious, I was more now. Eager to know what this is all about. The bug was probably stuck into some inner wall of the hanger room, hopefully it can pick up the sound from there. Nothing came for next seconds, I ask, is there a frequency jammer. I can't hear anything.

M says, the bug is active boss. I don't detect any other high signals to cause disturbance. I suspect someone is using a Kuretine inside to block the sounds from leaving the room. M was right, I can't see the glimmers right now, so there's a good chance someone is using a kuritine or they themselves are using a Kuret. They probably didn't even want those 3 to listen what's going inside. I was getting impatient now. This was a bust. I am getting worried about Elina and Ryan much more now.

After scanning their heat signature this long and using Ryans height, M was able to find the identities of the two of them. They and Peter were standing on one side, while rest on the other. Its not just that they are simply surrounding them, they got them cornered. I don't like this one bit. Their body posture seems to have implication of being interrogated. Peter has gotten his siblings into something sinister. I shouldn't interfere directly like this. What if she learns of me because I storm inside. Just an hour ago she said she wasn't a fan of me. This would completely break our friendship. I don't know if can take ruining another person after Catherine and Vanessa.

I grit my teeth in anger. What am I thinking. When did I get so bothered by receiving people's scorn that it would prevent me from doing the right thing. Whatever repercussions happens, its not worth them getting hurt. I take a deep breath to clam my thinking and resolve for a possible close encounter with this group. I have very limited options without my Kuret. But its not like I not done things like this before. I must not forget that I could do these sorts of things on Earth, without relying on my Kuret.

Just because my Kurets gotten stronger, I shouldn't be completely relying on it. My ego has gotten fat with pride and that's one of the reason I have been miserable without my Kuret. I knew that since morning, but I couldn't move past it then. That has changed now. Seeing Elina in a hostile group like this is driving me. I don't believe Peter would let them get hurt, but he did got them involved for some reason. And if anything happens to them, it wouldn't be just on him, but on me too.

I tell M, prepare for infiltration. M responds, not advisable boss. You have not fully recovered from your fight with Charles. And without access to Kuret, you can't fight them. I make small laugh, tell me something I don't know. There is no backup coming, at least not in time. I have to do something. With the level of their security, I don't want to wait anymore. So override any concern setting for me and help me instead. M takes a moment to process and replies, switching to infiltration mode. Retrieving the blueprints and running algorithm for best point of entry undetected.

I began crawling around the field. Whenever Cory comes to the southeast side, I lie down still and avoid making any sound. With painful patience, I cross the land and hide behind the steel fence at the corner of the hanger entrance. M

hasn't response with an optimal entry point, so I sit tight and look for possible place to break into. Not many options. The hanger garage door is wide, but will make too much noise to cut through. The basement door is an option, but Quintin is patrolling below. His light controlling Kuret makes him able to detect light. Like Polly, he also chose the best place that gives the most advantage. Basement rooms and paths that are dark.

What's more, he can go invisible. If he suspects something when I break in, I might not be able to see him. Even with my night vision shades, the machinery around the basements generates heat. Its dark in the basement, but its hot as well. I am not fully equipped with any weapons too. I could get cornered if I am not careful there. So that's not an option too. As I crossed off other entry points, M says, I found a way to get inside boss. Through the water input pipe in the southwest. The pipe is large enough to fit a person in it. The pipe has a hatch outside and another one that opens inside the building. The outside hatch is easy to open and enter. Then you can cut through the other hatch from the inside with a laser and gain entry into the water treatment room number 5. It's one of the stations where Kuret treatment happens.

I ask, what about the water in the pipe. I don't have my underwater breathing apparatus. M answers, at night, few selected pipe are shut down. The water is closed off from the river side as well, so it will remain empty. It will be however, be terribly damp due to constant river water being fed through it. I can't worry about that. This looks like a viable option. I ruffle inside the bag and confirm I had the laser cutter. I ask, any idea how thick the iron is around the hatch. M says, unknown. The laser will cut through all of the material listed from the blueprint. with 97 percent probability. I will take that as a good sign.

Then I ask, this could work. How do I gain access to the hanger area room then. There is only two entry point, the garage door and inside door where Polly is guarding it. M answers, you navigate on this path from the control room. M shows a path in a hologram of the building. It leads to a operating room in the first floor that has window facing to the hanger room. I should be able to pry a small window open and listen in. I nod, all right, start showing me the path in my eye piece display.

I approach carefully to the outside hatch as M directs me. I was coming much closer to Cory's view now. While he may not be able to see me, he could hear me opening it. I have to time it properly when he is farthest away from this side. I have been observing his strides a while ago when I was waiting at the fence. He is moving in a predictable pace, so I have exactly 1 minute and 18 seconds before he laps this side. I hid behind a tree preparing myself to run when Cory leaves this side.

M started a countdown in my shades screen. As soon as he was out of view I dashed as deftly I could without making a sound. I saw the hatch door coming into view. I hope its not rusted. M told me earlier its used for regular maintenance inside, so I really hope its loose and quite enough. A moment later I skid down and grab the large handle The cold metal comes in contact and I anxiously start to rotate the hatch. This hatch is supposed to be a two person job. Its very heavy and refusing to budge. I put all the force into my wrists to get it moving.

A few seconds went by and I all managed to do was a little superficial movement. Shit. M failed to tell I it was this heavy. This probably isn't a problem for the workers, with their Kuret. Honestly, this should have been nothing for me. I grit my teeth in frustration as I kept pushing. Then I saw the countdown on my eye glass. I wasted a minute, this is bad. I let go of the handle and crawled back to the nearest tree I had marked for hiding in case I couldn't do it. Just few seconds before Cory came into the view, I hid behind the tree from his angle.

My fist tighten agitated. I can't fumble like this. Its pathetic. I get a flashback of the fight with Charles. I felt the same as back then. I was loathing myself when made mistakes and hid behind a boulder and pit. I thought I had moved passed such emotions. But it came back. No, I have been feeling it whole day in its own way. I have become over reliant on my Kuret. Since the war last year, I have become physically stronger, but my mental states been affected. So much so that I become weak without my Kuret. M begins a new countdown as Cory makes his next lap. But I didn't move. I took a deep breath to clear my thoughts.

I recalled Hansens and James words. Two mentors from two different planet, but same one lesson for me. Learn from mistakes. Even when I couldn't remember Hansen, I was unconsciously following his teaching. Drew also mentioned about repressed memories guiding my decisions unconsciously. But did I learn from the fight. No, I didn't. Not really. I had to fight the yips back then, and I will fight this mental block. With or without my Kuret. I resolved myself again. If I can't do it with strength, I will find a different way.

I opened my eyes and turned to see Cory leaving this side. I crawled back to hatch and sat in front of it. I was too agitated earlier, but I calmed myself to breathe slowly. Analyze the situation, like how I been doing all my life. The hatch is big and heavy, I didn't feel it was rusted, so its just about the correct force and angle. There is no strong stick to use as leaver and no gloves or cloth to get better friction with hands. I got an idea, instead of continues force, short burst of momentum could work.

I position myself on my back and angle my right leg towards the round edge of the hatch. And then I kicked with all my power I could muster. My kick make a low thump sound, and the hatch moved ever so slowly. I corrected the angle a little bit and kicked again. The hatch was turning with this position now. I felt a rush of adrenaline and continued to kick at the corner. It was definitely loosening now. But the time was running out. I hid again behind the tree once more. Even though this was a small insignificant obstacle, I felt some mental pressure I had all day getting lighter. It felt strange that a water pipe hatch did the trick for me that nothing else worked. Luck and coincidences, powerful things in the correct situation.

Once he left, I went back to work. With a bunch of more kicks at the correct angle, the hatch become loose enough for me to move it with my arms. The hatch was making small sound from the metal turning, but from the surveillance drone I saw Cory not reacting. I didn't want to waste another chance so I pushed a little faster and got it open. Now I have to open this heavy hatch, not just with brute force again. I crouched myself in a position where I bend my back and knees to use my entire body as a leaver.

This is the same concept used in tug of war, using the entire whole body weight. The result is how I expected, the hatch was heavy, but gravity was much stronger on myside. My grip tightens as I lunge backwards to the opening hatch. And soon it opened completely. Only 20 seconds remaining before Cory came in view. I swivel on the ground and jump in feet first. M was right, the pipe was big enough for a person to fit. The splash of the puddle in the bottom made an echoing sound in the hollow pipe. I sure hope no one heard that, because this was unavoidable.

I turn up and jump to grab the bottom inside handle of the hatch. I can't let it remain open for Cory to accidently see it. I was risking making a large sound when it closed. When the metal clashed, it made a low pitched sound. It reverberated in this pipe. I looked anxiously at the Cory from the surveillance camera, the thermal view showed no change. I exhale a long breadth. I dodged a bullet here. Maybe the sound didn't travel far like it did here. I confirmed Quintin and Polly also weren't moving far from their spot.

I didn't want to take more risk, so I began walking inside with slow and careful steps. It was getting damp and hot as I reach the building. My shoes were getting dragged in moss and a bit of mud. This is not how I imagined my infiltration would look like without my Kuret. I remembered how I was able to use the Kuret that reduces friction when I was crawling in the passage while looking for Charles in the coliseum. I smiled at that, compared that elegant and skillful work, this is brutish and ineffective.

I shake myself out of the negative feeling. It doesn't matter how I do it, as long as the job gets done the way I want. A few minutes later, M shows me the hatch distance in 50 meters. It comes into my view and it was the same as the one I used to enter. However, this was on the side, not on the top. At least M had chosen the correct pipe. It was on the top, I don't know how I would have opened it from the inside, even with my laser cutter. Actually, I wouldn't let that stop me. I would definitely find a way even if that had happened.

Once I reach to the spot I whisper, M, start scanning this area use the blueprints to find the approximate location of the lock I need to cut. I pull out the laser cutter from my bag. M begins to scan from my shades and begins to perform analysis. A minute later M says, analysis complete. The eye glass shows me the spot on the pipe wall that had the lock. I get to work and fire the cutter. M had shown me a rectangular area, so I was cutting though the metal in a unform way. This would have been a sinch with my glimmers. No, don't go there again. Doing it differently, doesn't mean its wrong.

Soon I fished the breaking the lock. I heard a small metal creaking. I have to carefully push it out and make sure it doesn't fall down. Otherwise there will be big noise for the whole building to hear. Using M's help I locate the best place and angle to push the hatch so that it doesn't fall. I took my time this time as I wasn't in a real rush. And gradually, the hatch opens with a whooshing noise. With one eye I was staring at the widening gap, with other I was monitoring the feed from the surveillance drones.

Finally, the gap was large enough for me to get out. With meticulous movements, I climb out of the pipe and push the hatch back into the pipe. I looked around the room with my night vision. It was like M said, it was a control room. There were machines and controls all around the room. I located the door and walked towards it. I was very close to Quintin this side of the building. However, I had the advantage here. I have an eye on them from the outside and inside.

I realized my shoes were wet and the sole was covered it dirt. He might see my dirty footprint as I move around the place. I removed them from my foot and threw it in a corner. I removed the socks too, since it was soaking wet. I thought the concrete floor would be cold, but the heat generated from the machines makes it warm. I then wait for Quintin to be farthest away from this door. Once M confirms it, I crack open the door and move out. I walk sideways, hugging the wall on my backside. This was the best way to avoid making any sounds.

M had turned on a virtual route though my shade glasses and I continue to walk through that route. I passed through a machinery room and took the stairs and back down again. I had studied the blueprint earlier too, so I know I was heading in the right direction, just talking the long route. Soon I was near the hanger area. I still couldn't hear anyone talking. I tried to list down all the Kurets I could recall that makes this effect. The obvious one is the sound absorbing Kuret I used in the match with Charles. But there are couple more that can have the same effect. If there is an alpha with them, it could prove troublesome. Their range will be far more than normal.

I was now getting closer to Polly. She was 50 meters to my left, while I was crawling in a room parallel to her. I held my breadth and made sure to turn off my watch and shade before approaching her vicinity. I won't let her detect any electrical heat coming from any of the devices I have. I was a little worried about the body heat, but M had accounted for that too. I was walking beside a small turbine, its speed was reduced at night, but it was generating enough heat to mask my presence to her.

At long last, I reach the hanger control room. With arduous and anxious steps, I open the door and slithering. I am crouching down as I enter to avoid being seen from the windows in front. I didn't dare to look up and see who or what people were doing until I find a good spot. I found one at the corner. Based on the thermal vision, they are standing at an angle from where they can't see this corner. I take the corner and stood up hugging the wall. I was worried that I wouldn't be able to hear them even from this distance, but I could definitely hear muffled noises. I am relieved that I am inside the Kuret range.

The windows are drilled into the wall, so I can't pry it open. But fortunately, I had the device for this type of task now. I fished out my listening device from the bag and stuck the dish end to the window. This one had a vacuum suction feature that can listen to sounds from thin walls and windows. M syncs it to my transmitter in the ear. I begin to hear static noise initially as it calibrates gradually.

Now's the time I can figure out with Peter has his new friends are mixed up in.

David (Chapter 72)

Tuesday, January 13, 2026 20:37

I begin to hear muffled noise. Still not clear enough to understand. M was running analysis and adjusting the device's configuration. I bet there is interference due to the sound blocking Kuret. It will definitely have some physical jamming property. M says, boss, the signals I am getting are distorted, but I am analyzing the waveform to adjust for this room. Give me one minute to recalibrate. While I waited I decided to risk it and take a peek from the corner at them through the window.

This room was dark, but the hanger area wasn't. The low illumination yellow light came from Kuritines glow sticks on the walls. They were not using electricity of the building, avoid even being detected by the islands electric grid. They really don't want anyone knowing they are here. After a long waited moment, I finally get to see the people involved in all this. The first people my eyes laid on were Peter, Elina and Ryan. All 3 are looking scared and tense. But not hurt. I sigh of relief left my lips.

Ryan was clutching Elina from behind. No, Elina was keeping him behind her. Peter was beside the two, but positioned himself in between them and other groups. Like a mediator. I was right, the others were cornering those 3 for some reason. Unfortunately, I couldn't see any of their faces from this side, only partial faces. M was already running analysis on facial recognition on the people through my shades. There was one guy was behaving more agitated and vocal. And Peter kept waves his arms around as to rebuke in response.

A moment later M says, boss, audio signal reconstruction complete. There is a delay of about 0.2 seconds due to the signal reconstruction, so please prepare yourself for the visual and audio misalignment. It would have been worse. At least I can hear them now. The first voice came of the agitated man, easier for you and give up. I got all night and nothing to do until I catch the person. We will get to the truth eventually. I hear others grumbling as the voice laughs.

I whisper to M, it’s a long shot, but run voice recognition of all of them against the network social media, any online video and officers database. We may get a hit. M says, on it. I recognized Peters voice, why do you think you will get a different answer. I will keep denying it whole night if I have to. I can't believe how stupid you are thinking I have anything to gain from this. Looks like he has been defending some accusation from others. And somehow that also includes Elina and Ryan. I hope they weren't involved.

The angry voice says, Wyan, lets beat some sense to him. My body freeze for a second reacting to this. Are things escalated to physical altercations now. The guy named Wyan replies, I told you many times now. No violence, we are civilized business men. Besides, I am still not sure if she is cleared of suspicion. I ask you again Elina, tell me you did it. You will a world if pain. Elina, visibly shaken and scared, shrieks, you keep asking me things I don't understand. Please Peter, you promised us it wasn't dangerous. Let us go.

Peter replies, not before they realize we got nothing to do with this. Wyan, just trust me, Elina had no idea this was going on. You already confirmed she wasn't near this shipment ever before, so she has nothing to do with this. Neither do I. my eyes turn towards the crate lying in the middle of the hanger. This is linked to his part time job. I began forming a hypothesis, actually, it was almost certain now. They are illegally importing stuff from outside. A smuggling ring. I lean back to the wall in shock. Such a criminal activity was happening under our noses and no one knew. Everyone were busy with the tournament, and these guys must have exploited that as well.

I see M running analysis on the crate too. I couldn't see what was inside it, but it was large. Whatever it was, it was too large to be smuggled in without detection. So there must be something hidden inside. Elina cries, Peter, please. At least take Ryan away from here. You all have to believe he is not involved in this. Another guy steps forward, no ones leaving until we get answers. I don't care if he is a kid. Everyone here is an equal suspect. Huh, what's going on. I thought everyone were ganging up on the 3 of them since beginning.

The angry guy says, not this again. Everyone's been vetted. Nothing was stolen from this shipment and the previous one. The guy replies, but not the one from 3 weeks ago. That’s why we all are here right, it happened once, so no reason to believe it didn't happen again. We got to check again. Suddenly people argue over that. I hear frustrated shouts of voices, waste of time, nowhere close to the truth and stuff like that. M still hadn't identified any of the voices. This Wyan name could be an alias too.

Wyan raises his hand, shut up. All of you. This is serious, stop behaving like animals. We will get to the truth eventually. Yes, every been tested. But that doesn't mean anything, any of us could hire someone to steal it. I don't care how many times we do this, we need to find the culprit. I am getting a more accurate reading of them now. Seems like someone has stolen something and they are grouped here to find the culprit. I guess thievery is a common side effect of criminal behavior. Even if your in a group. So how Peter, Elina and Ryan fit into it.

Peter turned to be a criminal after all. His laxed attitude in the bar should have been apparent that it would lead to him doing this. I am not that surprised he actually became a criminal. But Elina, I can't picture it. Sure she struggled financially, but she is stable now. I don't think I mis judged her to be greedy enough to commit crimes with her brother. So far I still haven't heard what's her involvement in this. Peter says, tell me what we can do more to prove it. You already questioned us, tested our Kuret prints on the crate and continue to hound my family. What more could you want.

Wyan says, I have been saying this. I have handpicked all of you, so I know your ambitions and the lengths you would go. She is the unknown variable here. I want her to admit it. I know a guilty person when I see. Ryan behind her shouts, leave us alone. We told you, we have not stolen anything. Elina grabs Ryan and pulls her behind her to shush him. The angry guy says, the kids got a mouth. Don't know about the girl though, but my money's on the kid. He small hands are perfect for grabbing stuff from small places.

People begin arguing over it. Wyan, apparently the boss of this gang was not yelling at people to shut up. They are kind of disorganized, but they do seem to be listening to him. M says, boss. I have identified the crates. Its registered under Elina. She has ordered it for shipments of various kinds of liquor. Her last shipment was for whiskeys. My heart drop hearing that. Was Elina also mixed up in this. I recalled all the conversation I had with her. She claims she can read people, well, so can I. And she was honest about being profitable the right way. I didn't feel anything from her that screamed she was being deceitful. She is a hard worker, until Peter. Would she really risk her family and reputation by joining Peter with this.

I refuse to believe that. But then I realized I was also lying to her. Could it be she was too. Is she scared because she is caught stealing or is a genuine fear. But all this for a bootlegging theft. No, that doesn't explain the severity of this issue. Regardless of whether Elina is involved, her shipment must be a cover to smuggle in the actual goods. Wyan turns to Peter, I have one final wat to figure out if she is lying. Peter says, great. Lets get this over with and prove our innocence.

The angry guy says, really now. Why did you wait until now to say it. Wyan says, I wanted to avoid it. Its not reliable, but they are not cooperating with us. Even when I am so graciously keeping everyone from you all. Elina cries for help, please, believe me. I know nothing of this. Peter hid this from us. I don't know about missing drugs. My eyes widen at that information. She didn't know. Whatever inkling I had, was being washed away with relief. I shouldn't have doubted her, but I couldn't exactly rule it out until now. Then my gut tighten on the new information too. Drugs were being smuggled in. What kind, something that would useful for Medrones.

The angry guy says, not missing women. Stolen. MCTL, Hetrox and Pesphinate. It was your shipment, you found out and stole from us to report us, Didn't you. A small shiver goes through my spine. My heart beats faster when I heard the drug names. I know them. All the high ranking officers know it. Elina shouts, I didn't take whatever the hell it is. I didn't know my crates were used for it. And no one reported it, because we didn't know. Please, let us go. I was hearing them, but my mind was racing on different thoughts.

The poison used on Marina and almost on Blake. They were the once who did it. Wait, somethings not right here. I only found residue for MCTL and Hetrox. I didn't know about the third one. Besides that, why would this group try to sabotage the tournament. I am missing something here. Wyan says, I don't believe you. You have a look of someone caught in a trap. I can tell. Your brothers are clueless, but I am not sold on you. Elina yells, I am scared Peter. You promised we would be safe if we were honest. I have told the truth all this time.

Peter says, she is right, Wyan. You don't have a shred of proof. Don't just blame her or me with just wild intuition. Will you promise to let them leave once you know they didn't steal the drugs. Wyan laughs, you don't make demands here. I will not let anyone go until we find the culprit, even if she turns out innocent. Elina makes whimpering noise. I could feel she has been crying. Ryan behind her was grabbing on Elina's waist as she steps a little back from others.

She was really scared now. And I can't blame her. This is less of an interrogation, and more of baseless accusation. I so wish I could just jump in and stop these people. Even if I had my Kuret, I couldn't risk it without knowing their identities. M hasn't been able to identify anyone with their voice. It had a low success probability anyways without a dedicated voice database. The facial recognition was also not happening from this angle and no clear lighting.

Wyan walks and whispers something to the one of the people. One thing I don't understand, why did they reveal their faces to Elina and Ryan. I have listened enough to understand that they made Peter bring Elina and Ryan because they had access to their shipments. Peter was in a rush because of others. They must have threated him or his siblings. And Peter was right to be scared, they got some pretty powerful warriors with them. Still, none of it explained why they didn't kept their identities hidden from those two. They can't be this foolish after doing this much consideration in their security. My throat becomes hard thinking a possible reason.

Wyan said he won't anyone leave, even if Elina was innocent. Lets assume it did turn out to be someone else, what will happen to Elina then. This might not be a real hideout, but she has seen their faces. They can't risk her exposing them. I gulp hard realizing they don't intend to leave her. I don't know what this Wyan guy is capable of. He might blackmail her with something or worse, eliminate her all together. Shit. Why didn't I think of this earlier.

I whisper to M, I don't care what you have to do. Get some backup. Send priority network message to all the officers and patrols in the vicinity. I don't care who it is. M says, boss, there is a problem. My link is broken with ART, unfortunately the facial and audio recognition have not been working since beginning. I had assumed the IP requests were sent and taking time to respond, but on further analysis, its been running on a continuous loop. I believe along with a sound blocking Kuretine, they have some sort of electrical disrupter as well. What the hell.

M says, I have been running with limited capability and most of my processing is focused correcting the audio signals and surveillance feeds from the drones. The thermal image is also receiving static noises. Shit, I was focused too much on these guys that I didn't notice the glitches on the frames at the corner of my eye glasses. I put my hand on my temple frustrated. I ask, how did you not detect this before. M says, suspecting the disturbance is from a Kuritine similar to a EMP field, very stable, but very small too. This looped field was allowing infrared thermal signals, but not the frequency of island network or the ART.

This is worse than I thought. No way he don't plan to do something to Elina and Ryan after making sure such level of secrecy. I should have told M to send an alert to others if I couldn't from inside. Too late now. The only other way is for me to go back the way I came. But I couldn't leave after seeing Elina crying and Ryan scared out of his mind. I don't know what Wyan has been discussing with others, but it can't be good. Curse this, of all the day I have mental issues, this had to be worst one.

The angry guys shouts, what's this kid. I saw you looking at the door. Don't you dare. Elina shields Ryan form the guy who was walking towards him. She yells, don't come closer. Peter steps in front of them, he, leave it alone, he is not going anywhere. But the guy shoves him away, buzz off. Wyan told you, you are not in charge here. Peter gets pushed away and falls on his ass shouting, you bastard. You will regret this. The guy laughs hysterically,

pathetic, you are a bottom feeder. We are using you, not the other way around. Don't you forget that.

Before I could understand what he means by that I saw Ryan coming out escaping Elinas arm and runs towards him. Oh no, don't do it Ryan. My eyes twitches in despair as he kicks the guy in the nuts. The guy wasn't expecting it and he shrieks in pain. He bends over a little stumbling a few steps behind. Ryan says, stay away from him. Elina frantically runs behind him shouting, Ryan. No. Don't. The guy stand up still in pain and coughing, freak this kid. Behind him Wyan says, stop this Grover.

He yells, like hell I will. The guy gets his balance and shouts at Ryan, you little freak. You will pay for this. Peter screams, no don't. I was frozen, in the dark when I see the guy use his Kuret. I couldn't tell what it was in beginning, but then I saw it. It was a light yellow Kuret that was turning into a rope. I don't know this Kuret, but I have seen it somewhere. But I couldn't focus at all. Because of what happened next. The guy throws his Kuret on the Ryan, but Elina manages to push him out of way.

No. no. She wasn't fast enough to dodge it herself. I slammed my hands on the glass unconsciously without caring if was spotted. Elina cries fill the air around the empty room as she falls bleeding on the floor. I got angry seeing the face I was seeing an hour ago so happy, and now covered in blood. She falls on her back on the ground and remains still. No, she can't be. This is wrong. Ryan crouches down beside Elina shouting, Elina. Peter screams from the floor, what the hell did you do.

Wyan and others came rushing towards them. Wyan yells as he grabs the man, freak Grover. He disperse his Kuret, he made me do it. My eyes were glued to Elina's motionless body. My whole body went limp and fall back to the wall. I didn't care if they saw me now. This is my fault, I let her die. What the hell was all this for. I couldn't help her, I didn't bring help. I was useless. Ryan was wailing over Elina's body. My heart begins to race and sweats pour down. I began shaking.

I saw it then. History repeating itself. I saw Zakerine over Johns dead body. She was crying and trying to revive his corpse. My vision gets blurry. I only saw Zakerine in place of Ryan. John's body where Elina's bleeding. My body feels like its about to burst anytime. I am having a full blown panic attack. But I couldn't feel it. All I felt was despair. Nothing changed. I let her die. Ryans going to die too. Just like the pile of dead bodies hunting me. I was deluding myself, thinking I could save them.

My body felt so heavy that I got dragged down and hit the floor. My hands are trembling as I grab my chest. My teeth is shivering, I could taste the fear in my mouth. My ears are filled with the cries of Ryan. Then I hear Zakerine voice. Her cries mixed in with Ryan. What's going on. I am loosing my grip on reality. Am I stuck in the past, or in the future. I grab my hands on my throbbing head. I want it to stop. My heads about to burst open. Its too much. How I am letting this happen again despite getting strong.

A voice looms in my mind, did you really become strong. You are still that scared little kid inside. I recognize this voice. Its him. My worst enemy. I said aloud not caring about others, get out. The voice says, I can't stupid. I am dead. You soon that kid will be too. And then you. Just imagine this, you survived so much, only to be killed by a couple of common criminals. I shout out, leave me alone. The voice now comes back with his face in front of me, its so pathetic. So many people died. And you wasted their efforts. You should have just stayed on Medrine to die. Let someone better take your place.

I covered my ears to stop the phantom voice, shut up. I closed my eyes, but his face becomes more closer to me laughing manically. He says, just die already. You couldn't save Zakerine then, and you can't now. She will die again. I shook my head. No, she won't die. He says, she will always die. Zakerine made her choice to die. Now its your turn. My anger was souring such height that I could actually feel my blood boil. Is this it, am I really going to let her die again.

I saw Zakerine now. She was happy and we were laughing. We were enjoying on our missions, then she was annoying me when we wrote the book. Our training sessions together. I was going to loose all of it. Again. The voice says, yes. You will. You are still so weak. My sister see's your true self now, something I have known since beginning. I grit my teeth in fury. My heart was about to burst any moment. I want this to end. I want Zakerine back. In the middle of all the voices in my head, I heard Elina's name from Ryan.

My mind suddenly singularity focused on that one cry. What am I doing. Elina is still alive. I can still save her. I couldn't save Zakerine. But she isn't Elina. The voice rejects it, you can't. You are the same. I ignored it. I was only listening to Ryan. I could hear only his voice. My voice. The same kind I had when Zakerine was dying. I saw myself then. I looked pathetic, weak and most of all, terrified. Is this all I am in the end. With all my intelligence and strength, my will is this weak.

The voice kept trying to drag me down to the abys. But the cries kept me strangely together. This can't be all I am. I have changed since then. It can't be only what I am seeing. Slowly, but gradually the voices fade. I focused only the cries, mine and Ryan's. Then I heard the cries of others, Branden, Hansen. They were there too. But that didn't stop them from fighting back. If they can do it, so can I. My teary eyes open with sudden burst of energy. I was back in the dark room.

My body was still shaking beyond my control. And yet somehow I was able to make a fist and hit my thigh. My heart felt like its racing out of my body. I shout out, I going to save them. Let me do it. Move dammit. My voice was loud, so was my anger. The anger finally brought my Kuret out. I felt my whole body tingle with familiar power. My bones that felt so brittle, felt alive again. My Kuret burst open from my body like a exploding bomb. Flowing out in all directions, across the walls and rooms.

This was the trigger I needed. My Kurets back. All the voices filling my head were gone. No. I could still feel them. They only gotten quitter for now. That didn't matter. I was back. My body slowly calms down, so does my heart. I got up from the floor and stood on my feet. I turned to the window to understand what I had just done. My Kuret had seeped into the entire space in the hanger area. The Kuretine glow sticks were flickering under my Kuret presence.

I gaze down at my hands trying to understand what just happened. I overcame it. The realization finally hit me like a thunder. I am agitated as hell, but I can control my Kuret without crashing out. This is unmistakenly the same feeling I have relied on for years. I tighten my fist and thrust myself throw the window. I came crashing through it on the other side. I hear everyone shouting at each other confused. I could see them now, their glimmers. Its back as well. Its like my whole world lit up. This was different than my yips during the match. It was stronger, more deeper.

I land on the shatters glasses on the ground. I should be hurt, but the Kuret covered in my feet protected me. This is my Kuret dome. I was almost passing out a moment ago, what a complete reversal. I saw everyone's glimmers around me. They were all panicking, running around in confusion. Some had red glimmers, some blue and others orange. I could see it all. I turn towards Elina, the glimmers of her blood was potent.

But before I rushed towards her, I saw the person beside her. The one who attacked her beside her. I focused all my rage on him. With my Kuret thrust, I rushed ahead straight at him. He was shouting, what hell is going on. I respond to him with a straight punch to his face. My fist was covered in dense Kuret as I struck him. He bellows as I crush his nose under my fist and throw him away back into the pillar wall. It was good I let my anger at him. That burst of anger helped me calm down even more.

I look down to Elina's body. I could see glimmers flickering on her skin. My heart beats easier realizing I wasn't late. She is still alive. I can save her. I turn to others around me, you all are freaked.

David (Chapter 73)

Thursday, January 15, 2026 12:09

Its a chaotic now. Some of the people have cleared out from the hanger area. They are moving beside the wall or towards the exit. My Kuret has filled the entire place, making it pitch dark. I myself have been wrapped in my Kuret, probably making me blend in with the Kuret around and hiding my presence. As I calm myself from the panic attack I just had, I start to strategize. The first priority is to save Elina. She told me about her medical condition and I don't think that was made up. Her healing abilities are severely affected and I could confirm it when her bleeding weren't slowing, even for regular Medrones.

I don’t think I will make it in time to take her to a hospital or bring medical attention to her. Then the only option is for me to a healing Kuret on her. That means I have to setup my Kuret storm. And I need to dispel my Kuret dome in order to do that. But before I do that I realize one thing, I shouldn't let anyone see me. I realized the best course of action for this and waved my Kuret around to destroy the Kuritine glow sticks on the walls and pillars. One by one, the light dims in the hanger.

My eyes fell towards the center of the room. There was a briefcase with two large Kuritine put on a stand. One was purple and other radiated maroon. Those are the Kuretines that block sound and communication. I need to destroy the one that jams the signal, and keep the sound barrier, at least for now. But I can't tell which is it. The two Kuretines were kept too close and I was a little farther away to see the glimmer and its property. I could destroy both, but I don't want all the 3 bodyguards to hear people screaming. I had no choice but to leave it for now.

I hear someone grunting. There was a person who was still standing near me, what the hell is going on. Who's here. It's the boss, he had crouched down on his knees, but he wasn't frantic like others. I needed him to get out of my way. I grab his body with my hands on his collar. He was shouting, get off me. He tried to wriggle out in the darkness, trying to fight me off. But my arms, strengthened with Kuret, didn't let him go. I slam my knees straight into his face. He winces in pain from his broken jaw. I wasn't going to waste any more time on this trash, so I just threw a kick to his guts. He flies off to a corner and knocks out on the impact.

I begin to gather my Kuret in my hands and focus on making the inner sphere. I need to hurry, the 3 problematic people will be here soon. I don't know if that will be enough, but at least I will get one shot of Kuret. I will the Kuret around my hands to move in circular motion. My Kuret dome begins to shrink into a ball in my hand. I poured all my will into making the Kuret vibrate faster and gather the ambient Kuret inside it. People were still shouting around me, some cursing while others were asking where is Wyan.

I ignored them as much as I could. My hands were trembling, still reeling from the effects from the nervous breakdown. I focused on saving Elina and nothing else. My Kuret sphere suddenly turned into a wild exploding ball. I could feel it, its similar to what I did in the match. But its erratic, much less controllable. I figured it was beginner luck the first time. Doesn't matter the efficiency for now. As long as I can get one Kuret blast. Then I hear the glass shattering above me.

From the glimmers I saw Cory jumping throw the windows the first floor. Shit. The sound is cancelled in this area, but not the vision. I need to hurry up before Cory comes down here. My fist tighten and a small yell comes out as I kept pushing to make the Kuret storm forming into a smaller size. I felt it then, the pressure in my hands. Yes, its working. Just few more seconds. At the corner of my eye, I saw Elina's glimmer flickering slower. Oh shit. Ryan wasn't even paying attention to what was going around. He had his hands clutched on Elina's shirt and buried his face on floor, like he is trying to stop the bleeding by covering her shirt.

He was unknowingly hurting Elina. Its not his fault, but he was making it worse. I tell him, let go of her Ryan, you are hurting her. He didn't let go of her. Either he ignored me, or didn't hear me. He is in shock, his glimmer showed yellow. I see a similar glimmer coming from the person hiding in a corner. Peter, who was now cowering and scared shitless, hiding in the corner behind the crate. Damit, both brothers are too damn rattled. I had no choice but to do it. Its not done, but I can't risk anymore time.

I prepared the Kuret storm and throw the healing Kuret on Elina. This was nothing short of a gamble, unlike Janathan, I can't adjust this Kuret compatibility to the targets body and Kuret. All I can hope a large overdose of alpha level healing Kuret would be enough. But the Kuret I showered Elina wasn't at alpha level, hell it was even less than the average. I didn't have enough time to prepare it. I grit my teeth in frustration. I kneel down and focus on the largest part of the wound on her chest. If I can't heal her injuries, at least I can slow it down.

Few more seconds and I saw her glimmers stops fading. Her heartbeats is slower, but at least it isn't going down. That’s a good sign. I let out a sigh just as the healing Kuret ends. I still had my Kuret storm held together, but it was a just hollow now. I had no choice but to disperse it. I felt sweat tricking down my face from that sudden arduous task. But my work is not over. Elina's is hanging on, barely, for now. She needs help. But now I can focus on others.

I move towards Ryan and tell him, get help. You need to go and alert any officer you can find. Ryan wasn't letting go of Elina. He cries out, I am not leaving her. She is hurt. I knew I was asking too much of him, but right now, we are in middle of a mess. Having him here is problematic for what I am going to do. Using my Kuret I yank him away. His grip on Elina's clothes were tight, but I wasn't going to make it easy on him. He stumbles on his legs and falls down.

Even if I was not using my night vision shades, I would have seen he was crying hard. Tears filled his eyes and face. I tell him, you are hurting your sister. I'll keep her safe, so go and get help. He was too scared to be doing anything when he couldn't even see me. He frantically looks around, tapping his hands on the ground searching for Elina, where is She. Elina. Dammit. I was expecting too much of him. He isn't like me. I am putting unreasonable expectation on him.

I saw Cory coming out of the stairs and looking around the place. I don't have time to deal with Ryan. I prepare to fight him and raise my arms. It won't be easy and the other two will be here soon. I turn to Elina, then to Ryan, then to Peter. I saw people trying to leave, some already did. I figured out what I need to do. I put him arms back down. I need to be smart about this. I ran to the room I was hiding earlier and jumped through the broken windows. The remaining glass shatters into pieces, but I didn't care.

I went to grab the bad I had left behind and pulled out the voice changer. I slap in on my neck and whisper, M, listen to carefully. I need you to do exactly what I say. M says, understood boss. I begin to gather my Kuret into another sphere. Now that Elina was not in mortal danger, I was more calm and could focus better on building my Kuret storm properly. As I prepared my Kuret I gave instructions to M, once I destroy that EMP Kuret, get all the bots you got as backup here. Have them close the entire building. Bolt the doors, cover the windows, I don't care how, just keep anyone from escaping.

M says, what about the warriors boss, the bots can't stop them. I say, leave them to me. I will stop them. You just make sure others don't leaves this building. If somehow anyone escape, tell me. I will drag them back inside. M says, understood. They will be here in 45 seconds once the link is restored to ART. I take another breath while making the Kuret storm more stable. The wild exploding kuret was still not like how I used it during the match. But as long what I plan works, it doesn't matter if Kuret produced isn't on alpha level.

I peaked out through the window. Cory is navigating though the place, I saw him talking to someone. He must be trying to understand the situation. I need another minute. I just need 5 decent shots of Kurets, that should be enough. Then I see Ryan crawling around the ground helplessly. Peter had curled up in a corner. I explain the next order to M, get one bot inside and carry Ryan out of here. Get him to the road, take the northwest road, I think there is a patrol path coming soon. M responds, preparing instructions for the bot. Wouldn't it be better to send the message myself.

I say, just let Ryan get help. We need to keep our presence hidden. Don't let anyone see any bot too. M complies, adjusting the battle protocols. And then I explained the 2 remaining orders to M. Once done I turned around again. Cory had found his way in the dark towards Ryan and Elina. He must have heard Ryans cries. I don't know what he might do with them. So I got up and braced myself. My Kuret storm was making whooshing sound, so staying hidden wouldn't matter. My position was a good enough vantage point to attack.

I built this one better than the previous one. The exploding Kuret was still not showing the same level of energy from the coliseum. But for a makeshift one, it wasn't bad. M says, the voice configuration is 80% complete. So I can't attack Cory yet. Fine, I can finish off others as much as I can. I throw a sound wave Kuret to the 2 Kuritines in the stand. I had recognized one of the people's Kuret glimmer earlier. They are from the same bloodline from that alpha who could amplify sounds using Kuret. The one I used against Charles.

Cory and few others back away when they hear the Kuritine breaking from the sound pressure. I kept throwing the soundwave to the entire room, dragging it across to anyone close by. One guy tried to defend himself with his Kuret. I couldn't recall this glimmer Kuret. He didn't have a strong Kuret though, because he was hurled into the air and thrown back to the pillar up side down. One more unlucky person was not able to dodge it. It hit him in his legs and his knees broke, twisting it around. Red glimmers erupted as he slumps down and shouts in pain.

I stop this Kuret realizing its good enough and prepare for the next victim. Cory yells preparing his rotting Kuret on his arms, who the hell was that. A women screams, Lance. What are you doing. A different guy from some far corner shouts, what are you talking about. I wasn't going to give them time to talk though. M says, link established boss. Deploying the bots. I also have the results for the facial scans from earlier. I smile at that, tell me what Kuret does that guy who attacked Elina has. Show his Kuret marker if you have it.

M shows the face on my shades. His name is Grover and his bloodline Kuret is to create Kuret ropes. They are not that strong, but its sharp. The actual good news was that I did have his bloodline marker. M shows the marker pattern in my screen and use it to prepare my next Kuret attack. Meanwhile people were shouting at Lance. Lance was shouting back, I don't what you are taking about. I didn't attack anyone. Then someone used a Kuret to start a fire and light up the place.

Oh, no you don't. I can't let people see each other. I don't how good I would be able to replicate Grovers Kuret without testing it. But I didn't have any choice but to use it whatever it may be. My Kuret storm shakes and a long raggedy Kuret rope comes out. It was barely shaped like a rope, more like brown threads crumbled together. But it had speed and power. I had aimed at the women near the fire and it struck her back. She stumbles down while wriggling, freak. Grover, stop this. Its me god dammit.

She hits the floor beside the bricks she had lit on fire. The Kuret rope I throw cuts off in the middle. I guess that’s all I can manage without controlling it. However, the Kuret attack was still coming out from my Kuret storm, so I aim it towards the bricks and knock them out from their place. The rope's force was dense enough to blast them far and fast enough to put off the fires. The little embers still remains, but it was significantly dimmer now. Like water I continue to spray the Kuret rope all over the place.

People were trying to defend from it. I saw Kuret clashing all over the place. Some where caught by the attack and cut themselves. Cory wasn't much fazed by it though. His rot Kuret was very strong and could easily disintegrate the Kuret rope as it came in contact. With two attacks in a row, he had pinpointed the origin and was running at me shouting, Grover, what the hell. Stop this madness. Just on cue, M says, voice configuration completed boss. I shout out, Wyan, he is the traitor, get him. Cory's glimmer flicker in confusion. Because it wasn't my voice, it was Grover.

He shouts as he ran at me, what did you say. I stop Grovers Kuret useless attack on Cory. He will reach me too fast, I need a little more time for my next Kuret attack. I tell M, switch voice. A moment later I shout, I knew you were a scumbag. Never should have trusted someone who was once a lackey of Nathan. Cory abruptly halts his one man dash at some distance. He shouts, Quintin, what are you doing. I wasn't going to say anything more, let him sweat on that.

This was enough of a stall to prepare for an attack. I aim my Kuret storm at Cory and fire the yellow beam of Kuret at Cory. I had used his Kuret before, so it was much stronger. Hopefully it will fool him enough to think it was really from Quintin. Cory couldn't dodge a light speed attack. The Kuret hits him square in the chest and he was dragged away. He grunts while shouting Quintin to stop. He had enveloped his whole body with his Kuret to lessen the impact. If I had Kuret to spare, I would have continued. But I need to save 2 more attacks.

I drag the beam away from Cory and aim it towards the top steel stairs. I cut through one edge and then the next, the pieces break apart and fall on top of Cory. The steel makes loud noises as it crushes Cory in a rubble. However, this is no where near enough to stop him. His rot Kuret is highly effective on steel. All I wanted to stall him more. I halt Quintin's Kuret once I had added few more rubble on top of Cory. Then I kick the outer door open and walk outside.

I could see Polly's gimmer coming from the door. I ran towards the door with while preparing my next Kuret. There are people breaking the locked doors and trying to escape through other exit paths. Good work M. The bots were able to lock the steel doors and reinforce the windows. If people had worked together, they could have broken out, but these guys were organized only in crime. M says, boss, I have a ART bot carrying Ryan now. I will take him to the nearest patrol route. As I ran, I quickly turn my neck for a second. An ART bot had managed to sneak inside somehow. It was picking up Rory with its four arms. If it found a way to get in without being noticed, it will get Ryan out too.

I bring my attention back at the door where Polly emerged. She shouts, Wyan, what's going on. Someone tell me. I whisper to M, switch voice. A second later I yell at her, Wyan, I got her. She is also working with them. Polly had already prepared her Kuret around her, Cory is that you. Keeping them confused as much as possible, that’s the only way to completely trick them. I throw Cory's attack, the rotting Kuret was now coming at her confused face. But she wasn't about to take it head on. She sucks the moisture from the air around her.

The rotting effect of Cory's Kuret is a physical effect. Polly must have already prepared in advance in case Cory ever attacked her. The rot needed air gasses and particles to travel, and without it, its effect goes away. She was making good use of her dual Kuret. But I knew this already. I just wanted her to be distracted for a moment, I aimed the rot on the ground where was standing. This is the hanger area, but there is another level below, the basement. She must have realized my goal too when her glimmer became agitated.

I came running towards the door because I wanted to stop her and keep her in that exact position. A place above the basement floor, where there is a large water tank spinner below. The floor crumbles to rust and she falls through before she could jump off. She falls into the water, making a large splash as she and other blocks of concrete beings to get dragged away in the circular current. Like Cory, this was just temporary, she would soon vaporize or freeze the water. And then finally, my last target came into the room from the basement door on the left of the room, what was that just now. Who is attacking us.

I made sure I was farther away this time, because Quintin may clock a mans silhouette in the dark speaking a woman's voice. I scream at him, Wyan, Quintin is working with the traitors. We have to eliminate him too. Quintin looked around in the dark rushing toward Polly's voice. He asks, huh. What. Wyan, what's going on. Where is everyone. I had switched to Polly Kuret now. Hers was tricker, like Vanessa's, I have no control over what may come out. It didn't matter though, because Quintin would believe it's Polly.

The Kuret that came out was freezing out the moisture in the air. Quintin protects himself the cold using his Kuret light heat. He yells, what the freak Polly. You gone mad. He goes invisible in defense and starts to run at me from a different position. Him going invisible would be a problem, for others, but its wasted on me. His glimmer was clear as day for me. I aimed at the place he was running towards. He is shocked that his position was found so fast. He builds up enough Kuret around himself to fend off the freezing moisture around him.

This isn't enough to corner him though. With the last sparks of Kuret that was left in my storm, I threw all the remaining at him. This time, the Kuret turns the air to molting hot around him. A large amount of steam comes out from the collision with the icy moist around him. His Kuret can't protect from this. The scorching heat turns his skin to red. He shrieks in pain, what the hell are you doing. Get away you bitch. He ran off and plan to attack from a safe distance, but Polly Kuret has much more range.

His blisters on his body from the heat was still growing as he tried to dodge it. Quintin decided he needs to get away first. He crashed through a door into a room and ran farther away from the attacks range. That’s it, I used all the Kuret. A moment later the attack subsides. I break down my Kuret storm and kneel down for a moment. I didn't realize, but I was heaving. My sweat covered all around my face and body. I wasn't planning on such a close combat fight again so soon. M was right, my body is already so sore from just doing this much. M says, boss, your heart rate is spiking too hard. You should back away for a moment.

No. This isn't enough. Not even close. Cory is digging his way out of the steel rubbles. Pollys blazing heat could be felt all the way up here. And Quintin will heal soon from that heat wave. I stand up and dug my hands into my pant pocket to out the other thing I took earlier from my bag. An adrenaline syringe. M says, boss, I recommend to use only half. You will risk reopening your wounds if your body takes the full doze. I concurred with M on this. I rotate the dial and set it to inject only half the doze. I felt a sharp pain when I inject it on neck. Ideally, I should do it in my heart for maximum effect. But I am way too amped up right now and my heart will hurt.

I grunt a little from the prick as I pull it out. I could feel the effects slowly taking over. I focused on bringing my breathing down and analyze the room. I checked on Elina first. Her glimmer was still flickering, but wasn't weaker. So her healing is countering her condition. I wished I could get her out, but I am in a very precarious situation right now. Others will most definitely get in my way. If she was in a much more dire condition, I would definitely abandon my plan and get her out myself.

M says, boss, I am monitoring Elina's condition. Her bleeding has slowed and gradually healing. I have an ART bot standing by that will take her away to a hospital in case anything happens to her. I turn up and see a surveillance bot in the air with a small beam pointed at Elina. say, good. Actually, keep two more bots on her. I don't know if someone might get in your way, but do it anyways. M says, requesting backup bots for Elina. Now that I have confirmed Elina is not in danger, I focus on others. Apart from the ones I took down earlier, there are still 6 people standing.

Apparently, two have managed to break open the barricaded door and are somewhere inside the building. One has somehow even managed to break out of the building from the basement floor. And remaining three are still inside the hanger area. I need to finish mopping them up first. I bring out my Kuret and throw a line at the nearest person, who was hiding behind the pillar near the garage door. The guy was not a fighter, I could tell because he panicked and stumbles down as he heard me approaching him.

Now that I was close enough, M could use the facial recognition on him. His name was Wiz and he had a puppeteering Kuret. I didn't wait for him to use it. I kicked him in his face. His jaw and nose break as he yells in pain. I grab his leg and using my Kurets force, I threw him over the room into the air. His body hits one of the hanger pillar and he slumps down out cold from the impact. I threw my Kuret line at the next person who was running towards the broken exit Quintin left behind.

Her name was Jade. She can create a Kuret glitter, probably useful for distraction and, maybe entertainment. It wasn't going to help her out when she threw it at the dark figure looming at her. I don't know if her Kuret had any other effect, but my Kuret disintegrated hers on contact and I grab her neck in one arm. She yells writhing to get away, please I beg you. Let me go. She winces in pain under the pressure. Her legs dangle in the air. She even tried to kick me with it. I effortlessly grabbed that leg with my other arm.

She yells, I won't say a thing. I don't care if you are the one who stole from us. Just let me go and I will remove your name from the records. Please. My grip tighten. What does she mean by that. I didn't know what those records were. I will check her out later. I turn to the last person, hiding behind the crate. He is still curled up and frozen in fear. I can't let him remain like this. I need to get him moving for my plan to work. I need to nudge him. I throw a Kuret line and drag Jade along with me. She was now panicking seeing that she was being carried somewhere.

Once I reach closer to Peter, I drop Jade a little closer to him so he would be able see her. Jade thought I was letting her go, thank you. I don't care why you did this, I am not going to tell anyone. My plan was working, she really thought I was someone from her criminal group. I smile a little knowing my half baked plan was working. She turns her back to me and begins to run. Sorry, I wasn't going to let you get away. I just needed you to run towards Peter direction.

Once she was beside him, I sprinted and thrust my foot, sweeping her legs off. She halls hard on the ground face first and grunts in agony. Peter finally woke up from his fear when Jade falls beside him. Jades bruised face rises and looks up to him. She says angered and confused, help. Whoops, I wasn't planning on letting her see him. I crouch down and jab her neck with my palm. The Kuret assisted force was enough to slam her face to the floor. I saw her glimmer dwindle down as she looses consciousness.

I was being too hasteful here. I didn't want anyone to see each other. Otherwise they could clear them of suspicion later. I thought that seeing another person fall in front of him would jar him open. I don't know if he could see my face. Though he might be able to see hint of green light of my shades night vision. It doesn't matter though. He is so scared, I doubt he be able to differentiate between my shades light from a person's eyes glowing from Kuret. This got the job done, seeing her cut down in front of him, made him rattled enough that he crawls back and begins to run away.

Good, he is leaving now. I tell M, you know what to do. Make sure he gets out of here without him realizing it. M says, already deploying the countermeasures as per your last order. I sure hope it pans out the way I hoped. I hear a angry voice now, come out Quintin. I am going to make you regret this. He got out much faster than I thought. I still have 3 people to capture. I threw a Kuret line to the 1st floor railings and fly up.

Once I cross the railing on the floor, I ran towards the outer balcony space where Cory was patrolling earlier. I kicked the door open and face towards the lone escapee. There was a drone tracking him from up, he isn't getting away from me. I threw a line towards his direction and flew in the air after jumping off the ledge. I sour through the air, the wind against my face when I land on the ground. He was running towards the main road, maybe he thought he could find someone to help him. Otherwise he would try to escape in the grass land on the other side of the building.

It wasn't as dark as outside, so I need to finish him much cleanly. I tell M, distract him. Throw flood lights at him when I say. M brings the drone down towards him. The guy heard something coming from the air and looks up while running. I say, now. The drone throws a small, but blinding light right at his face. The guy closes looks away and brings his hands up in reflex. I had closed my eyes before since I was still having night vision mode on. I saw his glimmer becoming agitated.

He was off balance, I threw a single punch to his gut. He falls on his back, clutching his stomach in pain. He even threw up a bit of blood and spit out of his mouth. Did I punch him so hard. I must have used my Kuret to strengthen it unconsciously. He writhes in pain as he tries to crawl away. Suddenly, he digs his fingers into the road, leaving scratch marks trying to run away in all fours. M shows his identity, Puttan. He has Kuret to make his nails into claws. So maybe that’s how he was able to escape, cutting away the lock hinges or something like that.

I was in a hurry though, so I ran behind him, on two legs unlike him. I jump into the air with my Kuret and land a kick on the back of his head. He didn't even get a chance to defend and knocks down hard face first into the road. I turn back and throw a Kuret line into the air, extending it back to the edge where I jumped off. As I fly back to the balcony, I tell M, have a bot carry him and throw somewhere in the hanger area. M says, boss, I believed our objective was not to involve any bots in the fight. They might be recognized later and your involvement will be exposed.

I let out a small sigh from a exhaustion as I land on the 1st floor. I begin running towards the other side where the 2 remaining people hiding. I say, even if he could recall what happened to him, he will say a light attacked him. People will naturally assume Quintin attacked him. Its all good. I was imagining it, but my god, I swear I could hear M laughing. Maybe it was just the adrenaline. M says, ordered bot number 3 to carry him. Shall I dump him in

west side of the building.

I say, yeah. Now where are the other two exactly. I halt when I reach the end and gaze over the roof. I could tell from the glimmers their position, but I needed another pair of eyes to know their precise location and where to land safety. M displays the camera feed in my left eye shade. One guy was hiding in the basement, maybe some machine room. The other woman was moving slowly in another room that connects to a water pipe. I should have known I wasn't the only who would use the pipes to enter or exist.

The women, Kiera, with a exploding Kuret was a little farther. But if she used her Kuret to break into a pipe, it would be difficult to capture her without damaging the pipe. Her exploding Kuret might even collapse the pipe on top of us. I decided to grab her first. I threw the Kuret line in the air and swing down towards that section. With my glimmers and the position M told me, I was able to pin point her position accurately. I decided to rush in through the window. I threw a Kuret line from my back to angle my decent.

I bring my arms in front of my eyes as I crash through the control room's window. Kiera was on the left side of the room, and steps away when she hears me land inside. She yells with her arms raised, don't come any closer. Wyan isn't going to forgive you. Neither will I. I shouldn't have, but I chuckled knowing she too believed I was one of them. Her Kuret was aimed at me, I don't know what it was aimed at, but I got out of its path. Behind me, a broken window frame exploded.

I roll away safety and hid behind a small turbine machine. I wasn't so much scared by her Kuret, but the window I crashed through was seeping more light than I hoped. I positioned myself so she couldn't see me. She yells angrily, yeah, that’s right. Get away you freak. She mistook my demeanor as a precaution from her attack. I didn't know she could explode things away from her. I know of the other bloodline members, they need to touch things to explode stuff. She isn't an alpha, so I thought she couldn't do it.

Best guess is that she is directly related to their current alpha. But her range and the target size must not be at that level. There are some unexpectedly good people in this gang. She must have been in the tournament. I didn't bother to check her rank though. I had already formed a plan. I grab a fist will of the broken pieces from the frame she exploded. I whisper to M, bring a bot that has a retrofitted a fire gun to the room behind the wall she is standing in. Then on my mark, spray it on the wall.

M says, I got what your cooking boss. I am brining an ART bot in 30 seconds. There was a small chuckle again from M. Okay, I am not hallucinating. What's with this setting of hers. When did I upgrade her humor model. Ah, forget about it. I waited as the bot positions itself. Kiera, shouts, I am getting out of here. You hear me. If you don't want to get blown to pieces, leave the freak alone. She slowly moves towards the hatch on the water pipe. Hurry M, I will get only one chance.

I held my breath for while until M says, its positioned boss. I say, do it now. Kiera had her arms raised on my direction all the time. She might have an impressive Kuret strength and control. But she lacks any combat experience. She didn't hear the bot that wheeled inside the room behind her. The wall begins to get warm, then hot and then crazy hot. A few seconds later even a novice like Kiera realized what's happening. The wall begins to peel off, like the blaze was melting it.

She shrieks, what. Wait, is this, Polly. No, stay away from me. She turns her back to me and left it unguarded. I jump off behind and threw the broken frame pieces to her. Those pieces begin to explode when they come near her vicinity. I was right to be wary of her. I close my eyes to not get blinded by those mini exploding pieces. She was too late to know what hit her. I jump and thrust my knee into her mid back. She cries out and gets crushed between me and the melting wall.

Her skin burns a bit on contact while her screams fills the air. Before she could around, I take my left hand and thrust a jab at her throat. She jerks sideways to the walls clutching her hands on the burning skin on her neck. Then I finished her with a punch to her head. He eyes rolls up in pain before she could see me. She wriggles a little when she hits the floor and gets knocked out. I back away from the wall, since the heat was a little too much for me too. I clear out the debris I collected from my arms.

She most definitely is close relative of the alpha. She was clever enough to try and trick me into thinking she had to aim her Kuret to explode things. When it fact, it was an area attack around her, like a bubble in all directions. Anything around her can be exploded. But she has a limit, I threw those pieces knowing it will give me the cover to get in close.

After taking a moment to settle myself down I tell M, lets go. One more left. I sprinted off searching for the last one.

David (Chapter 74)

Thursday, January 15, 2026 18:19

This guy is probably even tricker than Kiera. M showed his identity as I navigate my way towards Max. His Kuret can create distorting vertigo on people around him. He could confuse my sense of direction from a pretty far range, even before I could throw my Kuret at him. He is decently skilled too. He chose to hide out in a section that has long hallways, numerous control rooms and corners. He is clever enough to take advantage of the confusing surrounding to infect others with his Kuret. This Wyan character is mildly impressive to recruit such people into his criminal gang.

I had to be careful here. He wasn't much of a threat, but I needed him to believe I could be anyone while I attack him. That’s why I have been beating down everyone physically. No one can read my Kuret signature as evidence later and no can see my Kuret in the dark. I halt when I reach about 50 meters from him. I don't know much about his bloodlines alpha's capability. But this distance is a safe bet. He is hiding in the closet room, fear coming from his glimmers. However, he was constantly using his Kuret around him. I could see his Kuret clustered around him.

I could throw my Kuret at him, but its too far. Its effect will lessen and I won't be able to eliminate all his Kuret. His physical effect on me would work even if a tiny bit of it hit me. That’s only one way though. Since he was doing me the favor of hiding in one place, I could just bury him in that closet. I tell M, get a bot in the basement and make it fire propulsion blasts at the ceiling. Make it look like its going to crumble away. M says, one bot on its way boss. You are on a roll boss with the attacks.

M's puns are too amusing for her core programming. I didn't expect her recent upgrade now had some personality. Regardless, it was reassuring that the ART bots are working synchronously with M. I didn't realize before, but this is the first time I am using them in the field. I should view their action post mission report. My thoughts are interrupted when M says, ART is in position boss. I ran to the basement and position myself to the place he will fall.

I see the ART bot M brought. It had four gas powered air propulsion cannons. Ordinarily, it would be used for flying only. I suppose if a bot focuses it on one point, it becomes lethal. I signal the ART bot and it fires the cannon at the ceiling. The compressed air dugs large creator in the wall. I couldn't tell from this distance, but it was definitely getting bigger with each blast. The impact vibrates the whole building. I look around for the 3 glimmers, that are still a little far away.

But that’s not going to stay the same for long. I have made many noises, with Kiera and now this. One of them is bound to reach here soon. I prepare a plan of attack for each of them. Meanwhile, the walls becomes thinner on another blast and derbies begins to falls down. I see Max's glimmer running around the closet. He was trying to reach for the door and leave. Unfortunately for him, I already instructed another bot to block the door. His Kuret doesn't effect inorganic beings.

I could even hear his faint shouts as he pounds the door, trying to break it open. Another blast did the job and broke the ceiling. Large debris fall down, and in middle of it was Max helplessly getting crushed in between. It wasn't going to kill him though, but he won't be able to move with broken bones now. I see his Kuret disappearing around the area, he was knocked out. Damn, I didn't even need to physically get my hands on him. I ordered the bots to leave this place, its going to get messier.

With this, all 9 people are taken care off. I quickly checked on the situation, give me the sitrep. M says, I have just dropped off Ryan to the nearest road. I have covered his head with a cloth, to hide who was carrying him. Ryan was out of it when the bot left him, but now is running off to the direction where a patrol will soon be there. Based on daily routine patrol logs, they will find him in approximately 8 to 11 minutes. That means I need to neutralize the 3 of them in that same time. Its a damn difficult task.

M continues, Peter has evacuated the premise as planned and I have kept a surveillance on him from the air. I sure hope he goes where I hope I want him to. M says, Elina's condition has improved gradually. The bleeding has stopped and her healing has kicked in time to fix her cut on the lower right liver. Her life isn't in any danger now. This is working as I planned. Now I just need to finish off 3 very strong people in about 10 minutes. I mockingly say to myself, easy right.

I had hoped to use more of the Kuret storm to trick them more. Maybe even get them attack each other without me directly. But the attacks I did earlier weren't alpha level ones. I had managed to caught each one of them by surprise. They are now wary each other. They have spend time beyond the tournament, so they have decent knowledge about each other too. They would figure out that their attacks are too weak to be an alphas. And besides, I don't have the time to create my Kuret storm anyways.

Its the hard way then. I look for a good spot around the rubbles for launching an attack. I found a room with some machines not running. Its about 10 meters away from Max's unconscious body and I could easily attack through the thinner walls here. I went through this rooms door and walk towards the opposite wall. I tell M, its now a danger close combat. I need you to intuitively organize the ART bots in case I need backup. M says, calibrating for auto mode.

When few deep breathes, I gather my Kuret around me. Recalling the memories and sensation from my fight with Charles, I begin to vibrate and rotate my Kuret on my body. My Kuret control was weakened, I can tell. I may not be able to get the last Kuret form I used later in the match. After a while I feel this is enough. Otherwise they will recognize me, even in the darkness. As I focus on downing that Kuret armor, M says, boss, I have lost visual on Quintin. He is somewhere in the basement, along the hot environment of the machines and heading to your direction. He will be reaching you first.

So he is my first target. He thinks Polly attacked him, I can't let him see me in the light. My Kuret begins to gradually soften and I cover my arms, torso and legs. I will my Kuret to became stable around my joints as well. This will have to do. It was a very shoddy work. Even when I had time to concentrate, I couldn't reach the same level as before. It really was the first time intuition thing that drove me to such high level. However, if its even half as powerful, its enough to taken them down.

Now I have to be very careful here, I have to taken them on one by one. Or somehow force them to fight each other. I am not confident I can take all of them down in my current condition. So I plan to whittle them down individually and then throw them to others to finish themselves. Once my Kuret form was done, I remained still and focus on seeing the glimmers. Quintin is invisible, and he is walking along a path that even I won't be able to detect his glimmer instantly.

There is debris outside, I just have to make sure he is facing opposite to me when I attack. As I listened silently, felt a long time by the way, a sound came of a very light footstep. I immediately turn to that direction and saw his glimmer. He is here. I position myself and brace myself for a surprise attack. His slow and cautious approach made him difficult to listen, but he was tense enough that his glimmer was just enough to sense him. Once he was in the defenseless position, I forced my Kuret to thrust me ahead.

I bring my arms in front of me and break through the wall behind Quintin. The force of the thrust was reminiscent. It was still powerful enough for me to break through the wall completely. He was also on his toes and had prepared a bunch of Kuret lights around instantly to attack. Before he understood what hit him, I grab him by his neck and slam him to the wall. The light Kuret he threw hits me from all direction. But it did nothing. These are light attacks, protons. Sure it was dense enough to physically cut though my Kuret, but its still lighter than others. My Kuret, which caused Charles body to falter, was cancelling out his attack and leaving me with minor pricks.

I raise my elbow and land a powerful blow to back of his head. He grunts out in pain and removes his invisibility. M was making decisions for me with the voices. I say, I know its you. I am taking you to Wyan. He grumbles, bitch. I didn't like the way he said that to me, or Polly. So I land a Kuret kick on his lower abdomen. Had tried to protect himself with his light Kuret, but it cracks under my Kuret and my knee lands on the target. The wind gets knocked out of him again.

I land another punch on his upper back, hopping to impact his lungs. He bursts coughing from the pain and closes his eyes. This is it, I grab his head from the back with both my hands. He has never fought me before, so no way he would feel my Kuret on him. But I need to get away before his pain subside and he thinks clearly. Good thing my whole plan was to keep him distracted. I drag him with his face across the wall all the way as I force the Kuret on my back to push me ahead.

Quintin was desperately trying to get away from my grip. He had been continuously attacking me with his light Kuret. His battle senses is impressive, even when his face is getting crushed against a wall, he is not stopping. And that’s exactly why I can't beat with in this situation. I made turn to the hall where the wall ends. His face finally open for a brief moment, Polly, you are dead. He shouldn't waste his energy cursing, because I just pushed him to the other wall and continue dragging him.

He was getting more desperate, blasting me with his light Kuret at point blank behind his head. I will my Kuret in the torse to cover my head. And just like how I remember, it breaks into tiny little threads of sparks, running around my neck and skin, to finally converge in my face. I was protected before he could fire his Kuret. I was right to cover my face, because he fired it at light speed. He could have fired it anywhere, but his intent gave away the attack.

I could feel the force of this one. It even brought me to a halt in the hall. It felt I hit my head on the ocean surface. This attack a lot of weight to it. If I didn't have my Kuret, he would have burned through my skins and bones. He went in for the kill. But I was resisting it. I still had my hands on his neck and smushed his head to the wall. While his attack kept happening, I saw at the corner a glimmer approaching. I was dragged Cory to her. She must have heard the commotion and got here first.

I can't let them meet yet. Quintin is primed now. He won't listen to any reason and attack her. But she isn't pushed far enough. I need to keep Quintin here for a moment. His light Kuret was not backing down. His determination to kill is quite strong and fueling him. Well, I just have to pour more gasoline on it. As I was stuck, under his Kuret light pressure, I raise my right foot and stomp his foot. With the added pressure from my Kuret, his foot got crushed under mine.

This created enough distraction to slow down his Kuret attack and he winces in agony. I used opportunity to pull him closer and grab his head with my elbows. With a swift sumo move using my Kuret to thrust him up, I slam his entire body on his back into the floor. His face was cut and bruised all over. His eyes were squinting and he most definitely couldn't see me. I land a another blow on his chest with my Kuret covered elbow. He chocks and spits out blood as I take a step back.

He was writhing on the floor and cursing something. Must be for Polly. I didn't waste time and thrust myself towards Polly. Quintin was tough, he kept me occupied far too long, because Polly was right at the corner. I used my Kuret on the back to kick into a higher gear. The force of my propulsion is something I am still not used to. I nearly hit the wall as I turned at the corner. Polly wasn't surprised, she was anticipating me. She was charging at me mad, Cory, I am going to melt your bones for that dirty trick earlier.

There was no light from the windows here, so its great she thinks I am Cory. But now the problem is I can't get near her. As she was approaching, she was leaving being a melted floor and wall surfaces. She had raised the temperature around her to blazing hot. Even with my Kuret protecting me, my skin will burn off. Plus I have exposed skin, physically attacking her is not a good idea. I wish I could throw my Kuret on her to stop her producing the heat.

But unfortunately I have to go to her. She knows Cory rotting doesn't work on her, so me staying at a distance will be suspicious to her. I can't let her think even for a second that I won't do what Cory could do. I grit my teeth knowing I heading to a furnace. As I fly in the air, I will my Kuret to spread out and cover as much of my body I could. I could feel the hair on my body burning from the heat. I just hope my Kuret vibrations are strong enough to cancel the heat.

Polly was going to attack with her fist. Her glimmer was coming off it more. I crouch down and land an uppercut aimed at her chin. She dodges it before it hits her and throws her other fist. I flick it away my arm, countering with a kick. She jumps avoiding it and brings her knee, which was burning the air around, in front of me. I forced my Kuret to pull me away back and narrowly escape my head from getting burned. I take some distance away from her and gather my footing.

She is good at close combat. With the type of Kuret she has, she had to be proficient enough in hand to hand close combat. She charges at me again with another punch. She is able to see in the dark quite well with her Kuret. I counter it with my elbow and throw a punch at her chest. She blocks it her other arm. The contact was brutal, she already had wrapped her arm with a heat wave that burnt me. I grunt and back away again. This is going nowhere. She has the upper hand, while I am handicapped.

She grins saying, come on. Bring it on you little freakier. If you think hiding in the dark will help you forget it. I can sense your body heat. No point in running. I knew that already. It would have been much simpler if could use my Kuret on her. She was trying to goad me to attack her. Cory is definitely the type to be rage baited. I decided to change my plan, I can't fight her like this for long. If can't make her mad enough to confuse her more about Quintin, I will have to redirect her to the person she will attack without hesitation.

I dashed in front of her. She laughs manically, yeah. That’s more like it. She was preparing to release huge amount of heat around her. My eyes widen at that, oh shit. I jump and let my Kuret thrust me with as much speed I can. This is going to hurt a lot. I clench my teeth as I slammed head on into a burning furnace. Polly brought her arms to catch me and keep me pinned down. I was momentarily stuck in a mini sun as I continue to push Polly backwards.

The arms she had grabbed me felt like it was burning my skin off me. I can't stay like this. I shouted, hoping M understood my reasoning of the voice, you are a slut. I always knew that. It came with Cory's voice. It worked, it was slightly distorted due to the heat, but that just gave more credibility to the voice. Polly got even mad and raised up the heat. It was a move to distract her footing as she grabbed me harder. I used that opportunity to push myself up in the air.

While Polly grabbed on me, I willed my Kuret to burst out. I envisioned the spikes on my arms. The same I had conjured when Charles kicked be before I was knocked out. I don't know how much was successful, but it was enough to hurt her. Her grip loosens and with a spike filled fist, I pushed ahead for a punch to her face. The force was enough to knock her vertically into the ceiling. I was on timer, so I bailed from there. With another boost of my Kuret, I was propelled into the air again.

I ran fast as I could without looking back. I hear Polly falling back flat on the ground and yelling in pain. I too was in pain. Few more seconds and she would have probably boiled my blood. Even my bones feel the pain as I rush head, creating more distance from her. Once I was out of her range, I could feel the cold air of the abandoned building air. That relieved some of the pain, but I am very sure I got burn marks all around me. I wasn't just running away, I was heading to a certain place.

I wanted to take a break, but its important to challenge him again. I spotted Cory's glimmer. He wasn't even trying to hide or be stealthy like the other two. Instead he was using his rot Kuret around like a wave and disintegrating floor. I guess when you have a strong metaphysical attack, its more beneficial to remain open. Once I reached the staircase where he was heading down from, I shouted call, hey. But then I immediately stopped. It was my own voice.

Dammit, the voice changer must have short-circuited earlier when I tussled with Polly. What do I do now. I need him rattled enough to believe that I was Quintin. It wasn't just the device on my neck, my shades, watch and transmitter were also burned and broken. I immediately stop in tracks, near the end of the staircase. This is bad. These people can't be tricked easily. I have been building up the illusion meticulously and precise actions. Take away the vision and Kuret, only voice is left that will overwhelm their senses.

I was running out of options, but then I saw a glimmer of something. My eyes widen at drone arriving beside me. I realized that M understood my predicament. The drone creates the voice, found you again freakier. You won't get away this time. It was Quintin voice. I smile and jump into the air with my Kuret pushed me straight up. Cory was using is rot all over the staircase. Maybe he has been thinking Quintin would be invisible and using his rot kuret around would prevent a surprise attack.

Cory shouts in response, bring it on you scumbag. I will turn you into dust. Just then I thrust my body through the stairs he was rotting and come out bursting through the concrete. He was already prepared for this though. He was ready to grab on to me, I pulled away before he came in contact. His fingers grab on to a rock which instantly turns to dust. His Kuret is dangerous, I am able to cancel his Kuret in the air with my own. But even I would get infected if he touched my body.

I jump backwards as he tries to grab me again. With the dust I just kicked up in the air, his vision is even more blocked with the dark. I prepare for a close encounter. I pour all the Kuret on my body on my arms, making it denser and stronger. Its a risky move, my entire body is exposed. But I have no choice now. Because at the corner I could both Polly and Quintin moving. I don't know if they encountered each other yet. But I am sure Polly will be here before Quintin.

With a burst of momentum from the Kuret on my arms, I lunged straight to Cory. He was prepared with a strong, dense Kuret on his arms to block me. But my Kuret was significantly stronger than his. I crashed straight into him and pushed him back where he came off. The acceleration I had on my arm felt like I was tugging on a jet ski. The I rushed ahead with Cory yelping in pain when I broke the door and came bursting out the room. I don't stop here. I continue to push him backward and force him backwards.

He yells, stop this you freak. What would, his voice cuts off when I rang his head like a bell on a steal door. He was already using a crazy amount of Kuret around him. The doors were almost like a sandpaper at the point of contact. I just hope my arms are still intact on his chest. We break through more doors and walls, pushing him as much as possible from others. The pain is hitting me hard now. I am very sure its from the burns I got earlier and now from my skin peeling off.

I need to fish this quickly. My plan is simple, to get two people isolated first. Initially I wanted Polly and Quintin to fight, but these guys are way too tough. So now its Polly and Cory first. I was never going to beat them handicapped this much. Case in point, even as Cory was being dragged across by me around the rooms, he grabbed my arms and poured his Kuret on me. I couldn't focus on whether it was effective or not. I just had to get him away. I finally reached an open room. It was another water control station.

I concentrated to make another spike. But I couldn't do it. I am at my limit right now. So instead I just went with a brute force Kuret blow. With such a dense Kuret on my arms, it almost exploded likely a bomb and physically hits Cory in the upper body. He yells out in pain with this close proximity attack. His grip leaves me and I waste no time to fly into the air. I purposely went to this spot, closer to the Hanger area so I can jump to the nearest point in the first floor. I grab on to the railing and crossed over it. I slump down and hid behind the railing wall.

The adrenaline I took earlier was wearing off. I felt it for a few seconds ago. My sore body was paining all over. The control over my Kuret wavers and the armor cracks out. My Kuret goes back inside me leaving me all vulnerable again. But its not a mental block anymore. Its just pure exhaustion. I saw myself bleeding on my arms and chest. Then I felt it trickle on side of my jaws. I couldn't tell if it was because of Quintin's relentless barrage, Polly's nightmare furnace or Cory's zombie grip.

I was wincing in pain. A second later I realize it’s a good thing. That means everything is still intact. I crawl a little away from the railing and sat at the corner. Below me, Cory yells, where the freak did you run off too now. He chuckles a little, that was impressive. You dragged me all the way here. He was walking around the place trying to find me. And he would have eventually noticed the staircase that leads up here from below. But I had stalled him long enough that Polly came rushing into the room from the broken door.

I saw glimmers of red on her neck. She was bleeding a little there. Though I doubt it will for much longer. She took her fist and slammed it into the wall. Apparently, she had changed her Kuret to her other one. A layer of thin ice spreads across the wall and it cracks near the impact. She shouts at him, finally. Let me get a good at you before I turn you into an icicle. This is it. All the planning I did was for this. Will Cory take the bait. They both should be way too angry and frustrated to be thinking clearly.

Cory was mad, and now visibly puzzled. He says, Polly. What the hell happened to you. Wait, no. buzz off. I need to finish off that bloody Quintin first. He tried to leave her side and exit this place, but Polly wasn't going to let him. She threw a kick at him that was so cold, I could see ice in the air. Cory blocked it with his hands and pushed her away. The both back away and keep a distance, freak this. She scoffs, you think you can just ignore me. For him. Not a chance. I am putting you down.

Cory didn't had a clue what just happened. He glares at her. Then something makes him to cover his arms with his Kuret again, do that again and I will crush you. He spats off a bloody spit and says, where is Wyan. What did you do to him. She says, now you care about him. She takes a step closer, the air chilling around her. She yells, after I popsicle you, I will bring you to him. Cory was so confused, he probably knew something was off. But with all commotion and the hints of traitor I laid out. He must have pieced it together.

He glares at her, you think Wyan will take your side. Hell no. Not after what you have done. I am bring you to him. Polly brings her fist in front of him, shut it. I am going to kill you. Cory charges in, bring it on bitch. They both clash with their Kuret. This is so much better than I predicted. I thought they would accuse each other of traitor out in the open. I wasn't sure what would have happened then, would cooler heads prevail or become hot headed.

I planned it very carefully to not give them enough time to think about what's going on. The first step was the surprise ambush, keep them separated and off balance. Then there were frantically searching for me, or rather each other. And I further pushed them over, by baiting them and beating each of them. The conclusion was this. They will not listen to each other no matter what. They are a bunch of hot headed pissed off people. If Wyan was here, I bet he would have been level headed enough to stop them. But his was already knocked out.

I was grinner like a madmen when I saw them duking themselves in the most severe case of confusion and manipulation.

David (Chapter 75)

Thursday, January 15, 2026 22:38

If I wasn't in pain, I would have laughed much harder than I am. But even this simple movement was now aching my neck. Cory's attack didn't hurt me badly, but it was quite a strong blow. I am sure he broke one or two ribs. My hands were trembling a little. The heat and rotting Kuret was stilling reeling on it, even when I had protected myself with my Kuret. But I am not injured too severely. Just have a sore body aching everywhere. I think I have overworked my body and I am certain I can't use either my new Kuret or the Kuret storm.

I peek down to the two people still locked in battle. They had been going at each other for quite some time now. Cory had to be way more confused than Polly. But he was not backing down. He kept trying to grab Polly and infect his Kuret on her. She deftly moves around to dodge it and counter with her punches. Its impressive Cory was able to sustain himself in Polly's vicinity. A while ago, she had switched to her heat Kuret again and blazing up the place.

Cory was apparently, rotting away the heat. I didn't knew he could do that. How does that make sense scientifically. It's quite a spectacle, so I have to believe he is targeting the Kuret around her that lets her control the adjust the temperature. When I mimicked and threw Cory's Kuret at her back in the hanger, I couldn't control the rot like Cory can do. He is proficient enough to selectively rust off the Kuret before it generates heat around him.

Polly was also cancelling his Kurets. Just like how she did it with me, she is removing the moisture. So basically, they are engaged in a fist fight. Whoever lower their guards first, will get hit. They both were jumping around the place, locked in deadly combat. Polly charges with her whole body burning now. In response, Cory enveloped in a Kuret so dense, I could see the air particles turning to dust. He charges in straight too. I tighten my grip in anticipation, who will prevail in such a compatibility.

Turns out, no one. Their Kuret clashed, hurting each other. Some of the rot managed to hit Polly in the face and abdomen. Corry was punched in the inner thigh with Pollys fist. They both stumble away in pain. So it’s a draw then? Polly yells, you freakier. She had part of her face peeled off from the rot. However, that didn't stop her from rushing in with a new kick. Cory couldn't dodge it because his leg was immobilized, so instead he poured his Kuret on the floor where Polly was running on.

Polly jumps out of way seeing the floor crumble and goes for a high kick. Cory yells, take this bitch. He showers her with another blast of his Kuret at her mid air. They both clashed again for the 9th time. Surely, there will be only one left now. The clash resulted in debris and walls around them disintegrating and bursting to flames. The heat flames even reach high up that I had to slouch my head down to avoid my hair catching on fire. Once the dust settles, I raise my head.

Both of them were down. I don't believe it. Did they really go for a mutual knockout. I can't be this lucky. Turns out, I actually wasn't. The debris clear out and Polly picks herself up. Cory was lying on his back, writhing with the pain of huge blisters on his body. Even if he could heal himself, he won't be able to move for some time. Polly wasn't fearing any better. She was bleeding all over her body with cuts and disfigured skin patches. I think Cory's rot Kuret couldn't protect himself from the Polly's heat entirely. While Polly was able to shrug off a lot more of Cory's Rot.

So I guess the winner of this round is clear. She was in the top 100 not for nothing. She limps and drags herself to a bleeding Cory. She picks grabs his collar with her one arm and pulls him up a little bit. She spits on his face. Oh, damn. That’s got to hurt his pride. Cory's boiled face somehow became even redder, as did his glimmer. She grabs him by his hair, I told you I am going to kill you. Cory tried to move away, but his body was too broken down.

She slams his down on the floor. He couldn't defend much with his own Kuret now. She still had some left in her tank though. I see ice forming in her fist, ready to smash a punch in his face to end him. Just then, the final contender comes rushing in. Quintin face was still bruised, but he was healed enough to come back up. He saw one look at Polly hovering over a beaten Cory and longes at her, you bitch. Get away from him. I couldn't have manipulated the situation better than how it happened right now.

Polly won against Cory, but she wasn't exactly in the best condition for another right. It was now Polly's turn to be confused and yells, what the hell Quintin. He ignored her. He was already mad from his face getting plastered along the walls earlier. He lets out a barrage of Kuret light on her. Polly couldn't muster enough Kuret and strength to dodge it. She slides away on the ground and hides behind a pillar. Corys head falls down and I see his slimmer flickering away.

Marvelous, one down. But that means I need to enter the fray soon. I gather myself slowly and prepare to enter this three way battle. Quintin continues to hurl his light Kuret at Polly. He was so angry, that his Kuret was lasering through the rooms everywhere. Even where I was. Thankfully, it didn't hit me. Polly wasn't so lucky. Most of the directed attacks drilled inside the pillar and hit Polly. She winced in pain trying to find more cover. But she was way too battered to fight back. Quintin threw another round of Kuret and one pierced through her shoulders.

That was the critical blow. Quintin goes invisible and circles around the pillar to catch Polly. She is on her last breath. Her glimmers is filled with pain and anger. She will be knocked out cold any second, even before Quintin reaches her. In one last desperation she lets out a scream and blasts a wave of icy wind around her. The wave covers everything in thin layer of ice. The floor, the walls and the debris from the destruction. She must have done this to catch Quintin, wherever he was.

Quintin wasn't expecting this sudden attack. He was caught in it. A side of his body was covered with freezing cold wave. That last attack finally did in for Polly. Her head rolls away in exhaustion and pain. Two down, one to go. Quintin becomes visible again. He grunts as he picks one of his arm with his other. When Polly blasted her Kuret, Quintin uses his Kuret to protect himself. But unlike his Kuret, he doesn't react in light speed. He couldn't fully save his left arm and part of it was covered frozen. I couldn't help but giggle realizing that he has frost bites on his arm.

He yells, bitch. This hurts dammit. I am sure it does. He will probably recover soon anyways. I wasn't going to let him though. I don't know how much I can when I am still in pain. But Polly gave me a gift I wasn't expecting. I need to use it now. While he was distracted by the mess I created for them, I took the long way around down. I crawl away slowly and slither inside the room. As luck would have it, M had prepared an ART bot for me.

The bot wheels at with one its arm extended at me. I was in pain, but still laughed as I grab that metal arm and it helps me stand up. The bot helps me from stumbling down. My right foot gave me a sharp pain. I think I must have twisted it. The bot throws a light at me and scans from head to toe. M's voice comes, boss. You need to be bandaged. You have few broken ribs, burned skin and sprained ankle. I nod, I know. I can't ignore it anymore. But Quintin is the only one left, and mildly hurt. Before he heals, I need to finish him off.

Using the bot as help, I dash to the other door and head the nearest stairs. I ask, what is he doing. M says, he is checking their pulses. I have detected their vitals. They are only unconscious for now. I was a little worried about Cory, but I guess he is a tough bustard too. If Quintin hadn't shown up then, he might have been killed. With every step hurting my leg, we somehow climb down the stairs. This made me realize that I was in no condition to dodge or rush at Quintin.

Maybe if he is immobilized, I could attack him. I need to rely on the bots now. As we come closer to the room from behind, I try to figure out a way to retrain him. I thought of one. Its quite a strange one. I ask, do we have any bots that can throw a rope or net laced with poison. M says, we don't it boss. Figures, this was a very out of the box idea and I would never configure such a weapon in any situation. M says, however, we got carbon wires that we run electric current through.

I remember that weapon, I designed it for capturing Kuret animals. It could work. Its dark there, his arm is frozen and he is in pain. It wouldn't make it difficult to him believe a certain someone his attacking him. I say, prepare that. Grab all the bots you have that can do that. Surround the room and then blast through the walls, we will go all in one attack. Restrain him to the pillar while electrifying his ass. He would most definitely be using his Kuret to cut through the rope. So keep adding it on top of him, empty everything you got.

M says, understood boss. Deploying the ART bots. Ready in one minute. That was probably how long it would take for me reach the room. Once we arrive, so did the bots. I can see 5 glimmers around the room. Quintin couldn't sense the light from them because of the walls and machines that had caught fire earlier from Cory and Pollys battle. Once everyone were in position, I signal them to attack. All 5 bots break through the 3 walls surrounding Quintin.

He was probably less alert since both warriors were down. He didn't react enough in time. He did threw his Kuret around, but the bots had prepared in consideration and had some sacrificial bots guarding them. The dust thrown in the air hindered what little vision Quintin had from the fire. The bots throw the electrified carbon net around him. He shrieks in pain as get hit with massive amount of current on the ropes. The bots aimed at him in angle that made him push towards the pillar.

He threw his Kuret out in defense, but more bots rushed in to defend the 5 bots. I raised my over my eyes, covering the glare from the light. More and more carbon nets entangle on him. Soon, he was stuck to the pillar. His screams fill the empty air. His left arm was no longer in frost bite, but it had to hurt even more now. Still this wasn't enough to take him down. His barrage of Kuret attack didn't stop as he yells out angrily, face me Grover. You coward.

It worked, it actually worked. I was sure it wasn't going to work this good. However, he was too furious and irrational to actually believe the ropes with the electric cuts he is feeling is from Grovers rope Kuret. I have primed his mind to perfection. Its not over though. The ropes were piling up on him, but he wasn't slowing down his attacks. If anything, it was growing in number. At this rate, we won't have enough bots to protect the 5 bots keeping him restrained.

I tell M, stop the current. Just keep him restrained and throw me at him. M says, that’s too reckless boss. I yell, just do it. I gather all the Kuret I could pull out and prepare for a final knockout. The bot carried me to the entrance. Oh boy, this is going to be crazy. The bot rushed inside while carrying me by the torso. Like a baseball, it hurls me straight towards him. I gathered all the Kuret on my arms and throw my Kuret on his face. He yells, what the hell.

He probably didn't understand why he went blind. He throws his Kuret at me. Just like earlier, even without looking, he had got blinding accuracy. Thankfully, as I was thrown up in the air, he missed most of it. But one was heading straight at my face. I can't change my direction, so I blasted a wave of Kuret from my body to cancel it out. The Kuret light disperses before it could hit me, but the force was enough to hit he on my neck. I grunted in pain, yet continued on my pull.

I sped up the pull on my Kuret line and clashed straight into his abdomen with both my fists. The impact was devastating for him at this point blank range. My hands tremble at the pressure, but I didn't stop yet. His Kuret looses its strength, pinning him to the pillar even more tighter. Blood trickles down from his mouth. His Kuret attack was still up, but it had lost its power. I was able to cancel it out with just this much minimal Kuret. With one last pull I crush him further back.

That's when the pillar couldn't hold it together anymore and broke. I lost my balance as I stumble down on my side covering my face for the impact. After I roll away, I look at Quintin. He was still tied to the fallen pillar. And yet the guy wasn't completely down yet. Jeez, just how much longer can he go. I yell out, Grover get him. M understand my intention and ran the current on the wire again. With a much weaker Quintin, it worked even more

effectively. He was able to cut through some of the ropes with his Kuret. But the damage was done.

He had scars from the cuts all over his body. He slides down from the pillar into a motionless body. Holy shit. My body that was tensed up till now, finally relaxes. I yell out with a bit of pain, bloody hell. I did it. I took down two alphas and a dual Kuret user under 10 minutes. A bot comes closer to me. M makes a sound like she was clearing her throat. I laughed, really. The bot helps to stand up, fine. Yeah, we did it. But I am taking the credit for everything.

M says, of course boss. I did all the work, and you take the credit. She was being purposefully being facetious with me. I can't deny it though. I couldn't have pulled all this alone. I ask, how much time do we have. Did Ryan find the patrols. M says, they are on the way boss. I estimate we have around 3 more minutes. I grit my teeth. I made it just in time. But there are way too many evidence here. I ask M, please tell me you have some bots cleaning my DNA evidence. I have been bleeding and sweating all over the place.

I waited for M to respond, keeping me in suspense for a while, already working the scene. Your extreme stealth activity was evident enough for me to initiate the cleanup protocol. I sigh in relief. Earlier I asked M to made intuitive decisions. Glade it worked out. I see the bots picking up the broken pieces of the ART bots wheeling away. Behind them, a different sphere drones hovering in air that were spraying acetone liquid and blowing off tire marks. The protocol is in full effect.

I tell M, take these 3 to the hanger area. With the bots help, I rush towards the hanger area with 3 unconscious, beaten down, warriors. Each of believing that they were fighting each other, from start to finish. Two minutes left. The hanger was now filled with unconscious bodies. Even Patton, Kiera and Max were brought here. All in one place, with a smuggled goods with their Kuret prints all over them. No matter who they blame, who they point, no one is going to get away from this.

M says, boss while scanning the everyone earlier, I found they don't have any phones on them. I turn towards Wyan. He seems like a cautious guy. It wouldn't be a surprise if he ordered no one to bring anything here that could have a GPS or bugged. Then I remembered something from earlier. I look around the briefcase I blasted at the beginning. I remember seeing something else as well. I saw a glimmer coming off the broken wall lying on ground. I say, pick that up and check. The bot uses his 3 free arms and pushes it away. The bottom revealed a small iron box. Its quite thick, so I don't know what's inside. But it has to be their phones inside. This is a good, now I can figure out who hired them to smuggle in those drugs.

The bot picks up the box and carries it. M says, boss, sanitizing is at 95 percent completion for the building. Unfortunately, we have run out of time. The patrol officers arrived much earlier than anticipated. Luck runs out eventually. I answer, lets leave. Keep one cleaner bot and one surveillance bot behind. I doubt the whole cavalry is coming here immediately. Let it finish its work, even its slow. M says, assigning the stealth task. My leg hurts as I run towards the front exit. Its too late to go though the pipe now always.

I was too tried to keep track of the path. This basement and ground level has too many rooms and machines. Many of them were kept as redundant for emergencies, so the paths looks the same. Finally we cross the stairs and exit from the front. At this point I was too exhausted to even use Kuret in my eyes and saw no glimmers. M had called in the car beforehand and was waiting. Before I got in, wait, you swept the whole building clean, but did you pick my specs from Peter's jeep. M says, good catch boss. We almost blew it, leaving behind a big evidence.

Speak for yourself, you, strange AI. The bot helps me get inside the car and then sped off towards the jeep hidden in the trees. I thought Peter would take the car when he escaped, but just he ran on foot, scared out of his mind. He didn't even realize he could get away much faster on his jeep. Well. Doesn't matter now. The bot comes back with the specs and puts it on passenger seat with the iron box. ART opens the back trunk and the bot slithers inside.

Just then I hear the sound a car coming from the road. I say, M, take us through the grass and hide us until they go inside. M responds, hold on boss. ART takes us off road and accelerates into the uneven terrain. The car jerks up and down as it travels inside the land. After gaining some distance, it stops to hide. I could feel ART was shifting the outer color to darker green to match this region. I wait here in silence as two officers step out of the vehicle with Ryan and run inside.

We barely made it. I take big sigh. M, take us out of here. We couldn't drive on the road, not if we want to be caught on cameras. So M plotted a course for ART to the neatest safe point that we can use to entire into the city. I wasn't too thrilled, because it meant more turbulent journey. I took for the bag that M had collected from the room I was hiding in the hanger room. It was siting on the leg area. I pulled it out and opened up a small box from it. It had a spray made of antibiotic cocktail so that my wounds don’t get infected.

I took my time applying it on my entire body. Meanwhile I watched through the surveillance drone hidden in the hanger room. The officers were shining lights around the place. Ryan head straight to the Elina lying on the floor. I was even more relieved when they also confirmed she is fine. Not that I didn't trust M, but it just bolstered the fact that she will be fine. Soon they started inspecting my handiwork. All gathered in a place, at the scene of a crime. Their and mine.

Won't be long until they call the IDF. Vanessa might be called here soon. Or maybe it would be Somers. Either way, I ended up making a lot of mess for them in a short time. I wish I could have stayed and explained. But I had a plan. I can't go change it now. I ask M, where is Peter. M opens up a different camera that showed him hiding in some construction site a mile from here. My eyes twitch in disbelieve, what is he doing there. Is he for real. Is there anyway that he is contacting someone from there.

M says, unlikely boss. I don't see detect device on his person. I slam my fist on the dashboard. He is just hiding in fear. Dammit. I was really hoping he would lead me to other members or to the person he stole the drugs for. I am almost very certain that he stole the drugs and brought Elina and Ryan as a cover. By using his family, he would gain whatever little sympathy from others and be free from blame. That’s my theory and that’s why I let him escape. The plan wasn't perfect, but I had hoped to get something out of him.

I guess I have to go pick him up and interrogate myself. Though, I decided to wait for some more time. Let him feel the guilt and maybe he would run off somewhere more useful. ART got us on the road after a while. I ordered to head straight to the house. I haven't forgotten about the tonight's deadline, but I need some first aid pronto. Its around 8 right now, so I have enough time treat my wounds before I go to Drew's place. I tell M to send a message to Drew saying I will meet at her in her field around midnight.

Soon I arrive at the cliff on the outer edge of sector 5. I say, M, keep monitoring the IDF and the network. We need to be sure, our hands are clean from this. Even if things doesn't work out with Peter, we want don't want to be involved in this. M says, I am monitoring the feeds, boss. Sommers and Tessa are on the way to the water treatment plant. So its them first. I assume Vaness and Blake were held up in the officer building due to work. But soon they will move out too.

ART was already ready to dive into the ocean when the car drives inside the garage. I waited inside the car until we were underwater. With the more dexterous house bots, I limp my way to the infirmary room to treat my wounds. M had already calibrated for the medicines and bandages based on the scans earlier. M says, shall I prepare the nano bot chamber. I raise my hands, not yet. The nano chamber is not effective for a short time. I will use it later. For now just do the disinfection and wound dressing.

I ordered the bots to leave for a while to clean myself up. The hot water helped me clean off all the dirt and blood on my head and body. Now that things have calmed down completely, I felt my chest and leg ache. After a checkup from the x ray and body inspection, I was bandaged up with a cast around my chest and leg. My foot burned in agony when the bot moved it and locked in the correct position before applying the cast. I had multiple burn marks too, curtesy of Polly.

I ask M to adjust the composition of the burn paste to be applied for my neck and face without the bandage. I can't be looking hurt, again so soon. The bandage dressing on the other burnt skins is good enough for now. The nano bot chamber was slower, but it was less painful. This manual process was faster, however, painful. I forget the times I jerked in pain when the gel was applied or a cut was stitched. I wished I was unconscious for this, but I need to be wide awake for this manual processes. M herself is not confident on the bots following careful instructions and not mess it up.

The entire process took several hours. It was grueling time, but this was on me. I knew I shouldn't have tried to fight all of them when I wasn't fully recovered. Both physically and mentally. Speaking of which, I could feel my panic attacks are not an issue now. I tested it few more times now by bringing out my Kuret. I felt the exhaustion, but not the gut retching full blown nervous breakdown I had been struggling all day. This is not I how imagined I would overcome it. I don't know if this helped my PTSD or other symptoms.

I do feel a lot lighter, like a burden I had been carrying for years has been lifted. I might have internally rationalized saving Elina as saving Zakerine. Not sure how I feel about this. But at least I got past through the trauma. I sigh recalling that moment. I heard that guys voice back then. Obviously that was my own subconscious talking to me. But even when I know I he was an imagination, it made me feel so mad at him. What kind of hang up do I have with him, even after all these years.

M says, boss. I found a message from the IDF that Elina has woken up. That pulled me out of my own thoughts. I was siting in the bed room sofa chair and eating my dinner. I put down my fork and ask, that’s great news. How is Ryan. I regret a lot of things I could have done better tonight. One of it was him. I basically pulled him away from her dying sister and left him helpless on the side of the road. That was at least from his perspective. I don't know what I could have done differently, but I wouldn't have make the kid more miserable than he is right now.

M says, unknown. I only intercepted a message from the doctor about Elinas condition. I can confirm all the people involved are in custody in IDF. I nod as I continue eating. I am sure that they all are being treated as person of interest right now. Then I asked the important question, please tell me Peter has finally got out of hiding and is somewhere in the city. M opens a camera view from a drone of Peter in the wall display. He was walking down the road now. I was relieved he finally snapped out of it and moving.

I couldn't see his face from this high angle, but his posture is raggedy and slouching. But something else is weird, where is he going. The road feels familiar to the one we just came from. I ask, what place is this. M says, boss, he is 0.3 miles away from the water treatment plant and walking back in that direction. I freeze up for a second. I take a sip of water from the glass before putting my hand on my forehead. This behavior from him was not what I expected.

I close my eyes trying to sort this out. Does he have an ulterior motive. Could he going back to retrieve something. That can't be true, he is not panicking or running. It doesn't look like someone wanting to evade capture walking so openly in the road. I waited for him to do something unexpected at the last moment. But it never happened. There was a crowd near the plant, people and reporters hovering around the barricade officers put up. He simply walks into the crowd and gives himself up to the officers.

After interacting with them for a while, Tessa comes out and grabs him away by the arm into an officers car. He actually turned himself in. So I was wrong. He wasn't the thief. He is not bold or daring enough person to surrender himself and make his innocence with such a tactic. More like a guilty person who got his siblings involved in something he shouldn't have and guilt had eaten away at him. I tighten my fist, I made a wrong assumption back then. Oh if I had known back then, I would have pounded him too like others.

M says, shall I continue to have surveillance on him. I wave my hand, no. Leave it alone. He isn't going to escape from IDF when he just walked in himself. Pull the drone back. Pull of them back. I take another sip of water to

calm my nerves a little. I was so close to figuring out who was sabotaging us in the tournament. Or I thought I was. I ask M, you have saved the recording of their conversation from earlier, right? M says, yes. Before the watch was destroyed from the battle, I was able to upload a backup to ART. Shall I play it for you.

I say, not right now. Just analyze the discussion and isolate any indication of deception or lies from the others. I don't know how effective it will be with partial videos and reconstructed voices. But do whatever you can. Its still possible the culprit was someone else in the group. M says, creating an objective of analyzing the recording. Wyan was very eclectic group of people involved in this. I admit I don't the guy well. But the operation he was going on was very impressive. If he wasn't doing it in this island, I would have recruited him for my human operations.

Would he make a mistake of not exploring the option that it was really an outsider. He said he handpicked everyone and he was very sure none of them did it. Setting aside personal bias he might have towards his people, he was oddly focused on Elina and Ryan. But that can't be. He was very sure of himself. Going by your intuition is a very risky gamble. I would very much like to hear his statement when he wakes up. But I could be making the same mistake by personal intuition. I want Elina to be not guilty because I know her. But its not impossible she or Ryan found about Peters little scheme and got greedy for some reason.

Ah, I wanted to talk to them. But its way to risky. If by a terrible chance they did stole it for the person, they would know I am on to them and cover their tracks. I made the painstaking decision to hide my involvement so that the person behind this would think the group imploded on its own, unaware that I did it and on their trail. M cuts in my thinking, boss. I have two different reports for you. For the time being I pushed aside Elina or Ryan's possible involvement.

M says, I intercepted a message that mentions Cory tried to escape IDF about 2 hours ago. He almost did, but Vanessa stopped him. I scoff hearing that ridiculous escape attempt, why are you getting this report now. M says, it seems Vanessa has put a lid on the entire IDF communications. I assume it’s a preventive measure to avoid anyone knowing that they have detained so many people at the IDF. That does sound plausible. I ask, anyone hurt. Cory was soundly beaten up by Polly. Well, little by me too. But I had to learn the hard way that there are still alphas that I didn't get to fight in the tournament who are very resilient.

M responds, unknown. If Vanessa was there, then I don't doubt she would have stopped him without letting him hurt others. That was pretty reckless move from Cory. I get he didn't want to get entangled again with us, given his history of the Valley. Still, breaking out of IDF? Where does he think he will escape. Even Peter knew there is no place to run and accepted his fate. For a brief moment I entertained the thought if he was the culprit and was running to guy he stole it for.

No, it doesn't make sense. He was way more concerned about Polly being the traitor and fought her till the end. In that sense I can rule out the other two as well. They were the muscles of the operation, not the brains. I ask, what's the other thing. When M told me about it, I cock my head gazing into the ocean in the window. This is bad, very bad. My assumption what who was behind the sabotage was wrong. Its good that the suspect pool has dropped to fewer people, but it leaned to a different group entirely.

I couldn't dwell on it too long because it was time to visit Drew. I changed into a casual dress to hid the bandaged underneath it. Hopefully, she won't suspect my involvement. Around 11:30 ART brought us back up in section 3 and I took the car to her place. On the way M says, boss, Peter is being interrogated questioned by Vanessa and Blake. This could be interesting, let me hear it. M activates the bug in that room and I listen in to the conversation. Peter actually felt guilty and wanted to see Elina and Ryan. I don't think he was lying, so its almost certain he doesn't have anything to do with the actual culprit.

As Peter recounted his perspective of what happened, I was smiling. He was there in the hanger the longest, so if really believed people were fighting each other, it’s a good bet everyone thought the same. Then I realize he missed out or told some events out of order. Well, he was scared out of his mind. He being able to tell this much is good enough. They both were able to pry out information from him. Enough details to correctly guess that someone else was definitely involved.

For the time being their prevailing theory was that it was some hidden bodyguard of Wyan. Not a bad guess. Honestly, I have outdone myself. I manipulated the whole flag capture game, but actually, doing it on few people is much harder. They still don't know that it was me. I know that I have to reveal it to at least Blake later. I can't let him waste manpower on a hunt for me. Best to focus on getting them convicted in the tribunal. When Blake allowed Peter to meet with Elina, I became little concerned. Not for Peter, but his siblings appear to be completely rattled. What does this mean for the Elina. Too early to say.

Then Peter revealed the information about the drugs. I didn't expect Blake to go full ballistic on him. But he wasn't alone. I felt the same when I heard it few minutes ago. I was so mad, but I had other things to worry about. I don't even want to know what Marina would do when she hears about it. Fortunately, Tessa intervened and stops Blake from making a punching bag out of Peter. I guess that would be it, but I was able to hear the next conversation even after Peter left the room.

I ask, what is this. M replies, I suspect the bug was dislodged in that short altercation. To think Blake used so much force. I hear Nathans voice now. What the hell is he doing there. How did Vanessa allow him inside. Before I could figure that out, he was already on to me. Of course the guy who was obsessed for a time with me last year would figure out first. As he laid out the breadcrumbs to others, they all realize my involvement. I was hoping to tell only Blake first.

Oh well. Its not a very big issue. I am hundred percent sure, the four them are not suspects. But I can't let Nathan have so much fun, not after he ruined the epic reveal I was thinking of doing. Wait, I can still mess with him. I say, M, send this message to their phones and delete it after 30 seconds.